

I Am Yours

**Memories of a beloved teacher:
stories from devotees of
Shrii Shrii Anandamurti**

A n a n d a M a r g a A r c h i v e s D e p a r t m e n t

“Tell everyone, all my sons and daughters, that ‘I am yours.’

I love each and every particle of the universe.

My love is for everyone. I am always with you.”

Shrii Shrii Anandamurti

I AM YOURS

Memories of a beloved teacher:

stories from devotees of Shrii Shrii Anandamurti

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INTRODUCTION

This is a book of spiritual stories – narratives about ordinary people’s devotional lives and their relationships with an extraordinary teacher. Shrii Shrii Anandamurti (1921-1990), more affectionately known as Baba, was a spiritual master of great power, compassion, and vision. He founded the socio-spiritual movement Ananda Marga, an organization that grew in size from a few devotees in India in the 1950s to a worldwide organization with tens of thousands of members today. This book deals with the experiences of Ananda Margiis – members of Ananda Marga – born or living in New York Sector, which is the organizational designation for the United States, Canada, Mexico, Central America, and the Caribbean countries.

Devotion – all-embracing love – is very important on the spiritual path, and in this book Baba’s devotees describe a wide range of experiences of this great love. For some, Baba is father; for others, friend; for still others, the beloved. Each individual feels that He is theirs alone. They feel great pain at being separated from Him. And the connection runs both ways. His disciples are His nearest and dearest. Hence the title of this book: “I Am Yours,” a phrase which Baba used when He departed from the Philippines in 1969.

Although Baba left His physical body in 1990, the spiritual relationships continue. As He reminded His followers, the true guru is the unchanging Supreme Consciousness permeating all things, a connection that is open to everyone.

He was born Prabhat Ranjan Sarkar in Jamalpur, in eastern India, on the full moon of May, 1921, an especially auspicious day (the Buddha was also born on this day). He gave His first initiation into meditation practices when He was still a young man, to a notorious criminal who approached Him in order to rob Him, but who instead experienced a conversion. This kind of dramatic transformation was typical of Baba’s effect on people. After coming into contact with Baba, devotees often experienced tremendous joy, peace, and inspiration, as if the true purpose and meaning of their lives was now clear.

Baba encouraged people to work for *dharma* (righteousness) and social justice. He consistently set an example for His devotees, showing them how to be more truly human by coming closer to God. And He inspired them to serve others.

In 1955, He founded Ananda Marga, an organization dedicated to these ideas and to reviving and propagating the ancient meditation practices of *Tantra*, a part of the Indian spiritual tradition with an emphasis on practice rather than theory. Although Ananda Marga was originally composed of family people, Sarkar soon created an order of renunciates – monks and nuns – who could work full-time as a complement to the family margiis to help implement these ideas in society. He soon also proposed an alternative socio-economic theory to capitalism and communism that He called the Progressive Utilization Theory or Prout. With its emphasis on strong ethical values and its extensive involvement in public relief work, Ananda Marga grew throughout the 60's, attracting thousands of people, including many civil servants.

Both the Indian central government and the communist bloc of West Bengal began to perceive Sarkar and Ananda Marga as threats to their power bases. There followed a controversial period. In 1971, perhaps instigated by the government, several followers split from Baba and tried to implicate Him in conspiracy charges. He was arrested and jailed, and during the ensuing Emergency period in India (as Prime Minister Indira Gandhi declared martial law) thousands of margiis were also jailed. After seven years imprisonment, during five of which Baba fasted on liquids to protest a government poisoning attempt, all charges were declared to be unfounded, and He was released. Throughout, Baba had remained the eternal optimist, firmly committed to His principles.

He then traveled widely, including to Jamaica and Venezuela in the Western hemisphere, and later to Europe. In the 1980s, Baba continued to introduce and develop new spiritual and social theories. He also composed devotional music, a body of some 5000 beautifully poetic songs known as Prabhat Samgiit. He penned books explaining the contributions and personalities of Shiva and Krsna; developed a social outlook called Neohumanism which gave philosophical grounding to the ideas of universalism and social equality; wrote commentaries on linguistics; and offered a groundbreaking theory on the link between matter and consciousness which He called the theory of Microvita.

He did all this while continuing to meet with and inspire thousands seeking His spiritual guidance. The Indian scriptures say, “He alone is great who can make others great.” This is how many devotees feel about Baba, that His greatness was reflected in His commitment to uplifting the human condition. Baba always encouraged people to become responsible stewards of the planet. Unlike some gurus who have caught the public’s attention because of their luxurious lifestyles, His focus was not on Himself or His own comfort, but on serving others.”

This book follows a roughly chronological order, ranging from the reminiscences of a few early Indian devotees, to Ananda Marga’s arrival in the Americas, to the stream of devotees traveling to India to see this extraordinary master in person. Each remembrance is told in the words of the storyteller, expressing their own individual understanding of the philosophical ideals, and their own level of practice. Many of the stories are transcribed from videotape; (the editors have noted in brackets, for example, when the narrator laughed or cried while telling their stories). Several highlights are common to many of these stories. The experience of Personal Contact, or PC, offered disciples the chance to receive individual attention from Baba, to spend time with Him one on one, and receive His blessing. And there was *Dharma Samiksa*, an extraordinary period in 1981 during which Baba reviewed the spiritual life of each person who came to Him, noting their past, present and future, their health and karmic situation, and recommended physical and spiritual exercises for each. Thousands of margiis also attended the semi-annual *Dharma Maha Cakras* (DMCs) in India, three-day gatherings during which people enjoyed collective meditation, music, food, and Baba’s discourses. The highlight of these gatherings was Baba’s *varabhaya mudra*, a dispensation of spiritual energy.

An explanatory note needs to be made regarding the physical touch of the guru. Baba’s touch – whether a pat on the cheek, or a hug – is said to have had a deep and profound impact on the devotee, often removing karmic obstacles. Moreover, in both PC and *Dharma Samiksa*, Baba sometimes rectified the mistakes of His devotees through punishment. Often He would simply touch the disciple with His cane, transmitting energy to them; other times, He gave stronger hits. Although this kind of reprimand may be difficult to understand on its surface, it is common in the history of guru-disciple

relations, especially in *Tantra*. It was an expression of loving guidance, accepted gratefully by disciples, which served to remove an individual's karmic obstacles. Indeed, following PC and *Dharma Samiksa*, many noted their lives had changed dramatically.

The editors have opted to capitalize pronouns referring to Baba, since this reflects the degree of respect and love Baba's devotees feel for Him.

All quotations in italics at the beginning of chapters are by Shrii Shrii Anandamurti.

An abundance of Sanskrit or Bengali words appear in the text. Most of them are italicized and defined in the glossary, apart from several commonly used words such as "guru," "sadhana" (meditation) or "darshan" (seeing the guru).

We hope the reader will come away from this book with a new understanding of Baba's contribution to society. But more importantly, we hope that the depiction of the depth of love expressed for and by Baba and His devotees will inspire the reader in his or her own spiritual journey. For in the end, this was Baba's goal: to propagate a spiritual vision and way of life; to teach us how to love.

CHAPTER ONE:

HOW COULD YOU LOVE ME SO MUCH?

“Brahma Himself is the Guru. There cannot be any second Guru. Generally people say that the form is the Guru, but the form is not the Guru; the Guru is expressing Himself through that form.”

Ananda Marga was growing by leaps and bounds in India during the late 1960s, and margiis there experienced many extraordinary moments with Baba. Slowly the organization began to expand overseas. Baba began to send *acaryas* to New York Sector in 1969. These early *acaryas* discovered a great receptivity to the practices of meditation and yoga. People turned out in great numbers to learn, and many became devotees of Baba.

One of the first New York Sectorial offices was set up in Wichita, Kansas; soon, regular retreats furthering the teaching of meditation and yoga were held in many areas. Margiis busied themselves with social service activities, and many attended Local Full Timer (LFT) training sessions. LFTs dedicated themselves full-time for the mission, immersing themselves in service projects. Ananda Marga groups (units) sprang up all across the sector, holding weekly meditation and social gatherings. Stories of Baba’s omniscience and grace related at these gatherings inspired people to begin to travel to India to see this mysterious Master for themselves.

Gayatrii Vashist

(daughter of Ac. Candranath Kumar, India)

I was initiated at age three, because my father was one of the early margiis. He used to go every Sunday to see Baba in Jamalpur, so Baba was the *acarya* of my brother and sister and my parents. I also wanted to do sadhana, but I was only three years old. My brother and sister used to tease me, “You are the only one Baba did not give sadhana to.”

I used to cry and ask my father, “I also want to learn.”

One Sunday he went to Jamalpur and asked Baba, “Baba, the youngest one wants to learn sadhana, but she’s only three years old.”

Baba said, “OK, you can teach her *nama mantra*.”

After that, Baba visited our place in Bhagalpur. I was there, feeling very proud that I was also initiated, that I could go and meet Baba. I was standing near the door, and Baba called me inside. I went and sat on Baba’s bed. Everyone was looking at me, with a “get down, get down” expression.

Then Baba said to me, “You do sadhana regularly?”

I told him, “Yes, Baba.”

“OK, fine, what do you feel, doing sadhana?” As a child I had heard some people say they hear flute music, so I thought that maybe if I said this, there would be great praise from Baba. I said, “Baba, sometimes I hear flute music,” and He said, “OHHH? Flute music?” I still can’t remember very clearly, but my parents told me this.

Another time Baba came to our place, and was sitting next to many flowers offered by devotees. As children we never bothered much about Baba, our eyes were on the flowers. Let Baba go and we will grab the flowers, we thought. Baba was leaving, and I went and took a big bunch of flowers. Baba shouted at me, “Gayatrii, it would better if you learn some discipline.” I was very scared, and put them back. As He was leaving, He turned back and smiled, and said to me, “Now you can take the flowers, I am going.” When I remember those incidents I feel we were really very lucky.

I was a naughty child. Once Baba was eating His food. My father, mother, brothers and sisters were all present. When Baba finished His food, He asked me if I wanted a *rasagulla*, an Indian sweet. He said, “Gayatrii, have a sweet.”

I was feeling shy, and I said, “No, I will not have one.”

My mother jokingly said, “Now you are offering and she is not taking, but when you leave, she will eat them all.”

I felt very bad, that my mother was complaining about me. I said, “Baba, she is always talking like this about me. But my father never says anything bad about me.” Baba started laughing and pointed at my father, and said, “He is a good boy.” As He was leaving, He told me, “Now I am not watching, you can have the sweet.”

Then Baba said to my mother, “You should not scold children much.” I felt very proud of myself, but after Baba left that room He said to me, “But as a child you should also behave in a nice way.”

My father was very close to Baba. Regarding family matters, Baba used to guide us, in little details. Once my father was transferred, we had to move, and all our luggage was placed on the truck. Baba came and said, in a sad mood, “It was a very nice house, but you all will have to leave it.” Afterwards we were transferred to Tatanagar, another city of Bihar. Baba visited our new place. It was the cold season and there was a fire in the room. All of us were sitting there. We did not want to leave Baba, and it was late. Baba told us, “Now you children should go and sleep; this is sleeping time. Tomorrow you can be with me again.” So what I gathered was that He was very particular about discipline, even for a child.

You may have heard about Makhan Dada, our cook. We had a big family, and he used to cook for everyone, including, on *dharmacakra* day, all the margiis who came. Once one margii came to see Baba at our place, and Baba asked him, “Do you do your sadhana regularly?”

The margii said, “Baba, I do it in the evening, but I can’t afford to do it in the morning, because morning time is too hectic and I have to rush to the office.”

Baba said to him, “If you want to learn how to do sadhana regularly, ask the cook Makhan. He’s working day and night, and if he can manage it, then why can’t you?”

My mother is a simple village lady, not very educated. She is the first lady *acarya* of Ananda Marga. Baba told her, in the beginning, “Ma, you have to prepare for the *acarya* exam.”

She said, “Baba, I am not very educated, I’m from a village, how can I do it?”

Baba said, “No, you have to do it.”

And there was another lady, an MA in English, very educated, who was also taking the exam with my mother. My mother was very nervous, and thought, “Why is Baba doing this to me, such an educated lady and me taking the exam together?” They both sat for the exam, and my mother cleared it, and that lady could not. So it’s all His Grace. He wanted her to become an *acarya*; it was His blessing.

My mother used to have a problem with sneezing. If she had something cold in the morning, or took a bath, for half an hour she would sneeze continuously. When my father learned sadhana, my mother was wondering, “What kind of sadhana is this, that he closes the door in the room? I think something is wrong with him; some day he will leave us and run away.”

So she asked him, “What kind of sadhana you are doing?” My father said, “If you want to learn, I will talk to my guru.” So he talked to Baba, and Baba said, “OK, you can bring her.” At that time, Baba was staying at the Railway Quarters in Jamalpur. They went, my father did *sastaung*, and my mother did also. And Baba said, “No, no, ma, not for you. You can do like this” [gives namaskar]. He always used to respect women. That day my mother had had for breakfast some cold thing like yoghurt, then she had her bath with cold water, and then she went to see Baba. And Baba initiated her. And from that day on, her sneezing problem disappeared.

Slowly, margiis were increasing in numbers. Baba started traveling by train from one place to another. Once He visited some city of Bihar, and we all went to see Him. A very large crowd was there to see Baba, and I was a little girl. The crowd pushed me on

to the track, and I fell down. No one was able to see me there. My father was speaking with Baba inside the train. All of a sudden the train started. At that moment my mother saw me. But because she was in a panic, she could not speak or shout. She was numb with shock.

All of a sudden, Baba, who was sitting in the compartment, asked my father, “How is Gayatrii, is she OK?”

My father was surprised. Why was Baba suddenly asking about her?

“Yes, Baba, she is OK,” he said. At that moment the signal came on and the train stopped. When the train stopped, my mother came to her senses and shouted, “Gayatrii is there!” Then someone pulled me out. I don’t remember it very clearly, because I was small. But something happened. My parents tell me that Baba saved my life. The train had already started, and exactly at that time He asked my father about me, and the train stopped for a few seconds, and I was rescued.

Once we had an employee named Gaya, a wrestler, very proud of his muscles. He was initiated by my father, and went to Jamalpur to see Baba. He went for field walk with Baba. They came across a small river, and were wondering how to cross it. He said, “Baba, you can sit on my back, I will cross it.”

As Baba got on his back, He asked, “Well, am I heavy?”

Feeling proud, Gaya said, “No, Baba, you are very light. I can carry anything.”

After going a few steps, he felt that something extremely heavy was on his back. He said, “Baba, you had better get down now.”

Baba started laughing. “Oh, am I heavy?” Wherever there is ego, Baba just finishes it.

Giridhara

Warren, Vermont

In November of 1969, I received a postcard from a friend whom I had not seen in a year and a half and had lost track of. The postcard was mailed from India and it said:

When the disciple is ready the Master will appear. Shrii Shrii Anandamurti, the possessor of the eight occult powers is the Master. I will be coming to Boston with a teacher of this meditation, please help me set up lectures.

This postcard was from the person who later became Didi Ananda Mitra. She was the roommate of an early girlfriend. In late March of 1970, Didi called me and said she wanted to bring Acarya Vimalananda Avadhuta to Boston and would I help set up lectures? I was happy to do so.

I had never met a real Indian yogi before, and he was an impressive sight in orange robes and turban. He had great charisma and a wonderful smile that radiated light and peace. You could see that there was something special in his face. Didi scheduled me to learn meditation so in the afternoon of April 3, 1970, I went to be initiated.

I was traveling to the West Coast. A big retreat was scheduled at Desolation State Park on Whidby Island, north of Seattle. There were 96 people registered... most were young students or hippies, though fairly clean as a group. The setting was very beautiful, cabins on a small bay with tall Douglas fir trees climbing the side of a hill. We would sit under the trees with the beautiful smell and terrific view out over the water and he would give philosophy lectures. Once after about an hour and a half lecture in detailed philosophy, Dada said, "You know, philosophy is of no use whatsoever. Its purpose is only to make the intellect content enough to allow you to do your meditation."

At the end of the retreat, Dada decided to do something that he had not done at all yet in the U.S., to lead a collective *Guru Puja*. I remember feeling very clearly as if a weight had been lifted from my shoulders. I felt light and I distinctly felt that I was walking about two inches above the grass. As we were getting into the car to leave, I

remember seeing the blades of grass with a great clarity and I knew that we were very high from this experience.

In the winter of 1971, we planned a retreat at a house outside of Boston. I came down and there must have been 25 new people that came by early evening. It was a very high and inspiring weekend. On Sunday night, I gave a ride back to New Haven to a friend of mine, Yamuna, and several new margiis from there. Even though I should have been tired, I felt very energized and so did my friend. This particular evening, Yamuna started meditation seven minutes before me. I noted on my watch when I set my timer and started my meditation. I remember hearing her timer go off, but I kept meditating. Suddenly, I felt my mind completely disappear... complete nothingness. Then I felt the universe coming back into creation and I felt tremendous waves of bliss. I was crying and experiencing waves of happiness beyond anything I had ever imagined. I cried and felt this for some time. Then I heard my timer. When Yamuna finished her meditation she had opened her eyes and she later said she saw Baba walk into the room and put His hand on my head.

I did not see Baba, I only experienced the *samadhi*. I believe this to have been *Nirvikalpa Samadhi*. From then on, I knew that Baba was my Guru and that He could take me all the way. That certainty has kept me free from any wavering or difficulty my whole margii career. I experienced this directly and I knew that it was related to the wholehearted and intense service that I had done these three days at the retreat. Yamuna was greatly vibrated and moved by the waves of bliss that I experienced. She got something of a contact high from this.

I think it was 1971 when Dada Yatiishvarananda came to the sector. There were three family *acaryas* here who had been keeping things going – Dada Raghawji, Lalji, and another. There were also enough margiis to keep a structure going.

Dada Y first flew into Montreal and I drove up to meet him at the airport. He was so thin. We were all very impressed with his energy. He was very nervous at first. I noticed something when we meditated with Dada that evening. I felt that as he did some lesson (probably 5th) I could feel energy in the room and my own energy go up.

The next day, we returned to Vermont. We had not had a *sannyasi* come to the dome before and we gave him the only bedroom, which was mostly occupied by a large waterbed. I expect that Dada had never seen a waterbed! He closed himself up in the room and did his meditation. We had prepared a dinner, but he never came out and so we eventually went to bed. He had been expecting us to call him for dinner and we had expected him to come out when he was ready. So Dada ended up with no food. He was very hungry and suffered mentally and physically that night, wondering how he was going to eat in this new country.

We arrived at Goddard College in Plainfield, Vermont in the early afternoon. It was a very hot day by Vermont standards and some students were walking around the campus, going to classes, completely naked. We walked onto the campus, and Dada saw this and I could see his mind reeling! So this is America! His mind was completely blown, but he didn't say anything. We went into the hall where he was to lecture and introduced him. Dada asked us to make a rule that anyone getting initiated would have to have clothes on. Dada initiated many people for several hours that afternoon. One of the sisters really got into the meditation. She moved into the *jagrti* and later wrote beautiful devotional songs. Her name was Nayan. I used to sing one of these songs to my daughter to put her to sleep.

In the hush of splendid skies our lord comes
And like a flight of birds his eyes are dancing
And in thy rhythms oh lord we are dancing, we are dancing
And like the planets round the sun
Oh my lord, in thy divine effulgence we are dancing, we are dancing.

Vasant Vashista India

I was initiated in 1964 by my *acarya* Shankarananda Dada, in Rajasthan, in a city called Udaipur, at the residence of Mangal Biharji. I must have been 21 or 22 at that time, and I was not inclined towards spirituality. I wanted to enjoy life.

But I was visiting my mother in Rajasthan, and it so happened that I got my initiation. And after two or three days Baba was coming to Delhi, and so in two or three

days time I got my Personal Contact (PC) in Delhi, for 45 minutes. And after several days, there was a *Dharma Maha Cakra* (DMC) in Jammu. So in a week's time, I had my initiation, PC, and DMC. Things happened very fast for me, I was not ready. I just followed others around.

Before I entered the PC room, I heard that Baba used to punish people with a stick. I was standing outside the room before I could enter. I was not scared. I went in, and did *sastaung* to Baba. He asked me to remove my shirt, and then told me to get a stick from the corner. I understood now it was my turn. So I gave Him the stick and the moment I gave him the stick, I realized that now He would beat me. I started sobbing, crying like I have never cried before. I just gave Him the stick, and then started crying – I could not control my sobs. Baba just touched the stick to me, and said, “I feel like hitting you a lot but I cannot.” In Hindi He said, “Affection stops me from beating you.”

He could not beat me. And then He gave me a lot of love. There were certain promises He asked of me. And He also asked, “What do you want? Tell me what you want and I'll give it to you.” He has kept His promises. What I wanted, He has given. Probably I have not come up to His expectations, what He wanted from me. This is what is in my mind.

PC with Baba for 45 minutes was something I can't forget. After that, the biggest impact came in Jammu. There was not so much rush in those days. My mother said, “Why don't you go and massage His legs?” It was after the DMC lecture, and Baba was taking rest. Anyone could go in. I went there, and I pressed his legs for 15 or 20 minutes. He was lying down. People said that if you massaged His legs, you could smell the smell of sandalwood, so I came back and told my mother that nothing was happening, there was no scent, nothing like that.

But the next day, the day for departure, all of a sudden something hit me. My *ista mantra* started automatically, and it didn't stop for days together. Day and night, I made no efforts to do sadhana.

Now, because the *mantra* was going on nonstop – I was trying to stop, it was not stopping, I'm trying to get out of it, I can't – I went to Delhi. I tried to go to the movies, here, there, but I was not enjoying any of it, because when the *mantra* is going on day and night, nonstop, there is only Baba that you see everywhere and nothing else. And

that's what happened. Baba gives different experiences to different people, and this thing lasted 15-20 days. Probably it could have lasted forever, but when I came back to Bombay, things went back as they were. I can never forget it. I was always naughty, but still I understood that it was only Baba. Baba Nam Kevalam really meant Baba Nam Kevalam, nothing else.

One time I had the chance to go with Baba in Bombay on field walk. I was really free with Baba. Whatever came in my mind, I said.

“Baba, I have a little question.”

“What?”

“I attended DMC in Kolkata, and you gave darshan and DMC speech in Bengali. Everything was in Bengali, and I didn't understand anything, because I don't know Bengali. But still I enjoyed that DMC a lot. Also I attended DMC in Jaipur, and everything was in Hindi. I understood everything but never enjoyed it. Baba, why was it like that?”

Baba said that at the two annual DMCs in Kolkata in May or Anandanagar in December, “People don't come to listen to my speech. There are many books you can read for that, but they come to enter that circumference, that area vibrated during annual DMCs only. People come and the moment they enter that perimeter they start getting peace, because the place is vibrated. In ordinary dharmacakras, the same vibration is not there. That's why you enjoyed in Kolkata.”

There used to be annual DMCs in Kolkata. Tiljala was not built at that time. Baba stayed in a hotel, and from there He would go for His evening and morning walks, and His darshans. One senior margii came to know of the timing of Baba's coming and going. At that time, there were so many people who would just rush to the *pandal* when He was coming out, and you couldn't really be very close to Him, or see Him, or He see you.

So I got a chance to slip into His room, when He went for his walk, and the VSS (Volunteers in Social Service) didn't catch me. Once inside, I was waiting for Baba to come back. He was gone for quite some time, and I didn't know what to do, so I was just playing around with all His things, His glasses, and the jar from which He drank water,

and His seat, sometimes I was doing *sastaunga* there, or doing sadhana. It became dark. I put on the lights, and started doing sadhana in front of Baba's seat.

All of a sudden, the door opened, and Baba entered. The VSS were behind Him. He said, "Vasant?" I said, "Yes, Baba." That was just good enough for me. Then the guards put me out. But my work was over. Because at that time we just wanted Baba to look at us. Even if He would just give us a glance, it was good, and if He would talk to us, it was very good. We didn't want anything more than that. Our visit was successful if He talked or looked at you. Even if the VSS people would say anything to me, I didn't mind.

Prakash

Northhampton, Massachusetts

I had a spiritual seeking in me, but I didn't know I was looking for a guru. I met some friends teaching a yoga class at Dartmouth College, started taking the class, and decided to move in with all these other people who were meditating. Just after I moved in, I went to my first retreat, and that's where I had my first encounter with Baba, in February of 1972. Four or five hundred people showed up at the retreat.

People were telling stories about *kapalik* sadhana – stories of meditating in the graveyard – and something magical happened. In the midst of a snowstorm, with winds howling outside, Madhuri told a story about how Anandamurti got His name.

Once when Baba was young, He attended the wedding of a relative. He got restless and went for a walk in the forest. It was late. A yogi was there, dancing and singing – 'What is my name, I have no name, I'm on the path.' Suddenly he sees Baba and asks Him what He is doing there. Baba replies, 'What you are doing here?' The yogi is charmed by Baba and answers, 'I'm on my way to the graveyard to do the sadhana that my guru taught me.'

'What kind of sadhana is it?' Baba asks. And the yogi explained this sadhana to Baba.

Baba said, 'Very interesting, but it isn't quite right.' So they sat down in the forest, and Baba taught him, initiating him into *kapalik*. He put the yogi into *samadhi*. Baba was sitting there waiting for this yogi to wake up, and finally He said, 'I have to go home.' The yogi, coming to, said, 'You can't leave me, I've been waiting lifetimes for you!'

Madhuri was telling this story, and she was speaking right from her heart, and suddenly a wave of bliss went through the room, and just burst in my heart. I started crying and crying and I didn't know what it was, but I felt that I was home. I started to analyze the wave, and as I analyzed it, it stopped, and then I let go, and it would come again. I'd been involved a lot in the anti-war movement, in which you get really carried away and you get pulled out of yourself, but this was something different. It came from within, like an ocean wave comes up and through and bursts out, and I realized that was

my first realization coming from Baba. Something that Didi said about waiting lifetimes and lifetimes resonated with me. I wanted to know where I was going and what this was all about.

About a year after this I went to graduate school in dance at UCLA. I wanted dance to be about spirituality and service and activism, and there wasn't scope for that at school, for meditation and yoga to be the basis of dance. So finally I dropped out, and went up to the Bay area, and went to LFT training. It was an incredible experience, in March of 1973. By this time I'd been given the name Prakash by Dada Jagadeva, a wonderful man who was very inspiring. My name means light, effulgent like the sun.

The LFT trainers were Madhuri and Giridhara. There were 19 or 20 of us in a very beautiful place in Los Altos Hills, with very intense meditation and stories. We were studying aikido, and psychosynthesis, and we would create dance. We studied the *cakras* and *kosas*, and Madhuri would relate it to Western religion. And she taught us that the way to understand Baba's ideology is to understand how it relates to the society we live in, in a comparative way. She didn't teach us things in isolation. It was not just about memorizing Ananda Sutram, but how to relate it to the practical world. We studied Buckminster Fuller, and psychology and the arts, and it gave us confidence that we could go out and teach people about Baba's philosophy, and relate it to all that we knew, and we could use art and dance.

Eighteen people moving together, getting up early and running, it was incredible. There was a devotional vibration, and wonderful *satsaung*. And we just had this thirst for learning.

I became an LFT. My first posting was amazing, to start an ERAWS (Education, Relief and Welfare) LFT training center in Washington D. C. I went to D. C. for a big demonstration against the Indian government, because Baba was still in jail. There were hundreds of people camped out there. We all stayed in the *jagrti*, with people sleeping on the stairs, camping outside: it was a small property, but a large family. We had done rallies in San Francisco also, meditating in the street. We protested outside the Indian embassy, meditated in the streets, singing kiirtan.

After the demonstrations were over, the training center started. In the mornings I taught people spiritual philosophy, and in the afternoons, Madhuri and Bholanath, the trainers, helped set up internships throughout the D.C. area. We worked with the Black Panthers, in soup kitchens, in schools, doing all sorts of social service. The idea was to train people in the spiritual philosophy and to give them practical experience, and set up social service projects all around the country. I taught the way I had learned from Didi; I had all her notes. That's when I really learned the ideology. I had to be established in my practices because I was teaching people.

Manoranjan

San Francisco, California

My experiences with Baba go back to before I became involved with Ananda Marga. In this lifetime my spiritual awakening occurred fortunately or unfortunately through drugs. Any time I would use them I would have a spiritual experience. Sometimes my experience would become very confusing – I would have *siddhis*, in terms of telepathy and precognition. It was confusing to me. Sometimes I would become very disoriented.

I began to experience a voice inside. If I listened to the voice, things would become settled, and I would fight my way back again. The voice would say, “You shouldn’t take these things.” And I would say OK. But after some time it would become attractive and I would take it again. And the same disoriented feeling would come – reality would become confusing.

I was going deep in my mind, having profound experiences and not really understanding what was happening. I began to depend on the voice, though I didn’t know what to call it. At first I thought it was my grandfather, as it was a very loving thing. Your father wants you to do certain things, but your grandfather is older, and it’s more an unconditional type of relationship.

So I thought maybe it’s my grandfather, who was dead. Then I thought, “No, this is too heavy, too intense. I don’t know, maybe it’s Jesus.” The voice would always rescue me, and sort of chide me, “You should stop taking these things.”

But drugs were very stimulating to me. I had a spiritual hunger, but I had no direction. In 1970, I decided to travel; I was 19. I met someone in Luxembourg who gave me some LSD, and then I was in Valencia, Spain, and took some of it, and had a very intense experience, very difficult. A soldier was very unpleasant with me with his machine gun. It was quite scary. I was walking back to my hotel and suddenly it was like the world stopped. Everyone on the street – people, cars – stopped.

But inside my head the voice said, “I’ve told you for the last time! Stop taking this!” The voice was giving me a good spanking.

“Do you want me to test you? Should I throw you out in the street? I’ve told you for the last time.”

Then suddenly it all stopped, and cars started going again. I went back to my hotel room, and cried for hours, “I just want to be good boy.”

I was planning to go to Morocco and get into other mischief. But that was kind of a turning point for me. So I went back north and bought a book on yoga in Switzerland. It was mostly about hatha yoga, but it also talked about raja yoga and guru. So I decided to go to India, to see if I could find my guru. So many things happened. So-called coincidences occurred. It was like I was a little ant, and situations guided me this way and that way.

I thought when I got to India everything would be nice and peaceful. Ha! What a joke. Things were very difficult, there was so much cultural clash, and I said, “Well, I’ll go to Ranchi, and if things don’t work out there, I’ll wire for money to fly home.” I went for chai with one of the fellows at the hostel, totally in the bowels of Delhi, a place difficult to find. We’re drinking tea, and someone entered the tea shop, and he knew the fellow I’m with.

He said, “Oh, I just came from the Ananda Marga ashram in Ranchi.” In that moment I had a kind of déjà vu. It was like a stream of images, like a flip book, going through my mind. I couldn’t speak. It was a realization. It was obvious to me, that this was the voice. “OK, take me,” I said. So much time passed while I was in this state, a few minutes.

I took initiation in Delhi at R. Prasad’s house. I don’t remember the *acarya*’s name. I got *nama mantra*. I met Yatiishvarananda on his way to the U. S. Then we went to Ranchi. The week after my *diiksa* was a very intense time. I wanted to have Personal Contact, but I was a brand new margii. In the ashram, Baba’s darshan room was one room in the corner of the school. Mukul and I lived on the stage, behind the curtain. I couldn’t go in for darshan because I hadn’t had PC, but I would go out and sit outside the wall, with Baba on the other side, as close as I could get to Him, even closer than most of the people in the darshan hall. And I would think about Baba being on the other side of this wall.

Pranavananda was Office Secretary at the time. Every day I would go to him and say, "I'd like to get PC."

He would give me these questions. "Why are you here?"

"Oh, I came to learn yoga."

"Go back to the U.S., you can learn yoga there!"

So he would give me these tests. But I stayed. One day I came and said I want to have PC. And he said, "OK." I lit up. And he said, "But first go meditate for 24 hours."

And I was like, that's pretty funny! He was smiling, but he's serious. And I was like, "You're out of your mind. I can't even sit still for ten minutes!" [laughs]. Nonetheless I resolved to do the best I could. I went down by the lake and started meditating. I meditated for part of that day, and then the next day some more. At a certain point, I just couldn't meditate any more. The first part of the meditation I was so angry with him, but by the end I was so grateful to him, because I'd pushed through to a different state of awareness.

I came back, he looked at me and said, "OK, come on." I had heard from Mukul about his PC. Apparently he had done some unscrupulous things in his life, and Baba beat him with His stick pretty soundly. I was a little nervous, but went in anyway. Baba had me sit in front of Him. He was asking me questions that seemed a little silly. I thought, "Why are you asking? You know everything."

"Where are you from? Are you a student?"

And I said, "Baba, I'm a student of life!"

And Baba got this look on his face like he'd bitten into the most sour fruit [laughs]. Then He just sort of went on.

"Have you been a good boy?"

Of course, I'm thinking of everything I'd ever done bad. "No, Baba."

"Do you deserve punishment?"

"Yes, Baba." He has this little bamboo stick.

"Take off your shirt. Raise your arms."

Now I was really scared, standing there with my eyes closed, sweat just pouring off me, waiting. And I heard this whooosh, the stick swishing through the air, but it didn't hit me. Still I had my eyes closed, I was shaking because I was tense. Again, whhooosh.

Still He didn't hit me. Again. I was thinking, "Oh Jesus, He's just been taking warm-up swings, He's going to kill me." I don't know what He thought of that. He must have been really amused.

Then He said, "OK, put your shirt back on." Oh, I must have been a good boy. So that was my punishment, just the suggestion of it. He had me come sit on His lap. He's looking at me, and says, "Come on, smile!" [laughs]. Baba took His fingers and poked my mouth into a smile. I couldn't keep looking in His eyes, it was too intense. I was just sitting there in awe. He was talking to me so sweetly.

"Lead a valuable life. Do something for humanity."

Then He touched me at different points on my chest; I felt like I was a little machine and He was adjusting the dials on me for how I was supposed to go. That was it, a sweet experience.

One night in darshan He was talking about *Parama Purusa* and the permanent abode. He called on me, "Little boy, where are you from, where is your home?"

Immediately I formulated this whole thing to say where I'm from; I was kind of a young hippy kid. I was going to say, Portland, Oregon, United States, North America, Earth, Solar System, the Universe. And I had this whole thing in my mind, so I started out, "Portland, Oregon," and He cut me off.

"He thinks his home is in Portland, Oregon?"

And then He shot me this look, and the exchange was, you think you're clever, but don't be so clever. He didn't say it out loud, but that was the understanding I had. I knew He knew. It was obvious He was cutting me off.

I went back to India again in 1980. At that time Baba was in Kolkata. All these dadas were asking, "When did you arrive, have you had PC yet?" No, not since I arrived! Still being clever. So all these dadas were trying to get PC for me. I never lied, but thought maybe I could get PC again.

Baba was going for field walks, coming and going from the gardens. But PC wasn't happening. I always bought flowers and went to Baba's room in Jodhpur Park and put fresh flowers there every day. Because I knew He knew I was doing this. So every

day I was going to His house, going to darshans. After a week or two, I was getting a little discouraged. One night I was so tired, lying in my hotel bed. It was time to go, but I was so tired.

Then the voice in my head said, “Come on, why not try?” Alright, I got up, took a bath, put on clean clothes, bought a garland, and went to Baba’s house. I was waiting. There was no one there. No margiis, only one dada. I was the only one. Baba came for field walk. So, we went for field walk, Baba and I.

I kind of understood – you don’t get a second personal contact, but... We had kind of an understanding. So we drove out to the lake, and He went for His walk. And an interesting thing happened. We were walking, and a car pulled up. It was mysterious. Why is that car there? The thought came to my mind, that this could be a dangerous situation. I had some proficiency in martial arts. So, I was ready to give my life right then and there, for Baba. This whole drama happened and my response to it was in my mind. In retrospect my understanding was that it was Baba’s gift to me, that He structured this little event. And I connected with a place of courage within myself. There was no thought, just duty. He revealed something of myself to me.

We were really not talking too much. I was giving some thought to becoming an *acarya*, even though I was married. I didn’t want to come right out and ask Him. You ask Him advice, and He won’t give you the answer. But in a roundabout way I asked Him, since I knew there was a training center in Kathmandu.

I said, “Baba, I’m interested to know if Kathmandu is a good place for me?” He looked at me, stopped walking and turned, and said, “The whole world is a good place for you.”

Then we set off walking again. So I was no closer to the answer to my question. We didn’t talk much. I remember the experience with the car, the question, and He using a white towel to wipe His face of perspiration. I couldn’t formulate any questions. It was His gift to me; I didn’t need anything else. It just felt kind of complete. To me it was really special. No one else at Baba’s house? How often does that happen?

In a DMC, I was supposed to take Baba’s photo. It was known I was a photographer, so I was supposed to take Baba’s picture during the darshan. And it was

such a difficult thing. Because all these dadas, half of them were saying, “Come on, take it, take it!” and the other half were saying, “Sit down, sit down!”

Take it, take it! Sit down, sit down! So I was having maximum clash. I was supposed to be taking Baba’s photo, and there were 15,000 people in the tent. I was getting maximum clash, and no matter what, I couldn’t do the right thing. Arrghh! So finally, at the end, I took my photos, and then Baba stood up and did namaskar to the whole crowd. I took a photo, and then He turned around and did namaskar right to me. And my hands jumped. You know how in Zen archery, the whole idea is there’s no mind, no thought, and my hands were like that. The camera was in my hand, Baba did namaskar, and Baba took this photo. I had no thought involved in taking that photo. And the understanding came, Yes, yes, you had so much difficulty, and you persisted. You kept your mind in the right frame. It was like an acknowledgement. Good job, Manoranjan.

I find Baba’s presence in my life now in so many small ways. I think really it’s the small ways that are the most endearing, because I feel so taken care of. He looks after me in the tiniest ways – little things. He takes care of me. Perhaps you could say these things happen in every person’s life. And it’s true. God is in contact with each of His created entities. He has that personal relationship, and those experiences are there for everyone to become aware of. But Baba has helped me to become aware of these things. They may be there for everyone, but not everyone is aware of them. Just silly things, like leaving the house, and out of the blue, a voice comes, don’t forget such and such. Why did it come in my mind? It’s the same as the voice, “I told you to stop taking that.” Baba continues to be present, guiding me in little ways. Big ways too, but it’s actually the little ways that are sweeter. He takes care for even trivial things.

Dharmaputra

Ananda Kanan, Missouri

I was initiated by Dada Vimalananda in a simple little house in San Francisco in 1969.

As I was growing up I remember a constant feeling of frustration. It was like I couldn't find any truth or reason behind things. I had a lot of trouble with the authority of my parents, teachers and other adults. I'm sure all kids felt this but I was extreme about it and it gave me a lot of trouble. It was mostly through music and the writings of some great thinkers that I first caught some glimpses of universal truths that rang true to me. I realized there was truth in the world but I was having trouble finding it.

I didn't believe in the God that was being shown to me through church, etc. In fact, I was incredibly angry with this so-called God. I used to curse Him in the privacy of my bathroom, shaking my fist at the ceiling and crying, "How could you create a world like this without any truth that makes sense to me?" I would blame Him for all the troubles I used to get in. I used to ask parents and teachers WHY a lot. And the answer, "Because I said so" or "God will punish you" only made things worse.

When I was 17, I had a drowning experience. I broke the first two rules of body surfing, which was going out alone and during a storm. The waves and swells were monsters, of 10, 20, even 30 feet. Before I realized what was happening the rip tides were carrying me out to sea. I had no choice but to ride the waves directly into the rocks and try to cling on for life. For 45 minutes I struggled with every ounce of my strength against the monster waves. Many times I smashed against the rocks and was flushed up and down in 20 to 30 feet of water like a giant toilet. Then for the hundredth time, as I was under 30 feet of water and was so weak I couldn't even move my arms, I started to lose consciousness. That would have been the end.

Suddenly everything changed. All the tension and worry disappeared and I forgot who I was, where I was, or that I was in the ocean drowning. I felt a warm, friendly 'Something' out in front of me... like a friend or a father welcoming me. I started to merge into a beautiful, warm white light. As I was enjoying the wonderful safety of that light and at the very last possible second I had to remain alive, some invisible force

reached out and stopped the waves. Just as I was about to take my last breath and inhale water, the waves stopped and the water washed back out to sea. I looked down and saw that I was standing on the sand. I somehow crawled up the rocks. Then, the very second I made it to safety the waves came crashing back in full force

In shock and disbelief, I looked around half expecting to see WHO it was who had stopped the waves and saved my life. As if there was someone was up on the cliff watching... with his finger on a wave machine. It was completely obvious to me that there was some Great Force in the world watching at that moment. I felt that the personal hand of God had saved me. Why, I didn't know. From that moment on I started to think more and more about God and felt that He wasn't something far off in the sky but somehow, was VERY close to me. It became a very personal thing for me. For many years, I didn't tell my family. I kept it to myself but used to remember it when I felt sad, alone or confused. It gave me great strength and hope then and still does.

One of the first places I heard the universal truths that I felt were missing from my life was in the words and music of Bob Dylan. To me they opened up a whole new way of thinking and understanding. They helped me to relate to some of the confusion I was feeling. He showed that a person could have deep, moralistic thoughts and feelings, and be cool at the same time. In fact he showed that true understanding and insight was REAL freedom and the coolest thing of all. He certainly wasn't a goody-goody and his personal life and actions weren't the best of examples, but in his honest, simple and straightforward style he accomplished a tremendous amount of work and his voice was heard around the world. I feel he helped advance collective consciousness in many ways.

Shortly after that I found some book written by Albert Einstein that really blew me away. Then I came across yoga books by Patanjali and Yogananda and read them and practiced those techniques for about two years. Then I came in contact with Ananda Marga. And I really felt I had gotten close to where I wanted to be. It was there that I first saw with my own eyes a spiritually vibrated person. That was Madhuri, who now is Didi Anandamitra. She had just returned from being with Baba and she was GLOWING with spiritual energy and bliss. It was undeniable. Right after initiation I felt different and in only three days I was able to walk away from and forget all the persistent bad habits that

had been smothering me all my youth. They just disappeared as if they had never happened.

But I still couldn't accept the idea of a guru. I thought the spiritual path was something I could just read about, and practice and realize on my own. I accepted the fact that some great entity would have to tell me how to do it, but then I was on my own. The idea of another human being that I was supposed to surrender to and put all my faith in was totally against my instincts.

I'd been in Ananda Marga for two years, and a reason came up for me to go to India. Dada Yatiishvarananda needed someone to go for AMURT work in Bangladesh and I thought, "OK, I can go and do this AMURT work and while I am there I can see Baba." This was late 1970 and things in India were already in chaos.

I attended my first darshan with Baba. I was around a corner in an L-shaped room but I couldn't really see Him. I could hear him talking and there was all this excitement and people were going into *samadhi*. I felt comfortable and safe, out and away from all the drama around the corner; I wasn't ready to be that close.

I went for Personal Contact on Christmas Eve Day. There were four or five of us. We had to wait outside this room. We were told to take a bath, and wear clean clothes. We were meditating on the verandah and I felt I had opened and cleared my mind and was trying not to have any preconceived ideas about guru, Baba etc. I was hesitant about the idea of guru but everyone around me was so into it and they were such beautiful and trustworthy people that I thought I should go along with it and see what was there.

As I was sitting there after my meditation some mysterious person walked by carrying a magazine and somehow it just floated down into my hands. I see now it was a cosmic set-up by Baba. It was an article from India Today, in their words "exposing" Shrii Shrii Anandamurti. They were claiming all these horrible things about Baba, saying He captured and kidnapped young people, brainwashed them and turned them into mindless orange zombies. All the fears and doubts I had about Guru completely came to the surface and took over my mind. It was like pouring gasoline onto smoldering coal. I was feeling all this darkness and rage and hate. My whole life I'd always hated the idea of falsehood, from politicians to preachers, always hated the abuse of power. How Baba knew this and brought it to the surface so forcefully is beyond comprehension.

So I was sitting there in mental chaos and I heard my name, “Dharmaputra, GO, it’s your turn.”

I thought, “Oh my God, NO, not NOW. Give me a moment to get my head together.” But they were pushing and pulling “Come on, come on, go, go, go now.” As I was getting up, one brother was coming out of the PC room having just seen Baba with a big smile and watery tears flowing down his face. And I was thinking... “You fool, you idiot, you sissy wimp, don’t you KNOW? How could you be so easily misled?”

At that moment I thought the LAST thing I EVER wanted to become was some blissed-out, spaced-out margii with big silly tears rolling down his cheeks.

I was being pushed into the PC room and my mind was so twisted with anger, hatred and fear that the room appeared as a long tunnel with Baba at the end and I could feel the walls closing in on me. Baba was sitting there. I went through the motions and did *sastaung pranam*. I sat up but couldn’t look at Him. I was thinking in my mind, “If you try ANYTHING, any sly little tricks to control or brainwash me, I’m going to know it and then I’m out of here. I’m not going to let it happen.”

Baba said nothing. He was so calm and composed. Then I felt His hand come over and gently, yet firmly, grab the top of my head. His strong fingers pressed against my skull. There was a vibration and for a second I felt weightless as if I was floating. Then He said some Sanskrit words and with a slight jerk and push He pulled His hand away.

I still had all this doubt in my mind but I finally looked up at Him. He had the most amazing peaceful and beautiful and unassuming smile on His face. And then, with His eyes and a slight movement of His head, He very clearly indicated to me, “Go now.”

I thought, “That’s it? That’s all there is to it? This is what I spent my WHOLE life preparing for? Where is the *samadhi*? Where are the visions of past lives on the wall?” Again, with this beautiful smile He gestured to go out, as if saying, “It’s OK, don’t worry, just go now and don’t be afraid... It’s not over yet”

I left and went by myself to think about what had just happened. And standing there, numb, in that smoky Indian afternoon light just looking out in the distance, slowly an incredible feeling of empowerment and conviction came over me. I realized that very soon I would find out who Baba was. If He really were a corrupt individual I would come

to know it and be able to accept that truth no matter what it meant. In fact I actually wanted to give up the idea of guru once and for all. So much responsibility goes along with having a guru, I thought. Who needs it? The conviction I felt made me feel liberated and free.

“I can do my meditation, my yoga asanas, I know those are good for me, and I will find out for sure just WHO this Baba really was. For SURE I will find out.” I now had a mission. And I thought how to do that was through reading His books. So I figured that I would just do my meditation and read Baba’s books with a calm, clear mind and like a great detective I would look for any signs of evil intentions. And over the next few days whenever I read a page or two of something Baba had written I thought, “That is so good, so wonderful and helpful.”

Then on Dec. 28, as I was traveling on a train to the *Dharma Maha Cakra* being held Varansi, I finished reading a couple of paragraphs in *One Human Society* and it just struck me. “Wow, this is not only the most far-reaching truth I have ever read, this is way beyond what I thought could ever be put into words... such magnificent, benevolent compassion. No ordinary human being could ever think that far and have such deep understanding of humans and their plight here in this life on this planet.”

I closed my eyes and right away it was as if it was night and I was floating in deep, deep space with stars all around me. I was thinking, “Wow, this is what I’ve ALWAYS wanted to do, to just jump and float into space with all the stars around me on all sides.” It was even more Real than the world as we see it every day and not like a dream at all. It was the most real experience I have ever felt. I could feel the vastness of the void and deep space. It felt so natural and wonderful and refreshing.

And then I noticed this bubble rising out of the void. As if you were looking into the vast night sky and a huge moon was rising. Then I saw the glasses, and the eyes, and a face, and it was Baba’s face. Although my only thought was, “It’s HIM! The greatest, most magnificent entity in the universe!” He was so huge out there. As He was rising up and out of the deep void, He was getting larger and larger. Then as He was about waist high, He started looking around as if He was looking at every individual in creation and

checking on their welfare and progress. I could feel His eyes coming my way and I could tell I was next. I almost felt the urge to hide. It was so powerful but there was nowhere to go. His eyes came upon me and looked straight at and into me. There was an incredible twinkle of Love and Recognition. HE SAW ME! HE KNOWS ME! It was so powerful. I knew I was His and He was mine. My Absolute Forever Father.

He continued to move up and up and grow larger and larger filling the entire universe. My eyes didn't want to leave His face. It was so attractive and dear to me. Then, as He was rising all I could see was His shoulders, so broad and strong and covered in white loose cloth. Then only His chest was in view, then His waist, then His wonderful, strong hands and I wanted to jump and hold them but by then He was rising faster and faster and I couldn't grab them. Then all there was, was His legs, then ankles, then His feet... his FEET. "The feet of GOD!" I thought, and wanted to hold on to them. They seemed so incredibly majestic and important to me. Then He popped through some kind of layer and all of a sudden I could hear and see all this noise and confusion. And then somehow, mixed in with all that, were all the rumors and the blah blah blah about Baba.

And the thought occurred to me that it was nothing more than the dust under His Holy feet. His mind and purpose and Mission were so far above and beyond anything anyone could say for or against Him. And He was as unconcerned about the scorn as He was about the praise that people were bestowing on Him.

Then the train jerked and I bumped my head against the rail car and I came back to this world and started laughing and laughing. Baba was so great and almighty that anything anyone could say about Him was just like the dust under His feet. And I had to laugh at the silliness of the thought, that "I" was going to determine WHO this Magnificent Baba really was, and "I" was going to do it with a little pea for a brain!

Then I had to laugh again as I remembered and realized that now here "I" was... a blissed-out, spaced-out margii with big silly tears rolling down my face!

But now I felt a powerful desire to touch Baba's Holy feet. In the Personal Contact room I had been so close to Him but my mind had been poisoned with confusion. Now I understood that like a Cosmic Homeopathic Doctor, Baba had given me a good dose of the same poison that was already in my mind. So that when I went through the

sickness I could understand, by myself, in my own way, what Guru was to me. What patience and compassion He had, that He could forego looking good to me, for my own benefit. That was so amazing and beyond my human comprehension.

Then we found out that Baba had been arrested and I spent the next four months traveling in India waiting for Him to come out. The thought was constantly in my mind about Guru's feet. I was being tormented by the thought that I would leave India without seeing Him again. The only thing I wanted to do before I left India was to be in His presence with a clear mind and touch His feet. It's funny that before my experience the LAST thing I could EVER think of doing would be to touch someone's feet. It was not even in my culture. It sounded so brainwashed and bad.

Then on my very last day as I was getting ready to leave we were told that Baba would sometimes come out and sit on the verandah at the hospital where He was staying under armed guard. We were allowed to quietly sit below and watch Him as He came out for an hour or so of fresh air.

I was thinking, "Baba, this is my LAST day and you are up there and I am down here, and I so much want to be in your presence, closer to you, and to touch my Guru's feet before I leave."

Then some unseen force opened my eyes and I was looking straight at Baba. He quickly turned His head and looked directly at me. And out of nowhere that same unseen force made me stand up and I started walking towards the stairs that lead to Him.

I'm not a brave person for this kind of thing but I somehow managed to walk right up to the guards and I handed them my new ballpoint pen. I was told at one time that American ballpoint pens were greatly valued in India by everyone as in 1971 they were quite rare. Before anyone could say anything I kept walking past the guards and ran up the stairs. While walking down that long hallway to Baba, there was so much hurry and anticipation in my mind that it felt like there were flames all around me. When I made it to Baba I just jumped and prostrated myself into the safety of His shelter and did *sastaung pranam*. Then I did *guru puja*. When I finished I opened my eyes and right there, six inches from my face was His right foot. And I just reached out and held it. Then I touched my head to it. No words could ever describe the incredible softness and velvety texture of His foot. Nothing on this planet could ever come close to that feeling. It was

truly heavenly – from another dimension. Baba had known and fulfilled my wish.

Dada Shivananda was there, and he suggested that I travel with him to South India while I was waiting. I had heard a little bit about him. Another *avadhuta* said, “Do you know whom you’re traveling with? This is Shivananda, who used to meditate for 24 hours a day.” Dada told me a story, about how he was meditating ten hours a day, twelve, fourteen, and each day he’d do more and more. At one point he went into *samadhi* 24 hours a day. Baba knew this, and sent some *acaryas*, and told them how to bring him back to this world, to lay him down and pour cold water on his navel. And they sent him back to Baba, who said, “You’ve done enough meditation, now you have to do service.”

What he was doing at first was just going around and touching people, showing them God. Apparently he did a lot of that in South India, because wherever we went, people were laying down in *sastaung pranam* to him. But he would say, “No, no, Baba is your guru.” Baba told him, “You are confusing people, they need to work for their *samadhi*, so stop that.”

The first time I saw him, he was talking to someone, and he stopped and turned his head and said to me, “Do you remember the time you were...” and he started bringing up these things in my mind. It was like he was going in my mind and pulling up something and bringing it out, and with his intuitive power of observation, he was helping me see it for what it was. He did it for my heavy *samskara* of being a bad boy. I’d been getting into trouble my whole life. Plus, I always felt self-conscious about my height. And those are two things that he brought up and after that they no longer bothered me. Another dada told me later, “he’s not supposed to do that.”

In one town, there was a professor who had been with Baba since the beginning. One room in his house where Baba stayed was now a meditation room. We went in to do *sadhana* there, and 45 minutes went by, then an hour. I had never really meditated that long up till then. Two hours went by, then two and a half hours and no one was moving and I was thinking, “How am I going to get out of this?”

Right around three hours I slipped into a place out of this world. And it was like I was trying to climb onto the lap of some Great Entity. There was so much love coming

from this entity but at the same time I was feeling all of the things that I had ever done wrong. I could see ALL of them in front of me like one flowing action. This entity was pulling me up but I was feeling so guilty about all the bad things I had done in my past that they were like a big weight holding me back

He was pulling me up onto His lap with love and giving me a blessing and showering me with the grace of His understanding and saying, “I know why you did all these things. It was because you didn’t know that WE were ONE. You didn’t know that I existed, and that made you feel so bad and angry, that it caused you to rebel against everything else, because in your heart “I” was the most important Goal and without ME, life wasn’t worth anything! So actually, you were always doing RIGHT, by demanding that I show myself to you, or else the world could go to Hell. You are my “most loving son.”“

I was crying, feeling, “How could you ever love me so much?” Everything I’d done was nothing to Him; the only thing that was important to Him was me.

I’d always had a hard relationship with my father because of my bad boy attitude. But the first thing I experienced when I came down was that this was my father was so upset, because he didn’t know. It’s impossible to explain the connection there. But for the first time I understood why my father felt the way he did. When I came back to the U.S. I didn’t have that bad boy complex anymore. And my father was so amazed at how much I had changed.

After the meditation, we went in to eat, and I was so high and in such a different space that the food was heavy for me. I should not have eaten. But they fed us so much food, and I found myself eating two, three courses. The food felt like lead going into me. I instantly felt heavy and sick. I was feeling like I was going to die. I felt so terrible. It was hot. We were sitting around and I heard Dada Shivananda saying to me, “Just do your *mantra*. Whenever you feel any way, just repeat your *mantra*.” And I could hear my *mantra* getting louder in my mind. He repeated this, and it was like my *mantra* was shouting within my mind. And it pulled me right out of my sickness. After five minutes it was completely gone. I felt so light after that, like my food was completely digested.

Dr. Ram

Largo, Florida

I was initiated by Dada Vimalananda in 1969 in St. Louis, and then followed up by Dada Yatiishvarananda-ji afterwards.

Let me say a few words about my Personal Contact (PC). In 1971, I was in St. Louis. We were having a meeting at Dr. Danjoo Ghista's apartment. Ravi Batra also was there. Danjoo told me he had a dream that I was going to India. I had never thought about going, because I was a new margii, just initiated for a few months. Somehow everything happened so quickly, that within a few days I was in Delhi. From Delhi to Kolkata I had tremendous struggle to get an airline ticket, as the airlines were on strike. On reflection I think Baba put me to many tests, many obstacles on the way to see how much desire or will I had to reach all the way to Kolkata. I was supposed to go to Ranchi and I took a slow night train. In my second-class compartment, there were two youngsters, one from the Philippines, another from France. We were not talking to each other, everyone was afraid to talk, because of visa restrictions, and so forth. Later I found they were going to see Baba also.

Baba was not giving PC until my last of maybe five days in Ranchi. The day before the PC, we had *dharmacakra* in front of Baba. He was sitting at the podium, in a small classroom; 50 or 60 people were there doing kiirtan, which I had never heard before. And I heard later that Baba introduced kiirtan. People were singing Baba Nam Kevalam and jumping up and down; there was no rhythmic movement like there is now. I didn't know what to do, I tried to imitate the others; no one had explained it to me. After Baba gave darshan, the next day I had PC. Maybe I was expecting too many things in the PC, like many margiis who heard many miraculous things.

So I was slightly disappointed. I don't want to go into the details, but when I was about to leave the room, He called me back. He was smiling broadly, and said, "You have a question in your mind, whether to stay in India and practice medicine, or go back to America." He said, "You should go back to America and settle there permanently."

Baba's statement was very true. I did have that for a while in my mind. I'd been away from India for five years already. So later my U.S. citizenship became permanent.

Next time I saw Baba physically was in Fiesch. Several margiis from California went in 1978; we made the trip together with Dada Shantabodhananda. Baba was giving PC and people were sitting in line. I was in the line with Kirit, and Baba stopped the line before Kirit. We then followed Baba to Mainz, Germany. We were there a couple of days, Baba giving PC, and the PA told me, you should also sit. I thought he knew I had PC before. Anyway, I sat in the line and my turn came and I went in to see Him. Afterwards, I realized Baba pretended like He never met me before, asking what my name was, etc.

He talked for a long time about the languages of South India, where I came from, Kankuni and Pulu. These are several hundred languages there. Baba had never been to that province. But He knew about the history of those languages, and the script they were using. One was my mother tongue. I spoke Kankoni, a derivative of Sanskrit, totally a Dravidian language, and Baba seemed to know all about those languages. Then He asked me what my hometown, Urapi, was famous for. “A Krsna temple,” I told Baba, but He gently shook His head. Then I thought for a while, and I said, “It’s famous for cooking.” Baba said, “Yes,” and He smiled. Urapi Brahmins were noted for being great cooks. I was single for a long time, and I used to cook for the margiis , as one of my hobbies. I don’t know if Baba was connecting me with that or not.

And I noticed He did not do certain processes that are done in PC, but He blessed me. Then I thought maybe Baba didn’t know I had had it before. But a year later, my brother, who was also a margii, saw Baba in India, and Baba told him he had seen me in Germany. My brother looks quite different from me. Baba knew everything. He said, “You are the second born and got initiation next, and he was the first born and got initiation first.” So Baba would also be pretending sometimes.

Baba loves devotees so much. It’s not possible for devotees really to reciprocate. You always wonder at how little you are able to reciprocate. Sometimes Baba creates circumstances just to please you, and other times He does such great things for you, the devotee, yet He won’t appear as directly responsible for it. And sometimes you realize this years later, but you won’t know it at the time. In that way Baba is a pretender.

I tried to go into medical practice in Palo Alto, but was not successful, so I closed that practice after six months. I had some brand new EKG equipment that I gave to

Kolkata Dada, for Baba. I knew Baba had some abnormality in His electrocardiogram, and I thought perhaps it could be in His house and they could use it to check Him.

When I went to India the following year I heard from Dada that Baba was asking them, “Why you are not doing EKG on me?” every day scolding them. The problem was I did not know the electric cycle was different in Kolkata, and it needed an adaptor. So I went with Dada to the market and went to many shops. Finally we found an adaptor. Finally an EKG was done on Baba with that machine. He wanted me to feel good about it, to make His son happy, His devotee happy. He never had an EKG afterwards, He was making all those scenes just for me.

And another thing, Baba had some eye problems. Dada Shamitananda from Ananda Kanan was sending medicines. I was buying medicines and he was shipping them to Kolkata. Three times we sent eye ointment; that was the request specifically, that Baba needs antibiotic ointment. And the second time I thought this was excessive and harmful to use antibiotic eye ointment, so I wrote a letter and told Shamitananda that it has side effects and it was not a good idea. But why did they not consult an ophthalmologist? The next time when Shamitananda called, he said Baba was using so many tubes of it, and to please send more. So I thought maybe Baba had dry conjunctiva which is not uncommon in older age. I included one tube of artificial tears which keeps the eye moist, also in ointment form. And when Baba used this, He said, “I want to use only this one, not any of the others.”

It is strange why Baba waited so long. He knew what was going on, He knew His own people around Him were adding to the problem. I heard the same thing when He had a foot problem; they were going on with homeopathy and naturopathy, and not using allopathy. Finally Baba scolded them, “Call an allopathic physician.” And when he came, the foot was getting gangrene and they had to do minor surgery, and treat a sugar problem also. So Baba lets things happen, roll, to work out naturally. I felt good that He was using continuously the artificial tears, the thing He needed all along. I think we were not really taking care of Baba. Although it was not that easy, because He was playing a great drama also.

Madhusudan

Charlotte, North Carolina

I was initiated in April 1971 in Philadelphia. A lecture was held at an old Quaker church. I went because my roommate who had some contact with margiis told me there would be some realized soul who can answer all your problems. I was having a lot of problems at that time.

I was very opposed to yoga and meditation and used to argue with people about how useless it was. I was in a very contemplative mood, and my roommate said, “Why don’t you come?” and I thought, “Well, why not? I’m not going to join, I’m just going to watch.”

As soon as I walked in the building – the retreat had not even started yet – I was hit by this vibration that I couldn’t understand. It was like going through a door into another universe. All of a sudden you’re in the clouds. It was something very strange. I started talking with margiis, and I was so inspired by them, and thought, “I don’t know who these people are and what they are doing, but they must be doing something right.”

I had been studying philosophy for years in college and I had come up with some new theories of philosophy no one in college could understand, even my professor. And talking to the margiis they were already talking about the same ideas I had.

Here was a whole organization dedicated to the principles I had somehow come up with. I was overwhelmed. But I couldn’t understand any thing about meditation and yoga, it didn’t make any sense to me. I was waiting for this holy man to show up and solve all my problems. I expected a man in robes with a long gray beard. But the acarya was a family man, in a business suit, carrying a briefcase. It was very strange. I didn’t want to do anything. Kiirtan – what was this crazy dance? Meditation, it just gave me a headache. Finally I gave in and went for initiation. I was last in the line. The old margiis were coming for lesson review. They were going in to sit with Ac. Raghava-ji. It was hot and uncomfortable. I didn’t know what I was doing there. Finally I got initiation. That afternoon we went and sat in the graveyard and did meditation, which I thought very strange. The thing that really impressed me was a lecture on *Yama and Niyama*. I thought this was a revolutionary organization; if people followed these principles, capitalism was

going to die. I had been a political activist. They weren't talking about Prout in those days, but *aparigraha* inspired me.

The retreat was over, and I went back, and got really frustrated with the political movement. I hadn't gone to *dharmacakra* for two weeks after initiation. The unit secretary called me and said they were having Baba's birthday celebration. His name was Satiish, now known as Ac. Shambhushivananda. I didn't really want to go but somehow I went with my roommate to Baba's birthday celebration. We did kiirtan and meditation all day. I can't say I was terribly inspired, but something vibrated in me. But I started going regularly. And a strange thing happened. Whenever I started thinking about something, it would happen. I'd be sitting on the couch, thinking I needed to meet somebody and that person would walk in the door. "This is a very unusual thing, this meditation," I thought.

I graduated, and there was going to be the first sectorial retreat, in Kansas. I wanted to hitchhike across the country, but wasn't really planning to go to the retreat. I went out on the road, and hitchhiked to Boston, and found the *jagrti*, and some good margiis who brought me to the retreat. Dada Yatiishvarananda was there, and he completely changed my life. He said, "You're going to India in December; you're going for teacher training." What? I don't want to be a teacher. I don't even know who Baba is.

Somehow, after the retreat I went to California and lived in the *jagrti* for a couple of months, and somehow in my mind the desire came to go to India. I'm not even sure how I got the money. There was a big plane of margiis going the first week of December, 1971. Most of them were the most established margiis. I was like a baby compared to them. I still didn't know why I was going to India. But I felt I had to do it.

We arrived in Patna, put our bags down, and it was time for general darshan. Baba came out, and sat down on a nice chair. Who is this man? I was looking, looking. In all my travels I had a feeling that Baba was guiding me. But I didn't know who or what was Baba. So the question I had now was, is this the same Baba that has been guiding me? I was trying to get the vibration and feeling, and I say, "Yes, this is the same Baba." Kiirtan was going on. Then the kiirtan stopped, and four brothers came out dressed in lungis, carrying blazing torches and daggers. They started doing *tandava*. Dancers ready!

Baba was in a certain posture. During kiirtan He was looking and smiling, and everybody was in ecstasy. As soon as *tandava* started Baba sat in a very serious pose, holding His head up, and looking under His glasses. Ta ta tin ta, Baba Nam Kevalam.

The second day, Baba Himself explained. He called us all up close, 50 people sitting around Baba's feet. Baba started explaining, "Pull up your lungi or your pants above your knee." He pointed to the part of the foot for each call instruction, Ta Ta din. The forces of darkness versus the forces of light. Life and death. The skull and the torch. Baba said that in a Western country, you can use a plastic skull, or plastic snake, if you like. In the left hand, the force of death, and in the right hand a weapon. The weapon is not the destroyer of life, but it supports life, it's dynamic.

We weren't able to go to morning darshan because Baba said we couldn't until we got PC. Everyone would have to have lessons reviewed, have first lesson, and memorize *Yama and Niyama*, 16 Points, 15 Shiilas and Supreme Command. We'd never heard of some of this before. I was completely clashed. "What is all this stuff? It's not worth it." But everyone else was doing it so finally I got in the flow. I got my first lesson from Dada Pranavananda.

One of the evening darshans was remarkable. It was really special. During *tandava* He was His normal serious self, but during kiirtan Baba would look around and search out each margii and do namaskar, one by one. Oh, that was nice. But I didn't know how I would react if Baba looked at me. I was a little scared. The night before I stood very close to Baba, and Baba asked me, "Did you like the *tandava*?" I was so shocked that Baba would talk to me. To me Baba was something very great, incomprehensible.

Now I started to become tense, agitated. I was watching the daggers and skulls and everything, and thinking, "Who is Baba, really?" Then I saw on the wall above Baba a lizard about a foot long. I had been a little interested in the occult, and the lizard is an occult symbol. And I started to really get afraid. Then the thought came in my mind, like a flash, that Baba is Shiva, come to destroy the world. And I was shaking, terrified.

And just then Baba did namaskar to me and smiled. I don't know what happened. All I remember was, the answer to that statement came in my mind, "Yes, you're right, but don't worry about it, it's OK."

And Baba took all the fear, I had always been worried about nuclear destruction and the end of the world, and all that, and Baba took all of that fear out of my mind. And after that I just started crying uncontrollably for the next couple of hours. I was so overwhelmed. I never forgot that lesson. Baba really took something from me that day, like a big burden.

After that I got PC. We finally passed the test. It was *ekadashi* (fasting day), and we were all lined up waiting to go into Baba's room. And Baba said, "No, let them do their fasting, and the next day they will get PC." We had never done fasting before. A lot of the practices were there, but nothing was very formalized. We had to learn a lot of new things – *laungota*, all these things. The next day – was it Dec. 15? – brothers were going in and coming out with such bliss on their faces. I was really nervous. I got called and went in. Baba gave PC in the *jagrti*, not His house. I went inside and Baba was reclining on the bed.

He said, "Come here, come here, sit down little boy." I didn't want to come so close. I was so nervous, I didn't know what to do.

Then Baba said, "What is your name, little boy? And who is your father?" Why does He want to know who my father is? It was almost like Baba was talking with Himself, and I was just watching.

I said, "You are my father."

And Baba said, "Yes, and you are my son," and He rubbed His hand on my cheeks. I was in some kind of daze. It was the softest thing I had ever felt in my life, almost like wind, not touch.

"Little boy, what do you want to do in this life?"

"I want to do something good, to help people."

"Do you have the moral courage to do this?"

"Yes, Baba." I had no idea what moral courage was and why Baba was asking this question. I learned that later. Baba touched me on the forehead. "OK, you can go."

Was that all? I got up and forgot the door was locked, and it didn't open. The guard on the other side was unlocking, and I was pulling, and the door opened fast and hit me in the head. I turned around and looked at Baba. And Baba had such a compassionate look on His face. It was so funny, so amazing.

And that was it. It was so simple, but those words come back to me all the time. When you try to do something good, you face so many obstacles, and you need moral courage. Those few words were all I needed.

Diinabandhu

Oakland, California

My name is Dale Brazosky. While I was with Ananda Marga, Baba had given me the name Diinabandhu. In 1969, I took what I thought would be a one-year leave of absence from a PhD program – it was actually close to 20 years before I went back to graduate school. I have taken blessings and initiations in those years. Most of my teachers have been from the Tibetan Buddhist tradition.

In 1970 I was on my way to India and right before I went, somebody invited me to meet Vimalananda, who was an Ananda Marga monk in the United States.

I told him that I was visiting India and asked if I could visit Anandamurti and would he be there? He answered, “Oh, there are so many dasas there in India, yes, go ahead, why not?”

My original impulse to visit India was not to see Anandamurti but I’d had this experience and it was in the back of my mind at least to go visit him while I was there.

So I went and spent a month with a very strong yogi in Ceylon and then was drawn very strongly to Tiruvannamalai, the Ramana Marshi ashram. When I arrived, one of the first people I met was an English fellow named Philip, and I said, “What are you doing here? How’d you get here?”

And he said, “Well, I just came back from Ranchi where I was with Ananda Marga.”

And I said, “I was thinking of going to Ranchi.”

He said, “Oh, you must go, you must go!”

I arrived at Ranchi, a very pleasant hill station where the headquarters of AM were located. In the meantime, my legs had become infected with boils and when I arrived at Ranchi I could hardly stand. I was in so much pain. And when I arrived, there were probably a hundred or so *avadhutas* or *acaryas* in the yard dancing in expectation of something or other – remember, I’d just arrived – and some monk came to me and said, “What can I do for you?”

And I said, “Well, the first thing you can do is get me a doctor – I can hardly stand.”

And he said, “Oh, don’t worry about that. What are you doing here?”

I said, “I’ve come to meet the teacher, the guru.” And he said, “Well, OK, fine, there’s a good chance you’ll become a full time *sannyasi*...”

And I said, “I don’t know about that!”

And then suddenly all the monks were drawn to one part of the courtyard where there was a short, immaculately white-dressed man, heavy, you could say even a little fat, maybe 5 feet tall or 5’ 2”. The attention was all focused on Him and He kind of swept through the courtyard towards a car, and when He got in the car these hundred or so monks started chanting, “Baba Nam Kevalam” in some sort of ecstasy. Remember, I’m coming from a path of self-enquiry, which did not have outwardly ecstatic manifestations – inwardly, yes. This Anandamurti, as this gentleman turned out to be, could have been a college professor, could have been a government bureaucrat – in appearance – and yet there was an enormous response to Him just walking through the courtyard.

At that point I was given some medical care for my legs and was told what the procedure was to be given personal contact, which was an audience with Anandamurti. I didn’t pay much attention to the classes on philosophy, I think I memorized something. I got a haircut, my hair was long and matted, and they said if you’re going to see Baba you’re going to have to cut your hair and I figured it’s not such a great sacrifice. So I got a haircut and went in for my initial interview, and there was really an aura of great power – also some humor – but mostly a great power, in Anandamurti.

He said, “I can see that you’re very concerned with your personal liberation but I don’t see anything in your past history that shows you want to dedicate yourself to serving others. Even the higher primates take responsibility for taking care of a family, and you only seem concerned with your own *samadhi* and ecstasy. That’s not very good.”

At this point, I wasn’t uncomfortable, there was just kind of a sense of awe. Anandamurti had an enormous field of power around him. He said, “Are you not my son?” And at that point I was in a sort of state of shock – He could’ve said, “Are you a monkey?” and I would’ve said yes, so I said, “Yes, Baba I’m your son.” He touched me

on my forehead and my heart and said something like, “Now you’ll live to serve humanity.” And that was the end of the audience.

After that there was a group audience – the first one I had been allowed to attend because you had to have a personal interview first. And He immediately said, “Stand up, little boy, young man.”

He asked, “Do you have all the powers of *Parama Purusa*?”

And I said, “No.”

He asked, “Do you want all the powers of *Parama Purusa*?”

I said something like, “I don’t know.” And He called me over and said, “Keep your contact with me and put your other hand out.”

Remember this is the first time I’d been to a group audience, and all the audience was focused on me. And He called an Indian practitioner over, Vijay Kumar, and told me, “Keep your contact with me,” and Vijay took my other hand and there was a bolt of energy and Vijay’s eyes rolled back and he fell to the ground in some sort of trance. Baba looked at me and said, “I thought you said you were an ordinary little boy.” He had asked me if I was an ordinary little boy and I had said yes.

He said, “What I just saw was quite extraordinary. Keep your contact with *Parama Purusa*.” Again there was this identification, which is not unusual in *Tantra*, of the teacher with the almighty himself or herself. It was a little foreign to me, but He said, “You keep your contact with *Parama Purusa* and you’ll have all the *siddhis*, all the powers of the universe.” That was the end of that darshan.

That night I spent the whole evening sick – vomiting, diarrhea – I felt like there was some sort of purification. I was so sick I didn’t go to the audience the next day. And I was told that Baba walked in and said, “Where’s that extraordinary little boy?” I’m maybe a foot taller than Baba but everybody around there was a little boy. And He was told, “He was sick all night, Baba,” and He just laughed and dismissed the darshan and left. So that was my first day with Baba.

I didn’t take very seriously the dos and don’ts, the moral statements or the meditation. I was continuing my own practice of enquiry rather than the concentration practices of Ananda Marga. I was drawn to a particular yogi who’s since deceased,

Nityananda, who had been one of the first monks of AM and he told me his story. When he first met Baba, he was doing meditation in the mountains and Baba touched him and he had a vision of many lifetimes meditating in the mountains. Baba told him the reason he was still incarnating was that he didn't extend himself to others. Baba then touched him and put him into a state of *samadhi* that had evaded him until that time and he became a student and eventually an *avadhuta*. While it was hard to get him to sit down to give teachings, he was the only monk that I was drawn to for instruction, so Nityananda gave me the various lessons.

As time evolved there was a lot of attention from Anandamurti towards me. There were a lot of darshans focused on something to do with me or my inner process and sometimes nobody knew it but Baba. I remember there was time I woke up in the morning and I had a roommate at the time – Vishok, Vikash? – anyway he was a young man from Philadelphia. I just decided that he was one of the stupidest persons I had ever met in my life, and all morning I kept thinking to myself that I came halfway around the world and have to have a roommate who's a complete idiot. These things arise in the mind when you're doing practices. I remember brushing my teeth, thinking about this fellow, "Why am I stuck with this roommate?" Doing my meditation, "...stuck with this roommate..."

I didn't tell anybody. And then at darshan, Anandamurti said, "You know, there are many ways to concentrate. What we want to do is ideate and concentrate on *Parama Purusa*. But occasionally we have other kinds of ideation, like we wake up in the morning and we think, "How stupid is my roommate!" Or we brush our teeth and we think, "What an idiot is my roommate! And all morning we just think what an idiot is..." and I think he even said the name of Vishok. And He looked at me and said, "That is not the way we want to concentrate on our spiritual life!" And I knew he was reflecting on the mental content of the morning.

There was a DMC in Ranchi. The monks had spent 14 days building these giant tents and structures. The first day of the DMC, the first darshan was a very short one, and this is the way it was translated to me. "Sometimes we have to work very hard and then

Parama Purusa destroys everything to make us stronger and then we have to start from scratch and work even harder.”

And He left the darshan. It was a warm, sunny day and an English fellow and I took a walk. We wanted to go for a swim at a bathing ghat about a mile away. Before we got to the ghat there was suddenly an enormous storm – one of the worst storms I’d ever seen in my life. We couldn’t even see each other.

We walked back to the grounds and discovered that the two weeks worth of work – building those giant structures, the concession stands, food kitchens – had been totally ripped up by the storm. This was connected to Anandamurti saying that sometimes we work for two weeks or more and everything is destroyed. And He gave the monks 24 hours to restore everything. I’m quite convinced it was His *siddhi*, or power, that, for whatever teaching purposes, created this enormous storm and wind that tore down two weeks worth of work.

There was some trouble at the time. Some townspeople in Ranchi had wanted to attend and had been refused entry because it was, again, the policy that to attend this darshan you had to be already initiated into Ananda Marga – which is not unreasonable. You know, there are a lot of teachings that are just not open to the public, and not just in Ananda Marga. But they came back with a mob of a hundred or two hundred people and started beating people up, pulling them off rickshaws, beating up women, beating up Americans.

I was on a rickshaw with a European or American brother and was saying, “You know, I don’t get this fight for dharma. I came here to be peaceful and we keep hearing that we have to fight to defend against immorality. I don’t accept this, that you have to fight or take physically strong action in your spiritual life.”

We hadn’t heard about the townspeople beating up margiis at this point, but as we were going along we came upon a crowd of margiis saying, “Hide! There’s a group of people beating us up!” So this was relayed to us just after this European or American student had been saying he couldn’t imagine any circumstances in which you would have to physically fight to defend yourself or to defend others.

By the end of that night, the newspapers blamed the tension on Ananda Marga and there were hundreds of people ready to break into Anandamurti's house. And I guess at that point, the headquarters was moved to Patna. I remember we were woken up at 2 in the morning and given two minutes to dress and gather our belongings before being thrown into taxis and vans and we were moved to Patna from Ranchi.

There was another time, some local, maybe a margii, stole a hundred dollars from me. I was outraged – coming from the other side of the world and having someone steal money from me. And maybe Baba was told, maybe He wasn't, but in the darshan that day He said, "You know, there are two kinds of wrong in the world. One is doing something you shouldn't do. Let's say somebody's family is starving so he steals a hundred dollars from an American. That's not good, but the motivation was to take care of one's family. There's a much worse crime than that and that's if you have the capacity to serve others and you say you only care about your own spiritual evolution and you don't do it." And He shook his finger at me saying that my crime about not being concerned about changing the conditions that would force somebody, or at least force somebody in their mind, to steal, was a worse crime than to steal.

I didn't really speak about my roots, but Baba was speaking about the need to fight against injustice and out of the blue He said, "Diinabandhu, why did your grandparents come out of Russia?"

I said, "To escape a repressive Czarist regime."

He replied, "That is an example of the political inequality and unfairness that Prout and Ananda Marga wish to correct in the world." He was just revealing to me that He knew why my grandparents left Russia.

There was a time when most of the Americans and Europeans were getting bouts of hepatitis and would have to spend six weeks in bed or in a hospital getting more and more grouchy. Hepatitis somehow affects the liver and makes you irrational and angry. And I suddenly had hepatitis. But I decided that I wasn't going to spend six weeks lying

in bed and at that night darshan, Anandamurti stopped and suddenly looked at me and said, “Jaundice. Take care of it.”

But as He said it I felt a healing presence, and the next day I was riding around town on a motorcycle. So I felt like He was giving me the energy to not have to spend six weeks lying in bed. I felt that He gave me energy so that I could deal with it myself.

Baba was always very loving towards me. He’d given me the name Diinabandhu and when He would say it he would shake and nod His head and charge up every cell in my body. There were a lot of people there that feared him. He could be very intimidating but I never felt fear with Him. It was almost as if – and I almost hate to say this – it was like all of these outer forms, 16 points of conduct and this and that, it was as if for the two of us, it was theater, it was a joke. And I never took it seriously and He never took it seriously in relation to me. In my sense, it didn’t matter what I did. With His relationship, He was inside of me and I was inside of Him.

I guess a significant thing in my personal history was, one day an Ananda Marga monk asked me if I would write an article for one of their publications. They knew I was trained as an academic philosopher. But I quickly dismissed the idea and told him I didn’t come to India to write and be in my mind – he should find somebody else. I don’t know if the monks told Baba that I wasn’t interested or not. In darshan I would usually sit in the front row right in front of Baba, but this darshan I decided to sit in back. But there were no seats in back, and the only seat was at His feet.

At the time, He looked right at me and said, “It’s good that you don’t use creative gifts to become rich and famous. But if you have a creative gift and you say, ‘I just want to maintain my own *samadhi*, I don’t want to use this creative gift to serve others’ – let’s say one has a creative gift as an intellectual or a philosopher but he doesn’t want to use that gift, only spend time in silence – such a man is worse than a dead man. If you have creative gifts, you have to use them.”

So I started writing. I started working on a thesis I hadn’t finished because I had dropped out of academics. It was on freedom – the relationship of and demand for social justice and inner freedom. I finished it and realized that Ananda Marga, with its mixture

of inner meditation, outer social action, and spiritual economic theory – well, I realized if I had finished my thesis a year before I would have had to invent something similar to Ananda Marga philosophy.

This started me writing a series of articles, most of them in the local Patna paper. Every week they would publish another article about Ananda Marga, meditation and social service – and I wrote those under the name Dale Brazosky. Now this was during a time of great tension, and even a war between India and Pakistan, so it became very popular journalism around the country because they thought Brazosky was a Russian. Russia was a great hero of India at the time, so they said, “Oh, look, a Russian is writing about Ananda Marga!”

At the same time, I was involved with Public Relations because I was out in the media. I was also Baba’s son’s schoolteacher and tutor at the time. So somehow a man named Chopra, a famous photojournalist, contacted me and he wanted to do a story in Bombay Illustrated Weekly about Ananda Marga. My understanding was that it was to be a positive story. So we spent some time giving him background and even arranged for him to take a picture of Baba, which was unheard of at the time. Baba was responsive perhaps because He felt that if I thought it was a good idea, He would do it. There was a picture of me as well, teaching school.

When the article came out, about this time two things happened. The owner of the newspaper who had been publishing these big Sunday articles of Dale Brazosky’s met with me and let me know he was coming under enormous government pressure not to publish anything more favorable about Ananda Marga. He was almost afraid to see me anymore – something had changed. Also, before the Bombay Illustrated Weekly article was published, Chopra let me know that suddenly there was tremendous political pressure on him and the article wasn’t particularly favorable towards Ananda Marga. Bombay Illustrated Weekly was the largest English language magazine in India so millions of people read it. And when the article came out it was really questioning, “Who is this man?” and there was a lot of controversy – not just about me but about Ananda Marga in general. The article was really about Ananda Marga. Suddenly there was a whole political change of tone.

At that point I went to Ranchi to visit friends. I went to the Yogananda Center there where I had a friend and he told me he had been very worried about me and Ananda Marga. He said that one of the charges against Ananda Marga had been that they had found weapons and explosives in Anandamurti's house after they left Ranchi several months before. He said, "I was so worried about you, Diinabandhu, being involved with an organization with all these guns and rifles and bombs." And then he said he met someone in town who told him that the locals had forced him to sneak these weapons into Anandamurti's house. So he wanted to tell me that he was no longer worried about me but to also let me know that there was some kind of campaign to discredit Ananda Marga.

At a certain point, in October maybe, Baba was thrown in jail. I went to Puri at that time and picked up an English language daily paper and found an article that said something like, "Hypnotized Monks do Guru's Bidding." It was the first time that I read something that really portrayed Ananda Marga as some sort of evil cult. It hadn't really occurred to me, you know. The things that had arisen about arms and explosives in the paper, I had been told that someone admitted planting arms. But it was really shocking how Ananda Marga was being portrayed in the media. There really was a very strong campaign at this point.

I had a couple of darshans with Anandamurti's wife. She was a very strong, very loving woman. The scuttlebutt within Ananda Marga was that she was always telling monks they needed to meditate more and Anandamurti was always telling them they needed to do more social justice action. And there was this tension between the two of them. Many of the monks were very drawn to Ma and yet they couldn't fulfill her wishes and Baba's. One was saying get out there and work – you don't need so much time for meditation. And the other one was saying meditate more. In Ananda Marga, this was just like a cosmic drama. They were really like one entity.

Politically things were pretty intense at this point. So many stories were circulating: that the government had infiltrated Ananda Marga, and that if there were murders, they had done it to discredit Ananda Marga. Or, that Baba had nothing to do

with any of this, but power-hungry monks had done it. The type of meditation they were given could lead to power before wisdom, and Baba had just let it play out.

At one darshan He said something that related to this. He said, “You know, *Parama Purusa* knows the minds of all beings, and He knows there is the potential in people’s minds to do great evil. But He will not take any action as long as these seeds are just seeds. He has to let things play themselves out.” So that can be interpreted that He knew what was going on, but He wasn’t going to do anything about it, they had to play out.

At this point, I really wasn’t questioning whether it was true or not true. One avadhuta was saying, “I don’t really know if it’s true or not, but Baba has completely won my heart and it doesn’t matter.” Other people were saying that it was true, there was evil in the organization and He was responsible. And other people saying it was all a government plot and Ma’s impurities led her to take part. So it was really a Zen koan. But inside myself, independent of that, I was wondering whether it was time for me to leave.

In one of the last darshans with Baba, I was aware of a tendency in myself to manifest *siddhis* and to stop growing inside. You get certain powers and you play with these powers. Later on I saw that Baba was really speaking to the heart of something I had to deal with. He told me to stand up. “Diinabandhu, do you want *Parama Purusa* or do you want all the occult powers?”

I said, “I want *Parama Purusa*.” He asked me again. I said, “I want *Parama Purusa*.” Then He said, “Everyone come touch Diinabandhu’s feet, because Diinabandhu is a great *siddha* who has all the powers. Don’t you?”

I was sitting there, thinking, “What’s going on?” While He was working with me, Vijay Kumar, whom I could safely say was playing with *siddhis* more than I was – Baba was working him inside out. Vijay was almost crying from whatever Baba was doing with him; He was also working internally with Vijay.

Baba said, “Diinabandhu, forget the occult powers, just merge your mind with the Supreme Lord. Don’t be a fool, just go for oneness with God, don’t be caught with occult powers.”

Then there was a darshan when He turned to me, and He knew my mind, feeling that maybe I was leaving. I felt that something inside of me was untouched, that I had had this lesson in power, and that power was not necessarily compassion and empathy. It's not His fault, I'm just saying that the *siddhis* and power emphasis were overriding something else I needed to do. And inside, I was thinking, "I think I'm leaving."

He said "Diinabandhu, my Diinabandhu, always my Diinabandhu." That was the last time I saw Him. He was put in jail the next day.

And we went and met some of the supposed detractors, one who said he had known for months beforehand that all this was going on. And I said, "Well, if you knew for months, why didn't you say anything?"

And he said, "You have no idea of the pain I was in."

I went to see Neem Karoli. I felt I was being brought under Neem Karoli and Anandamayi's wing. I remember at darshan, everyone was murmuring and pointing at me, that he was with Ananda Marga. I went to Patna to get my things so I could go back to be with Neem Karoli.

In Patna I ran into Tom Barefoot. And while Tom and I were talking, I felt this extraordinary inner darshan that I knew was Anandamurti just filling me inside and out with bliss and presence. And at that point I decided I was staying with Ananda Marga, I didn't care what these stories were. I planned to come back to America; I wanted nothing to interfere with that relationship with Anandamurti. To not have any more questions. On my way to Delhi, five minutes outside the station of Allahabad all power went out on the train; there was a riot going on. People screaming, punching. I said, "I accept," and I got off the train in Allahabad. In the time with Neem Karoli I began to establish a relationship with him. And this time when I went to Delhi, it was with the idea that I had left Ananda Marga.

A couple remembrances of teaching were very valuable to me. At one point Baba was speaking about people trying to expand their minds to *Parama Purusa*. And He said very clearly, that was not the way He was suggesting people meditate. Instead of bringing your mind to a point and expanding it, bring your mind to a point and then at that *bindu*

have the awareness that *Parama Purusa* is infinite and totally surrounds you with infinite love and awareness encompasses you. Instead of trying to make yourself so big, make yourself tiny and small and then realize that only God, only *Parama Purusa* is there. That was a very useful darshan. Just being a point and then *Parama Purusa* is naturally there with His grace.

Another time He was speaking of the Buddha. Maybe not the Buddha that I understand, but He remarked once that all these people were coming to the Buddha with all this negativity, and Buddha would say, “It does not affect me.” Then Baba said people come to *Parama Purusa* with all this negativity and He doesn’t say it doesn’t touch me, He consumes it and takes it upon Himself to purify. Actually the role of Buddha is the same. The point is the true guru takes upon Himself the suffering of others rather than remains untouched by it.

My own experience? Baba was a vast guru. I left, I’m not doing His practice. But I will always have respect for Him. He is such a great teacher that what’s fact and what’s fiction in the political history of Ananda Marga is almost irrelevant. You can say, “How can we understand it?” But the point is He had such compassion, and such energy and such power and such clarity that I think it really doesn’t matter. If someone feels relationship in their heart with their guru, and they are continually growing, and their capacity for service is continually growing, that’s all that matters. I just don’t want it construed that I’m saying stay away; that’s not what I’m saying. I left not because of any facts, it was just time for me to move on. The way I was relating in Ananda Marga, the sense of power and ecstasy was the overriding feeling, and it was correct for me to go to another path to deal with it. I don’t have judgments about Ananda Marga. I hope some of the stories I told are of some use.

Moti and Reshma Los Angeles, California

Reshma: I saw Baba from the age of twelve. He used to come very often to Delhi. My mother was one of the main cooks for Baba when He came to Delhi. She used to leave us at home to cook for Him. Once my brother was very sick, and she used to leave us at five and go to Baba’s quarters, but come back during the day. She would bring a

little milk, *prasad*, and feed my brother. The neighbors used to say, “Why she is leaving her sick child?” But he became all right. My mother was a very quiet lady, and she never expressed herself to Baba. Once Baba went to the gate, and then came back, as if He had left something in the house. He did namaskar to her, and blessed her. But first Baba asked, “Ask me whatever you want.” And she said nothing.

After these blessings we suffered a lot. In 1975, the Emergency came. My father had to leave Delhi and go to Bombay. When the police couldn’t find my father, they told my mother they would arrest her. I was quite sick, and the doctor advised us to leave the place. So we left for Bombay. After few months, my father was arrested. During that time, we were homeless. We stayed with various uncles or cousins, and met on the weekend. Finally they arrested my mother and took her to Delhi, and my father was in another jail. So, we faced more separation.

At that time the jailer told my mother, “If you sign this letter against Baba, I will release you right away. And I know it’s your daughter’s wedding, and you have to be present.”

And my mother said, “Even if you take my head off right now, I will never sign that paper.”

The jailer said, “What about your daughter’s marriage?”

She said, “Well, if she is going to get married, she will, and if not, she won’t. And I am not going to bother about her marriage.” The jailer became red with anger, and kept her in a very bad condition in the jail.

I got married, and then met my mother in the jail. After four months the Emergency was over, and they were all released.

Actually my mother was a great fighter. She was very bold, and not afraid of anything. The only reason we left during the Emergency was because of me; I was very sick. Otherwise she was willing to fight with all the bullies, and they had no guts to enter her house when she was there. Maybe Baba’s grace was on her. She was quite a fanatic, I would say [laughs]. There were times when I would fight with my mother and say, “Oh, if Baba is God, why do we have to suffer all the time? We’ve only seen suffering.” And she would say, “But He is God, and I can only pray that one day you will get all the things you want in this world.” And believe it or not, I did.

I remember that Baba squeezed us so much. I used to wonder is this right? But you know when you're totally down, and everything's finished, suddenly He brings you up. This is what I could never understand, but now I do.

When I was 11 or 12, Baba used to be sitting very nearby. But we used to just look at Him, and think that if He is God, He should have like these extra arms and everything, like in Indian mythology. Everyone was saying He is God, and what was it actually? He looked like such an ordinary man, He can't be God. And my mother used to say, "You know, He's the biggest actor. He acts very well."

Moti: Every year we used to go to Kolkata for DMC. My wife insisted that I should have Personal Contact. Keshavananda told Baba that we had come. And Baba told him, "Moti loves me a lot, and Reshma loves me a lot. And I also love them very much. But they quarrel among themselves very much." This was the reply that came through Dada. "Do you fight, or not? Baba said, 'You both fight a lot, and you also both love me very much, and I love both of you.'"

Reshma: I had many problems with Moti. I used to pray to Baba, "It's because of you, you got me married." Baba didn't come to me, but in the room where I used to sleep, I could smell some very good fragrance of flowers. I got up, and there was nothing in the room, and I don't keep any plants there. I woke Moti and told him Baba was here, and he said, "Oh, you're sleeping."

I said, "No, I know this was Baba." Things then became better between us.

Moti: Since Baba stayed in our house, one dada said the vibration in this house would remain for hundreds of years. So I enjoy going to do sadhana in my Bombay residence, which is as good as Baba's quarters.

Reshma: Our whole family had a lot of love and respect for our grandmother, Ananda Bharati. [Editor's note: Didi Ananda Bharatiji became an *acarya* and *avadhutika* after fulfilling her responsibilities as a family person.]

She used to follow one guru, and had prepared herself to follow him her whole life. But suddenly he died, and she became very upset. She did not know what to do. She had gone to stay in her daughter's house in Udaipur. Mr. Mangal Bihari-ji was there. He happened to tell my aunt – Auntie's daughter, "I have one saint coming to my house, why don't you come tomorrow?"

That night my grandmother had a dream of Baba, and dreamt that her previous guru said to her, "He is your actual guru." She saw one man in orange robe and one man in white. The next day she went to Mangal Bihari's house and she saw the same dada and she saw Baba. There and then she got initiated. Then she immediately left to become a didi. Then my mother and father and all children took initiation.

I remember Baba used to wear very thick glasses. We never liked those frames, and thought they were too heavy. So Moti said, "Baba should wear very light frames; they will look better."

Moti made golden glasses for Baba, very nice ones, and took them to Tiljala. Dada said, "He's not going to wear such glasses," but Moti said, "No, it is my desire that He wear them once."

And Baba did wear them, two or three times. So He fulfilled our desire. Whenever we went there we would take some material for His clothes, and give it to the didis. In that way, I felt very happy that something was accepted of ours for Baba.

Once I said I was going to give a garland to Baba. We used to all wait outside for Him to come.

I said, "I am going to do it, even if a VSS guard kicks me on the hand, I don't care." You have to be very quick. I was looking everywhere, and as soon as Baba came I went there quickly and gave the garland to Him. Baba spoke something in Bengali, softly, and I couldn't understand Him. Then I wanted to touch His feet. But before I could touch His feet, the guard came and shooed me away. My *acarya* Ananda Gita said, "You got scared of the VSS; you should've just taken the chance and touched Baba's feet."

I wouldn't say He's my guru, I would say He is my everything: father, mother, friend. I fight with Him, mentally. When I'm happy I'm happy with Him. I talk to Him. He's like my own family member.

Ashoka Mahesvarii

I was introduced to Ananda Marga in 1964, when I was going into my second year of engineering school, in Pelani. My *acarya* was Shankaranandaji; he's still my *acarya*. He used to come to Pelani. There were a number of *margiis* there, devotees of Baba, who used to tell me about meditation and yoga, how it helps to improve concentration, improve your grades. And that's what attracted me to it first, improve my grades, and also the exercise part. So I took initiation. I was really not practicing that seriously.

But in December 1964, some of my friends who were *margiis* decided to take a tour of Bihar. They asked me to join them, and I agreed because I wanted to see Bihar, parts of North India I had not seen. Also in Bihar there was a famine, and they were doing relief work, and I thought this was a good purpose. We took a train and reached Vithya. They did not mention they would be seeing Baba.

Very close to Nepal, about 30 miles, there was a *Dharma Maha Cakra* going on. My friends showed me a few things, how to do *sastaung pranam*, and also reminded me of my *acarya's* name, since Baba used to ask those things, and they put me in the room. I was expecting Baba to be in orange dress, a *sannyasi*, but to my surprise Baba was a little, chubby, ordinary-looking person. It made me feel at home, because he was a family man. Then He talked to me, asked my *acarya's* name, where I was from. At that point, He grabbed my ears, and did His usual punishment, that you've been a bad boy, but He didn't punish me much. He put me in His lap. It was such a joy, such a blissful state, I thought, "Here I am with this cosmos, this guy who knows everything about me."

I asked Baba some question. At that time there was lot of controversy about whether there was life on Mars. NASA was doing a lot of research. So I asked Baba whether there was life anywhere else in the solar system. And He very smartly chose not to respond. He deferred the question, because He wanted us to find out through scientific

means. He certainly knew that there is no life, and now we know that there is no life there at the present time.

Then we toured with Baba, saw the place where He was living and grew up in Jamalpur. Mangal Biharji and myself and another acarya spent a lot of time at the *jagrti* in Jamalpur, a good part of time on Baba's field trip. Baba was a good family person, taking care of His wife, and His mother, and also taking care of organizational duty. In Jamalpur there was a margii named Bindeshvari-ji. Once he came to see Baba, but on the way to see Him, he passed away. So the other margiis requested Baba to give him life, and Baba reluctantly agreed. This man was in his mid-60s, but after Baba gave him life again, he behaved like a baby. He would laugh hysterically, and do different tricks on people. He would touch people on their forehead, and put them into *samadhi*. He would ask Baba, "Who is the bad boy?" And Baba said, "You are the bad boy." Baba was kidding him. He was an amazing personality. He had a job but whenever Baba showed up, he would be there, and when Baba would leave, people would hang around him and go into *samadhi*.

I had the good fortune to have two field walks with Baba, and in each I learned something unique. Baba asked me the meaning of my name, Ashoka. There was a great king, Ashoka. Baba said, 'shok' means sorrow, and 'a' means one who never has sorrow. I never knew that. Also He asked, "What is the capital of Ashoka?" I had forgotten. So Baba asked me to touch His hand. I touched His hand, and all of a sudden, the thought came in my mind that it was Pataliputra, or Patna, the same as became Baba's capital later.

Baba liked students, and He encouraged them to complete their studies. After this I wanted to become a *sannyasi* too, like many of my colleagues. But my *acarya* and my family discouraged it. They said it was a tough path, that I needed to finish my studies and then decide. I did complete my studies, and meditation helped me. I used to be in the bottom ten percent of my class, and I came into the top five percent in a year or two. So it helped not only spiritually, but also professionally. I saw Baba and took His blessing before coming to the U. S. I have been here since 1971.

I spent a lot of time in Jamalpur with Baba, and also in Ranchi. In Pelani there were about 20 margiis. We would go to see Baba in New Delhi, and the students would be massaging Baba. He used to give special time to students because they were His favorites. Kiirtan was not yet introduced. Baba's photos were restricted, and were not allowed easily. There's a famous story from those days. Baba was travelling in a train, and there were photographers who wanted to take Baba's picture. They couldn't get a good photo, and got frustrated. So the dasas asked Baba why. Baba explained the photography principle. He said the object which is being photographed must be dimmer than the camera. What was happening was whenever they were trying to take Baba's photo with a flash, Baba Himself made an even bigger flash, and they couldn't take the picture. Then Baba started to slowly allow the taking of His photo, limited to devotees.

Baba always spoke about ideology. He didn't go for His own personal glamour or personal image. He could've been a very beautiful personality like Krsna, but He chose to be just a very ordinary-looking person. His mission was to establish more than His personal thing. We see Him as our guru, and may choose to use His photo, that's an option; but the important thing He gave is the *pratik*, and the system of meditation, which is scientific. It was very appealing to the engineering students, as it was so scientific. And not only did He put old wine in new bottles, but He gave a lot of new things. *Pratik*, *tandava*, *kaoshikii*, Renaissance Universal club, all introduced as we were growing up. We thought this might be the end, but Baba kept giving until the day He passed away. Prabhat Samgiit passed number 5000.

His whole life was phenomenal. If you look at His teaching, here is a great personality who could be winning the Nobel Prize, if you put all His wealth together, but He kept Himself very quiet. He came quietly into this world, and He went very quietly. But He created an enormous spiritual wave, and spiritual people following Him all over world. Baba used to kid, when it was a small organization, He used to say how Ananda Marga would spread, with acaryas from all over world, from all backgrounds and religions. We didn't believe Him. But Ananda Marga had already spread around the world by the time Baba went into prison, and it spread even faster when He was in prison.

There are so many beautiful experiences of Baba. Just today I had one. While having my lesson revision, it took me back to Baba's lap again, the same thing that happened to me when I was 17. Now I'm 54. It put me in a beautiful state. Also, I had pain on the left side, and that disappeared. I was feeling immense bliss today.

Baba always kept a low profile, no show or pomp. He wanted people to grow spiritually; that was the most important thing. Other things will follow, service to suffering humanity will bring liberation of the self. I find tremendous energy from the dadas and didis, and margiis, who are the most beautiful people. Even my wife, who was not a margii, has become a more devoted margii than I by reading Baba's books and meeting acaryas. We need to do more and more social service and Baba's work.

Nandinii

Tucson, Arizona

To my recollection, Ananda Marga started in the U. S. in 1969, when the U. S. was in incredible political upheaval. It was also a time when a lot of people were starting to think about the metaphysical world. There were many people in the counterculture, antiwar, and hippie movements. They could not understand some of the traditional trappings of their churches. I think about 600 people were initiated in a short time in Carbondale. *Dharmacakra* was so large that some people had to wait in the hallway. Lots of university people, nontraditional, and some traditional people came. Many of us were teaching classes and getting very involved. It was so big back then that we couldn't anticipate how many people would show up at DC.

I was initiated Oct. 31, 1969, while living in Carbondale, Illinois. I was living with some friends, and we had wanted to learn how to meditate and get into metaphysical things for a long time. It was Halloween, and my friend suggested we go for a walk. There were people running around with costumes, and it was a little bizarre.

There were four of us walking down the street. We came upon this house with nice green grass with an Indian man sitting in the yard. He called us over and asked if we wanted to learn how to become yogis, and we thought, sure, since we weren't doing anything else that evening. We went inside the house and there was a dada dressed in orange. He said that he had just come from India and was initiating people all over the U. S. He asked if we would like to learn how to meditate.

We each went with him individually into the room, and got our *mantras* and learned a little about Ananda Marga. Then we sat around and talked, and he said that we should meditate every morning and evening for 30 minutes. Dada came the following Sunday with the Indian man we had met, who turned out to be Ravi Batra, and we had group meditation. There were just six of us. Then we started to have larger meditations, up to 150 people some times.

One night we were at Didi Ananda Mitra's house (before she became a didi), and Dada Vimalananda said that we were going to meditate for four hours. Since we had been margiis for such a short time we thought maybe it was normal. So we sat down and

meditated for four hours, and when we came out of meditation we sang songs, talked and had a meal. We started to meditate at least a couple of hours a day instead of half an hour. After some time we mentioned it to Dada, and he said, “Oh, half an hour twice a day is enough. I just wanted to meditate for four hours that night.” Dada initiated so many people that we had to rent a gymnasium at the university for *dharmacakras*.

It stayed that large for some time, and many dadas and didis came. Until that time Ananda Marga was very loosely woven, and then began to be more formalized. We were happy to see that. We were also happy to see that dadas and didis were traveling because we got to see them more regularly. And AM continued to grow into the 1980s when we established the national retreat site in Ananda Kanan. Then in the early '90s there weren't quite as many people. I always think that even though there are not as many people who stayed in Ananda Marga, the people who have stayed are the people who are really hardcore and truly believe in Baba and His work and His mission. I believe that will continue throughout the new millennium. The people who really love Baba will continue to come.

At the last summer retreat I sat next to a teenage girl. I asked her how she came to AM. She said that she was at the university and went to an Ananda Marga class given by a dada.

“How did it seem to you?” I asked.

She said, “I just had to have more. There is something for every aspect of my being in AM.” She said that Prout, Women's Welfare Department, service projects, meditation, asanas, “all made perfect sense. It was just what I was supposed to do.” I thought it was beautiful because I didn't know how different people see AM now – I know it has changed a great deal. I was greatly affirmed by seeing this young person joining Ananda Marga.

Guru Gopal Singh

Bernardsville, New Jersey

I was initiated by Ac. Maheshvariji, who was working for the Bihar Electricity Board at Dhanbad office. It was August 1963 when I took initiation. I went to Jamalpur for Baba's darshan. We stayed there for three days and it was very exciting to be with Baba. I had Personal Contact at least three times and field walk with Baba all three days. The happiness and the enjoyment were too great to describe. After the first PC I was feeling intense happiness and as if I was in a totally different world.

After our return from Jamalpur I started a new life. All my weaknesses vanished. My biggest problems were fear, lack of self-confidence and getting nervous during exams. These problems vanished and I got tremendous self-confidence with the feeling that the impossible does not exist. After a few months I went to Jamalpur for the *Tattvika* class given by Ac. Dasharathji. I was so lucky that most of the time Baba was teaching our classes. My writing power was very fast and I took all the notes from Baba. I use to go for *pracar* work every weekend and evening with friends.

In 1964 and 1965 I had opportunities to go to Ananda Nagar several times, and also to Jamalpur. Baba was always kind to give PCs all the time. He discussed a lot about Buddha, Netaji and world history. His description of Krishna was so lively, as if it was happening in front of Him.

I had lost my father in 1962 when I was only 17 years old, but after meeting Baba in my first PC when He took me in His lap, I just felt, "I am sitting in my father's lap."

Baba has said so many things that it is difficult to write. My ambition is to see every human being living happily, meeting all the basic needs. I do not want to see poverty and hunger. Only Baba will guide us to achieve this goal.

CHAPTER TWO: COME CLOSER, STILL CLOSER

“That which makes the mind soft and strong and strenuous, so that it may keep itself in a balanced state even in the condition of pain, that which perpetually creates a pleasant feeling within, is called love. Devotion is identical with love. The moment devotion is aroused, the love of God comes.”

Ananda Marga’s growth surged in New York Sector in the early 1970s. Service projects, cooperatives, and yoga and meditation classes sprang up in many parts of the sector. But in India, controversy swirled around the Ananda Marga organization. There, the movement’s revolutionary merger of spirituality and social justice apparently threatened the Indian government. Internal tensions also threatened the organization’s cohesion. Baba was imprisoned, as were thousands of Indian margiis. It appeared to be a dark period. And yet from His jail cell, with patience and extraordinary fortitude, Baba continued to run the organization, which went underground in India, but which in many other countries flourished. Protests against Baba’s unjust imprisonment galvanized support in New York Sector. And margiis began traveling to India to visit Baba in prison, often facing persecution from the Indian authorities. It was a unique time, one that challenged margiis to hold firmly to their ideology. As depicted in this chapter’s stories, Baba often demonstrated who was really running the show.

Bharat

San Antonio, Texas

In 1972, I was in Atlanta, married for the first time, but my wife and I were separated. I was dating one girl who was interested in psychics, and spiritual things. We drove to Florida on my birthday and ended up seeing a psychic there. I was not into anything to do with meditation; I was into having a party. My girlfriend wanted to talk to this lady psychic.

I said, "I don't want to hear about it, it's all fake."

But she went in to see the psychic, who said to her, "I don't want to talk to you, I want to talk to him."

I said, "Oh, you just want my money."

But I went inside, and she looked at my palm, and asked me a few questions.

She said, "You know, you have a terrible fear of death. I see the number two. In two years, two months, and two days, you will die."

"This is all fake," I thought.

"But it won't be the death you imagine," she went on. "What will happen is, the person that you are now is going to die. And that's what I'm supposed to tell you."

After this, the army was going to send me to Wichita for training. I called the colonel and said, "I'm a single man, I don't want to go to Wichita. I want to go some place where I can have a good time."

So they sent me to Thailand. After a month, I decided I wanted to live off-base. I found a beautiful house on the ocean, and I bought an old car. I had learned to play the guitar, so I would sit and play music by the sea. One night, a GI said there's somebody at the base giving a lecture on yoga. It was Dada Pinakpani, now Pranakrsnananda, giving a lecture. I was not at all interested in any of it, but I went.

There were military guys at the lecture, and everyone was drinking and smoking. The thing that impressed me was, none of it fazed Dada. He continued his talk. And for some reason, I became interested. After the lecture, he came to my house, and I became initiated into Ananda Marga. At that time, Baba was in jail. When some of the *acaryas* got out of jail, they would come to Thailand. I had this stream of *acaryas* coming to my

house. We would play music, and go to Bangkok and do social service. We worked in the slums of Klong Toey [crying], and that's where I got interested.

When my military time was over – I was married again by then – I went to India. At that time, Baba was in jail. I went into the jail, and Baba said, “Develop your full mental, physical and spiritual potentialities” [crying]. And He said, “Tell Liila to do her duty properly and faithfully” [crying]. And that was on July 4, 1974, and it was exactly what the psychic had said: two years, two months and two days. So that was a pretty amazing story.

When I went to see Baba another time, in prison, around 1976, He had been poisoned. After that, he fasted for many years. All He had daily was a glass of Ovaltine. I was really curious, as a physician. How does anybody survive? So I went to the jail with Arjuna from L.A. We went to see the jail doctor. You would think that Baba would have some spiritual kind of doctor, who would say all sorts of great things, because he's had this contact everyday with the guru. We went to see the doctor, and it's exactly the opposite, he's got a cigarette in his mouth, he's got a drink in his hand. He asks us, “Do you want some whiskey?”

And we said, “Hey, what's going on? This is crazy. Here this guru is writing songs, fasting, doing all this stuff in jail, and what is this guy doing?” So Arjuna put on his yoga hat and started telling the doctor, “You know, alcohol really brings you down, and Baba can teach you meditation...”

The man said, “Every morning I go into Baba's room, sit down, and He says that I am liberated. My soul is liberated, and I do not have to do anything. I can smoke, I can drink. He says, ‘You're a liberated soul.’”

The doctor continued. “One night I was drinking a lot and they came and said, ‘Baba's calling you.’” His house was next to the jail. “So I went to the cell and Baba was gone. Where could He go? And I looked on the wall and I saw Shiva dancing, doing the *tandava* dance. Baba was gone. The next day, Baba was there again.”

“Every time I drink I see Shiva,” the doctor said. “Baba's not my guru. I tell everyone that Shiva is my guru. He helps me.”

But then he said, “I go and talk to Baba for an hour or so, and then I go to the market, and I meet Ramananda and I tell him everything that Baba said, and then he tells me things to tell Baba, and I go back and tell him.”

This was Baba’s drama of how to get information in and out. He was in prison, and He was still running the organization. His Personal Assistant was meeting this jail doctor, and the jail doctor was never suspected of having anything to do with Ananda Marga because he’s an alcoholic, and he’s smoking, and he says Shiva’s his guru, not Baba. So this whole time this drama was going on and nobody knows. Later I learned that this jail doctor stopped drinking and is now very devoted and spiritual.

The interesting thing is that Baba’s eyes were sparkling, and He grabbed my wrist very tight, and said, “My legs are weak, but my heart is very strong.” You knew this was just a game for Him to fast. He was really thin. I think what happened was after that he developed diabetes. With starvation you can develop diabetes. I think the fasting contributed to that, there is evidence of starvation precipitating that. Somebody’s told me since that this jail doctor is now very devoted and spiritual, that he changed.

I saw Baba again at Lake Gardens in 1979. Around that time my time in the military was ending. I didn’t know whether I should continue in the military or get out. So I went to Lake Gardens, and they were doing personal contact with Baba. Somehow, I ended up seeing Baba. I asked Him, “What should I do? Should I leave the military?”

All the dasas said, “Hey, don’t ask Baba those questions. That’s a stupid thing” [laughs].

Baba said, “In 48 days you’ll know the answer.”

Everyone said, “What’s He talking about?”

So I gave namaskar, and I left. I was on temporary duty in the Philippines. I used to go to sister Nillie and Roshan’s house, in Mandalay City. We would do meditation, and then eat. That particular night, I had a very nice meditation, and I sat at the table to do a little more before the meal. And my mind just went. Out. I’d never felt any experience like that before. They laid me on the sofa and for 30-45 minutes, I was gone. As soon as I started coming around, I would say, “Clinic, clinic.”

“What are you talking about?”

“Clinic?” I don’t know, I was just saying clinic.

“What happened?”

“Great meditation.”

It was some kind of *samadhi* or something. I just felt wonderful, like I was flying. I started thinking that maybe Baba was telling me I needed to leave the military and start some clinic. So I moved to San Antonio, and in the poor part of the city, built a clinic for dialysis. And really I think that clinic has been a highlight of my ability to keep supporting a lot of programs. It was very successful. In some way, this was Baba’s way of telling me to start a clinic.

Another time we came through Nepal. I wanted my children to see Baba. One of my children had gotten lost in the train station; we realized he wasn’t with us, and had to go back and find him. He was just standing there. They were good travelers. Later I got off the bus and stepped into a mudhole up to my waist. We finally made it to Kolkata, and when we got there, everyone said, “Baba’s leaving, Baba’s leaving.” His car was ready. Then someone said, “Baba said get Bharat up here quick.” I’d just gotten there! So I went and He said, “Africa is in great economic depression. You must continue to assist them. They are not the dark continent because of the color of their skin, but because they are in darkness.” This is when we started programs in Burkina Faso, in the early ’80s.

Malati

Scottsdale, Arizona

In the early '70s I was active in a little Congregational Church in White Plain, and some margiis came there doing *pracar*. They cooked a vegetarian meal, and gave a presentation. I felt a connection to them, partly because I was trained in anthropology, and one of them had majored in that. They invited me to a *dharmacakra* in New York. Someone asked me if I would like to learn meditation, and I asked them what was involved, and they said not very much, it was free. So I was initiated, and I don't remember the name of the *acarya*. Jitendra-ji became the *acarya* I connected with.

I wanted to meet Baba, and I felt I was always connected not only with Baba, but a higher power through Him. I guess I'm one of the people who has made an effort to keep my Christian religious connection. I started out in a Quaker school, which introduced me to sitting quietly, but later I was in contact with more traditional Christianity. I had a friend in India who was a margii, who went to see Baba. When Baba saw him He made the sign of the cross. I was glad to hear that.

Through the Episcopal Church I was later connected with, I met an Indian parapsychologist named K Das. She knew about Ananda Marga and invited me to go to India, and part of her idea was to wean me away from AM. Her family was outside Kolkata, a Methodist Hindu family. The son had been told by a psychic that he was going to meet an American woman, and that was going to change his whole way of life. They kind of adopted me as a family member. I wanted to see Baba in the jail in Patna, and the son accompanied me. He was not a margii, but accepted that the teachings were relevant to him. He had been used to drinking a lot, and he did change his lifestyle, but when we reached Patna I think some of the margiis thought I had fallen into the hands of a CBI agent, as he looked like that. But he was very thoughtful.

The whole jail had become like an ashram, and most of the jailers had become devotees. Sisters had to go in in pairs. I was paired with a Norwegian sister named Arunima. When we saw Baba, I felt in His presence a very great sort of acceptance. There were some things I felt I hadn't handled very well with this Indian family, and it seemed as if nothing mattered to Him. I had been told that there was one question that

was best to ask Baba, and that was ‘What is the best way to increase one’s devotion?’ I knew you could only see Baba every two weeks, and had to decide what to do in between. The margiis were helping at the site of some flooding. There were a lot of choices to make.

Anyway, when I saw Baba I asked that question, and Baba said there were two ways of doing service; one internal service through meditation, and the other external service. Baba looked from me to Arunima, and addressed each of us. He said to me, “You have so many questions, and you haven’t asked any of them, and I have answered them all.” And I realized what He said about the two parts of service gave me a clue about how to decide what to do.

Arunima asked Him about her relationship to the head of Prout in Norway, who she was working with. It was a question of marriage, and she asked Baba what He thought. And Baba said, “I am in favor of all good things.”

Then He turned to me and said, “When you think about marriage you should ask yourself, ‘Do I feel like cooking, and cooking, and cooking?’ And then of course there will be children.”

And I thought to myself, I was in my early ’50s, and of course there won’t be children. I thought, “Baba, you know my age, you know everything, OK.” I found that very useful. What He had said relieved me, in terms of relationships, It wasn’t that I was to say, “Do I really love this person, but just, do I feel like cooking?” [laughs]. And I heard later that the following week He met with a group of American margii women, and told them that what they needed was to be liberated from the kitchen. And that reinforced this message. Those were the things He said that most impressed me. I realized that He did know what I was thinking.

I did see Baba again, at Ananda Nagar. It was great to be with all these devotees in this beautiful but less-developed place. At the end of DMC, thousands of us were walking down to the railroad. And at checkpoints people were asking your name. And someone said, “You didn’t give them your name, did you?” Yes, I did. Later as I was about to leave India, the immigration called for a “Mr. Mudd” and pulled me off the plane, and I had an interesting experience. But I felt no fear, and felt that the guidance of the Supreme was with me. And from the time I was initiated I always felt that if I needed

human contact, the right person would come in my life, whether it was a child, or an old person. Things seemed to flow in a happier and gentler way.

One experience led to a dream in which Baba appeared. I had been teaching at a Mohawk school (Way of the True Human Being). I was on the tribal welfare committee for Ananda Marga, when Master Units were being developed. I fell into being able to get some land in New York which now is owned partly by AM, and the rest by the Mohawk Nation. A lot of margiis felt a connection with the land there, on the Canadian border, near St. Regis Reservation. It reminded them of Ananda Nagar, and had a special quality. I had a dream that I was sitting in the house, which had been rebuilt, and there were other margiis there. A knock came on the door, and in came this man. He had a Sikh turban on His head, and it fell off, and I recognized Him as Baba. I still feel that that place will blossom as a Women's Welfare Department Master Unit.

Recently I've heard some things about Kirlian photography. Vishvamitra had been back to Jamaica eight years after Baba visited there, and knew the place where Baba was sitting, and photographed it. There was a great circle of light around that place, which is how he had seen it when Baba was there. He suggested that when a great personage was there, there would be positive *microvita* around [the smallest entity uniting spirit and matter, according to Baba]. I suppose this could be part of the explanation of these pictures.

I'm very grateful for how meditation and social service has transformed my life. I think that the heightening of awareness about the importance of consciousness, and experiencing the positive effects of the spiritual practices, as well as social transformation, is so clearly needed in our society. I do keep in touch with people in the Catholic Worker movement, and I sometimes feel if they had more inkling of the philosophy of social change Baba has given us, it would heighten the impact.

Arjuna

Los Angeles, California

I was initiated on August 8, 1971, by Ac. Yatiishvarananda Avt. The day I took initiation there were 45 other people in line. It was in the door and out. The whole process took about two minutes at the most. But Baba took care of me, and I've survived. The first experience I had with Baba was at a retreat in November '71. At the end of it, I was still thinking 'Is this Ananda Marga for me?' We had just finished the final *akhanda kiirtan*, and I was kind of staring into space, thinking. I had this thought in my mind, "Baba, give me a sign that I belong here." At that second I was staring at the piano, and all of a sudden one note on the piano pressed down. That was my first experience that Baba was there.

I went to a second retreat after that, in the spring. After the final *akhanda kiirtan*, again I was just sitting there, not thinking about anything in particular. But there was a guitar next to me, and as I stared at the guitar, it plucked a note. This is just a very simple story, but it shows how in the simplest ways Baba can show you that there's more to this world than what you actually see.

I had been in AM for two years. I was doing my sadhana each day, going to *dharmacakra* (DC) each week, but keeping my distance from being drawn in too much. One thing I was very adverse to was having a Sanskrit name. I just didn't want to go that far. One day at DC at the *jagrti* in Santa Monica I was doing sadhana, and somehow Baba came to me and called me Arjuna, or somehow that name came. The following week Dadaji Jagadeva – he was a dada from Holland – came to the *jagrti*, and he wanted to have a consultation with me, so we talked after DC, and he said, "You have to have a name now. I want to give you third lesson and I also want to give you a name." Then the thought came in my mind he was going to give the name Arjuna to me because that's what Baba had said to me. And as soon as he sat down with me, he asked me "Do you want your name now?" and I said fine. It was Arjuna.

I decided to go see Baba in prison in India, in July, 1977. The first time I tried to see Him there was a lot of red tape involved. We had to go to Bankipur jail and give them our passports. They said to come back in a week and we would probably be able to see Baba. In one week, Dr. Bharat had just flown in from Thailand, and we were told we would see Baba together. I had met Didi Ananda Mitra the evening before. She said that when you see Baba, especially the first time, you have to do everything perfectly, bathe properly, do 16 Points perfectly, wear a clean shirt.

In the morning I got up and had a nice clean blue shirt on and white pants and we left the Patna *jagrti* and bought garlands. It turned out that it was a fasting day. I had heard from other people who had seen Baba in jail that He always gives you *prasad* in jail. So this big clash came in my mind – should I accept and eat the food on a fast day, even if it's from Baba? There was no one there to guide me, but internally I just made the decision in sadhana that if Baba gave *prasad* to me, I would say thank you and just keep it in my pocket, and I would be strict on this day.

We went in to the jail cell, and this was the first time I had seen Baba. He was lying on His cot. As soon as we came in, He hopped up. He looked so thin. In the only picture we had of Baba in those days, He was a strong healthy person. But now he reminded me of somebody that looked like Gandhi. It was extremely hot there. We were led in by the warden and there were one or two CBI people in the jail there too, and they were taking down our passport info.

The first thing we did was *sastaung pranam*, and Baba called us over and we went right up to Him. He started to put His hand on my neck, and was massaging my neck and higher *cakras*. At first we looked deeply into each other's eyes, and then He told me to close my eyes. After I closed my eyes He said, "Open your mouth." So I did that, and He just grabbed one of these Indian sweets and forced the whole thing in my mouth. When I opened my eyes up He was laughing, because He knew what I had been thinking. So this was Baba as the jokester. Something that I had taken so seriously He made a big joke about like it wasn't that important. The guru decides what you're going to do.

Then He spoke with Bharat some, and He told me what my duty was. He said it was to seek out support from and unite the *sadvipras* of the world, so they can help the

suffering humanity. I felt really positive about that. I had felt my main purpose in AM was *dharma pracar* and I was actively teaching.

I asked Him about my relationship with my wife. We had gone on separate vacations, so I asked Him what I should do with my marriage, and He just stared into space. He didn't answer. Then I thought, "OK, I'll rephrase the question."

I said, "Baba, there are a lot of margiis in New York Sector who love you so much, but they are struggling so much in their marriages. What can you say to those people who are in family life in New York Sector to help keep their marriages together?"

He thought again, and looked out into space again, and then He answered in a strong way. He said that marriage is an all-round fight, and how can we build a world and a society if we can't keep our small societies together? He wasn't in a joking mood here, He was very serious. Now whenever I see or talk to family people who are struggling, this is the first thing I tell them, that this is what Baba said; if we want to build a universal family, then we have to fight to keep our small family together.

Then we asked Him the question, "Baba, how can you have been fasting all these years in prison? How do you do it and still stay strong?" And Baba said that through a yogic technique, He can extract the energy from the air and the sunlight. Then He made a muscle with His arm and said, "If the rest of the world would fast like I am doing, there wouldn't be a food crisis in the world" [laughs]. There He was back joking around.

We had garlanded Him when we first came in, and He gave us the garlands and also a jar of *prasad*. Until this day, I have kept the garland and the shirt and the *prasad*. They took us to the warden's office and I had this thought in my mind – I had seen this very nice man but it really hadn't hit me, who I'd seen. I was always trained as an intellectual, and it hadn't really dawned on me. So as the warden and the CBI people were questioning us, I just closed my eyes there, and for the first time in my life, I had an experience of pure white light, total peace, just absorption in a whole different world. It's a thought I think of every day.

That was the deepest spiritual experience I've ever had, sitting there, closing my eyes. I had that feeling for several minutes, and could not believe I was having that experience. I actually consciously tried to think of something negative, but that positive feeling had so taken over my mind I couldn't even will my mind to think any doubt, any

negative feeling. That was quite an experience for me. Then the warden started talking about his experiences with Baba, as he saw we were very inspired. He said that although he was not a margii per se, he'd watched Baba in jail every day over all these years, and one night, he went into Baba's cell, and Baba wasn't there on the bed. Instead, all he could see was Baba doing *tandava* on the ceiling.

I went to Nepal for three weeks, and when I returned to Patna, I had the strongest desire to be alone with Baba in jail. On August 14, I went to the jail, but all of a sudden I felt sicker in the stomach than I had ever felt in my life. I was sweating profusely outside the jail and I could barely move. And I was cramping terribly. I wandered around looking for a bathroom, and suddenly I stumbled into the jail warden's home outside the prison. He remembered me and let me use his bathroom, and then, feeling a bit better, I went back to the *jagrti*.

The next day was August 15, Indian Independence Day, and Dadaji Ramananda said that Baba would only be seeing Indian margiis that day after 8 a.m. I was feeling the urgency to see Him, since my ticket back to the States was in only a few days. Feeling much stronger I went to Bankipur Jail at 7:30 in the morning. No one was outside and I simply went up to the front gate asking if I could see my Guru, Shrii Shrii Anandamurtiji. The guard nodded his head and said come right in as if Baba was expecting me and there was no problem. This time they didn't even check my passport but just brought me directly to Baba's cell. It was an unbelievable feeling of being guided by Baba.

This second time I saw Baba in Bankipur jail, I remember being asked by my Sectorial Secretary to ask Him certain questions about how He felt about homosexuality. I said, "There are a number of gay margiis in New York Sector who love you a lot. And want to know how you feel about homosexuality."

Baba paused, and He spoke these words. He said, "If you eat too much you'll be fat, if you sleep too much you'll be lethargic. If you bathe too much, you'll get pneumonia. And if you have too much sex, it will create psycho-physical disparallelism." (I'm not sure if He said psycho-physical or psycho-spiritual). "The goal is for the

microcosm to merge into the macrocosm. Do what is natural in your life. Search inside the deepest core of your heart and you'll find the answer. Do what is natural."

When I told this to the *acaryas* afterwards, they said, "Well, this is Baba's way of saying homosexuality is unnatural, because Baba wouldn't be the type of guru to say something is unnatural, he would just say do what is natural." But then when I explained what Baba said to the gay margiis here, they all felt Baba was talking to them and saying that what they were doing is natural.

At that time there was a party in India called Janata Party. There was one man, an old freedom fighter named J.P. Narayan who was being asked to take charge of that party. He was on kidney dialysis. I asked Baba what He thought of this person, and of the party. Baba said basically it was old wine in a new bottle. So we shouldn't pay them much attention. Then He said, "Don't be like an owl. All these people who criticize Ananda Marga are afraid to see the light. They live in the darkness, just like an owl. They only want to come out at night."

Towards the end, Baba was massaging my neck and head. I asked him if I could massage His feet. He said, "If you like." I was massaging His feet, and closing my eyes and trying to merge, and at the end I put His feet up to my *ajina cakra*. Then He said, "That's enough." I did *sastaung pranam*, and went out.

Devinistha

Northhampton, Massachusetts

I was initiated in December 1971. I first met Baba in jail, in December '77. I went with Cirasmita and Kalyanii and Cirasmita's daughter, who was 13 months old at the time.

We went to Patna, and we thought we'd pretend we were tourists, but of course no tourists go to Patna. We got a room in a hotel and didn't tell anyone we were with Ananda Marga. The next morning we told a rickshaw driver we wanted to go to Bankipur jail, and all down the street we could hear, "Bankipur jail, Bankipur jail." Everyone was saying, "They're margiis, they're margiis."

So we went to the jail, and they told us we had to get permission to get in. At the office, they took our application and said, "We don't know when you'll get approved." Every day we went back and asked if we got approved, and they always said, no. Finally we started getting pushy, and we didn't understand that there was any system, we just knew we only had a certain amount of time in India, and we wanted to see Baba. So we started staying there, we said we would not leave until we saw Him, and we started doing kiirtan all day long.

The officer would try to meet with people but we would not leave. Finally he told us our approval was there, and we picked it up and we went to the jail. And they wouldn't let us in. There was a crowd of people there, the man at the gate didn't understand English very well, and he wouldn't let us in. We didn't know what to do. Suddenly, Yatish Coley, who is now Dada Shambushivananda, walked out of the crowd and said, "Give me your passes, I'll get you in." He took our passes, went up to the guard, and we were let in. We turned around to thank him, and he was already gone.

Inside the jail we had to wait a long time. It was hot and there were other people also waiting there. Finally they started organizing people to go in; I got paired up with a sister from Europe. At that time Baba couldn't see very well, and it seemed like He was focusing on her. She was talking with Him, and I was sitting back and thinking, "Well, eventually He will talk to me. I'm just going to look at Baba and see how He looks, and memorize His face so I can remember it in my meditation."

So she talked to Baba, and all the time Baba talked about how important Prout was, and how we should be Proutists, and how if Prout did not achieve its goals, then Ananda Marga could not continue to exist. He talked about how if people did not have food and clothing, then they would not be able to do meditation. I had not had a chance to eat that day, and I had fasted the day before, but I was thinking, “I wonder if Baba will notice that I hadn’t eaten.”

At one point He turned and said, “If you do not take food, how can you do sadhana?” [laughs]. He was just talking about Prout, and yet it was the only thing He directed towards me, so it was interesting.

Then the guard started saying it was time for us to go, and I thought, “I thought Baba was going to talk to me but He only talked to her.” Baba had given us *prasad* at the beginning, hard candy, and I was curious to know whether He would touch a sister. He put His hands on mine and opened them up, and then He just rested His hands on mine. So I knew, “Oh, Baba’s not afraid to touch me, Baba feels comfortable.” We did *guru puja*, and at the end Baba touched each of us on our forehead, and that was the end of my first visit with Baba, it probably lasted about ten minutes.

As soon as we got out of the jail, we immediately applied for passes to see Baba again. Then I went to DMS in Delhi. We came back on an overnight train and got back to the hotel and someone said we had passes waiting for us. We hardly had time to change our clothes before we rushed off to get our passes.

This time the three of us went in together. Baba was very open this time. At the beginning He said, “Tell me your story.” And it was like an opportunity for each of us to ask Him a question or tell Him something. Kalyanii started to tell Him some good news, and Baba shook His head, like, “This is not what I’m looking for.”

He turned to Cirasmita, and she said, “Baba, I just want to love more,” and Baba nodded His head, then turned to Kalyanii, who said, “Baba, I just want more bliss,” and Baba nodded His head, and turned to me. The night before I had been sitting in a hotel room, and put a table in the room, and was doing kiirtan round and round, until I finally fell over in bliss on my bed. And I had been wanting to ask Baba for a new name, and Baba had said to me internally, “When you merge in me, your name is Purusa.” I had

gotten the answer to my question, which was, when you merge in Him, names don't matter. But I could think of nothing else to ask Him, so I said, "I want a new name."

He nodded His head as if to say that was as important as love and bliss. And I thought to myself, "They want love and bliss, and I want a name?" So then He was laying down on His side, and put His head on his arms, and He was making these sounds, like, "Hmmm," and we're sitting there, our hearts opening up so much because Baba's making these sweet sounds like a baby. Then He opened up His eyes and turned to each of us, and turned to Cirasmita and said, "Do you know *pranayama*?" and she said, "Yes," and He nodded His head.

He turned to Kalyanii and asked, "Do you know how to do *japa*?"

"Yes, Baba," and He nodded.

He turned to me and said, "You will get a new name at the proper time." Then Kalyanii asked Baba what women could do in labor to reduce the pain. And He talked about the different *cakras*, and how if you had pain in your leg, then the lower *cakras* are where you concentrate; as you go up the body, the higher the pain, the higher the *cakra* you concentrate on. But, for childbirth, He said, the woman should concentrate on *ajina cakra*, or better yet, *ista cakra*. A couple of weeks later He gave a birth meditation for sisters in labor.

I asked a question about Women's Welfare Department (WWD). At that time we were trying to get WWD going in the States. "It's very confusing in the States. People think we will have separate dharmacakras, that the brothers and sisters will be divided."

Baba said, "Of course there will be adjustment according to time, place and person. WWD is simply an organization to serve the needs of women, and women have special needs in society." He seemed to refer to women who were abused by their husbands as people who could get help from WWD. Then He said WWD could help men, and referred to the men who abused women as those who could also get help. And He said that while WWD could take help from men – men could help in their projects – that WWD should take no direction from them, should decide their own direction. He made clear that how WWD worked in the U.S. or other parts of the world might be different than India. And again we got to do *guru puja*, and then we were ushered out.

I want to tell a story about my early time in AM. After I began back at college, my meditation began to be very hard for me, a struggle. One of the dadas, a Filipino named Dada Jiitendra, was coming through. But Dada was very busy initiating people. The only time he could get was when he was taking food just before he left town. So he set me down at the table, and turned to me and the first thing he said to me was, “How is your meditation?”

“Well, not that good, Dada.”

“You must sit for at least half an hour each time.” I was like, right, I can’t even sit for fifteen minutes.

And he said, “Why don’t you come with me to Vancouver?” He was driving from Bellingham to Vancouver, about a two-hour drive. We were driving in the car together, and it broke down.

And Dada said, “Well, this often happens to me. Even planes sometimes don’t get off the ground, because if I don’t do my meditation, things will break down, and I’ll have my chance to do meditation. Let’s all go and do meditation.” So we went and sat down in the grass, and I had no problem with my meditation, I was feeling blissful. And then someone came back and said, “The car’s working,” and we all went back to the car and drove off again. After that I had no problem sitting for half an hour. That meditation on the side of the hill sort of cured my problem of being too restless to do meditation.

Another time, I was an LFT, and we were riding in a step van. I was sitting behind the front seats, on the floor, there were two lanes going each way, and a signal ahead, which was green. We were going 40-50 m.p.h. and suddenly a car pulled in and stopped right in the middle of the roadway, blocking both lanes. Our driver slammed on the brake and skidded past the other car into the turning lane. We were all yelling “Baba, Baba, Baba!” And the car stopped and where the dashboard had been completely covered with things – a timer, keys, and a Baba photo – after we stopped everything from there flew off except the Baba picture. It was not tied down or anything, but it stayed there.

Another time I was riding a bicycle, coming down the road and a car was coming towards me. It started to turn and would have hit me, and I pulled into the wrong lane. An old man was driving and still he didn’t see me. I was falling off the bike. And I said,

“Baba!” And as soon as I said, “Baba,” the car stopped. Another time I was riding a bike and this dog came running out, barking. I was really scared and I shouted “Baba!” and the dog went running away. These are several of my little individual Baba stories, about when I called on Him in my life.

Shiva Genosoa, New York

My first meeting with Baba occurred indirectly, in a way that might be difficult for many to comprehend. It was September of 1972, when I was in the last phase of completing my doctoral thesis at the University of Minnesota. Quite unexpectedly, I enrolled in a yoga class, and I was not only surprised but amazed to find how relaxing and satisfying the class was for me. I attended each yoga class eagerly, feeling that the yoga was becoming a capstone experience for my doctoral education.

By December, I was initiated and in full swing. I decided to give back what I had received. I would simply teach a yoga class; nothing else, no guru stuff, which had little appeal for me and my imagined students. I knew very little about Baba at that time, except that He was in prison. Yet I also felt that I needed to say something about Baba, even though I did not personally know Him, for I knew, even then, that He was the force behind my instruction and initiation. I had been told that Baba had advised margiis not to talk about Him but rather to talk about dharma instead – advice that I found refreshing, since the world seemed to be awash with gurus in Rolls Royces who were only too happy to talk about themselves.

So it seemed even more fitting to say something about a man who said, “Don’t talk about me.” I decided to make my statement about Baba without words. I made a small wooden lattice, slung it over my shoulders, and wrote a sign inside the lattice (which was meant to represent prison bars): “BABA IS IN PRISON.” I wore this lattice and sign wherever I went, and I only took it off when I bathed and went to sleep. The effect of this nonverbal communication was surprising. Many people asked, when they saw the sign, “Who is Baba?”

After I made a brief reply – something to the effect that He was a spiritual teacher who was in prison because He opposed the policies of Indira Gandhi – many people expressed concern and wished him well. Others, who took a little more time with me,

commented, “This is quite interesting. Your teacher is saying, perhaps to us all, that the only place for innocence in our corrupt world is jail. Your teacher is quite something!” “Yes,” I would respond, all the while realizing that I did not know the half of it.

So this was my first meeting with Baba: what I call “lower case” Baba. I introduced Baba to people on the street; they introduced Baba to me. For me, even at that time, Baba was universal. “He” was everywhere – no magic guru stuff. My parents taught me as much, only their word for it was God. So I did something for Baba, and something was done for me. Though indirect, it was sufficient. Since I thought I never needed a spiritual teacher, I felt nurtured by the comments I heard, as well as by the many sights and sounds around me. These included the golden sunsets that illuminated the steel-grey skies of the Minnesota winters, the envelope of silence and reflection that accompanied my student days, and the faith that all things would work out, though I did not know how or why. I was to live four years with this understanding of Baba. I felt that I didn’t need anything more, though I was curious who this man in India was.

My next meeting with Baba was what I called “upper case” Baba. I met this form of Baba in an extraordinary meditation experience. After a lovely kiirtan with several brothers and sisters who were also learning yoga in the Minneapolis *jagrti*, I sat down to meditate. Soon all kinds of strange and wonderful sensations accompanied my meditation. To put it simply, it felt as if the sun were bursting in my heart. This experience lasted for some time, and I was quite overcome by it, as were my brothers and sisters, who were unable to ignore my involuntary cries, and who were also somehow profoundly moved by it.

This was my first meeting with this form of Baba – pure and simple; direct, not indirect; inside, not outside, through report or comment from others. In the days that followed, I began to realize that Guru is enlightened ecstasy, and resides within. This stage of realization was also sufficient for me. I felt I didn’t need anything more. But that created another question. Who was this “little brown man in India” whom I had never met physically? What was the connection between what I felt, “upper case Baba,” and the historical personality who lived far away, in a country I never dreamed of visiting?

I decided to work for Baba’s Mission in 1974. For four years, I worked and experienced an enormous amount of turmoil. Death and rebirth were frequent

occurrences; they were as regular as the seasons. Before I was to meet Baba physically, I was to meet Him again, in deep sadness, in an experience I call “dream” Baba. What set this in motion was a painful divorce. My former wife left both our spiritual path and our marriage, and my life, I felt, was shattered (though it had actually been liberated in a way that I could not understand). I suffered for months, not understanding why I was in such pain. Many of my friends were surprised, as if this were something that I should be able to take in stride. Only my family realized how deeply hurt and disoriented I was.

One night, as I was dreaming, I saw a man who looked like Baba. The dream figure turned and began to talk to me. He reminded me of the path I had walked in former lifetimes. He showed me many masters who had guided me in previous lives. As He called their names, in languages that were strange to me, I saw their luminous and exquisitely beautiful faces appear before me, and I recognized them and was breathless at this miraculous sight. They were so beautiful! Their names were strangely familiar, though I did not have the impression that I had ever heard of them or read about them. Then Baba said to me, “It is time for you to come to me. You must stop grieving and move.”

I woke up in a sweat, profoundly altered. I had already planned to go to Taiwan to study acupuncture. Incredulous, I thought that this might be the language of my unconscious encouraging me to follow through with my plan. The distance between me and that little brown man in India was closing. A few short months later, after traveling across our lovely land – from the Eastern Appalachians, to the Rockies, Arizona, the Grand Canyon, and the welcoming coasts and beaches of California – I found myself on a flight to Taiwan. The acupuncture adventure fizzled out – it was too impractical for my age and time schedule. Then surprising news came: Baba had just been released from prison.

I was encouraged to go see him, and I decided to make the attempt, even though many margiis had been stopped by hostile Indian immigration officers. A few days later, I stepped down on the tarmac of Dum Dum, Kolkata’s airport, and I immediately sensed that this would be friendly ground for me. As chance would have it, I met Dada Vijayananda on the transfer bus from the airport and traveled with him to attend my first darshan with Baba that evening. I will never forget my first impression of the physical

form of Baba – the external Baba, the little man in India about whom I had heard so much. My immediate impressions of him were twofold: first, I sensed that He could be very tough, a kind of wrestler, a person who could and would endure; second, I sensed that He was almost impenetrable, too difficult for me to fathom – very deep, perhaps even cagey – but not dangerous, just uncanny. I had never met anyone like this in my life.

I soon realized, as I heard Him talk, surrounded by so many devotees, that I would never be able to really know Him as a person, the way so many of the Indian margiis had. So I settled for what I felt was my next best option: to get to know Him through the dadas and didis who apparently knew Him well – or at least knew Him better than I. It was a good strategy, in retrospect, for three things were working at once for me: lower case Baba, upper case Baba, and just plain Baba, this strange little man sitting in front of me, the real hyphen who was playing a funny game that was somehow beyond me. In my personal contact with Him, I discovered Him to be like silk: I sat in front of Him, and I felt like a caveman looking blindly into the light. He was full of all kinds of jokes, corrections, and tenderness. I felt very comfortable in His presence, which is something like the silence that envelopes you now as you read these words.

I decided to follow Baba around India as he made a three-month tour – Kolkata, Delhi, Bombay, Madras. I made His schedule mine, and my visa seemed to agree with the plan. I learned so much from this journey, filled as it was with Baba's steady presence, which buffered the many jolts and shocks of the road, the normal deprivations, illnesses, and disappointments that accompany all travel. I also had the helpful advice of a few senior dadas, who looked after me as if I were their younger brother. Eventually, at the end of the journey, I was expelled from India by vigilant Indian authorities, who were also playing their game, which was actually quite unpleasant. What had happened in all of this was a deepening and unfolding of experience that time would turn into a treasure, once I had the opportunity to sift through everything and integrate it more fully. This treasure, I found, would enable me to understand and overcome the many challenges that lay ahead.

Without the experience of what I call triple Baba (lower case, upper case, and dream case, with “just plain” thrown in for extra measure – the proof of grace, if you will), who knows where I would be today, if I even would be today? This is impossible to

answer. But as I sum it up, I return to something quite simple: my cup has continually been filled with more, though I have not sought more. Not once, but three times – and then again, for good measure. It reminds me of something my first astrology teacher taught me: everything important in the birth chart is revealed in at least three ways. Take it from there – and my best wishes to you! Dharma leads to guru. Be true to what you know, what is true will come to know you.

Guhan

Englewood, Colorado

My first spiritual experience was in the year 1966 or 1967. I was about 20 years old and attending junior college near the Los Altos *jagrti*. I was caught up in the habits of my culture, i.e., smoking, drinking, dating, recreational drugs etc. I'd had a falling out with my Catholic upbringing and at this time I was not practicing any religion or spiritual discipline.

One evening I was in my room, a small concrete basement in a modest home. As I sat on the edge of the bed, I felt myself falling into a kind of trance. My head and senses seemed to melt away like candle wax and I found myself in my heart *cakra*. It was a glowing white color, and I was in a wonderful state of bliss. There was a person, a man, sitting in my heart *cakra* opposite me and some distance away. As I looked at him, I noticed waves of energy emanating from his body and coming towards me. And then I noticed his shoes. He was wearing penny-loafers and for some reason I kept looking at his shoes, at his feet.

I have no idea of time in this experience, as it was beyond time but as the experience started to fade, I felt anxious and upset because I realized I was coming back to the earthly plane. And then in the next moment, I realized I had to come back and finish my work, due to *samskara*. So here I was, back on the earthly plane, reality. The bliss was gone. I was saying to myself, "What was that?" And I realized I could not share this experience with anyone, not my mother, not my friends. They would not understand or would think I was crazy.

Fast forward now about four or five years. I was living in the Oregon woods. Dharmaputra, my high school friend, was living in the Palo Alto *jagrti* and invited me down to see a yoga monk from India. So I packed up all my stuff, arrived in the Bay area, was initiated by Dada Yatiishvarananda and moved into the *jagrti* with DP and other margiis.

After several weeks of living there, one day I found myself all alone in the *dharmacakra* room. I was standing at the mantle of the fireplace near a *pratik* and picture of Baba. All of a sudden, I looked at Baba's picture and said, "Oh, my God! There you

are!” It was the same person who had been in my heart *cakra* several years before. I turned and looked back and in a flash I saw the whole arc of my life and I thought, “Who is doing this? It’s not me. I may think I am but someone else is.” And I realized that God was doing everything!

I was a margii living in the Palo Alto *jagrti* near Stanford from 1971 on. Years went by. Many margiis traveled to India to see Baba or try to see Him, as He was in jail. You could fly to India from the USA for \$450 at that time on Air India. I was content and felt my time would come to meet Him. And it did. It was spring of 1978. After finishing some work, I found myself alone in New York in March. I arranged a flight to Bombay. Upon arrival there and after going through the initial culture shock of India, I proceeded to Patna where Baba was incarcerated in the Bankipore jail. I met Asutosha from Canada there and several other margiis trying to see Baba in the prison. I learned that we had to receive permission from the district magistrate to visit Baba, so I proceeded to his office in Patna. This Indian government official was not at all happy to see me.

“Why do you foreigners come so far to see a criminal?” he said. I kept quiet. After he was through venting, I told him I would like to visit Baba in the jail and I also would like permission for Asutosha. He told me to leave our passports and come back on Tuesday. This was on Friday. I thought it strange that in the midst of deportations, harrassments and persecution of Ananda Marga and its leader and members, I could just walk right up to a district magistrate, declare myself a margii and ask to see Baba, a prisoner, without being arrested myself! And even stranger, when I returned to his office on Tuesday, he gave me two permits to see Baba, one for myself and one for Asutosha.

In great anticipation, we headed to the jail to see Baba. When we arrived there, the prison superintendant and the guards were even more upset with us than the district magistrate. Our presence infuriated them! They told us point blank that we could not see Baba. They put us in a room and told us to wait. After some time, they came and led us to Baba’s cell. My heart was in my throat! I was nervous. I was finally going to see my guru. They led us to the cloth door of the cell. I found myself in front, and didn’t want to be in front. I hesitated for a moment and then pulled back the curtain and entered Baba’s cell.

He was lying on a cot looking directly toward me and giving namaskar. As I walked toward Him with a garland in hand, a clear ancient voice in my mind said, “Oh my God, He is in the human form!”

I reached Him and placed a garland around Him and Asutosha did the same. We did namaskar and then Asutosha spoke first saying, “Baba, I want to massage your feet.” Baba said OK and Asutosha moved to the end of the cot and started to give Him a foot massage. All of a sudden, I found myself face to face with my guru. Baba reached out and touched my cheek and gazed into my eyes for a few moments. I could only match His gaze for a short time and then I closed my eyes. It was so special.

He then asked our names and our duties. When I said my duty was VSS, He said, “You are a very small boy with a very big job to do.”

Then He rolled over on the cot to His other side and glanced out the small cell window and said, “Didi Uma, Dada Gagan and Dada Lokesh, they are the flame of my New Year’s *vanii*.”

Then He rolled back and faced us again and said, “Prout is the need of the hour. He reached out and touched my cheek again and gazed into my eyes. I could only hold His glance for a short time and then I closed my eyes again. He invited us to say something. I had two questions.

“Baba,” I asked, “is Subash Chandra Bose still alive?”

He glanced around the cell and looked at the CBI agent sitting in the corner and then back at me and said, “Now is not the proper time to answer that question.” Then He laughed and in His hearty laughter, I got the answer!

Then I asked Him about the origin of the swastika, a symbol which is very controversial in the West. Baba said, “Lord Shiva created the swastika.” Using His hands and fingers, He described the different aspects and meaning of it. Our time with Him came to a close. The most beautiful time for me was when Baba said, “Now you do *guru puja*.” Baba sat in a certain *mudra* or posture. We did it, and Baba received it. Then He said we must go now, go back and do our work. As we were leaving Baba was giving *prasad*, this sweet candy, this rock candy, just too much of it. It was falling all around, too much of it, my two hands couldn’t hold it all. When I returned to my hotel room and I

was all alone again, I was so happy. I felt I was one of the luckiest people in the whole world!

Then I thought – the candy! I was looking in my pockets, saying, “Where is it? He gave me all this rock candy.” Finally, I picked out a little handful. I thought to myself, “Oh God, that was Baba’s vibration.” He gave me candy, and I thought it was all this candy, but it was Baba! His vibration. It was just a little bit of candy! [laughs].

Gayatrii

Highland Heights, Kentucky

In 1969 I was initiated and began to read His books. Even to read the words in His books – the words of His discourses – even to see those words put me into an enthralled state, a state of intoxication, and a state of divine excitement, of spiritual ecstasy. Why? Because, I could feel, they were the words of GOD. GOD is who? Generator, Operator, Destroyer. He is all these things.

In October 1971, I waited outside on the tarmac of the airport in Cochin, Kerala, India, for the plane to arrive which was carrying my Lord. It was the first time to see Him in real physical form. Waiting and watching, waiting and watching – and lo, He appeared at the open door of the plane. Slowly, He came down the steps. Then He walked, quickly, doing namaskar as He moved. Inexplicably, I also moved, and was running silently behind Him, keeping up with Him, unbearably attracted to a Stranger who was also my Greatest Love. As no others ran, I stopped. Then a kindly brother told me, “Go ahead, run.” So I ran still faster to catch Him – that Elusive One, that Glorious One, in simple white cotton clothes and black spectacles. But – He moved faster! In the next moment, He was sitting in silence, hands folded in namaskar.

One by one we filed past the Most Illustrious One, most humble, most sweet love of my heart. As I passed, I gazed long and deep at this Stranger, this Unknown Traveler, taking in every detail of His form – the shape of His head, His hair combed back straight and smooth, His eyes hiding behind large glasses. As I gazed at His silent, motionless form, I knew. He knows all. He feels all. He loves all. He controls all. He is Master of the Universe. I knew, there was nothing about me that He did not know. As I gazed, I knew these facts. And receiving these facts, I felt such an unbearable thrill, such divine excitement – how to bear it! How to keep still! I wanted to scream to the sky His true identity. But, I moved on. I walked on.

Then high fever came and I could not rise from the bed. I wept for missing Him, missing His darshan, one day and then the next. Then my loving brother came and made sweet *mosambee* juice for me, and told me, “Baba was talking about you! He was saying, ‘She is my small, small child!’”

I asked my brother many times, “Are you sure? Are you sure?”

“Yes!” he said, “Baba was talking about you with so much love, so much affection!” Next day I determined to go, fever or no. Morning darshan was held. I sat in the front, and sang a song I had written a few weeks after initiation. I sang, ‘O Baba mine, Thou art so dear, O Baba mine, Thou art so sweet, O take me in Thy loving arms, and give me all devotion to Thee. I see Thee walking in the forest, I see Thee sitting in the field, I see Thee smiling, eyes half closed. So full of love, that’s how I see Thee...’

I sang this song, full of shyness. Then Baba came. I was completely transfixed. I only remember how beautiful, how magnificent He looked, and how happy and content I felt to do *Guru Puja* (the process of surrendering body, mind and soul unto His effulgence) to Him for the first time.

Then my Baba left. My Baba was in prison for so many years, in such unbearable conditions, in heat and squalor, in a small cell. He was so far away. But, He was also so close. Once I was at the train station in Madras saying goodbye to my elder brother. Suddenly Baba was in front of me, smiling. Stunned, I moved my gaze. But He was still there. Wherever I gazed, Baba remained! I felt so much bliss at seeing Him everywhere – I could hardly move, hardly speak! That was in 1973.

Years rolled by. I was in Houghton, Michigan, a tiny town in America. Baba was so far, far away. Suddenly, in 1978, Baba was free! I sent Him so many packets of flower and vegetable seeds – more than 100 packets. One day somebody told me that Baba acknowledged the seeds. He said that 80% of the seeds bore fruit. I was confused and asked my neighbor, a gardener about it. He said it was an excellent percentage, if 80% came up, and I was so thrilled. Baba wanted me to know that He loved the flowers as much as I did – more even – and that He had taken personal care of their growth! I was so happy.

Later that day I went to the department store. As I waited to pay the cashier, suddenly, Baba was in front of me. I could not believe it! And again, when I changed the direction of my gaze, He was there again! Everywhere I looked, there was Baba. I began crying uncontrollably, there in the store. It was too much; it was too overwhelming. I felt too undeserving of His grace, of His love. Why, when, where and how He gave His darshan – only He knows.

Sudhiir

Ananda Kanan, Missouri

I was in San Francisco. You might say I'd reached the end of my material voyage, that I couldn't find happiness that way. I was always searching for something that was real. Somehow I got hold of a copy of *Autobiography of a Yogi*, and from then decided that yoga was the path for me.

I decided to look for some way to learn yoga. I heard there were a couple of groups, and one was Ananda Marga. The other group wanted to charge money, and I didn't feel it was right to charge money for something so integral, so I tried AM. The first time I visited there was a big commotion going on, because Madhusudhan had just gotten back from India, where he had had a lot of personal contact with Baba. He had this incredible vibration, had spent so much time with Baba that he practically could light up the room at night. He got everyone else excited. A retreat in Hutchinson, Kansas, was coming up. I went home first, and had meat three times a day at my mother's house. Then I went to this retreat and that was goodbye to carnivorousism.

I got initiated the first of the year, 1971 and it changed my life. I was really desperate up to that point, saw no point in going on, no purpose to life. How could I live without a purpose? Once I knew that yoga was my purpose, everything just kept getting better.

I heard that Dada Yatiishvarananda was coming to the *jagrti* to visit, so I went there. I had been doing *nama mantra* for a couple of months. I felt I was sufficiently advanced to get first lesson. He stopped me before I entered the room, and said, "Who are you and how long have you been meditating?"

"Well, Dada, I've been meditating for a couple of months. Can I have first lesson?"

"No, it's out of the question, get out of here" [laughs].

I was so clashed out that I decided to leave AM forever. I went hitchhiking around and ended up in this place. I meditated there, and switched my mantra a couple of times, because I was experimenting, meditating under a fig tree, living this country life. After a

couple of months, I decided to go to the Bay area, where I saw a notice for sleeping bag cleaning, which I needed to do. I went to the place, and when the woman opened the door, she said, “You’re a margii.”

“How do you know?”

“You just look like a margii.” It was Cirismita, who lived in Berkeley, and she said, “There’s this retreat happening, you have to go.”

I said, “Oh, I’ve heard this before, I don’t really want to go.”

But something inside made me pause, and I said to myself, “I’ll go to the retreat, and if it doesn’t look good to me, and it probably won’t, I’ll go on to the Rainbow Gathering.”

So I went to Kansas again, and got so inspired, I decided to sign up for the Ananda Marga Universal Relief Team (AMURT). Dada Yatiishvarananda was recruiting people for the first AMURT team. They would get training, and then, it seemed to me like we were going to be parachuted into the trouble spots of the earth to save humanity! Which is what I wanted to do.

I went to Wichita for the training. Madhavi was the trainer in charge, and she was giving people all kinds of experiences. We were going to preschools, and homes, working with the retarded and the elderly, and all different kinds of social service groups, so I got all this exposure to these things which were completely new to me, and I had many experiences in a short period of time. Plus first aid training, so that we could be this SWAT team of AMURT. Meanwhile Dada started throwing lessons at me. I didn’t want any lessons from this man, and now he wanted to give me all these lessons, all the way up to sixth lesson. Because who knows, we’d be in Afghanistan or somewhere, and who knows what lesson we’d need [laughs].

Toward the end of our training, Baba had said we were supposed to start an LFT training program. Madhurii, who is now Didi Ananda Mitra, was to be the trainer. This was 1973.

We got a very good training from Madhurii and Tom Barefoot, now Giridhara. They put us through everything they could think of, a combination of bliss and clash. I couldn’t wait to leave. We all got postings, as they were thinking about filling needs for

AM in various places around the country. I was assigned to be the editor of the Crimson Dawn newsletter in Wichita.

At that time Baba had just been put in prison. Everyone at the sectorial office started going around the country attending all these protests and vigils for Baba in Washington, D.C., and Atlanta. As LFTs we were also supposed to be informing all the margiis about Baba. At a rally in Washington, I met the person whom I would marry. We started a RAWA *jagrti* in Atlanta, the first RAWA project in the sector. Also at the time we were starting Seva Ananda, a whole foods store, which later evolved into Seva Ananda Natural Foods co-op, which became the largest natural foods warehouse in the southeast of the U.S.

People were saying you have to go see Baba, they're now allowing people to visit Him in prison. This was a change. Before only a few top *acaryas*, and lawyers, etc., could see Him. Now, general margiis started to go see Baba.

In August, 1977, I had my first meeting with Baba in prison in Patna. I went with a few margiis who later all became *acaryas*. We had to go through a whole procedure to get permission. I was very nervous.

I saw Baba, and was so shocked. I'd heard he'd been fasting and was very weak, but He looked like a frail old person lying on his cot. Words can't express seeing Him in that state. The person I'd waited so long to see [crying].

He was saying, "Come closer, come closer," so I ended up the first one in, and I came closest to His head, and He kept saying, "Come closer, come closer," it just didn't seem to be close enough. He gave me permission to get so close that I was able to put my arm around His shoulders. It seems funny to think about it – the most incredible being in the universe.

I felt He was frail; I felt like comforting Him. I put my arm around His shoulder [crying]. I had no idea at the time how lucky I was to be able to do that. And I'm sure that was part of Baba's plan, to do this at the time I was so dumb and naive about everything. It just seemed like such a natural thing to want to do, to want to put your arm around your Baba.

I don't remember everything that happened, because from that point on my mind was pretty much gone. I was experiencing, I wasn't thinking. I do remember asking Him to say something about Renaissance Artists and Writers Association (RAWA.) I'm interested in art, I'm an artist. He really liked the question.

He said, "Renaissance Universal (RU) is like this" and made motions like two cymbals clashing together, "to create clash in the mind, and to bring people, by powdering down the mind, closer to *Parama Purusa*."

Then He said, "RAWA is to attract people's hearts to love *Parama Purusa*, to get closer, by the attraction of love through art." That was kind of the end of my time with my arm around Baba. I understood it was time for me to move aside so the other brothers could get close to Him.

You could barely hear Him, His voice was so low and quiet. I went to His feet, and I started massaging His feet [crying]. I spent the rest of the time massaging His feet, and didn't really hear anything else. I can't even remember who the other people were or what they were saying. We just sort of floated out. He gave us some candy, or *prasad*, to give to other people. And He said, "Come again, please. Come again and again."

I went back to Patna, and went to see Baba a second time. When I went to get permission in the office, the officer said, "You again?" I thought it was over, but he just laughed, and gave me the permission. So I went back in the cell with Baba again. It was *Shravanii Purnima*, and Baba said, "You've come on a most auspicious occasion." He made a big deal about it, and said, "I want to convey a message to the margiis, so remember the words."

It was something like, "Let my sons and daughters be loved by all good people of the universe." He explained that *Shravanii Purnima* is when the star Shravana, symbolizing the devotee, is closest to the moon, symbolizing the Beloved. It's the closest proximity of the devotee and the guru. That's exactly what was happening at the moment. We were this close to Baba [crying]. I'm only just beginning to understand what really happened there.

Afterwards, we did our *sastaung pranam* and said our goodbyes, and all the dadas said, "What happened?"

“Well,” we said, “He gave some words.”

“Oh, a *vanii* from Baba!”

So they took us to Baba’s house, and somebody typed up the message from Baba. We got to see all His clothes and shoes, His slippers and cane, everything just the way it was when He was taken to the prison years before.

Arpana Devi Detroit, Michigan

I went to see Baba in jail in 1977. Circumstances orchestrated the situation so that I had to enter Baba’s jail cell first out of our group of seven margiis. I was quite apprehensive about seeing Baba, knowing of His omniscience and fearing exposure of faults, insecurities, imperfections, etc.

When I entered the cell, Baba was propped up, doing namaskar (first, as always). His presence was overwhelming. I met, not the omniscient “judge” I feared, but a being radiating pure and unconditional love. I knew, without a doubt, that He was incapable of any thought, perception, or expression of any kind that was not for my welfare. All self-consciousness melted away like the darkness disappears in the presence of light. Absolute love and trust remained, and as I flew toward home, I felt that the plane was taking me away from where I wanted to be, my true home.

After seeing Baba, I had several Baba dreams. The common theme in them was that I was able to connect with Baba when I was deviating from “the crowd,” or doing something I wasn’t supposed to do.

In one dream I was with a group in a big house with many stairways, and doorways with VSS guards everywhere. Our guide took us to see Baba, and I realized after we had left the room and were leaving the house, that I hadn’t actually seen or connected with Baba. I ducked away from the group, edging along walls and ducking away from guards into doorways, working my way back toward Baba’s room. I opened many doors, and finally found His room.

He was sitting at a desk facing me, in an obviously important and private meeting. He looked up, became very angry, and in a terrible voice said, “What are you doing here?”

I just said His name, and did *pranam*. When I looked up, He was beaming a big smile at me.

In another dream, I was in the New York City airport, with an enthusiastic crowd of margiis waiting to see Baba. We were on a ground floor terminal, and VSS guards announced that we had to all go to another floor. I ducked away and stood alone in the corridor. I heard footsteps, and Baba and a companion rushed by with a briefcase in hand with their heads down. After He passed me, I called His name and He turned to cast His eternal smile at me.

Svarupa

Albuquerque, New Mexico

I was initiated in 1973 by Dada Shishir Kumar.

I was 18, and searching for something. One particular day, I came home from work, feeling it was some low point in my life. Baba talks about something called *samviit*, which is that peculiar force that awakens all of a sudden your desire for spirituality. It happened when I came home from work, and was lying on my bed, listening to the radio. The radio had a spiritual discourse from Ram Dass. He was a spiritual teacher, an American, and he had a guru.

Almost instantly, from the moment I heard his voice, and heard him speak about spirituality, and *Tantra*, very much like Baba's philosophy, from that very second it awakened this desire within me. I knew I had to find something to fulfill this desire. I didn't know where to look or where to turn. The first thing I found was a free magazine at a university, with an advertisement for some free classes. I called, and it turned out to be a *jagrti*. The classes were over, but they invited me to come anyway. I went, and it was my first *dharmacakra* (DC). Over the next few months I continued going, and still had this great admiration for Ram Dass. He had a book out.

At one of the DCs, I came and there was a large crowd there. I didn't know what was going on. We were waiting for DC, and a large number of people came in, all dressed in white. It turned out to be a group of people accompanying Ram Dass. That night he had given a speech in Albuquerque, and some margiis were there and invited him to *dharmacakra*. To me that was a great experience. It happened to me many times in my life that Baba fulfills desires, if you're following His path. Even before I was margii, it was the closing of some spiritual circle that I needed to close. Ram Dass was really my first spiritual teacher, and Baba brought him to the *dharmacakra* for me. In fact, I had my first spiritual experience in *sadhana*, a fantastic experience. Ram Dass is a great yogi, and has deep spiritual insight. Anyway, that sort of closed a chapter for me.

In 1977 or 1976, I had one experience. A lot of margiis had the same experience. It was at a sectorial seminar in Oklahoma. Lots of people were there, during a *dharmacakra*, in a large hall. They had just finished showing Baba's video. Baba finished

giving the DMC talk, and they stopped the picture with Baba doing his *mudra*. Then everyone went into doing sadhana, a long sadhana.

Something curious happened. Many times people have individual experiences in sadhana, jumping or making noise. This particular time maybe not the whole group, but certain parts of the whole group shared the same strange experience. First people started jumping. That settled down, and then people started laughing, chuckling. People couldn't control it, and it was like waves of this strange behavior going across the crowd. And then people started crying. And then for some of us, smells came into the auditorium.

Later that same year, I went to India the first time, Oct. '77, and He was still in prison. In between visits to the prison, a few margiis decided to go to Jamalpur. The first place we visited was the school. The dada there started showing us around. In a courtyard corner they used to have darshans. We went into a room and he said, "This is where Baba used to give darshan." As soon as I walked into this room, the same smell as I'd smelled at that *dharmacakra* came to me. There was no incense burning.

My first visit with Baba was in prison. You had to make multiple trips to the prison authorities to get the papers, and then had to come back until they saw fit to see you. Eventually you'd get an appointment and go to the prison. Then at the prison you went through the process of being fingerprinted and interviewed by the authorities and so forth, and that's when a lot of people were blacklisted, they wouldn't let you back in after that. But after that you were able to see Baba.

His cell was open to the courtyard, with no bars, just a cloth hanging over the door, but there were guards. When we saw Baba it was not alone, but with several margiis, and a guard. But the guard stood back and after a while, in Baba's presence, you didn't even notice the guard. When you came in the doorway Baba was lying on His cot. I heard a lot of stories about how emaciated Baba was, but because this was the end of '77, somehow His health had come back.

We did *pranam*, and Baba asked each of us our names, and our organizational positions. I was working in an Ananda Marga co-op in Albuquerque, and doing some related work, part of Food and Care Dept. Even now we do work in Food and Care. It was a nice experience, because Baba said, "Oh, that's very good."

Then He asked everyone if they had any questions. I didn't really have one. My impressions of that and of the second visit, were just about being in Baba's presence. One of my reasons for going was to just understand who Baba was, and what He really meant. I knew from His books and from sadhana who my guru was, but still I wasn't 100 percent sure. Seeing His eyes I no longer had any doubts. In prison, He gave you very direct focus; you could look directly into His eyes. You felt a sort of bottomlessness in Baba's eyes that went on forever. We were there for half an hour. He blessed us, put His hand on each of our heads, gave us candy, and we did *guru puja*.

It was a very strange time in India, because magazines had all these strange articles on Ananda Marga. AM was being accused of murder, and all kinds of horrible things, in their equivalent of TIME magazine. You couldn't go to a newsstand without seeing these things. It was a crazy time to be there.

On the trip to Jamalpur, there were CBI agents following margiis on the train. One gentleman asked me why I was going to Jamalpur. Then he tried to convince me that I shouldn't go. Later I realized this was someone following margiis and trying to keep them from going to their destinations. As soon as I got off someone met me at the platform and started asking the same questions. We had a lot of experiences like that, and we had to take a resolve to get through it all. In retrospect it was *tantric*, really, having to go through struggles in order to maintain devotion.

Cakreshvara

Seattle, Washington

It has been nearly twenty-five years from the one time that I met Baba, to the time that I am now writing this account. The memory however is as if this were only yesterday. May this heartfelt story be preserved and added to the garland of His incomprehensible legacy. By my word, these events are in truth and from personal experience.

A group of us had finished training in Sweden and were about to be sent into the world to realize His mission. I had undergone severe clash over memorizing endless *shlokas* without having translations... so many meaningless nonsense syllables to my analytic mind. I began to have severe resentment over what I thought was Indian-style clash for the sake of clash. At any rate, the training was about over and it was hinted that I would be taking a posting as RAWA Secretary in Europe. As a former studio musician, this was the closest prospect to heaven on earth. I had toured the continent, spoken with RAWA devotees and was formulating plans for a professional recording center.

Our reverend trainer took best care for our wellbeing. He intuitively analyzed the nature of our karmas and sent his recommendations to Baba as to where our talents could best be utilized. It was, however, the Lord's pleasure as to where we ultimately arrived.

Before leaving for our postings, the trainer said that all of his recommendations for our assignments were approved by Baba except for one of us. One was to be posted to Central Office in India. He would not tell us who this was until training was finalized. There was much excitement and conjecture. I was secretly thinking that as much as I had mentally blasphemed the very inventor of the *shloka*, the Sanskrit language, and everything remotely associated with Indian culture, at least that person was not me. As it turned out, when the postings were revealed, my position as Berlin Sector RAWA Secretary was scratched out in simple pencil by the Lord's own hand. In the place was His direction, "Central Office." I was in a mixed state of unbelief and reverie.

Baba was in the Patna jail at the time. The *jagrti* was alive with an international assembly of margiis from over the world, coming to pay respect to their Beloved.

One brother Hanuman was there also awaiting darshan. Hanuman was distressed over his Sanskrit name. This brother was in the final phase of formal study as a homeopathic physician and was given the name Hanuman by an acarya in Europe. I noted the similarity with the name Hahneman, the father of modern homeopathy. This brother knew little about Indian mythology, but was told that Hanuman was a venerable figure of great strength, unflinching devotion and intellect. He was happy with this until asked by an Indian dada what his name was. When he replied Hanuman, the dada said, “Achaa! Hanuman is the name of a big monkey.”

The brother was clashed to the core and was resolute that he would ask Baba for a new name. As time progressed, it was arranged that I was to see Baba with Hanuman and the two didis who had rescued me from the train station.

Before going into the jail, we had to submit to processing by the jail authorities. This was not good, since the CBI and communist factions were using the darshan of margiis to gather data on all who came to see Baba. The four of us were in the office of the jail superintendent, reluctantly giving information required before we were allowed to see Him. In the office were a couple officials and one individual whose vibration was so crude that I tried even to avoid any eye contact with him. The aura of this person was nearly black. I was instead concentrating with amazement on the superintendent. Every other word out of his mouth was about Baba. He was not a margii, but was immersed in the thought that his jail was the one that held Baba. Baba said this and Baba did that. With each repetition of His holy name, I felt a sanctifying impact upon the jailer’s mind. We collectively celebrated His auspicious presence. I gained a glimpse then of how He must be working toward the salvation of scattered souls in realms beyond the manifest structure of His organization.

As we were cleared to enter His room, the jailer forced an introduction to the crude individual sitting to his left whom I had tried to avoid even looking at. I forget his name.

“This is the personal physician we have assigned to care for Baba.” I felt a cold sickness pass through me. The thought of his hands touching Baba caused a deep revulsion in me, except for the conviction that our Lord was transcendent to the physical, and loved this crude entity equally as much as His love for the purest saint.

Through the courtyards and passages, we were led to a small, dark, and unventilated cell. A line of seven or eight CBI agents stood with hands folded, at rigid and paranoid attention against the east wall. The Lord lay on a cot against the west wall facing north, parallel to the line of agents. We filed into the shrine, myself first, followed by brother Hanuman, followed by the two didis.

We had seen so many photographs of Baba, the blissful stout figure with His benevolent smile. The shock was unbearable in person. The only thing I recognized was His thick black glasses. His subtle fair body was wasted to mere bones under the consequence of prolonged fasting. This was more than I could bear. We all fell to the floor in *sastaung pranam* and the didis sobbed uncontrollably in pain over His physical state.

After moments, He gently bade us to rise up. There were a couple glass bottles under His cot with sugar rock candy in them. He opened a bottle and distributed some of the candy to us as *prasad*.

In the darshan that followed, my Baba poured such loving attention on me. As I had the good fortune to be the first in line, I was merely inches from His face. He stroked my head and hair. I held His hand as He explained the meaning of my name. Baba became quite grave in mood and told me that I would be destined for considerable suffering in the next several months, and that drinking water would be a problem. He made several predictions about hardships I would face by way of trying to prepare me. In later contemplation, it was as if He were witnessing all time, and that I was merely a player in the events that were ordained to happen. Once I misunderstood the intention of His soft voice and He corrected my thinking, demonstrating that He was omnipresent even in my innermost thoughts.

Baba talked about the suffering of people in the region I would eventually be posted to, and exhorted me to do something to help them. His cosmic gaze was looking beyond the small room. He was witnessing something far away, and in that moment I realized the yogic dispassion of a great saint. Any lesser mortal would have been ensconced in the physical suffering Baba was going through. His focus was, however, not on His own physical hardship, but on the plight of His children in some distant place.

During the darshan, Baba would on occasion address or reprimand the CBI agents behind us. They would jerk to attention on His slightest address. “Yes, Baba, Yes, Baba, we will do. What you are telling is correct.” These people who were posted to intimidate and harass Baba were reduced to mere toys at His whim. I had heard that these agents had to be continually changed since they either fled in fear or became devotees.

In one awkward moment, I was holding His wrist tightly. As He talked, He slowly moved His head and eyes, staring at my tightly clenched hand. When I realized it, I thought, “Oh my God, I am holding the Lord of the universe hostage.” I released my grip and He looked back at me. At that time I had one other incidental misgiving. The entire focus of the darshan was on me. Baba gave fleeting acknowledgement to the other three saints, but all of His love and attention was being poured directly onto me. I felt uncomfortable for the other three who were being practically ignored by Baba.

Before the darshan, we were strictly told by Central officials that we were to ask nothing personal of Baba. I am not the most subtle of entities, neither then nor now. At my first chance, I begged the Lord to grant me purity and devotion to do His work. He looked away from me and said, “Those who want will get.” By His infinite Grace, devotion has come. Purity I am still waiting for, and will no doubt achieve this blessing in some future life as I struggle to know Him.

Baba’s attention was briefly turned to brother Hanuman, who immediately asked Baba for a new name. Baba closed His eyes for a moment and said, “You are now Shudodhana. Shudodhana was the father of Buddha. The meaning is one who earns his livelihood by moral means.”

Shudodhana was most relieved. Baba then gave respectful greeting to the two didis who knelt at the far end of the cot by Baba’s feet.

Our time was finished and we were asked to leave by the jail officials. We stayed on as long as we could, ignoring the badgering requests to leave. Finally, we could not stay longer. We exited the small cell in the order that we had come in.

This is difficult to explain, but outside the jail cell, back into the mundane sunlight, I was putting on my shoes, which were left at the door of the shrine. Intuition overcame me that I was leaving His physical presence, but that I could not go anywhere beyond the radius of His guidance. The shoes would carry me to places as of

yet unknown, but I could never walk outside of Him. In bliss or adversity, He would always be there with me.

Two days later in the Patna *jagrti*, I walked into a room to find Shudodhana in a terrible mental state. He did not even know that I had come in, as he was writing on several pieces of paper, talking to himself in a fretful way. I could see three pages filled with notes and a fourth page about half-filled. At that moment also, the two didis by chance walked into the room. There we were, together again.

I was wanting to share our experience with Baba, but was concerned about whatever problem was causing Shudodhana so much anguish. I asked him what he was doing and if there was some help I could give. It seems that Shudodhana was so lost in the Lord during darshan that he had no idea of the Sanskrit name given to him by Baba. He had been in this room for over three hours trying to write down every possible name he could imagine.

For this, I was happy to help. I told him that I had clearly heard and remembered every word Baba said to him. Shudodhana looked as if the weight of the universe had been removed. I proceeded to tell him that his name was Shudodhana, the name of Buddha's father, and it meant one who earned his living by moral means. Shudodhana thanked me profusely almost to the point of tears. We were smiling and laughing with joy. My reverie was only broken when I looked at the two didis who were frowning and obviously upset about something.

I quickly gathered my composure and asked them what was wrong. The first didi said that there must be something wrong with either my ears or my mind and probably both. She had heard Baba's conversation with the brother and He had given a completely different name and explanation. This was entirely bizarre, and we only had time to begin arguing when the second didi broke into the fray. She informed us that we were both crazy because she had heard an entirely different name and different translation. As the two didis and myself argued at an escalating volume, poor Shudodhana sat still, more depressed than ever. I was becoming upset, because whatever these two women heard was not what Baba had said.

Conduct rules out the door, I yelled at them to close their mouths for a minute. I informed them that if anyone heard correctly what Baba had said in His soft voice, it was me, since I was sitting closest to His face. They should understand that being at the other end of the cot, it would be possible for them to not have heard correctly.

There was silence for a moment and I felt that my point had been accepted and the matter was closed. This was not over, however. One didi countered with both anger and amazement. What was I saying? She was the first in line and was sitting at the head of the cot while I was at the end near Baba's feet. Baba was talking so softly, how could I have heard anything? The second didi entered the battle claiming that she was at the head of the cot and the other three of us were toward the far end. Poor Shudodhana was entirely drowned out in his claim that he was the first to enter the cell. All the yelling continued for a couple minutes and then in a split second, there was complete silence. We all came to a profound realization in the same instant.

We knew then that Baba was carrying on four independent darshans at the same time. As we calmed down and explained our subjective experience, each of us perceived that we were the first one to enter Baba's room followed by the others. Each of us sat directly in front of Baba, only inches from His face. Each also felt that the entire encompassing love and attention of our Guru was focused exclusively on us personally, and that the other three were largely ignored somewhere far away in the dark room by Baba's feet.

Such was and is His cosmic, and sometimes humorous, drama. We learned from this that while He is guarding the welfare of countless beings, He is at the same time caring for each one of us as if there were no other devotee in the universe for Him. Each devotee can rightfully say that He is mine and mine alone.

I remained in the Central Office for a while and did some work there until an appropriate posting was found. When one dada in the Rajasthan province was reposted to Africa, I was assigned to take his position as principal in an Ananda Marga school. I remembered Baba's serious warning about drinking water and I asked one Central worker about the conditions where I would be going. He was somewhat perplexed, since he said

the region in general was known for the purity and quality of the water. Surely Baba must have been speaking figuratively.

The long train ride at last began to Bikaner, near the India-Pakistan border. The heat was severe and at every stop on the way, I would cautiously get down from the train to test the drinking water. To my relief, the dada was right. As I traveled closer to Rajasthan, the water became more pure. I was wondering what Baba could have meant since I was experiencing the opposite of what I heard Him say. My mind listened to the rhythmic clatter of the rail tracks as I thought about the different words our small group heard in Darshan. This would just have to pass as another of His mysteries.

The train finally arrived in the desert city. I got down from my cabin and went to the water fountain for a cool drink. To my shock the water was like ocean water and I spit it out onto the ground. Water in this area had to be drawn up in stages from a hundred meters below the surface and was laden with salt and minerals to the point of being toxic. My body underwent extreme shock over the next weeks. I could feel the kidneys in my back inflamed and becoming rigid as I tried to adjust to the saline water. I would travel many miles on advice from the local residents that if I would go to a certain place, there would be a well that had water with less salt. All were the same and my health was deteriorating.

Baba removed me from Rajasthan after a tour in the local area. I was arrested in Batinda for being a Margii and was mentally abused for 24 hours by the police and CBI. Because they had no grounds to keep me longer and possibly because of my American passport, I was let go and was saved from the physical torture that had been endured by so many other margiis. As the train was leaving for Bikaner, the CBI changed their minds about letting me go and sent an agent on board to detain me. The agent grabbed my arm and a fight began. In the struggle, I was able to throw the agent off of the moving train. I was quite happy with myself that I had the strength and warrior spirit to conquer the enemy.

My celebration was short-lived, however. The Batinda officials had reported the incident to the Bikaner authorities while I was still in route. Needless to say, I had a warm welcoming party waiting for me at the Bikaner station. I was immediately arrested. It was very late at night and I had two sympathizers among the local police who allowed

me to stay in the school for the night. They would come at daybreak for the formal arrest. After they left, I contacted the local margiis who got me on a night train for Delhi. They threw me into a vacant cabin, which was odd for any train berth on an Indian train to be empty. In a few minutes, about ten soldiers arrived and told me to get out of the cabin since it was reserved for the military. I was very ill with malaria and could hardly rise up. I remembered telling them that I was sick from some deadly contagious disease that the locals feared. The soldiers fled in terror and I was able to get some rest in solitude.

Over the next several days, every *jagrti* or headquarters I went to had been just visited by the police looking for me. I was able to make it to Patna one last time for a train headed east and eventually out of India.

It was late in the evening and the sun had set. Circumstances were such that I could not have seen Baba in the jail, and was feeling too unworthy to be in His physical presence. I felt that I had been a complete failure. Nothing had been accomplished but taking food and being sick and causing so much trouble to the Margiis. I had to talk to Baba, though. Even if He knew all things, I had to explain.

Outside the jail, there was a small wooden fence or rail that separated the city walkway from the high stone walls. The inside perimeter was a bare, cleared area of stones and dirt. I climbed over the railing and knelt by the stone wall. The heat of the sun was still strongly radiating from the rock as I laid my hands on the wall and broke into tears talking to my Guru on the other side. So many things I said and explained. After some time, I did Guru Puja to Him through the stone wall before leaving. I mentally offered up a white and a red flower to Baba and asked His forgiveness for my shortcomings.

After a long Namaskar, I noticed a subtle perfume in the air and opened my eyes. To my amazement, now in place between myself and the wall was a large plant of some kind, having two large, fragrant flowers. One was deep red, and one the purest white. He had given His reply and I knew that I was to shed the past and move on fearlessly. I picked the two flowers and pressed them gently in a notebook. There was only time left to catch the train.

Although faded now from the years, I have kept the flowers. The sacred memory of His presence has not faded. It is my hope that others may find this story of historical or

inspirational value. My purpose in telling it is then complete. God's Grace be with you all.

Kamala

Eugene, Oregon

In April 1978, I went to India to see Baba while He was still in jail. After going through all the bureaucratic red tape and getting permission to go in, I found out that Baba was protesting at that time and not seeing anyone. Of course I was completely devastated. I went back to Baba's house in Patna and spoke to Dada Ramananda who was Baba's Personal Assistant at that time. He told me I could write a letter to Baba and he would take it to Him.

That night I wrote to Baba and with the letter I enclosed a picture of my two sons, who at the time were about one and three years old. Dada took the picture and letter to Baba and brought back a reply. Baba said that He was very sorry that He could not see me at this time and hoped that I would return again to see Him. On the back of the picture He wrote in His own handwriting, "With love, Baba."

I was very touched to have the picture, and as *samskara* would have it, the picture was misplaced some time after I returned to the United States. You can imagine that I looked everywhere for it for years but it seemed to have vanished.

In 1999, I had a health crisis involving non-Hodgkin's lymphoma. I had to make critical decisions as to which therapy I would undergo. I decided with much trepidation to have chemotherapy. A few days before I was to start treatment I was at the house of my ex-husband. He had been with me in India in 1978 to see Baba. He was looking through some old envelopes of pictures in his closet and to everyone's amazement he discovered the picture of our sons, which Baba had signed! I was surprised beyond words. It seemed to be the sign I was waiting for. I felt that Baba had reached out from the invisible world and handed me a message saying He loved me.

I am happy to say that I am now three years cancer-free and very happy to be alive to tell this story to others. Baba Nam Kevalam.

Kirit

San Francisco Bay area, California

I was initiated in 1975 in the Los Altos Hills *jagrti*. I had not seen Baba, I had seen only one of His pictures. I had only read Human Society Part I and I was struggling very hard to learn Idea and Ideology. Those were difficult days. I was struggling to understand who Baba was. Although I did not know anything about Him I was very impressed by His books and I felt a very strong vibration – even at that time I felt a strong cosmic vibration attracting me in His books.

Soon thereafter, I started seeing Him in my dreams. I saw Him come and give very specific messages in a collective environment. Much, much later I found out this is how He used to give His discourses. And every single time the message has come true later on. Those messages related to many, many things about the world situation – economics, things related to energy crises, things related to drought and water crises.

I wanted to see Him very badly, so in 1978 I finally managed to go to India. At that time Baba was in jail. Every time I made an effort to see Him, He created a situation whereby I could not. For example, when I had the opportunity to go see Him He had a struggle with the jail authority and stopped seeing anybody. I struggled and yet I still could not see Him. So I was very disappointed and I spent, altogether, almost three months trying to see Him.

Different dasas said to me, “Why are you hanging around here? Why don’t you go to Ananda Nagar and Kolkata, see some different places and see what’s happening with Ananda Marga? You should go out and see the senior devotees of Baba.”

So I went to see Naginaji, Chandranathji, all these great disciples of Baba. Then I again came back to Patna hoping to see Baba but still I kept failing.

Eventually they said that I should go to Ananda Nagar. I spent some time there and at that time Dada Amitanandaji was there and I became close to him. We became good friends and spent a lot of time doing sadhana and visited many villages.

From there he suggested that I go to Kolkata so I went for a visit. After some time Dada Pranavanandaji suggested I should go to Bangalore because there was a *Dharma Maha Sammelan* (DMS) going on there.

I went and spent a good amount of time in Bangalore. And again I came back traveling through Patna to see if I would get a chance to see Baba but again Baba refused to see anybody.

Meanwhile I developed an infection. I was staying in the office in Patna. There were no conveniences there. It was a very difficult environment and I was very sick. There was hardly anybody there to help me or take care. I was struggling.

Then one family *acarya*, Rasmohanji, saw me and said, “You should not stay here. Come to my house until you become better.” He took me to his house and I lay in bed trying to recover my health. This is the time something happened. What had happened during my whole journey was this: the Central Bureau of Intelligence (CBI) police had somehow gotten my name as being a prominent *margii* visiting India, but they did not know where I was. They were looking for me to deport me. The day I left Patna to go to Ananda Nagar was the evening there was a raid on the market, and many foreign *margiis* were deported. I spent some time in Ananda Nagar, and the day I left, the CBI heard that I was in Ananda Nagar, and they came to check on me. That was the same day I left for Kolkata. I was in Kolkata for a very short time. And once again, the day I left, that was the day they were inquiring about me. They traced me to Bangalore. I was walking around among the CBI officers, not knowing they were looking for me, and they never found me. I finally came back to Patna, staying at this *acarya*’s house, and they traced me there. I was in bed and I could hear what was going on.

They said to the *acarya*, “We are looking for a foreign *margii*.”

“No, there is no foreign *margii* here.”

They searched the whole house, upside down, everywhere, boxes, briefcases, suitcases, and finally they came to the bed where I was sleeping.

“Who is this?”

“This is one of my colleagues from Gujurat, he is sick, lying down.”

And they left. Much later I found out they had been looking for me. But by some strange coincidence, and some strange guidance, I was always one step ahead of India’s intelligence force.

Eventually Baba came out of the jail. We won the case in July 1978. I was in Ananda Nagar at the time. We were all very joyful. We had a lot of *akhanda kiirtan*, and

I immediately went to Patna. But I found out that Baba was not coming out because of some other charges pending. Again I was disappointed and returned to Ananda Nagar. I felt I would not get the chance to see Baba. Already three months had gone by. My visa would be up very soon. I was very sad, that in all this time I was not able to see Him.

Again we heard the news on the radio that Baba's bail had been granted, and He would come out. I rushed back to Patna, arriving a few days before He was to be released. I wanted to present something to Baba, and was wondering what I should give. All of a sudden, a silver glass for drinking water just came into my mind. I thought, "Yes, this is what I want to give Baba." I went to the market and bought such a cup, and sent it to Baba. Baba was very happy, but said there was no need for such things here. I thought it was strange that Baba did not accept my gift.

But Ramananda said, "No, He is just saying that He won't need it in jail." Sure enough, Baba came out, and that was the first time I saw Him, in the car when He was coming back. That scene I will never forget. So many people, an ocean of people. The streets were closed in Patna, the railway station was overflowing with margiis, the whole town had completely changed. When I saw Baba the first time, it was an unbelievable experience, because everything I had been feeling was there in front of me suddenly. It's like you're working for something for a very long time, and finally it arrives. You almost don't believe it.

He immediately started giving two darshans a day. We were all enjoying very much, and we were all struggling to get as close as we could. Baba was still in a wheelchair, as He had been fasting for more than five years. In the Patna house, I got a place right in front of Baba. I was overpowered with emotion and devotion. I tried to open my eyes, but I could not, and could not control my tears; they were flowing nonstop. As soon as I opened my eyes, Baba was scanning all the margiis with His head. He smiled at me. I wiped my tears. When His face was coming this way, I would barely open my eyes, and dry my tears. But after He looked at me and smiled, there would be so many tears.

Again and again, for forty-five minutes, this game went on – I could not control my tears, and He also could not quit looking at me and smiling. Then He finished His

discourse. Ramananda-ji pushed His chair, and had a strict order not to let anyone touch Baba. All the margiis wanted to touch His feet, but Baba was trying to regain His health, and he didn't want to burden Baba with the *samskaras* of devotees. The VSS guards were also protecting Baba. But Baba's wheelchair came very near and stopped, and I just put my head on His knee, and cried. Finally He gave me a blessing.

Next day I left. I was on the train journey to Bombay for three or four days, and for the entire time I was in a totally blissful spiritual state of mind. My mind was completely oblivious to the material world; it did not care about it, it had no concern for it. The train malfunctioned on the way, extending the time. I was completely isolated from everybody, and I did not mix with people. So it was very nice solitude on the train.

Another time in 1978, I was struggling so hard to get personal contact with Baba. But Ramananda had said Baba's health was not good, to let Him regain His health first. I said, "I understand, but I want you to know that I am requesting." I requested many dasas to take care of my request to see Baba before I went back to the U.S.A. Many dasas were my good friends for the three months I was there. Everything I had, I gave to my friends. But when I needed these dasas to take my message to Baba, all friends disappeared. And by that time, I had nothing left in terms of donations to give. All of a sudden I had no friends because I had no money left.

I was standing in front of Baba's house, and some Prout meeting was going on. I didn't care which trade it was, I just wanted to see Baba.

I finally said, "I give up. This is not my house, because I will not be treated this way in my house."

I told this to Baba, "I don't belong here." With tears in my eyes I turned around and said, "I am not coming to this house again." I must have walked five or ten steps, crying, having given up hope to see Baba in person. All of a sudden, Dada Dhyanesananda-ji came running from inside Baba's house.

"Come, come, you're being called inside!"

"Who are you? I did not request you anything."

“I don’t know, you are being called inside. Somebody sent for you.” To this day I am not sure what exactly happened. He dragged me inside, and there was a meeting going on – a UPSF (Universal Proutist Student Federation) meeting.

Baba was sitting on a cot, and I got the very best position in front of Baba. First Baba asked, “Who is not UPSF? This is a UPSF meeting.”

He was smiling. This was my first encounter with Baba closely. I was afraid to stand up, that I would be thrown out. So I said, internally, “It’s up to you Baba, you know I am not UPSF.” I surrendered. Baba smiled for a while. That was my first close contact with Baba, and He talked about many things, including certain things that applied directly to me. I wanted to dedicate my life to Baba’s mission. I was thinking to become a doctor, that way I could be independent.

Baba at that time talked about the essential elements for a successful revolution. I still remember the three points He mentioned. Morality, a strong spiritual/moral foundation must be there. Second, you should never lose sight of who is being served, never lose track of humanity. Third, pinnacled intellect. You must start with your foundation, a broad foundation, and build more pointed and specific to an apex, to specific points. Your intellect must be sharp and pinnacled. Then He looked around and said, “And some people think that ‘I am an engineer, and I will become a doctor,’ but this is not proper pinnacled intellect.”

At that time I knew that everything I was considering was nothing. Baba gave me the indication that I should not go for these medical things. So I did not go to medical school.

Giridhara (2)

On Christmas Day of 1971 I boarded a plane for Delhi. I was traveling alone, planning to attend DMC and see Baba for the first time. When I reached New Delhi, I remember seeing the surging crowds of taxi wallahs outside the airport. I almost turned back into the airport – the intensity of the crowd was so great. Finally I got a cab to South Extension and we had trouble finding the place, until I saw an *avadhuta* in uniform and got directions from him. I stayed there for two nights and then I had to move to the Prasads' house, because there were rumors of a police raid and I would be deported if they found a foreigner there. I recall that the second morning was *ekadashi* and the whole South Extension crew, who were publishing a Prout (Progressive Utilization Theory) newspaper, all got up well before sunrise and made a huge breakfast of cooked foods. They said that they had to work so hard that they needed to do this to have enough energy.

We got word that Baba had been arrested at His house in Patna and that DMC was cancelled. Sandiipa and I took a 2nd class sleeper with those little shelving units high up for beds. It was winter and very cold as the train had no heat. After 24 hours on the train, we got off at Patna Station and took a bicycle rickshaw to Pataliputra Colony. I remember when I saw the foreigners' *jagriti*, I was so impressed with the margiis; they looked like they were all saints. Their faces were all shining. When I stepped up onto the porch, I felt like I had stepped onto something that was moving. The vibration was wonderful.

Baba was being held in jail in a small town about three hours back towards Delhi. The train was hours late and it was about 11 p.m. when the Assam Mail train arrived. We mostly stood in this crowded compartment and held on. Three hours later we stopped in a small station that had no electric power and hence no lights. It was completely dark. A dada that I didn't know motioned for me to get off the train. I got off and placed my hand on my belt pack and found the zipper open and my passport, tickets and money all missing.

I was quite upset as I was aware that the CBI was after foreign margiis, and I was afraid that with no identification, money or ticket I was going to be in real trouble. I laid myself down wrapped only in a blanket on the cold floor. I was very cold and could not

sleep. I lay there alternating between great fear and worry about losing everything and great excitement that I might see Baba in the morning.

This back and forth drama continued until the sun was rising. Finally I was able to say, “OK, Lord, if you want me to come to you naked and completely without my Western resources, so be it.” I found contentment and held that feeling. The group of margiis hired several rickshaws and we rode out to the edge of the small village. The ride in the morning air was beautiful. It was very green and cool. We rode to a large building where we got down and waited for several hours on the grass in front of it. There must have been 200 margiis and lots of dadas and didis there.

Suddenly the door opened and Baba was standing in the door. Everyone jumped close to the door, but I was rooted to the ground on top of a three-foot wall. I could see Baba clearly. I saw Him and I saw His smile. I saw the white light coming from His smile. This white light enveloped me and my mind turned white for a while, then it turned orange and then it turned back to white. I knew instantly that this was the same Baba that I had seen in my sadhana back in the States. This was the same Baba. I knew that He was my guru. Baba then said to the margiis, “You all do your duty, you know what that is. Do kiirtan every spare moment.”

I later felt that these were His instructions to us for the long period that He would remain in prison. I was in a blissful daze, very exhilarated at seeing Baba and I also knew that I had gotten all I needed. We milled around for awhile and everyone felt the special spiritual vibration. Then we took rickshaws back to the train station and caught a train to Patna in the afternoon.

When we arrived back in Patna, I went to the Station Master to report the theft of my things and he quizzed me about who I was and said I was a very lucky man. He removed an envelope from his drawer and in the envelope was my passport, tickets and all my traveler’s checks and U.S. dollars. Only the rupees were missing. Everyone agreed that this was an unheard of miracle in India. No one ever recovers stolen property. Later we learned from a margii who worked for the CBI that the CBI had had me pickpocketed to see who was this new guy in town.

Baba had just given the 16 Points a few weeks before He was arrested and so this was an important topic. Kamala and I decided to interview Dada Pranavananda and others and put together a small book on the 16 Points. We carefully obtained information on each of the points and typed up a small book. A few months after I left India it came out as “How an Ananda Margii Should Live.” It was very useful for me to have carefully gone over the 16 Points shortly after it was given as I was able to note down some fine points such as touching the big toe to the ground outside the other ankle and bending the knee during kiirtan.

Finally it was decided to hold a three-week *Akhanda Kiirtan* to try to get Baba out of jail. This was held in the darshan hall in the overseas margiis *jagrti*, which was in the room next to where I slept. We had three shifts for the kiirtan. After two days of this non-stop kiirtan I started to wish I could escape, since everywhere in our house the sound of kiirtan was there. You slept to kiirtan, ate to kiirtan, everything, all the time. After about five days of frustration, the feeling changed, and I started to love the flow. Many days I did kiirtan the whole eight-hour shift. It permeated everything.

Finally the day for the ending of the three-week kiirtan came and we prepared for a large crowd. Many workers and margiis came for the final hours. The room was packed. The vibration was so strong that rings of golden light could be seen coming out from the center of the circle. You could tell by the vibration, the high pitch of the singing voices and the heads tilted back that the *bhava* was very, very strong. Margiis would fall over in samadhi and we would carry them out to the porch, out of the way of the dancers.

Near the very end of the kiirtan, Dada Pranavananda who was in charge of ending the kiirtan and leading the chants was going slower and slower around the mandap. His head was tilting further and further back. He was leaning on the dada behind him who was helping him to stay upright. Finally he could no longer stand and he lay on the floor as the kiirtan finished. We sat for sadhana and then this small faraway voice could be heard trying to do his duty and sing the *Samgacchadvam* chant. The voice sounded so distant.

The energy released from the kiirtan was amazing. During sadhana I felt someone behind me touch my spine at my *anahata cakra* and I felt as if a blockage was removed and I had an amazing sadhana. After the sadhana was over, I turned around and found a

small dada with a very sweet expression. We smiled at each other and I said, “Thank you.”

Baba was transferred from the jail to Patna Medical College Hospital. This was very good as the margiis were allowed to gather in the courtyard of the hospital and to sing kiirtan and have His darshan. He was housed on the second floor near the end of a long wing. Baba would come out and sit in a chair on the porch for some time in the morning and afternoon.

One day there were many margiis and workers present and Baba was obviously in a special mood. He looked very playful. He was smiling down at us and then he would give a meaningful look at the guard in full uniform standing at attention with the rifle guarding Him. He looked down at us and over at the soldier several times and then suddenly he raised his right hand in a *mudra* (I think the *mudra* of fascination with the first and little fingers raised and the rest in a loose fist). He shook this *mudra* for 5-10 seconds and looked intently at the soldier. Then we all watched as the soldier just fell over and collapsed on the floor. Baba looked down at us with a look of satisfaction as if to say, “You see!” The other guards dragged him into the guard’s room next door. Later the guard was seen looking out of the window at Baba with a look of total affection and bliss. The guard was transferred as he could no longer maintain his disciplined manner in Baba’s presence. It was clear that Baba was having His fun and showing the margiis something as well.

On another occasion there were many margiis and workers as there was a rumor that Baba was going to be taken to another building for an X-ray. Everyone wanted to give namaskar to Baba and see Him up close. I took my place on the stone steps about 2/3 of the way down the second flight of stairs near the bottom. I had been feeling very much part of the New Age spiritual movement and I had this idea that I did not like prostrations to the Guru. Loving namaskars, yes, but prostration seemed too much for me. As Baba came down the stairs and came near to me, I don’t know what happened. I found myself laying in *sastaung pranam* on the stone steps. I did not know that I had done this, I did not feel any pain from falling onto the edges of the stone steps. I only felt peace and

bliss in my heart. I knew from that second that the only position to be in Baba's presence was in *sastaung pranam*.

I eventually stood up and mingled with the margiis and workers. Everyone was in an excited state, as Baba had showered us with strong energy. There was a rumor that Baba would come back to the stairs in about a half an hour and so all but one very small brother from South India and I went off for a short walk either along the Ganges River which was just behind the hospital or out in the market outside the hospital. This brother and I were both just too blissful to walk. We stood right by the curb where the small van had been parked when Baba got in. In five minutes the car with Baba returned and we were the only two margiis present.

When Baba got out of the car we both did *sastaung pranam*, the dada grasped Baba's left foot and I grasped Baba's right foot. Baba of course could not walk and he stood there, gesturing with His hands, with a big smile saying things like, "My devotees, what can I do..."

This went on for maybe two minutes, and then He spoke to us and asked us to let Him go so that His guards could do their duty. Reluctantly, we released our gentle grasp and Baba went up the stairs with His guards. My hands smelled like roses or some sweet flower. I did not wash my hands for several days as the smell stayed sweet for several days. These events greatly deepened my devotion for Baba. I was starting to feel and experience *bhakti*.

On one other day at the hospital there were only three margiis present – myself, brother Dharmaputra from California, and brother Abhik Kumar (later Dada Abhidevananda). Baba was sitting up on the porch as usual but there was something in the air. The three of us did not talk or make any plan, we just all three walked nonchalantly toward the far end of the building as if we were planning a walk down to the river. When we got to the end of the building we all three turned and started up the stairs. I know that my *guru mantra* was going continuously very fast inside me.

We resolutely walked up the two flights of stairs and stepped out onto the upper porch. The distance must have been at least 20 meters. All three of us started walking down the porch toward Baba. As we started to approach where Baba was sitting, the

guards became aware of us and started to turn toward us and to move toward us. There were the two plainclothes guards and the guard in uniform with the rifle. As they turned toward us I could see that they had looks of complete horror on their faces, because they were moving in very slow motion. We walked right through them and fell to our knees at Baba's feet.

Again without any discussion or planning we started *guru puja*. I had my hands and head on Baba's right knee, Dharmaputra was next to me and had his hands and head in Baba's lap. Abhika Kumar had his hands on Baba's left knee. The guards continued to try to reach us, but they could only move in slow motion and could not reach us despite being only a few feet away. They were in some kind of time warp.

We completed all the verses of *guru puja* and Baba was very, very happy. Light was coming from His face. Finally He said that we should allow these guards to do their duty and we should leave now. We namaskared to Baba and then very slowly started to move away from Him and back slowly down the porch toward the stairs. The guards came back to normal movement but they were so confused by their experiences that despite having weapons they could only shoo us away with their hands as we slowly backed down the porch.

When I was about to leave Patna, I went to the hospital to see Baba sitting on the porch in the morning and to take my leave of Him. I was feeling totally fulfilled as I rode the rickshaw downtown. I felt that He had given me everything that I needed and that I was ready to depart. I had not felt any pain of separation; I felt fulfilled. But when I looked up at Baba and said my mental goodbye, my heart suddenly became filled with a feeling that I had never felt before – the pain of leaving and a sense of loss or longing for Him. I knew what this was and I appreciated that He had given this to me also. I was very intellectual at the time, but I got the feeling of devotion and the deep pain of leaving Him.

In the spring, we had a wonderful Vermont Diocese Retreat at a Quaker Camp in Plymouth Union, Vermont. I remember teaching *tandava* to the margiis and the kiirtan Saturday night was amazing. The Quakers are very spiritual people and this camp had been a center for them for 50 years at that time. When we did kiirtan the vibration was

very high and many people, myself included saw numerous bright blue balls of light floating up near the corners of the room. I felt that these luminous bodies were around the spiritual vibration of the center and attracted by the strong kiirtan. Over 60 margiis attended the retreat, all of them local. This was a period of great activity in Ananda Marga in the Northeast.

Soon, Madhurii established an intensive LFT training program in Los Altos Hills, which I attended. Soon we had many dedicated people available to start projects and do *pracar* all over the country. This dynamic training made many LFTs and WTs and really accelerated the pace of Ananda Marga in New York Sector. Many of the LFTs are now leaders in Ananda Marga.

The training center was called AMRIT (Ananda Marga Retreat for Intensive Training) and was a resource for margiis all over the San Francisco Bay Area. Madhurii also wanted to do publications, so we established AMRIT Publications. We produced *Baba's Grace*, *The Great Universe*, *Teaching Asanas*, and many smaller booklets for classes and *pracar*. These books were produced at night after the trainees had gone to sleep.

We started the ERAWS training center in the *jagrti* in Washington D.C. to provide a more focused LFT training for margiis who wanted to do social service. I was transferred to RU Secretary. We decided to set up an Office in Carbondale and Akhanda Darshan and I moved there. The Renaissance Universal Journal was conceived there, becoming a very good publication for several years. We scheduled what was called the Problem of the Day Seminar. We brought in eight Proutists and margiis and picked a couple of topics. The eight broke into small groups; each one researched the problem chosen and presented a final paper to the group after a week of research and discussion on Prout's solution.

The pressure to try to get Baba out of jail increased. This was the time of the Emergency and things looked tough. We wanted to organize a large protest march and contact as many government officials as we could to try to get some help for Ananda Marga and others in India who were being arrested and jailed without charges, as well as

to try to get Baba released. We brought about 60 people to Washington and we all jammed into the house there, sleeping like sardines packed tight. We organized the Universal Freedom March, which went from the Washington Monument to the Capitol building. We were not very successful in building coalitions, but it was a good learning experience and we built a team of hard-working margiis who have continued to do Ananda Marga work since then.

I was in charge of Baba's Release in New York Sector. After the march we kept a team together in Washington to work with the State Department and the news media to try and keep the Indian Emergency and Baba's case in the forefront.

I was sent to Nepal to try to secure travel documents and asylum in Europe for several workers who had escaped to Nepal. I spent a couple of very good weeks in Kathmandu with Shivananadaji, Chitgatanandaji and others. I was staying in an apartment with several trainees who had had to leave India. Shivananda would take us to special places for sadhana and he greatly encouraged us in our sadhana.

I returned via Nairobi where Ramanandaji had been expelled from the country. There was starvation in some of the tribal areas and Dada was intent on publicizing this to raise funds to help them. The government was concerned that news of starvation might keep tourists away and wanted the news suppressed. It was wonderful to attend *dharmacakra* in Africa and see our universal culture and the beautiful colorations of the local cultures blending in.

I went on to Geneva, where I met with the United Nations High Commission on Refugees and obtained some travel documents for the dadas in Kathmandu and some support in helping to get them out. I then went to London, where I met with Amnesty International to get their help as well. I was in ten countries in 30 days. I had a layover in Tashkent in Central Russia. I remember that the people I saw at the airport had a grey aura as if they had no life or creativity left in them. I saw this as an image of what Communism had done to their culture and their individual spirit. It was the most depressing place I had ever experienced.

After returning from this trip we continued to work in Washington to get Baba released. Cirasmita, who was an LFT, and I, got married on Baba's Birthday at the *jagrti* in Washington D.C. Soon after that we moved back to Vermont.

Chandra Shekhara

St. Petersburg, Florida

In February, 1975, I was in India working on Baba's defense work. I met with the lawyers and attended a court session. The day of the court appearance there were large numbers of guards surrounding the courtroom that was just outside Bankipur Central Jail. After court the lawyers left and I went to try to see Baba. Although it was the regular day for people to visit Baba, no one else was being let in because of the court activities and because there were security concerns related to a large Communist rally being held in Patna that day.

I went to the jailer's office and in fairly short order was let into the jail and led to Baba's cell. I had to leave my pen and paper in the jail office, though, which concerned me since Dada Pranavanandaji had asked me to get posting instructions from Baba for a number of new acaryas who were waiting in Kolkata until they had their new postings.

It is funny what you remember about such times. The first thing I recalled as I started to enter Baba's cell was the sight of little birds flitting through openings around the top of the room. I thought that these were fortunate little beings. After salutations to Baba, He called me closer and I sat by His cot and was able to hold onto His arm. Baba was lying on His side and was covered by a lightweight shawl. He had a slight cold on that day.

I don't remember everything that transpired but several things still stand out. First, I got all jumbled up with the postings. Although I'd memorized the names of the *acaryas* to be posted, Baba quickly gave both the location and specific task for each acarya. He did it so quickly that it was very hard for me to keep everything straight. I hope they all reached the places they were supposed to be.

During the course of our time together Baba mentioned Indira Gandhi and said that she was not a bad person but that she was not doing good things and should be told to change this.

At one point I was saying something and Baba closed His eyes. Somehow I knew I should be quiet so I stopped and internally said my *Guru Mantra*. Just as I did this, a big smile appeared on Baba's face. It was a very special moment.

Soon the guards said it was time to leave and I had to part from Baba. After leaving the cell and walking back to the jailer's office, I remembered stories that people told about wonderful scents that people sometimes smelled in Baba's presence. While I was in the cell I didn't notice anything unusual, but I smelled my hands that had been touching Baba's arm. There was a beautiful floral fragrance – not something I'd ever smelled before and I felt quite blessed by Baba.

Three and a half years later I saw Baba again, this time in Jamaica. Although there are many wonderful stories about Baba in Jamaica, three stand out for me.

The first was when Baba arrived at the airport. My wife Kalyani and I had arrived just a short time before Baba's plane was due to arrive. We were the last on our flight to go through the immigration check and the room was empty. Kalyani thought it would be a good idea to stay there so we could see Baba without lots of other people around. So we sat down and waited. One of the Jamaican officials came over and said we wouldn't be able to stay in the room. I told him that my wife was expecting (this was true) and asked if we could just sit there awhile. The official gladly obliged. It was a short time later that Baba's plane arrived and just a few minutes before a large group of *acaryas* rounded a corner and Baba was in the middle of them. As He turned the corner we gave namaskar to Him and He stopped and gave a long, beautiful namaskar to us. The energy was so intense and wonderful that I couldn't stand up.

The second story involves my personal contact that took place on Baba's first full day in Jamaica. After entering Baba's room and doing *pranam*, Baba called me near Him and asked my name. After I said my name, Baba told me that although I might be a very small boy yet I could do great things. He said that even though an atom is small it still possesses great energy. Baba then said a blessing in Sanskrit and touched the top of my head. It felt as if a fountain of energy began bubbling up from the top of my head – it was a wonderful feeling. And then the personal contact was over.

The final story from Jamaica involved my desire to hear Baba say "*Parama Purusa*." I always felt that when Baba said this it had special force because He knew directly of what He spoke. Well, one of Baba's talks turned out to deal with *Parama Purusa* the Great. Not only did I greatly enjoy the talk, but my duty during the *Dharma*

Maha Cakra time was to transcribe the tapes of Baba's talks so that a written version could be distributed to the margiis. In this way I got to listen through the talk many times and got to hear Baba say *Parama Purusa* until my heart was content.

CHAPTER THREE:

I THINK EVERYONE ENJOYED THEMSELVES?

“For Jinaniis (those who want to realize God only with intellect), the path of Dharma is a razor’s edge, but for Sadhakas (spiritual practitioners), it is like a flower. Since God is attainable only by devotion, therefore He is with you.”

Following an international outcry and independent judicial inquiries, and a change in the political climate of India, Baba was cleared of all charges and released from prison in 1978. Soon afterwards He embarked on a world tour. Although not allowed into the United States for political reasons, He did visit Jamaica, and many margiis attended His darshans and *Dharma Maha Cakras* there. He also traveled to Switzerland, Iceland, Germany and other European countries, and again North American margiis made the journey to be with Him.

Vishvamisra

Asheville, North Carolina

My first contact with Baba was when He came to Jamaica in 1979. I had gone to India in 1978 and spent six weeks trying to see Baba – this was towards the end of His time in jail – and I was not successful. I had extended my stay there, was quite sick with dysentery, and I had to leave and come back to my job and family. Baba was released three weeks after I left. It was quite meaningful that after all that effort to see Him, finally we were going to see Him in Jamaica. My mother and son went with me.

The setting was so lovely, an employee-owned cooperative hotel. All the margiis were staying there, high on a mountain. Baba was staying in a margii's house down below. He came up in His car, and the first time I saw Him, He was ascending the stairs to the lecture hall. My dear friend, Shaktideva was Baba's bodyguard and he came leading Baba up the stairs. Each day Baba gave darshan in a very intimate setting in that hotel. Many of Baba's lectures were very well-suited for this Western audience. Baba spoke of the many psychic issues He knew many Westerners were beset with. His darshans went straight to the heart, trying to help us work through some of these issues that plagued the Western mind.

Daily, we would go down to His house and see Him come out for field walk. The occasion finally arose when I was to see Baba and have PC. I went in the room and did *sastaung pranam*. Baba was seated across the room on His bed. I sat, and Baba said, "Come closer, my son." It took about four times of His coaxing me until I was seated as close as I could possibly get, next to the bed. Baba began by asking my name and duty. Then He said to do something great for the suffering humanity, something concrete. I was looking up at Baba, probably in awe, and Baba wanted to help me relax. And He said, "Remember, something small can be great," and gestured with His hand. I was overwhelmed with that charge to do something concrete for humanity. To accentuate the point He reached over with His hand and pushed the corners of my mouth up and said, "And smile a little!" It's been easier to smile since.

This was most of the communication in PC. But really it was about the tremendous vibration of love and affection that Baba radiated that was so overwhelming.

I went back outside and sat in meditation, feeling this overwhelming urge to be closer and closer to Baba. My mind was only riveted on that, how to get field walk, to be with Baba as much as I could. One opportunity came up the next day. Dada Ramananda said “We need to get visas for the trip to South America – will you go down and get visas for this party of 12?” And I thought, “Well, yes, this is an opportunity to do something for Baba. Of course.”

So I went to the consulate to get the visas, and it occurred to me to get a visa for myself, in case the opportunity arose that I could go. I wasted no time in asking Dada if it was possible if I could go with Baba and His party, not thinking about any other circumstances, that my son and mother were there, and I had a job. Amazingly, he had always been quite reserved with me about trying to see Baba in India, and now he said, “Yes, it will be fine, if the pilot says it’s okay.” That just fired my imagination, but knowing it was all in His hands. I was in a total state of surrender.

I was given opportunity to go on field walk at the University of West Indies. I was walking alongside Baba, who said that this university will play a great role in the Caribbean *samaj*, and Jamaica will play a great role in this part of the world, because of its openness. We noted a mural on the wall which reflected the multi-cultural theme Baba was talking about; it had people of all the islands, like it was the hub of some melting pot of the islands. Baba was an extremely fast walker, to get exercise, but He was constantly educating us about culture and the environment, plants, the place we were in, and its place in human society.

DMC was scheduled that night. The feeling was even more exaggerated because we felt Baba was going to be leaving soon. I had the opportunity to do *tandava* that night, with torch and dagger. My mother was there, and my son, and they were totally enthralled by the vibration of Baba. Baba gave His talk, which was aimed right at the heart of all the listeners. When Baba gave the *mudra*, there were many people crying, screaming, going into *samadhi*; the vibration simply knocked many people over.

For me, I felt this tremendous warming sensation in my chest, and felt as if my body was lifted off the floor. Looking at Baba, it was as if He were enveloped in light, the room was filled with that light, and I was in some other consciousness, blissful. When

He left the room, He left very slowly, and as He walked along the open side of the building, He stopped and spoke with people, giving namaskar. It was not like many of the DMCs I saw later in India; Baba lingered. The feeling was He couldn't resist so much love coming from the margiis, such an intense exchange. And we all bathed in that.

And then Baba finally left. We were told that Baba was leaving the next day and there would be a going-away darshan at the airport. There was a private plane coming from Caracas. Oddly enough, the airport was on strike, all the personnel gone, and the airport belonged to Ananda Marga, and Baba, with nobody else there. It was a celebratory mood, and Baba gave a brief talk. Then Baba and His party were leaving for Caracas. I had my bag with me just in case the pilot said I could go. Finally the pilot came out and was inspecting the plane. I said to him, "Sir, is it possible I could go with this party?"

"No, it's not possible, we're overweight already."

Then Yatiishvarananda said to him, "But he's a vegetarian, he's very light!" The pilot laughed but he didn't give any ground, "No, I'm sorry." Then everyone started getting on the plane.

I was standing there and something inside said, "Get on." So I got on the plane. I was standing inside and I saw the baggage area, and I just sat on top of some bags. The copilot came back and saw me, and said nothing, and closed the door. The plane started taxiing. Then the pilot looked in the rearview mirror and said, "Hey you." I thought he was about to throw me on the tarmac. He says, "Come forward in the plane so we can balance the weight." So I came forward and the only seat left was just across the aisle from Baba. So I sat there, enjoying His grace, being with Him. He was fulfilling my desire.

Ramananda was telling the pilot in the cockpit that he need not be concerned about this flight. "Who is that man in white back there?" the pilot asked. In terms that the pilot could understand the stature of this gentleman Ramananda said, "[He's like] Jesus Christ. He's flying this plane, so you need not worry." So we had this marvelous flight through this star-glittering night across the Caribbean.

We arrived at Caracas early in the morning. We were met with a beautiful South American kiirtan reverberating off the walls of the airport.

On field walk the next day we went to a botanical garden. They opened the rear entrance, so we had it to ourselves, compliments of Baba. Baba was walking with the assistance of Dada Ramananda, and He said, “I have to take the assistance of someone because of my eyesight. You know they tried to poison me in prison, but they did not succeed, did they?”

Then He looked up and pointed at a plant about thirty yards away. He began to wheel off the genus, species, and said the Portuguese brought that plant here, and He talked about its medicinal value. He went on like this, pointing out plants, whether they were they domestic or imported, their qualities.

We came to a beautiful waterfall. I was carrying Baba’s chair, and He said, “I’ll sit for awhile.” I looked up at the waterfall and I couldn’t understand where all this water came from, since there was no watershed. I had always had the question, “Does Baba know everything I’m thinking; is He with me all the time?”

And Baba said, “My son, do you know the sources of water from a waterfall?”

“I know some.”

“What are they?”

“There’s snowfall and rainfall, and also rivulets and springs.”

“Yes, those are two sources. What is the third source?” He asked with a twinkle in His eye.

Then He answered, “The third source is in an area where there is a very high water table and small undulating hills, the water breaks out at the highest point. It’s called the artesian principle.”

And then He said, with that smile that melts one, “Now, my son, do you understand?” So many things I understood then.

He began a discourse about the derivation of the word water, in Greek and Latin. He talked about the language tree, and bifurcation of language, which later He wrote about. Afterwards a didi and I sat down and said, “What are these field walks all about?” We decided Baba was teaching us about our relationship to everything: to society and nature; natural remedies; the impact society has on the environment; and the potential for

working together – a better cooperation with nature and between people. Baba was opening our eyes, expanding our minds about what the potential was.

There were only about 40 margiis in Caracas. I had the chance to go again on another field walk. This time we went to a zoological garden. Baba talked about the role of Caracas and Venezuela. He said they will play a role in fostering world government because of their openness and universal mind, that they were in a good position, not so identified with politics like other parts of South America and the U.S. We were taking notes.

The first stop we made was where the lions and tigers were. “What family do these animals belong to?” Baba asked.

“Baba, they belong to the cat family.”

“Is that so?” And He pointed over to the lions. “Notice the nature of their head, it’s angular,” and He described the lion’s intestinal structure, it’s claws.

He said, “Look at the tiger, it has a rounded bony structure, in contrast to the lion. Does not the lion run in packs? And the tiger, does it have the same behavior? No, it’s a solitary animal. How is it that these animals belong to the same family?”

“We don’t know, Baba, that’s the way they are classified.”

He said, “No, this animal belongs to the canine family, and the tiger belongs to the feline.” So Baba was giving us a lesson in rational zoology, teaching us how to think. Since then I’ve read a zoological treatise on this, that there’s a continuum between cats and dogs, and with some types you can hardly tell the difference.

In the reptile house, He was pointing out snakes. He asked me the name of a particular snake, and I happened to know it. He said, “Oh, you know so much about reptiles.”

We were walking by the alligators, and an egret was picking the meat out of the teeth of an alligator. One of the South Americans said, “Do you know what they call this animal?” pointing to the alligator.

“No.”

“Baba, we call it Baba.”

Then Baba said of Himself, “But this Baba is not so dangerous.” He continued, “You see, that bird and alligator have a pact; the bird takes the meat and the alligator gets its teeth cleaned. This is a good example of coordinated cooperation.”

We walked by the seals and sea lions. Baba explained, “Although they have rudimentary flippers, they once were land animals, and they evolved back into the sea to escape predators.” And in my mind I was thinking, that must include whales, too. I was thinking about the harvesting of blue whales by the Japanese; they were threatened with extinction. I said, “Baba, are the blue whales about to become extinct?”

And He looked at me and said, “My boy, people with blue eyes and blond hair will one day be extinct. People will come here from another planet and observe the ruins of our civilization. And they will say there was once a very advanced civilization here that built very tall buildings and had advanced technology. But they couldn’t learn to live together. My son, do you want that history should read this way?”

And I said, “No, Baba.”

“Then you will have to perform your mission.”

Baba is saying to us that we are writing history. The life of a spiritualist or sadhaka is one of some social action, and some self-realization. And we can make a difference. We must do something within the scope of our capacity.

Baba gave DMC there, in Caracas. I didn’t experience the same vibration as Jamaica. There was a similar vibration, but not as intense as the first time. But one of the other things that did occur was a personal message from Baba.

An *acarya* came out and said to me, “We asked Baba a question about society and what our role was in dealing with social problems, and He told us we should talk to you Vishvamitra, because you have a good understanding of social dynamics.” It was a special message; Baba was saying, “Use your talent, Vishvamitra, in dealing with the social environment, and to correct social ills.” So I took that to heart.

And soon Baba was leaving again. We went to the airport, and it was a very sweet departure. There was something lighter about it. The feeling was that though Baba’s body was going on this plane, Baba was still with us, that we would never be separated. That was my personal feeling. Baba always taught me, that the relationship was like hide and

seek: you want to see Him, but the physical body wasn't always available. His darshan wasn't always available. But the vibration that He was giving if you surrender, in your sadhana, was always there. He wanted us to relate to who He really was, on the deepest level, Anandamurti, embodiment of bliss. And not to fawn on the physical, although that was precious to us, and we miss that.

Jiivesh

Blacksburg, Virginia

My first physical encounter with Baba was in September of 1979 in Kingston, Jamaica. After attending several of the most beautiful darshans with only about 200 other devotees, I had the opportunity for Personal Contact (PC). I had been intoxicated by Baba's beauty and purity. I had heard all the stories but the reality was overwhelming. He was so attractive that I could not take my eyes off of Him.

After one darshan, I was told by a close senior *avadhuta* that Baba would give PC upon His return to the house where He was staying and I should run down there immediately. Without any further thought I took off running for Him. I was not alone in this endeavor; however, I had some athletic background, which may have helped. But surprisingly, one brother, an unathletic accountant, finished ahead of me after running through a thick wooded area instead of down the winding roads. We were both in the front of a group of wild-eyed devotees running as if their lives depended on it. This brother was bleeding, he had lost his glasses, his shirt was torn and his ankle sprained – but what desire! He later became a Whole-Timer (WT).

Anyway, I arrived at the house and was second to see Baba until several senior WTs brought a few brothers to the front of the line. This was especially deflating for me because two of these brothers were from my unit and all three of us had shared a bit of ego tension; needless to say both of them were placed right in front of me. I couldn't stop these feelings of jealousy but didn't have long to entertain them, as I was soon grilled by Baba's Personal Assistant, Dada Ramanandaji, where I swore to do (or that I had done) whatever he asked or required of me.

I meditated while waiting to go into His room (I was drenched in sweat and my legs were throbbing but I would not move for half-bath or anything else), hoping that nothing would prevent me from having an opportunity to see Him. I was surprised when each of my two fellow unit brothers came out from PC looking very normal. I didn't have time to think long about this puzzling reaction because Ramanandaji pulled me close and asked if I knew about *sastaung pranam* and, after replying yes, I was literally pushed through the door of His room.

So there I was, sweaty and nervous. I awkwardly performed a sprawling *sastaung pranam*. When I sat up, I namaskared Baba very slowly and carefully. He said sweetly, “Come closer, come closer, my boy.”

I moved forward and sat as close to Him as etiquette would allow. Baba was radiantly smiling and sitting on the edge of His bed. He asked my name and where I was from. I played along and told Him, internally thinking how beautiful He was and how I never wanted to leave His presence. He paused and then again said, “Come closer, my little boy.”

When Baba asked me to come closer a second time (I was already sitting close to and in front of Him) I moved up so that my knees slid under the bed and my nose was an inch from His feet. Without thinking I began to massage His feet. They were so soft and I was intoxicated by His fragrance – I was really out of my mind. He permitted me to massage His feet for several minutes without talking; it was an ecstatic experience.

He then said softly that all over our planet so many are suffering. His voice was filled with pain. “You must become an ideal boy and serve the suffering humanity.”

I said, “I will, Baba.”

Then He placed His hand on my head, His thumb was at my *trikuti* and the palm of His hand rested on my *sahasrara cakra*. I experienced this in what seemed like slow motion. He closed His eyes and repeated a lengthy *shloka*. I was watching His face but when I felt energy moving up my spine I closed my eyes and experienced a powerful burst up to the top of my head. After maybe 20 or 30 seconds, He finished the *shloka* and brought His hands together in namaskar. I returned the namaskar and then returned to massage His feet with the top of my head blissfully on fire. After a few minutes, I was told my time was up by someone outside the room.

I backed out of the room namaskaring with my eyes on Him. Once outside I did not look at anyone, and went and sat down in the front yard of the house and meditated for much of the afternoon, internally replaying His voice, His appearance, His fragrance and His touch and feel. From that day forward I have continuously experienced the most pleasant “burning” sensation at my *sahasrara cakra* and it is activated with my *mantra*, with His image, or with the thought of Him.

Arati

Ithaca, New York

Baba somehow stole His way into my life and captured my heart when I was 21. I had not met Him, but had only heard about Him. There was something about His picture and about Baba Nam Kevalam that had a magnetic pull for me. From the first time I heard Baba's name something in me stirred. I was a student at the University of Stony Brook in Long Island.

Dada Yatiishvarananda was giving a talk at someone's house. I went there with a couple of friends. I remember hearing about Baba and wanting right then and there to get up and learn meditation. Strange sensations overcame me and my friends drew me back to reality. My friends were not affected at all by the talk and so we left. It wasn't until several months later that I again had the opportunity to come in contact with Ananda Marga, and this time I took initiation.

That was in 1972. I did not meet Baba until 1979. As a young margii I had some Baba dreams. There was one where Baba was in wrestling clothes and was wrestling. I thought this was an absurd dream. Soon after that dream I heard that Baba had a fondness for wrestling and would have his workers wrestle for Him and sometimes with Him.

In 1973, as a new margii, I moved into the *jagrti* in Boston and worked on organizing retreats and did office work for Ananda Marga. I soon met my husband, and we got married and over the next four years had two children. When Baba was released from jail we went to Jamaica with our children where I met Baba in person for the first time.

It was everything you would expect it to have been – the culmination of years of devotion, and the depths of clash and despair. In my life experience Baba has brought me closer to Him mostly through much clash. The clash was that I was not able to get Personal Contact and my husband was told he was “disqualified” from attending darshan, as he was an ex-wholetimer. But through this little drama Baba accomplished much with me.

It is hard to put into words my experiences while in Jamaica. They were all so subtle – Baba playing with me, answering my thoughts, my small wishes, teaching me

things through serendipitous happenings. It is too much to write and to others it would be so simple and insignificant. But for me they were interactions through which He communicated with me... such as looking into His eyes, seeing His pain when he hurt His shoulder, finding myself alone on the street with Him when He left darshan.

I wanted to be alone with Him. PC was not to be for me. But during one darshan my four-year-old daughter insisted she had to leave and go to the bathroom. I tried to put her off, but in the end I had to leave the darshan with her to avoid her having an “accident.” As we were returning we saw that Baba was leaving the building and heading for His car with one assistant. I immediately ran with my daughter and stood by the car door and gave Baba my namaskar. He fulfilled my wish to be alone with Him.

My husband and I were extremely sad because due to the disqualification rules, he was not permitted to attend darshan. But even this Baba tempered two times. Once we were all outside the darshan hall. Baba arrived one hour early for darshan. The guards were frantic that the room should be full before Baba entered, so they ordered everyone to enter the darshan hall immediately. There was no time to check passes. So my husband and the other disqualified margiis ran in with everyone else. So He fulfilled my wish to sit as a family in darshan.

Another time we were at Baba’s house with the children. Everyone was ordered to go the darshan hall. But we did not leave, because my husband was not permitted to attend and I was needing help with the children so I was not able to go alone. So we just rested outside under the trees by Baba’s house. Baba was still inside, because He hadn’t left for the darshan hall yet. All the other margiis were gone, except for one other family with two children. For some reason the children decided to pick flowers for Baba. Before we knew it, without having thought about it, we were all lined up outside Baba’s house and every child had a flower except for my son who was only eight months old.

Baba came out and noticed the children and was in a very happy mood. He bent down and one by one took the flower from each of the children and gave them His namaskar. Next to the children, my husband and I were standing and my husband was holding our son, whose name at the time was Arjuna (later changed to Kapil). Baba went right up to Arjuna and said, “And how about you, little boy?” meaning, does he have a flower too?

Arjuna, who was just an infant and normally extremely shy of strangers, starting leaning forward towards Baba until their faces were an inch apart. Then his little body started to shake, and from somewhere deep inside emerged a very loud and resonate “B - A - B - A” as if spoken by a very strong grown man. We were all amazed and Baba threw back his head and started laughing with joy. Then He took the flowers he had collected from the three little girls and gave them to Arjuna by placing them in my husband’s hand. I still have the flowers till this day. Later that day we were told that Baba shared the story with His workers.

Another experience I will share was my experience of DMC. My husband was not permitted to attend, so he stayed back with our sleeping daughter since DMC was to be at midnight. I went with my baby son. I was experiencing tremendous despair that my whole family could not attend, and my mental peace was disturbed and my thoughts were painful. I sat in the back of the room holding my infant son and weeping most of the time. Baba entered and gave His DMC and then it was time for His *mudra*. Many people were shouting and falling into states of bliss. What happened to me was so simple and yet it made an extremely deep impression on me. My mind entered into a deep state of peace. All my negative thoughts and feelings were gone and I entered in a space of total stillness and quietness.

I did not have another opportunity to see Baba for ten more years. In 1989, I traveled to India alone without my family. I was not there for very long but during that brief visit Baba completely pulverized my soul. What a magician... just a little contact with Him can completely transform us. Again for me the contacts were subtle and personal. I did not have PC, nor did I have a conversation with Baba. I remember setting Him four tests, privately, by which I would know that He knew I was there, and He passed all four of them. I got to see Him often when He went out for field walk several times a day. We had a special darshan for Westerners and I sat in the front right before Him. That day I learned that darshan is not about our seeing Baba, but about Baba seeing us. By His looking at us, we are transformed.

I experienced many things about Baba during that visit. I saw His sweetest joy and smile, and I heard His deafening storms as I sat outside His door for hours. I learned the ins and outs of what got one past a guard and into the part of the building where Baba's quarters were. During that brief visit, He plunged my mind into the state of the Void and He set my small being with its attachments and desires aflame in a devouring and all-consuming internal fire. While so many people have stories of actual physical contact and conversations, I cannot boast of those. But I can certainly attest to deep internal transformation from interactions only visible to Him and myself.

When it was time for me to leave India, just then Baba came out for field walk. There was a large gathering and I was standing in the back. By some magic the group seemed to part and there was a distinct path for me to walk down which would place me right outside the window of Baba's car. Without a moment's hesitation I walked down that little path and then the crowd closed in again. I was standing right outside Baba's car window. There was no one else on that side of the car. Baba first turned and namaskared the large group out of the other window and then turned toward the center. It was not clear whether or not He would turn my way, as I was the only one on that side of the car. At that moment some thoughts entered my mind about some work I might do for Him. I wondered if Baba wanted me to do that work. I thought that if He does He will surely turn in my direction and give me a namaskar. At that moment He turned in my direction and looked directly at me and gave me a deep namaskar. I felt a wave overcome me. Baba's car drove out and I sat on the ground and did sadhana. I feel He blessed me on that day to do some work for Him.

A few months before Baba left His physical body, I became quite ill and used to cry for days on end without knowing the cause. I knew that Baba was not well, and I heard He might be coming to the U.S. for treatment, so I decided to knit a green wool scarf for Him. I would knit and cry, not knowing why. One morning I had a dream early in the morning of Baba and a black spot had come to sit on His perfectly pure white attire. I was extremely disturbed by the dream. Later that day I heard that Baba had left. That very day I stopped crying. I now knew why I had been crying all those months and now my tears were all used up.

He comes now and again in a dream... when my desire is intense. I keep a diary of my dreams... they are very simple... just sweet moments with Baba very close.

Jyotishvar

Los Angeles, California

I was initiated by Ac. Yatiishvarananda Avt. in Carbondale, Illinois, which was a very big unit back then. I'll tell about the experiences I had in Iceland. It convinced me that Baba had very special powers.

It was part of Baba's tour of Europe. I was very lucky to be in Volunteers in Social Service (VSS) at the time. I had always been interested in martial arts. VSS was just getting started, and since Baba was coming to the West, we realized that Baba would need security, a bodyguard, crowd control. I was living in Los Angeles with Kamalakanta. We were training hard every day, rigorous about our sadhana and training.

We both flew to Europe. Dada Shantabodhananda was in charge of New York Sector VSS. He assigned me to be in charge of all security there – it was a tremendous opportunity, a blessing, and I was completely dedicated to it. We organized all the guards around Baba's house 24 hours a day. The crowds were very large, and security was very important. We were always checking on the security, and would sneak up on Baba's house in the middle of the night to try to catch the guards off-guard. I went on all the field walks myself, with four VSS guards around Baba.

One day Dada Shantabodhananda brought me to Baba's house and said, "Wait right here, don't move!" He went in and then ran out, excited, and said, "Baba wants you to be His bodyguard!" I was so excited. Any time Baba left His house to go on field walk, or go to darshan, I was always at His side. I carried a bag with a thermos of milk and water – a time-honored tradition of Baba's field walk supplies. I was lucky to be able to serve Baba like this.

In the night I shone the flashlight for Baba wherever He walked. At the time of darshan it was kind of like being a Secret Service agent for the president. You were the closest person to Baba, and looking out at the crowd constantly, ready to die for Baba. There was no question, if shots were fired, you'd stand in front of Baba and take them. There was no doubt in my mind that I would have done that, or any of the other VSS guards also. We were experiencing a tremendous exalted state, it was like a kind of *samadhi*, but we could function, we could do everything, we were 150 percent, not

spaced out or drunken. We enjoyed tremendously, but we were working overtime always, solving problems. It was the greatest moment in my life.

Then we got to Iceland. There was a karate dojo right across from where Baba stayed. I trained there everyday and got to know those brothers there. I was very much into my martial arts then, and still am. We arranged to have DMC at the karate dojo.

During *Dharma Maha Cakra* (DMC) someone had to guard Baba's house. One VSS brother would make a sacrifice not to go to DMC but stay and guard Baba's house, all alone. That brother always got some kind of special blessing. This was the first time that no one volunteered for that duty. The dadas took me aside and said, "Jyotishvar, you've got to take this duty, you've been to so many DMCs. You can be Baba's bodyguard the whole time He is here, and go on all field walks, but we have to ask that you guard Baba's house during DMC."

I don't know, I was so selfish. I think today I would volunteer, but I was young, and I refused repeatedly. I still can't believe I did that. I even asked all the karate guys I was training with if they would guard Baba's house. They said they'd make a ring around Baba's house and no one would enter. And I told the dadas, but they said it had to be a margii. None of the karate guys wanted to get initiated. So I would have to do it. I was very bitter about it.

I was always in a frenzy while organizing the security, but now while everyone went to the DMC, with all this tremendous energy, everyone running to the dojo. I was the only person there, and I became crazy. I was pacing wildly around the room; I couldn't imagine how much pain I was in. I don't know why, I just resented it so much. I was supposed to guard the door, but I went inside Baba's room. As soon as I walked in, I was just caught up in the energy. The room was thick with energy, really amazing. I went up to Baba's bed. And there were His shoes. His shoes were sitting there, really well worn. He had gone to the DMC wearing the slippers we had given Him. I sat down there, abandoning my duty – anyone could have broken in – but I sat down there and put my hands in His shoes.

Just in that second, I don't know if I went in *samadhi* or what, I don't recall becoming unconscious, just at that moment I heard all this racket outside, and I thought, "Oh no, there's an attack on Baba's house, and I'm not doing my duty!" So I got up and

went outside to my post and the whole room was filled with margiis, coming back from the DMC. But not enough time had passed for it. I was completely confused. It couldn't have been more than five or ten minutes, in my mind. Baba came in, and people were shouting "*Parama Pita Baba Ki!*" Baba was just about to go through the door, and He stopped. I was trying to look very VSS but I was completely disorganized. Baba turned to the crowd. He said, "I think everyone enjoyed themselves?"

And He looked right over at me, I was inches away from Him, and He looked right in my eyes, and said, "I think everyone enjoyed himself?" He had a big smile, looking at me, and then He disappeared. Then all the dadas came up and said, "You see, Baba gave you a special blessing." But they didn't know that two hours had been erased from my mind.

At the very end of Baba's visit there, we were at the airport, and there were very few margiis there. Baba was flying on to Europe. I was unable to get a seat on the same plane, but I saw that Baba was sitting in the lobby waiting. I went and sat there with two or three margiis. Baba didn't say anything. Some Indian dadas were there and Baba spoke to them in some language.

After this He looked down at us and said, "What language was I speaking?" Nobody knew.

I didn't know but I said tentatively, "Hindi?"

Baba put His face down close to mine and said, "What?"

"Hindi?"

He didn't respond directly but sat up very happy and pleased, so I guessed that I had guessed right. Then He looked at me and held out His five fingers and said, "You know so much about languages. Which languages do you know? English?"

I didn't speak any other languages at the time. But Baba seemed very intent that He wanted to be able to count on His five fingers all the languages I could speak. At that time I could only speak English, so I thought it was strange. But as the years rolled by, I developed a very strong interest in foreign languages. I lived in Germany and became fluent in German, then I studied Chinese in Taiwan and became conversational, then moved to Japan where I have lived for eight years and learned Japanese.

So I need one more language to fulfill Baba's prediction. That's what's great about Baba. He could have told me anything. "Oh, your mother's name is Betty and your father's name is William, you were born in Illinois" – He could have told me anything and I would have gone, "Wow, this guy is a magician." He didn't do that; He said something that on the surface looked like He made a mistake. He didn't try to impress me. It was to leave an indelible mark that now twelve years later I don't forget. And also perhaps influenced the course of my life.

After Baba left I went back to where He had stayed. There were so many things there that Baba had used, towels, a brush. And the margiis and dadas had just cleaned it out. But left on Baba's bed was this foam mattress, so I thought, "I'll sleep on this mattress." I slept on it that night and it was fairly wonderful; I had extraordinary dreams. I also got a small hand towel. I was playing the violin at the time, and I used to use that to keep my instrument in. I also found a disposable razor that Baba had used. I kept it and used it for months, every day. I would tell people I'd been using this disposable razor every day for four months and it was still sharp as ever. To me it was a kind of miracle.

Aditi

Albuquerque, New Mexico

We saw Baba in Jamaica! I had never seen Baba before. I came to Ananda Marga, really enjoying the meditation, but very ambivalent about gurus, or anything devotional. I came from a very scientific, analytical family, and I have a scientific career. And I was known as being quite skeptical about those things.

But I strongly wanted to meet Baba, to maintain my skepticism, probably. It was a big deal that He was coming. We were living near Denver, the only margiis there, and they forgot to call us. Finally someone remembered and told us. And we were on a plane in 24 hours, which was exciting and chaotic and a little crazy.

Seeing Baba at the airport, I'd never experienced anything like it. It was late at night, He came down, and we all ran madly towards His plane. I'm sure there were security people there but it didn't make any difference, we were all out on the runway. One tall brother suddenly flung his arms back and fell straight back, and I was watching his head bounce on the cement. I was going, "Ohmigosh, he's dead!" And Dada Daneshananda was running by and I said, "Dada!" He looked, and said, "Oh, don't worry, he's in *samadhi*," and we both ran on. And the brother actually was fine later. We were all so excited that people were falling into *samadhi*, and the fact that we could kind of consider that normal, shows what state we were in.

We were all crowded around Him, and Baba seemed to be almost in a light. The biggest thing for us, was that we had our marriage blessed. We had requested that long before we went.

It was one of the reasons we got married then. We were hoping, though it wasn't guaranteed. In the way all sorts of crazy things happen to people, it wasn't made easy. First Dada said, "No, it just isn't going to happen." And then he said "tomorrow" and it didn't happen. And then, he said that after a darshan Baba had agreed to do a few of them. Baba went for field walk, and we went down to His house, far from where the darshan house was. Darshan wasn't supposed to start until 1 p.m. And while we were there someone ran up and said, "Baba's starting darshan!"

We were hoping that we were going to have wonderful sadhana beforehand, that it was going to be this perfect experience. And in fact we were rushing up the hill, our sides hurting, and I was crying, because I cry easily, and we were saying, “We’re going to miss it!” Running and running. We got there and He started darshan, and we were supposed to have had our marriage blessed before darshan.

We were on one side of the hall, outside, knowing we’d missed our big opportunity. It was really important to me. We were watching Baba, and He finished darshan, and started to get up, and someone came in and whispered in His ear. He looked around, and they’re whispering, and He’s shaking His head. Then He nodded, and they let us come in.

I’d given up by then by about the third shake of His head. I was still crying. But the actual experience, I don’t remember much. He said something about Shiva and Parvati. My only memory was watching His hands, and looking at His rings, and it was a wonderful memory. Those were Baba’s hands. And He gave me the garland, we’d made a garland, and said, “This is your wedding property, so keep it safe.” We still have it around a picture of Baba. It was the first marriage blessing in North America.

In ’84 we saw Baba for about two seconds in Allahabad, and then at DMC in Kanpur and in Agra. We were there to see Baba, and we knew He was in that town, but had no idea how to find him. We finally went out, and bumped into an *acarya*. He made arrangements for us to go to where Baba was. We went by night, dressed in Indian clothes, by bicycle rickshaw. We got there and got just a glimpse of Baba, because it was all over. But I could look through a door and see Baba lying there. And after all that drama, it was very heartening. Then we got His tour schedule, and could see Him in Kanpur. Kanpur was a small gathering, maybe 100 people. I remember doing kiirtan in the tent and opening my eyes and Baba staring right at me. It was such an intimate DMC. I guess everyone has different type of *samskaras* with Baba, and for us a lot of them were all these crazy experiences just trying to see Baba. You could read in the old days how you had to go through all these trials and tribulations to see guru. For a lot of margiis, you’d have to go through all kinds of terrible things – running from the police, being fingerprinted, questioned, and deported.

In 1986 we didn't even make it out of the airport, because they had our names. We had our new baby with us. Once I got to see Him I didn't so much care about what kind of interaction I had. In '89 it was so busy you had to wait and wait for hours to get close to Him, although He did keep giving darshans on Sunday. I went while He was giving lecture on *Shabda Cayanika*, one of the letters, and afterwards Dada Vijayananda translated for us. I managed to give Baba a garland on that trip.

In the darshans in India we never heard a word of English. But it was wonderful not to have to pay attention to the words. In Jamaica I felt like I had to pay attention, but in India I could just watch Him, His expressions, what He did with his hands, his head. It was so nice. You could pay attention to Him instead.

Satish

Cuba

I was only 14 years old when Baba visited Jamaica. It was an experience that no one present will forget. I remember that we made all the preparations in August – there were margiis from all over New York Sector. I was a member of the Volunteers in Social Service (VSS) team. We rehearsed all security measures. We stayed up all night to make sure that our *tandava* was perfect. Our VSS dress was all in good shape.

Wow, it was then announced that Baba would not be coming to Jamaica. How disappointed we were! With tears in our eyes, the margiis from Latin America, Guatemala, and Mexico who had saved so much to come to Jamaica were not able to see their Guru. They all left in disappointment.

In the next two weeks, the news came. Baba would definitely be in Jamaica. I am not sure how those margiis who had saved to come to Jamaica once were able to find a second way to be back in Jamaica on Baba's arrival. Baba's arrival was dramatic. Three days before His arrival the meteorologist announced that it would rain for the next five days, and sure enough it started raining.

I remember that Brigadish (Maurice Rhodes) was on his way to the airport to pick up Baba; he would be Baba's chauffeur. We were all drenched in rain. It was two hours before Baba's arrival and like a flash of thunder, it stopped raining. All was well. The sun shone at 5 p.m. (which was not normal on a rainy day in Jamaica). All smiled at Baba's arrival. There at the airport Baba stepped forward and we were all blessed with His love.

It was at the airport that Baba smiled at me and gave me His namaskar. I was a VSS worker and so I was not able to respond in the way I wanted to respond. I was disappointed as I tried to have Personal Contact on four occasions but was not able to do so as I had VSS duties.

In August 1987, I was an LFT in VSS in New York and I had to report in India. At my first reporting I was all prepared to have Personal Contact but again I faced Baba's play. There would be no more PC as duties were not accomplished in all sectors, so I returned to New York City.

I was disappointed. I thought that Baba did not want to bless me, so I would continue but with much pain in my heart, disappointment and a little anger. It was then in October, 1982, that my acarya, Dada Shankarananda, sent me again to India with one mission – to have PC. He instructed me well. “Do not return to New York Sector until you get PC,” he said, “This is your mission and this is your privilege and this will happen only once in your life.”

I went back to India with one conviction: PC or never to return from India. Those of us who know Dada Shankarananda know of his lion heart and penetrating instructions and force, so I yielded. I arrived in India and after three days I had conjunctivitis, so to my disappointment I was not able to see Baba for two weeks. How I suffered. At last the day came unexpectedly. I was summoned. Then it happened suddenly. I really was there in front of Baba’s room. I had so many thoughts in my head. What will Baba say to me? I had so many questions to ask my guru. There were so many small thoughts running around in my head.

Then I was in front of my guru. Baba beckoned me to come close to Him. He asked me my name and I told Him.

Then He closed His eyes and a few minutes later with eyes closed He said, “Satish, my boy, do you remember when I was in Jamaica at the airport and I looked around and smiled at you?”

I was dumbfounded. All my questions were gone. What more could I have asked when Baba could identify that while He was in Jamaica He smiled at one of His little sons. My mind was transformed into a ball of love and devotion. My guru was with me in all His glory and universal might... and with all His love.

He looked at me and said, “I know that you have many doubts. Do you have any doubts now, my little boy?”

Lost for words, I said, “No, my Baba.”

He said, “You have done a few wrong things in your life. Do you want punishment?”

I said, “Yes, Baba.”

He then waved His stick over my head and said, “You are my little boy, how can I punish you? Go and do work to help save the world. You are one of Baba’s sons.”

He gave me His blessings and I left His room with a new vision and might. It was then that I knew that I had to do something to save the world. I have been trying to do all that I can. Now I am in Cuba, doing His work in the actions that I have made commitments to.

Gopi

Monterrey, Mexico

I entered Ananda Marga in 1974 in the Philippines, when I was just starting at university. I was brought up in a very strict Catholic family, in a very strict school. After being there for about 13 years, I was searching for something more. One day at the university I saw a dada and I just followed him. I didn't know what he was going to do. And he invited us in to a conference room to talk, and said, "Just for a moment, close your eyes and try to meditate." I didn't even know what meditation was. I remember I just closed my eyes and said, "Please Lord, show me the way." And from that moment, saying those words, everything changed in my life. For some reason I just wanted to be in the yoga house, just wanted to do meditation. Everything changed.

I saw Baba's picture, and thought, "I've been looking for Him for such a long time." I decided to become a Local Full Timer (LFT).

Baba's Personal Assistant, Dada Ramanandaji was touring the Philippines with Dada Adveshanandaji. They passed by my province, Cebu, and I met them. Dada told me, "Come with us." Without asking my parent's permission, I went. I felt Baba manifesting His presence, His love, so much through other people. When the dadas went for *kapalik*, they would always call Gori, one of the margiis, and Gopi, my name, "Gori-Gopi, come with us." I didn't know what *kapalik sadhana* was; I would go to the cemetery but I was not afraid. This was the start of my Ananda Marga experience.

I was a margii for seven years before I saw Baba physically. I had no words to explain what I felt when I saw Him. Someone you have waited for, felt His presence, but not known physically, and suddenly you see Him, and He looks so simple.

There was a field walk. They gave a schedule of who could walk with Baba. For some reason we arrived in a place and Baba didn't like it. We went back. And I felt so depressed, that my chance was over. But the following day Baba was going to go to a convent in Jamaica, and they called me for field walk. This walk was filmed, and when I saw it again, I couldn't believe I was given the chance in this life to be near the guru. I always wanted to be near Baba, but so many people also wanted to and you couldn't be so near Him. As we were walking through the gardens of the convent, Baba started to say

that some flowers in Jamaica actually came from Asia, and people have brought them to America. He started to talk about some fruits. I was the only Filipina there.

He was saying, “There is one jackfruit... who knows Tagalog?”

I was so shocked. And then He looked at me, “What is the Tagalog word for jackfruit?” And before I could answer, He said, “Lanka, lanka?”

And I said, “Yes, Baba.”

Then He started talking about other fruits. There was a fruit named chilemoya here. And He said, “This one in the Philippines, what is the name of that fruit?” And He again turned to me, and before I could answer, He said, “Apis, apis.”

“Yes, Baba.”

They were walking back to His car, got in the car and Ramanandaji called me. At that time, my name was Guruvati. He turned to Baba and said my name, “Guruvati, Baba.” Baba said, “Hmm, Guruvati. Such a small girl, and she knows so many things!”

Vishala

New Haven, Connecticut

In 1977 I was living in Vermont and I took a meditation class with Cirasmita. One thing I remember very strongly is that after my first meditation class I had a dream, and in the dream I was dying. I was feeling total annihilation, like I was dying. All of a sudden I heard “Baba Nam Kevalam,” all this kiirtan singing in my mind. And I just held on to that, and it was very beautiful and peaceful.

The next week I went to meditation class and told them that I thought I had this problem, and told them what happened. And Cirasmita started laughing, “You have one class and you have this experience!”

Later that summer I had another experience. I had many bad habits, a lot of American-style partying and drugs. I had stopped these things when I started meditating, but I still had those kinds of friends. And one night a group of friends came to my house and said, “Come out with us, we’re going to go partying.” A margii sister was living next door to me, it so happens, and she just looked at me, and I felt this intense thing – later I understood what it was – I felt this “No.”

I became extremely afraid, and I said “no” to these people, and slammed the door. And I got afraid and went into my room and put the covers over my head. They kept knocking on the door to get me to go out with them, but I said no. And that night they were all killed in a crash, and I was saved. I hadn’t even been initiated yet. I feel that Baba came through and told me, “No, don’t do that.” I felt that something was happening to me, I didn’t know what it was. I started meditating, going to *dharmacakra*.

Anyway, I went back to college. I was 19, and I still hadn’t been initiated by an *acarya*. I’d already been meditating twice a day for a year, and I got initiated and received first lesson. Baba had been in jail, but He got out of jail, and the following fall He was coming to Jamaica. So everyone was going. I was sick, I had pneumonia, but somehow I had this force in my mind that said, “I’m going to go.” I was a very young margii but I had this pull to go. My roommate was a margii and she was going to go, too. Then I thought, “I can’t go, I’ve had pneumonia, I’m in school, I have all these courses.”

But that night, there were robbers outside our window, trying to get in, and suddenly I was like, “OK, I’m going to go, let’s leave.” As if Baba was making me go.

We got to Jamaica. I was really sick, and young; it was totally crazy. In the beginning my feeling about Baba was “Who is this person? Why am I here? He’s trying to manipulate everybody.” I had this ego. “He doesn’t know me, He doesn’t know who I am. Why am I doing this?” All these thoughts were coming in my mind.

In the middle of the next darshan He gave, He stopped, looked over and pointed at me, and said, “And you.” Everyone around me fell over, and I just felt it was like Baba took me at that moment. And you, you will be my devotee, too. In one look and one word, I felt He captured my heart for the rest of my life.

Before that everyone wanted Personal Contact, and I was so-so about it. But after that I was like, “I want PC!” and I was chasing Didi around trying to arrange it. Baba never gave me that much personal attention when He was in His body. But He gave me a few subtle things that lasted for the rest of my life. Very small things, but they always had to do with my spiritual practices. And I could watch Baba.

One time we were doing *kaoshikii*, and I noticed that people were not doing it properly, and Baba stopped it, saying “No, that’s not proper.” I was like, “I have to learn how to do it, and from now on I’ll do it twice a day.” And I feel like Baba needed me to know at that moment how to do *kaoshikii*, because it was going to affect my health for the rest of my life.

We went to the airport, and stationed ourselves purposely to be where Baba was going to walk in. Some people had bought some French fries. And looking at it, I thought that this was not sentient food. They were fried in lard or something, and somehow I knew. But I thought, “Well, I’ll just take it,” and I ate it.

Right after that, I knew I’d done something very wrong. I shouldn’t have done that. And just then Baba came in, and looked at us, and immediately turned around and went into the bathroom. And it was like we had stationed ourselves for Baba but we had done this one thing that was not right, and He was in a subtle way training us to do the right thing. Not only giving this unbelievable love, but teaching us how thin the line is in

Tantra, and how important it is to be very careful about what you're doing. And I really brought that with me to this day, and I think about that sort of thin line.

Baba is that very thin line, of love but also *Tantra*, and you have to be very disciplined if you're going to be with Him.

Sadhana

Madison, Wisconsin

I was ripe for the picking by my Guru Baba. In 1973 I was 24 years old. But the seeds that grew into that ripe fruit were planted back when I was 13 years old. That summer I fell quite unexpectedly into a deep pit of depression. The lights went out on any sense of meaning, hope or joy. I simply couldn't feel anything inside but a bleak emptiness. Running from it into reading alone in my room day and night, I found escape but no solace. I certainly didn't feel I could tell anyone what was going on.

So I waited it out until the distraction of school resumed, seeming to bring me out of it enough to go on acting as if I were OK, but something in me had changed forever. I had even, before this time, had a deep sense that this world was not as it ought to be, that human life should be full of peace and harmony. But I had seen enough to know all of life was not this way. As the daughter of a U. S. diplomat, I had traveled all my life until then, living in foreign cultures for several years at a time. Fascinating, varied and friendly as other cultures were, I just knew something was not as it should be. In the natural world was the only resonance of that pure harmony I longed for, so I often escaped to the trees and the blue sky.

As I grew older and more sophisticated, I found some meaning in creative expression through music and poetry. It was in playing music, improvising, with others that I experienced letting go my own limited, earth-bound consciousness to fly on the wings of an expanded Self at one with others. But these moments never lasted long before I would be dropped back into my unhappiness. Being young at the time of the civil rights movement and in college at the height of the anti-Vietnam War movement, I was able to channel my unhappiness into efforts to change the world. While making my efforts to have an outer impact, I was also reading Taoist and Zen approaches to inner realities of mind and consciousness. These spoke of the kind of inner freedom that rang a bell with me, offering some lasting peace and a way out of the existential emptiness.

In the fall of 1972, after two years of living and traveling overseas, I returned to the town where I had gone to college to settle down and find a job. The depression hit full force.

When He finally came into my life, the match with Baba and His ideology could not have been more perfect. Being a Guru who equally emphasizes spiritual progress and social change, His teachings fit like a glove. I can remember, in my early reading of Prout, how I felt I was reading my own ideas articulated by someone, as if He had read my mind. This relationship with Baba started quietly. I attended a meditation class with my sister. I signed up without realizing it was Ananda Marga. The synchronicities were there in that the margiis had come to the school where I was teaching a hatha yoga class to offer that one of their acaryas give a lecture to my students. The talk had been confusing, but the friendliness and sincerity of the local margiis who brought him stuck with me. One of them, Jinaneshvar, became my meditation class teacher, my best friend and eventually my husband.

The real, profound impact of the meditation itself began when I received initiation from Dada Jitendra in 1973. I could feel I had been handed, with this technique (first lesson) a truly powerful tool for inner transformation. But I still did not realize the depth of my connection with Him. He was, to me, simply the man who perfected these meditation tools and this philosophy I admired. But to love Him or see Him as a manifestation of Cosmic Consciousness was still far away.

In my early days as a margii, I felt my inner skeptic holding me back from fully embracing this as my path. I had spent years distrusting 'isms' and outer sources of authority. Yet the power with which the meditation worked to center my mind and the new sense of joy it brought won me over, eventually. My first week-long national retreat introduced me to longer three-times-a-day meditations. I found these tedious and hard to sit through, yet when I returned home several dramatic changes occurred, during two *dharmacakras* in particular. First, I experienced a total lifting of the anxious, depressed, empty feelings that had been with me since adolescence. These were replaced by a sense of surety that a source within me was ever-present and all I ever needed.

The very next time I attended a group meditation (having had an incredibly joyful week) I experienced diving deep into that source and breaking through into a revelation of my complete oneness with all of life, infused with my love for it all. The inner

transformation worked by these meditations convinced me I had found my spiritual home.

Yet who Baba was and how He related to these experiences still confused me. I had observed the older margiis ecstatic with love for Him and this felt very foreign to me. Not only did I see myself as too intellectual to be a *bhakta*, but I had no personal experience of Baba to make me feel drawn to Him. I had discussed these doubts with Jinaneshvar at my first retreat and his support to trust my sincere intentions and my own inner process was reassuring. I felt less out of place and risked another national retreat six months later. I came to the next year's retreat determined to know more about who this guru was to me. Did I really have a personal relationship with Him? If so, why didn't I feel it?

In my determination to have an answer I decided at the retreat's *akhanda kiirtan* to do non-stop kiirtan myself until something happened to let me know Baba was there for me too. After just two hours I suddenly felt these powerful surges of bliss rolling up my spine and spreading throughout my body. They continued whenever I meditated for weeks after, although I tried to suppress them out of embarrassment at the movements they caused. So I truly felt I had been answered and ever after that, when I needed Baba's help or just to know He was with me, I found Him ready to respond within me. He began to win my heart as well as my mind.

At the time I first encountered Ananda Marga I was also becoming involved with the man who was to become my first husband. Had his interest in spirituality been as strong as mine or had I been married before meeting Baba, this story would have been very different.

However, by the time I realized how much Baba meant to me, I was already deeply invested in a relationship with someone who, while supportive of meditation and of Ananda Marga superficially, turned out to be quite threatened by my love for Baba. So what did I do with this difficulty? I agonized, struggled and suffered. I could not let go of either of these loves of mine. I sought countless compromises, ways to include him in Ananda Marga activities, ways to explain and justify my choices. It was very painful to

have to hide so profound an inner relationship as I had developed with Baba from my own partner for fear of his judgment or rejection.

The year before we made the commitment to marriage, the struggle was particularly intense. I kept questioning if I was supposed to give up relationships altogether and take *acarya* vows in order to work full time for Baba's mission. My pull to work for and please my Divine Father was very intense by then. On the horns of this dilemma, I kept struggling and asking for guidance from Baba. It came in a most unique way. At the time, Baba was in jail and few margiis could get in to see Him. I had not tried to go to India. It was quite dangerous. Yet one night, I awoke, or so it felt, fully alert and conscious, in a line waiting to see Baba outside His jail cell. I pinched myself to know I was not dreaming.

Full of excitement and some apprehension as to how it would feel to finally meet my Guru in person, I waited my turn in line. At last I was let in and knelt beside the cot where He lay, covered by a light blanket. As I bowed my head in greeting, He lay still and then returned the greeting with eyes half closed. He reached out and took my hand so lovingly and drew me nearer, up closer to His face. Holding His hand, I felt enveloped in my love for Him. I felt His love flowing freely towards me as well. Then I know what I wanted to ask. "What about my relationship with...?"

"Do whatever you can for him and leave the rest to me," came the reply.

I felt so blessed and reluctant to leave; yet the experience was beginning to fragment and slip back into the normal realms of time and space. Baba handed me some rock candy from a jar by His cot and then I was back in my bed, sleeping again. Although I did not know how to take this message from Baba at the time, in the months that followed I felt more and more that I needed to see this commitment through, not change altogether, or so Baba's message seemed to imply. I can see now the karmic reasons why we were together and I honor Baba's gentle message to stick it out. My experience of Baba is that He has asked of me that I undergo some very challenging undertakings in my life, this relationship being one of them.

One more time, in 1982, Baba again came to guide me and to ask of me a new challenge. I was almost 34 years old and married to my non-margii friend. I had been unclear about my readiness or even my willingness to have a child, never having had strong yearnings in that direction. I had been asking Baba for guidance, but receiving no clarity. Then one day, while I was at a meeting in the local hospital, an overwhelming urge to meditate came over me. I left the meeting as quickly as I could and went to the meditation room provided by the hospital. As soon as I closed my eyes, I saw Baba seated before me. What He told me was that if I wanted to attain the highest form of bhakti where I would love *Parama Purusa* only for the pleasure it gives Him, not for my own sake, that I should have a child. I had always wondered how I could ever attain that form of *bhakti*. It seemed so far from where I was. Here was His answer. I immediately took the resolve to follow His guidance. There was no longer a doubt or moment of hesitation. And Baba did His part. Later on when there were obstacles to fulfilling this decision on the physical plane He removed them so that my daughter could be born in 1983.

As deep as my bond with Baba had become, I was to find that there was yet a deeper experience of the profound bond of love between us waiting for me in Jamaica. In the fall of 1979 North and Central American margiis gathered in a lovely hilltop retreat center outside Kingston for four of the most blissful days I have ever experienced. When my plane landed, Baba had already arrived and gone to His house below us in the valley. Margiis were streaming in from all over the continent, 250-300 in total. That evening, we had our first, long-awaited, darshan. After we were seated and singing *bhajans*, Baba entered the hall. I could not believe how glowing and beautiful He looked to me and His voice was so deep and powerful. From then on my heart was lost to Him.

I ran down to His house every morning at dawn to sing kiirtan, outside, for Him. We crowded outside His door every afternoon to see Him come out and go on field walk. We sat for darshan morning and afternoon in utter bliss at His nearness. Every moment of those days I felt as if I were in heaven and I only wanted to be near Him. To my eyes, every particle of dust was dancing in love because of His presence. He was truly my Krishna and I his *gopi*.

On the third day, I was finally able to have personal contact with nine other sisters. It was not easy to get on the list for PC, but I was determined and had the help of a friend so at last I could sit before Baba and receive His direct blessing. He asked my name, and told me, “You know what it means? Meditation.” He then reached out and pressed my crown *cakra* with His finger. I could feel it vibrate. But most of all I could hardly stay in my right mind. Being near Him, the whole world felt unreal, ephemeral and only light shone within me.

The last night of His stay was to be DMC. The hall was packed and I got a place about halfway back, not near enough for my liking, but still where I could see Him. At one point during the evening I realized He was looking directly at me. My mind couldn’t accept the attention to me and denied it could be, until later when the friend next to me said, “He was looking at someone over here, wasn’t He?”

When I felt Baba looking at me, I fell into a deep meditation and had a powerful vision of Baba sitting at the center of the universe and me dancing around Him with the clear message that throughout eternity, now and always, this is where I truly am. In the midst of lifetimes of experience, now, past and future, I have always been and will always be in His orbit. I am never far, always in His presence. Behind the day-to-day experiences, this is what is most real. How sweet and profound that moment was.

We went to the airport late that night to see Him off to South America. Singing and crying, my eyes were glued to Him until his plane was out of sight. I could not believe the bittersweet longing of separation could be so strong. And then I went back to my daily life, but something in my relationship with Baba was changed, a level of devotion and love for Him was there that I found hard to contain, it was so powerful. In the years that followed, I lost that feeling, even though my devotion to Him stayed strong. It surfaced for a brief moment in 1990 when there was a hope He would come to the U.S. and I could see Him again, but, again I felt so swept away by the feeling that I could not hold on to it. And then He left His body a few months later.

A few years ago, He came to me in a dream. I sat with Him while He sang some of His songs to me and then as He got up to leave, that blissful feeling from Jamaica swept over me and He said, “Don’t forget this feeling.” So, by His grace, it is not far

from me anymore, buried in some inaccessible recess of my heart, but available when I open to feel the bond of love He showed me back there in Vrindavan, in Jamaica.

Pashupati

Raleigh, North Carolina

One or two days after receiving Personal Contact (Jamaica, 1979) I found myself talking with Dadaji Ramananda about AMURT work. He was very pleasant, and very sensible and practical – a delight to work with. We initially met outside, and then in his room, which was across the hall from Baba’s room. At one point, a gong or bell was heard, and Ramanandaji immediately got up, said “Baba,” and walked out into Baba’s room.

Baba had some of His laundry (a shirt He’d worn) sitting on Ramanandaji’s floor. I took the liberty of smelling it, to see if the sandalwood odor I’d always heard about was permeating it. It didn’t.

Anyway, Dada Ramanandaji shortly came out, and said that Baba would soon be leaving. I took the opportunity to stand in the hall near where He would be passing. He passed just by me, and just after He did, I suddenly said, “Baba!” He turned, looked me straight in the eyes with those doe-eyes of His, and melted my heart. I realized then the softness in those eyes, and how much love He must have for us. This experience stayed with me for quite some time.

After I got home from Jamaica, I realized that I was quite happy. I expected to be a dynamo of energy after meeting Baba, but instead I was merely mellow. Perhaps a bit more *sattvic*. I was already fairly *rajasic*.

Later, I was in India, going to visit Baba in Ananda Nagar in 1986, not having seen Him since 1979 in Jamaica. Although I didn’t recognize myself as craving the presence of His physical body, I found myself running after Him and chasing after His car, like a mindless idiot or a dog on the highway. Very interesting.

There was much waiting around when Baba had reporting scheduled. I remembered that Baba once said that He didn’t mind being late for darshans because the margiis would sing kiirtan while waiting for Him. So I sang kiirtan and did sadhana while waiting.

In reporting, Baba noted that the targets had not been met. He asked, “Should we give punishment?” Some said yes, some said no. Baba said, “It is not proper to give punishment all the time. Let them try harder.”

In DMC, Baba gave a wonderful discourse in three languages. I found my mind wandering somewhat. This was partly because I was jammed between many *avadhutas*, who had graciously allowed me to sit near the front of the 20,000 people there, since I had come all the way from the West. However, it also meant that I had to sit with my knees up to my chest, shoulder to shoulder and elbow to elbow with several other *dadas*. This physically difficult posture made it difficult to meditate or concentrate.

But at least I could see well, and hear pretty well, too. When Baba gave His *mudra*, I tried to sit in half-lotus to prepare to receive it properly, but to no avail. I heard lots of people screaming and jumping around me, but I could only envy them. Then, some of the *dadas* got up to follow Baba as He left the dais. Finally I got to sit in proper position. I did *dhyana* (sixth lesson), and suddenly my mind got very light, and felt encompassed in light.

The feeling persists even as I write this. I did not move for several minutes, but I just enjoyed the bliss. I still do.

At the DMC in May of 1987, I attended AMURT (Ananda Marga Universal Relief Team) global meetings with *margiis*, *dadas* and *didis*. We met in Kimshuk’s bedroom at Baba’s house (Kimshukji is Baba’s adopted son, and is now an *acarya* in his own right.) The meetings ran overtime, due to some people not arriving in time from their various countries. Therefore, we planned to give report to Baba on the day after DMC. However, it turned out that some of the AMURT workers had already made plans to leave Ananda Nagar immediately following DMC, and so the final report meeting could not take place as planned, as Baba demands that all sectors be represented during reporting sessions. That night, in *darshan* (where Baba gives a more informal talk), Baba spent half the *darshan* commenting on how some of the workers “left in a hot haste,” and was obviously displeased with the disruption of order. Then He went on with the lecture.

Vijaya Laksmi

[Editor's note: Vijaya Laksmi, a great devotee and dynamic worker for Ananda Marga, passed away in 2003. Her selfless service stands as an example. She will be missed.]

I was initiated in 1971 in Los Altos Hills, California. I was raised a Catholic, but after I went to college and into nursing, I had given it up. I thought it wasn't something I wanted to continue in my life even though I was still very emotionally involved in the spirit of Christ and prayer. I was then married, and living in Berkeley, California. A few years later I began to look at different meditation practices and different psychologies. When my oldest daughter reached nineteen or twenty, she was initiated. I remember I was in the kitchen doing dishes and she said to me, "There is a very special time when a Guru comes to the earth and it has such profound meaning," and she wanted me to look into it. So I went to Los Altos and did very nice kiirtan. I didn't stay for DC because I wasn't yet initiated. After that, I thought it all seemed very beautiful. But I was very hesitant to join another group after being in the Catholic Church. Gradually, I got acquainted with some of the margiis.

Within six or seven months, I was beginning to be acquainted with the whole spiritual path, with Dada pushing me. When I decided to join Ananda Marga, I was especially impressed with the social service and what that meant because that was what I wanted to do. Even before I could realize some of the spiritual aspects of it, I was studying Baba's social theories. I was very impressed with some of the *acaryas*. We didn't have any didis around then. The first didi that came was Didi Ananda Rama. She came to train the GV sisters. So, as soon as I became initiated, I gave up meat. That was the easiest thing I ever did. It just seemed automatic. But I kept eating eggs and fish. Then in about eight months or so I was completely vegetarian. After that, things moved very fast. Baba was in jail and we were not able to see Him. But we were very close to Him and we were doing everything we could to help our Guru.

During the time Baba was in jail, I was taking a class with a very politically active teacher. One of our projects was to do something that was a little against the rules or very

activist in nature. So we put a committee together and decided we were going to do a demonstration in San Francisco. We decided the theme of the demonstration was that justice was dead and we were going to have a funeral.

We started down Market St. We had cars with lights and people had black bands. We had a police escort, which was very unusual. As you know, funerals move very slowly with the lights flashing. We proceeded down Market St. with the police escorts, and I remember two or three margiis had those black veils over their faces.

Then we stopped at the Indian embassy and were going to deliver a letter. We wanted to take the coffin in, but they wouldn't let us. So we took the letter, and the officials were just so angry when they saw us there from the window. We were spreading literature and had a megaphone and telling about what happened to Baba. And actually there were two or three TV stations which came to film us, so we were on TV. That was a very unique experience. We were very brave. We wanted to let everyone know about Baba's case.

The first time I saw Him was in Fiesch. I remember that everyone wanted to go and it was such a frenzy getting ready. It was Baba's birthday also. There were so many margiis from the U.S. and all over the world there. I remember I was sitting there after sadhana. People were singing and then shouting "*Param Pita Baba ki!*" The energy and magnetism was just fantastic in that room. And so when He walked in, everyone ran over to see Him including myself. While I'm not a very emotional person usually, I burst into tears as soon as I laid eyes on Him. I did not even know Him, but tears just flowed. It totally surprised me because I just didn't know what was happening to me.

Then we had meditation and darshan for DMC, of course. It was just so beautiful, absolutely the most beautiful thing I had ever seen. I didn't know what was going on, but I knew that there was something so beautiful, so subtle, so special, like nothing I had ever encountered before. I was so overwhelmed with this beautiful spirit, I decided to stay in the DC hall to do meditation. All of a sudden Dada Yatiishvarananda ran into the room and said, "Vijaya Laksmi, I think you are going to be chosen to go on field walk with Baba. Hurry, hurry, you have to hurry because you have to give report on what you do, what you have done in the last year, the last six months, the last three months."

I ran up there. I was fairly new to DMC, and I had on nylon stockings. And to get there, we had to cross a little river, and I didn't even care. Baba was staying up on top of the hill at a chalet. I was just running and running, carefree and getting all wet and everything. So when we got there, they were busy taking reports. They took the reports and several of us sisters were chosen. That was the first time sisters were chosen to go on field walk. Devinishta was guarding and there were a couple of sisters from Australia. Baba, of course, rode up ahead in a car. So we got to the mountain, and it was so beautiful. The tops of the Alps were cutting through the sky like knives. There were spring flowers on the ground.

Baba came out. They had a little chair for him, and He looked up. I could see the reflection of the mountains in His eyes. He said, "I think this is a good spot." Then He sat down. We all sat around Him. I was so close that I could have reached out and touched His knee. It was so nice to be there because He was talking about different things. He was talking about how life began on Mars, and the flora and fauna around the place.

Pretty soon He stopped talking and there was a young margii right in front of Him with blond, curly hair. He did namaskar to him and then tousled the curls on his hair. I was thinking, "I wish He would do that to me." He started talking on the side of the brothers. I thought, "I wonder why He isn't looking over here at the sisters." And then immediately a thought came out of my head saying, "I may not know why, but I'm sure He has a reason." And as soon as I thought that, He turned around and looked at us and began to talk about women.

He gave the very famous discourse about how women had so much power and ability to lead at one time. And when someone introduced you, you didn't say who is your father and who is your uncle, but who is your grandmother or mother. And then He said something funny, "But we mustn't get so proud about it, we mustn't boast about it." It was beautiful. It was a great experience especially since I wanted Him to do that. As soon as the thought came in my head, He immediately turned to us. I had just surrendered saying, "He knows, and I don't." As soon as I said that, He turned, and it all happened.

After that, we came down from the mountain. I was amazed to see how beautiful Baba looked especially after being in jail for so many years. His skin was so golden brown. He seemed strong with a healthy voice. I just couldn't believe it, but I knew Baba

could do all that. After we came down, they had a car there for Him. I was among the people in the front, and I just hated to see Baba go. I wanted Him to stay for a long time and be with us. All of a sudden He beckoned, saying, “Come.” I wasn’t sure what was happening, but Didi said, “Go, He is talking to you.”

So I went and Devinishta came also because she was GV. I bent down to the car right close to His face, and He said to me, “Always uphold the dignity of women.”

Then He gave namaskar and left. I was so impressed with that because the whole morning had been about sisters and their relationship with Him and their dignity. That field walk was so special for me.

There is another story that happened when He went to Jamaica, and I think it shows Baba’s sense of humor. We were walking along during evening walk and pretty soon a dog started barking and Baba was talking. The *acaryas* started trying to get the dog to stop barking or get rid of it. All of a sudden Baba stopped and said, “Don’t worry, they [the dogs] are doing their duty.”

Another funny little story. I became very close friends with sister Jagadmitra after our initiation. She couldn’t go to Fiesch to see Baba. Her husband was a margii but still ate meat. She called my house one day and my youngest daughter told her I was in Jamaica to see Baba. She was so excited, she just left a note for her husband saying, “There is a roast in the oven, I will be back later.” She didn’t tell her husband anything else. She didn’t tell him that she was going to Jamaica.

There were very beautiful darshans. There was not enough room for the margiis, it was so rushed. We had *dharmacakra*, and that night we took Baba to the airport. He was going to go to Venezuela. We all did kiirtan and *tandava* for Him, and He flew away. The hurricane that happened in Santa Domingo happened immediately after DMC. Baba wanted volunteers, so many AMURTEL and AMURT volunteers were excited to go since we were so charged from Baba’s presence. The first AMURTEL (Ananda Marga Universal Relief Team – Ladies) group was formed in Santa Domingo.

Prakash (2)

I first saw Baba in Switzerland in May, 1979. What I remember most about Fiesch was personal contact with Baba.

Baba was staying in a little chalet. There was all this chaos outside, as everyone wanted to get inside to see Baba. I was a Proutist; Devinishta had come back from India and said Baba told her, indirectly, we have to be Proutists. Dada Tadbhavananda pulled me into the house and said to Baba's Personal Assistant (PA) that I should get Personal Contact. It was very sudden, I wasn't prepared, but I was thrust into the room, and was sitting with my legs underneath me. And the first thing Baba said to me was, "Sit in proper position." He asked my name, and who was my *acarya*.

Then He said, "Do you want to do something little or something great?"

And I said, "Baba, something great!"

"Do you have the moral courage to do it?"

"Yes, Baba." I was very serious; then He looked at me, reached out and pinched my cheek, and said, "You can smile!" That was all.

I did namaskar, and Baba put His hands on me, and gave a blessing. Then I went outside and I just cried and cried, as if something had been opened up in my heart, as if all the longing, all the pain in my heart had been released. Afterwards – this was on Baba's birthday, Purnima, May 1979 – afterwards at darshan all I remember is that as Baba was speaking, saying, "No one or nothing in the universe is unimportant." I felt that that was what happened to me in PC, that Baba removed enough of the barrier between me and Him, that suddenly all those feelings of being little were released. Society tells us, that you're insignificant – capitalism is based on the idea that you're nothing – and all of Baba's mission is about seeing the greatness in everyone.

And with that little touch, Baba did that, said, "Do something great, and have moral courage," and then the smile, so that while we are being strong and courageous, we do it with joy and happiness. He doesn't want us to be so serious, so burdened by the heaviness of a great mission. He wants us to feel love and joy and compassion as we're doing a great work. I remember from LFT training one of the meanings of Brahma is one who makes other great. Baba's mission is about making others great. We all have to

become great. That touched me so deeply. In darshan I felt Baba was speaking just to me.
“You’re not alone, or insignificant.”

Devinishta (2)

I went to see Baba in Switzerland, and Baba's arrival was delayed by a few days. The European margiis had not come yet, and very few people were there to prepare. So we were welcomed with open arms. They needed more people to prepare for Baba's coming. They gave me money and said to go out and buy fabric, and make a place for Baba to sit. I had only seen Baba in jail, but somehow instinctually I knew how to make the pillows. It felt like it came from another lifetime or something like that. I bought beautiful gold fabric, and some brocade for the pillow in back, and gold velvet, and I made a place for Baba to sit. And they needed someone to make the flag for Baba's car, so I sewed that. Then they had sheets and pillowcases not the right sizes, so I got to sew Baba's pillow for Him to sleep on. And I very much enjoyed doing this for Him.

We had a few Prout meetings there, and every day we would wait for Baba to give darshan and field walk. Up to that time, field walk had always been only for brothers. But in Switzerland, some of the sisters felt so sad about it that they were doing a protest, a 24-hour kiirtan, to get a chance also to have personal contact and go on field walk. When Baba found out about it, He said, "Well, why not?" But they decided that the sisters wouldn't ride in the same car with the brothers. Unfortunately, most sisters didn't drive. I knew how to drive, and had a U.S. driver's license, so I was told I could drive, but I had no car, of course. Finally, an Italian brother said I could use his car. But the Italian cars were very slow, and we had to go all over the mountains of Switzerland.

I was told if I drove, I had to be a GV guard. I was a Proutist, but everyone was taking turns being guards. So there I was, dressed in my guard uniform and driving this car. I was flooring the gas, but all the other cars were going too fast, and we dropped behind, and got lost and couldn't find our way back. We were sad, because we were going on field walk for the first time, and couldn't get there.

So the next day, they agreed that the brother who owned the car could drive. He was able to keep up with them, and we got there and went on field walk. Baba talked about plants and trees. I never knew exactly what was happening. We were given no training for guarding Baba, and for the first time in my life I was guarding. The other guard wanted me to drop back, and I thought, "Well, my job is to make sure the sisters

don't bother Baba, so I need to be close to Baba." So there was this silent struggle between us, he saying, "Get back," and I saying, "No, I'm going to do my job!" [laughs].

We also got our marriage blessed in Switzerland. We made garlands out of flowers we were able to obtain from a local florist. There were three or four couples waiting to have their marriage blessed, and we sat right down in front of Baba. I was sitting three or four feet from Baba. Baba was up a little higher, so we were looking up at Him. It was a very interesting darshan. You know, whenever you'd see Baba you'd have these different questions, you'd have these concerns about things having to do with you as an individual. For some reason, Baba decided to talk about dance. My husband, Prakash, is a dancer. So we were sitting there and Baba was demonstrating these different *mudras*, and moving His hands around the whole time, talking about dance, and that was so meaningful to my husband.

Then part way through the darshan, Baba picked up one of the pillows I had made. He started rocking it like a baby. We had been trying to get pregnant for a number of years, so one of our inside questions for Baba was, would we ever be able to get pregnant? Baba was picking up the pillow I had made for Him, and rocking it like a baby. And we were able to adopt two children a year or so after that, then were able to give birth to one, and adopted two more after that. If Baba was predicting we would have a baby in our arms, He was right. Baba blessed our marriage like He had many others; He took the garland we had in His own hands, and told us to live like Shiva and Parvati, and then gave the garland to me and told me to take the garland home and take care of it.

I also got to see Baba in personal contact, in Switzerland. I thought it was rather unfortunate the way PC was arranged there. They would just grab us and put us in the room. I was a GV guard, and I had no time to meditate or anything beforehand. It was so frustrating because if Baba wanted our vibrations to be easier to handle, then giving us time to meditate beforehand, and not putting us in in a hurry, seems like it would be better. Anyway I went in, and there were 17 sisters. This was supposed to be personal contact and there were 17 of us. I felt frustrated. I don't think I had a very nice PC because I didn't want to be stuffed in there with 17 sisters on the spur of the moment when Baba was getting ready to go to darshan. I wanted Baba to have time when He could really pay attention to each of us. Basically the didi there said our names and our

trades, and Baba said a few words. There wasn't much more to it. I never told anyone that I was hoping for a chance some time later in India or something to have PC, but that was all I had.

The other two times I went to see Baba were at DMC in India. We had children then who were one, three, and five, and we were one of the first Western families to bring their children to India. I think people were interested to see how we did. When we came, it was just in time for DMC, and Baba had already moved to Tiljala. We stayed in a hotel, and they came to pick us up in a car in the middle of the night [to avoid police detection], and covered us up, all of us who were white. My children are black – they could show their faces because they blended in, but the rest of us had to cover up with shawls. And they dropped us off in Tiljala. We brought a tent with us, which we set up on the rooftop, so our family could stay together.

As we were leaving India that time – we stayed for about five weeks – there weren't many people at Lake Gardens, so as Baba was going for field walk, the *acaryas* put us in front by the plants so He would see us. And as He passed, I said, "Namaskar, Baba, we're leaving." And Baba stopped and gave us a nice namaskar.

"Will you come back?"

"Yes, Baba, we'll come back."

When He returned from field walk we saw Him again. There were these double doors He passed through, and as Baba was walking up the stairs, He could tell that people were peeking through the crack in the door. For at least half an hour, He stood on the stairs just so all of us could stand on the stairs and peek at Him. It was sweet.

Having promised Baba that we would come back, the next year we came again – the kids were two, four and six. Again we went to a hotel, and every day we'd spend until noon just getting our laundry done, and then we'd go to see Baba go on field walk. One time Mahajoy couldn't stop saying namaskar to Baba – she would say, "Namaskar Baba, Namaskar Baba, Namaskar Baba!"

And Baba would stop and say, "Namaskar to all of you." Baba had this agreement, I think, that He would never not return namaskar to someone. So finally we told our children they were allowed to say namaskar only once each time they saw Baba.

That time they gave us a room at Tiljala with other families. Baba used to do field walk on the roof of His building. If you sat at any of the windows of our building you could see Him walk back and forth. And at night time there was kiirtan; everyone would stand in a window, crowds of people, and you couldn't carry the same tune from the top to the bottom floor, so you'd have all these tunes going on all at once. And Baba would walk back and forth, and if you were lucky He would stop, and lift up His cane, and do namaskar to you, and then we would go, "Ohhh, Baba." It was just so wonderful. I would put my youngest child on my back in my backpack, and stand there doing kiirtan, and she would peer over my shoulder to see Baba. It was beautiful.

Gayatrii (2)

Baba was coming to Jamaica! It was September 1979. By His grace, and due to the kindness of my brother, I was in Baba's house from 6 a.m. until midnight daily, preparing food for Him! It was His sweet grace. In the beginning I hesitated to cook. Then Madhu said, "Come Gayatrii, you must cook for Baba!" So I began to cook. First I cooked cabbage – the simplest of vegetables, and cooked in the simplest way. It was given to Him for dinner. Next morning, Madhu called out to me, "Oh Gayatrii! Baba loved your cabbage! He talked on and on about the origin of cabbage, the entire history of cabbage, how it spread to the different countries and continents!"

Oh, Baba! How happy I was! Imagine, for Baba to get excited over cabbage! Slowly I cooked more and more items for Him and watched the tray go into His room, and then come out with a clear and sometimes substantial portion missing – I would just jump for joy! On another day, my (spiritual) brother gave me the towel with which Baba had wiped His face. The towel was filled with the most divine heavenly fragrance – it was the scent of purest sandalwood. Never have I smelled such a divine fragrance before!

In 1971 I had had PC (Personal Contact) in Cochin with Baba. But, there in Jamaica, Madhu told me, "You have to have PC!" I decided not to mention to anyone about my Cochin PC. I decided to follow whatever Madhu and Didi Karuna wanted. They organized my (second) PC with Baba! We went in together. It was indescribable. Five or six of us were together with Baba, with PA Dada and Karuna Didi. As my turn came, I went on my knees at His feet. I began crying. It was too much for me, to be so close to Him, even touching Him. My love was too much. My longing was too much. The intimacy was too much. I cried so loudly.

Through all my weeping, Baba was talking so much, but I heard nothing. He was taking apart each syllable of the name – Gayatrii – and giving the Sanskrit origin and translation. But, I was only crying in bliss to be at the feet of my Beloved. Finally, He made me listen.

He said, slowly, "Gayatrii ... means... mother... of... the... universe!"

I listened. I heard. I remembered it for life. All those days, I had not asked Baba for anything. But that day, I told Him, in my mind: "Baba, when You return from

fieldwalk, can You not smile at me, as I stand in the line when You walk past?” And then, I forgot my wish. Later on in the evening, Baba came. And as He approached, He was looking directly at me, with such a big smile on His face! I was stunned! (I had forgotten about making this very wish!) Then I was overwhelmed. His love was too much to bear. I had never experienced such love before. It was Infinite love! His love was vaster than the cosmos! To feel it even for a fraction of a second meant my face was covered in tears. Grown men, forty and fifty years old, feeling His love as He passed – they all were weeping! Such was His love. So was it to be loved by Lord Anandamurtiji!

Time moved on. It was 1982, in Patna. Daily, morning and evening, Baba would come out and walk up and down the driveway, next to the garden which was filled three feet high with all sorts of flowers – tuberoses, zinnias, marigolds, chrysanthemums, gladiolas, lilies, asters – Baba surrounded by flowers. It was paradise! Daily, we waited on the verandah for Him to come out and begin His walk. One day He stopped just in front of me, and spoke in English. He said, “This world is for human beings... not for demons.” He spoke so seriously that I remembered these words forever. There was a sister there whose husband had just been killed in the *samaj* movement (Baba’s plan to remove the regional exploitation by outside capitalists). One evening, this sister fell at Baba’s feet, weeping profusely due to the loss of her husband. Then Baba spoke. He told her and everyone present: “Let there be no unhappiness in your hearts. Let everyone be immersed in serving the suffering humanity, by doing *samaj* work for the sake of the Supreme Entity.”

After His walk, Baba would sit in the chair, and all His devotees would dance, singing kiirtan, in bliss, around Him. Many times this occurred. As we danced and sang, Baba sat, so quiet, so silent, mostly with eyes closed. He was enjoying! He was loving the devotees all around Him. Occasionally, He opened His eyes, to look deeply into the eyes of a particular devotee. One must realize that in the infinite depths of His eyes lay the entire universe! It is impossible for mere mortals to comprehend, to fathom, the infinite attributes of the Lord! Can a small ant fathom the intricacies of the human being – the mind and heart of the human being? Similarly, it is impossible for us to comprehend the Lord. But, His love was pouring forth to all, causing some to go into ecstatic trances as they danced. Such days with the Lord cannot be forgotten!

Uddhava

My name is Uddhava and I'm from Stockholm. I came to Ananda Marga in 1977, more or less by chance. I saw a poster about it, and I joined the meeting. I got initiated the same year. I went to some retreats, and did some kiirtan. I remember the first *akhanda kiirtan* was six hours. I thought, "Oh, these crazy people." But anyway I joined the kiirtan, and suddenly I felt it was over already. Those six hours were up, and I was lost in Ananda Marga. I tried to leave many times, but I could not.

I met Baba in Stockholm. The first time was in Fiesch. I was not so regular in AM at the time. I was not familiar with the rules, and my English was not good enough to understand what the dadas were saying. But anyhow, I was brought to Baba. I was not ready for any Personal Contact. But they just took me to meet Him. He told me to come and sit here. For me, it was uncomfortable. There was no space. So I lay down on the floor, and did what they told me, and He looked at me. I was looking up. I just saw something very, very beautiful. He looked in my eyes. I will never forget that. His eyes were very strong.

He told me, "You do not know the 16 points." I tried to say these points. I tried my best, but not well.

But He said, "You do not know the 16 points."

"Yes, Baba, I do."

I tried to explain. And then I could not answer.

"You don't know."

"No, Baba, I don't know."

Then He showed me something. I saw some ancient times, before we were living, and people were there. As I understood it, this time factor is not as important as we think. I got the feeling that very near and very far is all the same, and also, about the time factor, that very long time back and now is the same. He had this stick, and He told me to put my hands out, and now how many times I should beat you?

He explained, "You have done many things in your life."

And I didn't know about this stick. I really thought He would hit me hard; He looked very dangerous.

So I said, “OK, you beat me once.”

But He just beat me lightly. Then I said, “OK, 100 times,” and I thought He would really beat me. But He just touched me, and then He gave me some blessing. But these small moments I remember every day. When I came there I thought it was not important, but afterwards it has become more and more so.

Jagadmitra

I was initiated by Dada Yatiishvarananda in 1971. I always had a difficult time with sadhana, it was a big change for me, but every time my *acarya* would come he would encourage me. In 1978 we moved to California. I didn't know anybody in California, but for the first time in many years I was afforded time to do more meditation. I had never really understood Ananda Marga; I was always involved with the people and *acaryas*, but had no real connection with Baba. We were living in Pacific Grove, two to three hours south of Los Altos. One day after meditation, all of a sudden it was as if the curtain opened, and I felt for the first time who was running the show, behind all the organization, behind the *acaryas*, behind everything. It was a very deep experience that day.

The following year, 1979, Baba went to Jamaica. Prior to that, I remember going through a magazine, tearing out articles I wanted to save. I saw this picture with the word 'Jamaica' written across it. I had never had a desire to go to Jamaica, I had never traveled, except to the West Coast, and this warm feeling came all over me, as though I was getting sick, as if I had a fever or something, just chills. I didn't think anything of it, and it passed.

But later that year, Baba was supposed to come to Los Altos. And I didn't know anyone up there, but I talked to Vijaya Laksmi, who has since become a good friend, to get the details about what I should bring. Bring a fan, she said. So I took three days off work – I made up some story, I couldn't tell them I was taking off to go see my guru, they would never understand. And of course, Baba couldn't get into the country. So I went back to Pacific Grove, and realized I had forgotten the fan, which didn't belong to me. So the next day I called, and talked to Vijaya Laksmi's daughter. She said, "Oh, she's not here, she's gone to Jamaica."

"What's she doing in Jamaica?"

"Baba has gone to Jamaica." And it was like somebody put me in automatic gear. You have to understand how fearful I was in those days, never having gone anywhere by myself, or done anything by myself. My marriage was very shaky at that point, and when I went back I found out they had fired me from my job. And I was just amazed. I thought

to myself, “Jamaica? If I do nothing else in my life – I’ve just lost my job, my marriage is going down the drain – if I do nothing else in my life, I’m going to see the guru.” I left a note on the table. My husband was not vegetarian, and I had a roast in the oven. I put it on the timer, and left a note saying I was going to be gone for a few days. I ran down to the bank, had about \$400 to my name, and whatever I had was enough for a ticket to Jamaica. I packed this little suitcase, went to the airport and went standby.

It was as though my mind was just racing and racing, uncontrollably. At about 3 in the morning I was in the airport, and people were sleeping all around me. And reality set in. “Ohmigosh, what am I doing in this airport, across the country, all by myself?” I saw a few familiar faces that I had seen at retreats. Anyway, I made it to Jamaica, after Baba had arrived, and there was no room in the hotel where all the margiis were staying. I didn’t have a pass, so they wouldn’t feed me, I was bitten up with mosquitoes, and didn’t have a room. So I was feeling very badly. I met up with a couple of other women who had met a Jamaican brother who had a car, and he said he would help us find a place to stay. We did find a place to stay, four miles away. Next morning he picked us up, and he said, “Would you like to drive by where Baba is staying?”

So we drove by. I had no clue what was going on, really, we saw all these people sitting on the grass, and they said Baba was in the house. Vijaya Laksmi recognized me, and grabbed my arm and said, “You stand here, and get a good look at Baba.” I did. Baba came out the door, and went for a walk. A little later, they announced the bus to take people to darshan was broken down, so we should take taxis.

I was not a known margii, I didn’t have a posting. One dada came and said he needed someone to do some typing, and I volunteered. He took me to the hotel. We were leaving and Vijaya Laksmi said, “No, she can’t go; she needs to see Baba.”

Dada turned to one didi and said, “Didi, will you take responsibility to see that she sees Baba?” She replied yes. So we went up, but the hotel office was locked, and we couldn’t type. We went back down, and people were starting to leave in taxis. I was not aggressive. People sometimes get very aggressive when it comes to seeing Baba. So people were cramming into these taxicabs, eight to ten people in a cab, to go see Baba. I couldn’t get in. I just sat down on the grass, crying, thinking, “Oh, I’m going to miss the darshan.”

A few minutes later, Didi came by and took me in the house, with some other girls, for personal contact (PC) with Baba! It was so amazing to me that out of all this confusion and turmoil from the time I left California, after I had PC, it was like a quiet sea. Ah. This is why all this was going on. It was such a beautiful experience because so many times you would hear people say, “Oh, I wanted to see Baba and this dada or didi wouldn’t let me.” And I knew that when the desire is so strong, no one can stop you from seeing your guru. It’s the guru who opens the door.

There I was in Jamaica, not knowing anybody. Even somebody asked me, “What’s your posting?” And somebody that I didn’t know spoke up, “Oh, she’s GV” [laughs]. I wasn’t GV, I wasn’t anything. And doors kept opening, moving from here to there, and circumstance-wise Baba allowed it to happen. Well, I was just feeling wonderful. I felt like I’d never felt before. That was a long time ago. Still, He lives right here inside. I miss Him terribly.

I’ve been to India several times to see Him. Once I saw Him, I would be satisfied. The next year I discovered I was not satisfied, and I would go back to India. I brought this little plant, a little cactus, and put it in my purse. I wanted to give it to Baba. Usually you’re not allowed to give something directly to Baba, and usually there’s tons of people there. But when I got to India, we went to the Lake Gardens house. All the way on the airplane I was worried, sometimes crying, what if He’s not there, what if I can’t see Him? I was very emotional. It was exaggerated. I even thought as I was experiencing it that it was a little exaggerated.

But that’s what I was going through, and we got to Lake Gardens and there was nobody there, except this guard at the gate. They let us in. Baba was coming around the side of the house with Dada Ramananda, his personal secretary and Didi Ananda Karuna. I was walking, and I had this plant in my hand. All I was thinking the whole way was, “All I want Him to do is touch my hand. If He does that, I’ll be satisfied forever.” So He came around.

“Namaskar, Baba, I’m from the U.S.” We talked a little. I handed Him the cactus, nobody stopped me, and He went like this over my hand [shows how Baba touched her hand]. Oh! It was... so beautiful. Oh, He was like my father. I kept thinking, “He’s my

father, He wouldn't not see His child." You know, I'd come halfway across the world to see Him.

But I think spiritual greed sets in, you know? After that, I was still in India and decided I wanted another personal contact. I couldn't get enough. Well, that didn't happen! [laughs]. I kept talking to my acarya, "Dada, I have to get in for another PC." That didn't happen, and I was furious. Almost like, on this plane you have a fight with your husband or lover, the emotions were of that intensity.

CHAPTER FOUR:

YOU ARE MY REPRESENTATIVES

“If we want the development of this beautiful universe, we should try to accelerate the speed of spiritual progress more and more... not only in the physical or psychic or spiritual world of human beings, but in the entire living world, and not only the living world, but also both the animate and inanimate worlds...”

In the late 1970s and into the early 1980s, many margiis traveled to India to see Baba and get Personal Contact or attend *Dharma Maha Cakra*. In 1981, Baba offered a once-in-lifetimes opportunity to His devotees to come to India for *Dharma Samiksa*. In a small crowded room in Kolkata, Baba reviewed the spiritual life of each margii who came for this special program, sometimes commenting on their past or even future. They received His attention, His love, and also His reprimands. He prescribed asanas for physical problems. In the tradition of *Tantra*, He used His cane to punish some, which as many devotees confirmed, removed karmic obstacles. The event transformed many lives.

Arjuna (2)

In 1981, I went for *Dharma Samiksa*. There were hundreds of people in the office there at Jodhpur Park. People were lined up. I got pinkeye, so I couldn't see Baba for five or six days. I had to stay in this mass of people. I heard stories about how Baba would hit some people with His stick, but most people only got tapped on the hands or hit a few times. The day I went in, the line was arranged like a snake, and slowly you would see what Baba was doing to the people before you.

He would just tap the sisters on the hand, and with the brothers, sometimes He would take a strong swing, but then just tap them. I was kind of expecting that for me. When my turn came, we had our shirts off. I came in front of Baba, and He said, "Put your arms up."

He looked up and down, was scanning me. I think He asked, had I been a good boy? All of a sudden He started beating me. On each side, He hit me eight times, so there were sixteen times in all. And wow, it really hurt. I jumped each time; I'm not that strong a person! [laughs]. It was painful. Then afterwards, He asked, "Are you going to be a good boy?"

I said, "Yes, Baba" [laughs]. He gave me some asanas, and they were the exact same asanas that my acarya had given me. Those marks were with me for at least two weeks, and the sixteen, to me, had the significance that I should be stronger in 16 Points.

In 1984 I went to India again. Before that time I had thought this *Prabhat Samgiit* was OK, but it didn't really do that much for me. The first day I went to Lake Gardens, two or three sisters were singing *Prabhat Samgiit* as Baba was in this chair in the driveway. That's when it hit me, that *Prabhat Samgiit* was really special. I just cried, it was so sweet, and so beautiful. Just seeing Baba there, hearing it sung so sweetly, it finally made an impression on me.

You know, when I saw Baba in jail the second time, it gave me the feeling that if the guru wants to see you, He'll create the circumstances. I was with Dadaji Devashraddhananda. We flew into Delhi. The following day was some festival, and I really had a desire to see Baba's *mudra* again. I felt we should fly from Delhi to Calcutta. He wanted to take the train. I said, "Dadaji, are you sure there will be time to see Baba on

darshan on the festival day?” He said, “Yeah, we should be there on time.” We took this long train ride with some other acarya and LFT. We got into Howrah station around 2 or 3 p.m. There was all this traffic. We got to Tiljala around 4.

Just as they opened the gate, everybody was coming out of the DC hall. Baba had just given the *mudra*, and everyone was in bliss. We were just five minutes late. From this, you can only laugh, and feel that Baba is in control of everything, and when He wants to see you, He’ll see you, and when He doesn’t that’s fine, too. Every time I went to India to see Baba, every time I do sadhana, it’s all up to Him if He’s going to make His presence known.

In December 1986, I had a revolutionary marriage to sister Sharada from Taiwan. We had met two or three days before, and we decided to just surrender everything to Baba. We had our wedding on the 31st, with 10,000 people there. The following day Baba blessed our marriage. He took our hands and held our hands to His, and He said, “Be like Shiva and Parvati.” That was the first time I had really stared at His hands. They were so big and warm. It was a wonderful feeling for both of us to be in Baba’s hands.

I went to India again in 1987 for Personal Contact (PC). I had PC with Baba at Lake Gardens, upstairs. I went into His room, and did *sastaung pranam*. He called me over, and said, “What is your name? Do you know what Arjuna means?”

I said, “The way it was told to me was one who fights for morality.”

Then He paused, and said, “Arjuna means filled with energy, just bursting with energy.” That struck a sympathetic note in me. He asked me where my father’s father was from. I said, “I think he was from Germany.”

And He said, “No, he was from Northern Russia, from Siberia.” I thought, “Hmm, my dad always told me his parents were from Germany.” So that stuck in my mind.

This PC was short. He said, “Have you been a good boy?”

“I don’t know, Baba.”

“No, you’ve made a lot of mistakes, with women.”

He had his stick, and I thought He was going to beat me again. He told me to put my hands out, and this time He just touched them and said, “Be an ideal boy.” That was my PC with Baba.

When I came back, I saw my father the following Thanksgiving in Florida, and was asking about where my grandparents were from. And he said his father had come from Russia to Germany.

In 1989 Sharada was pregnant, and she was due to have our daughter in November. My dad and mom were still alive in Florida, but I hadn't heard from my mother since September. Whenever I called, she was sleeping or out. The baby was due around November 19th or 20th, but it didn't come on time. That week my aunt in Florida called and said my mom only had a day to live. So I was feeling my mother wouldn't live to see the baby. I asked Sharada if I should go back and see my mom. She said yes.

I flew down, and saw her in the hospital on her deathbed. This was the first time we really had this kind of deep connection. As I held her hands all I was thinking was Baba, giving His *mudra*, and healing. I stayed there one day, and said my goodbye to her. We held hands for hours. And my ideation was stronger than it had ever been. I left the next day, and Sharada went into labor that day. When I called Florida, I learned my mother's pain all of a sudden was gone; she got out of the hospital and went to Thanksgiving dinner with my family. People couldn't believe that she got up even. The next day the baby was born. We took pictures. I sent the pictures Federal Express to my mom in Florida. She saw the pictures and then she died. Baba really took care of everything.

Sadhana (2)

There is one more gift Baba gave me that I must tell about before this story will be complete. That is my trip to India in July 1981 for *Dharma Samiksa*. At the time, I had been married for two years and my daughter was not yet born. As I mentioned, my husband had a fair amount of clash about Baba, so when the call for margiis to come for *Dharma Samiksa* went out, I was not sure how to explain the time and money to him. Asking my husband to come with me seemed the best way to reassure him and he agreed to come with me and several other margii friends. As a result, when we arrived in Kolkata I knew I had a limited number of days to get in to see Baba before my husband would become impatient and want to continue our travels in India.

Dutifully he accompanied me by cab each day to global HQ at dawn to avoid the CBI surveillance, and dutifully he came by cab after dark each night to retrieve me. The hours in between for me were made up of sitting, cramped and sweltering with no food or water, waiting. But in the waiting we sang, meditated and met many wonderful Indian margiis.

Finally Didi Ananda Karuna got me in to see Baba on the third day. I was *Bhukti Pradhan* of our area at the time and so a report had to be given. I had been prepared ahead of time, but as in Jamaica, as soon as I saw Baba my mind emptied. I had been forewarned that He would be strict and serious. Yet with me, Baba was only full of encouragement.

“Good work,” He repeated, “Good work.”

Afterwards, I realized His words were for our whole unit, not me personally. We had been seen as too autonomous as a unit, taking Baba’s inner advice and our interpretations of His words seriously, sometimes challenging organizational positions or policies. So Baba’s positive words let me know we had His support for the way we were doing His work.

But the biggest impact of *Dharma Samiksa* was mysterious. It came after I got home and after some time had passed. First, I lost my desire to be *Bhukti Pradhan* anymore. Then, one day I realized I had been striving to be a ‘good girl,’ to please my spiritual Father, needing His approval. All of that need was just gone, missing from its

familiar place in my psyche. To come home with less organizational energy seemed paradoxical and yet that is what Baba took from me. He is truly a mystery, as He has said, and the way He works to bring us to liberation is also a mystery. To this day, I find it hard to grasp, to comprehend the grace that brought Baba into my life and into my mind and heart. There is nothing I could have done to earn such grace! Baba Kripahi Kevalam!

Vishvamisra (2)

My next opportunity to see Baba arose in 1981, when my *acarya*, Yatiishvarananda, called me and said, “Prepare to go to India.” I said, “Dada, what’s the urgency?” He told me that in the past great gurus would select one person out of 4 or 500 devotees to give *Dharma Samiksa* to every three or four years. And Baba was giving this to everyone now, but there was no assurance that it would last. I took him seriously, made my arrangements, and took off from my job.

At that time, there was a lot of interference in India from the local government, and CBI. It was sort of a cops and robbers scene. We were moving from hotel to hotel, and many people were being deported. We were very crowded in the small office, with hundreds of people there. We would sit in the larger room and meditate, then our names would be called, and we’d go with 15 or so other people into a smaller room with Baba. Finally I was called in. I sat there and heard all these stories. Baba was revealing personal things about people, things they had done wrong, and giving them punishment. The interesting thing about this was that I knew a lot of those people, and when I left the room I had no memory of what Baba had said about them. And the people I didn’t know at all, I remembered their stories. So Baba was protecting us in wiping clean the memory of the experience.

As I was sitting there, an Italian brother was introduced as Vishvamisra from South Carolina. Baba lavished such affection on him, and the brother got in His lap. I thought, “I wish that was me. After hearing all these stories, I’m probably going to get beaten.” But I felt a responsibility to let someone know that I was Vishvamisra, and not this Italian brother. I told the dada who was taking notes that I was Vishvamisra, and He looked at me, startled, but he went up and told Baba that he had the name wrong. Baba’s finger looked like it was two feet long, sometimes. “You stupid,” He said, and cleared the room.

But finally I got up to see Baba. Baba didn’t say much to me. “Your work is not good,” He said, in a semi-harsh tone. And I knew what He was saying – I wasn’t sending in reports, I was being lax in details in my Ananda Marga work. He motioned me to roll up my shirt, and He gave three licks on both sides of my chest. They were well-placed.

Then He motioned me to come closer, and took my head. Touching my head, He did some *mudras*, and said some *slokas*. Then He took my face in His hands, and looking into my eyes as close as I could get and still stay focused, He smiled this smile that would melt a thousand worlds. He just had this affection, and love, and tenderness. I was enveloped in that. It meant a lot to me, it was focused, and I was enveloped in Him. That remains a useful support in my sixth lesson.

He gave the asanas for me, and they cured many problems I had. I'm just now understanding that He gave me some asanas for problems I would encounter now, this year. He had an infinite capacity to give you what you needed. I sat outside the room doing sadhana, then we heard that Baba was coming out of the room. I stood up, and when Baba walked past me, He looked at me and gave namaskar. There was this tremendous vibration that went through my body, a shower of bliss. His mercy and His grace are infinite.

Baba gave darshan on a Sunday about the meaning of *Dharma Samiksa*, how seldom it was given and how important it was, the burning of the seeds of karma. I'm sure since then I've gathered some more *samskaras*, but I'm sure Baba has always helped me whittle them down, keep it at a low roar, so I can do some work while I'm here, in this body, and be His representative.

I went for *Bhukti Pradhan* (BP) reporting in 1984, at Lake Gardens. Baba was constantly taking reporting, throughout His life. Baba took so much personal care with us. This time we were squished into the *dharmacakra* hall at Lake Gardens. The *acaryas* told me to go forward. Baba said, "Let us hear from someone from a poorer country." They brought a Ghanaian brother forward. I felt the grace of being there close to Baba. He wanted the BPs to know everything about their region of the world – rivers, socioeconomic potentials, what the Marg was doing to help that place – in great detail.

One of the *dadass* told an interesting story. One day Baba came out and said, "Are you enjoying the showers?" It hadn't rained, but they knew what He was speaking of. It was invariably the case, singing *Prabhat Samgiit* and waiting to see Baba, that we were swimming in bliss.

Then Sudeva and I got into a strategic position to see Baba when His car came back. He got out again and gave namaskar. He started walking towards the back of the house. We said, “Baba, we invite you to come and visit the margiis in New York Sector.” And He stopped, turned around and walked back.

“You are my representatives, do you understand, my sons? And this influence goes out in ever-increasing circles, like ripples in a pond. And remember, you must come back, again and again and again.”

We understood Baba was saying to exercise every opportunity to be close to Him, not just in the physical sense, but in every moment of ideation during the day. To come back again and again to ideation on Him. He is seeking us even more than we seek Him.

The next time I traveled to India was with Shaktideva on Baba’s birthday in 1987. Baba gave him his old position as VSS guard as he had been in Jamaica. Baba gave a darshan about the existential value of animals. Most animals in the forest have very small mammary glands, but when we domesticate them they develop larger ones. This is not good for the animals. In fact this will lead to the extinction of milk cows, because of the change in hormonal structure. We will have to adopt only synthetic forms of milk. Baba was saying we should be respectful of animals, that their existential value should be protected by us. Shaktideva was doing *kaoshikii*, and one dada was correcting him, and told him to sit out during *tandava*. And I saw Baba turn and say, no, giving the indication, let him do *tandava*. Baba was always guarding the sentiments of His devotees, to make it softer, more spiritual, richer, closer to Him.

The last time I saw Baba was DMC 1989 in Ananda Nagar. I brought two sisters with me from Charleston, who were involved with the AM school in Charleston. By Baba’s Grace these two Western sisters were able to get there without too much hardship. The night of DMC, 30,000 people were there. Dada Haratmananda came up to me and said, “This is your opportunity tonight, Baba will give you an AMURT award. You can express yourself to Him.” I was a bit overwhelmed to go on stage, but I had nothing in my mind to express to Him. I went on stage after a number of other people received awards. I took the plaque from Baba and He gave me a namaskar and the most beautiful smile I’d ever seen. I returned that smile and felt close to Him. I had no idea that would

be the last time I'd see Him. In retrospect I appreciated that opportunity to say goodbye to Him face to face before He left His body.

Guhan (2)

It was the summer of 1981. I was living in Denver. Dada Y (Yatiishvarananda), more popularly known as Dada Why?, was passing through and announced that there was a special program in India and we should all go! So, I and other margiis traveled to India. Margiis and workers from around the world came and we all crammed into the little building at Jodhpur Park. Baba was giving *Dharma Samiksa*, a special cleansing, to all of us.

It was the most dramatic thing I've ever seen in my life. It was really hot outside, but the room was air-conditioned. As soon as you entered the room, it was like entering heaven. The room was at a slant, and Baba at the lower part of the room. Brothers and sisters were all mixed together. Twenty people were sitting in rows. It was just incredible to observe. There were many *acaryas*, senior *acaryas*, and margiis from all different sectors. They moved up one by one. I was traveling with brother Viniita from California. One by one, we stood before Him and many dramas took place.

Before my turn came, there was time to observe some of these dramas. At one point, a brother from India stood before Baba. Baba told us all to close our eyes. As soon as we did, Baba started beating him like anything. Every time Baba hit him with His stick, He would say 'sex crimes, sex crimes, sex crimes!' And of course, the Indian brother was crying. Then Baba pulled him to His lap and comforted him and told him to be an ideal boy. This incident had me a little concerned! Was Baba punishing him for an actual sex crime or just for being promiscuous? Having been born and raised in California and having had girl friends in high school and college and beyond, I decided not to wait and find out. I turned around and started heading for the door but we were crammed in this room like sardines and it would have created a big scene for me to get out of there! So, with some fear and trepidation, I gradually worked my way up before Baba.

As I stood in front of Him, not knowing what to expect, He waved His stick and looked at me with His X-ray vision. All of a sudden, he became very angry and said, "This boy hasn't done any work! Get Out! Get Out! Get Out!" He yelled. I couldn't believe what was happening. I was dying right there on the spot. I looked around and the

room was in total chaos, as if a tornado had blown through there. All the *acaryas* were looking down or looking the other way or covering their faces. Finally, one of the *acaryas* grabbed me and led me off to a small, dark adjacent room. He told me to sit and meditate and then he left. Sit and meditate? I was sitting there crying like anything. I could've sworn Baba was my guru. "I can't believe He's not my guru," I thought. But I was resigned to leave.

"He doesn't want me," I thought. I left the room and went out into the crowd of margiis and acaryas. It was so hot! In the process of packing my gear and getting ready to depart for who knows where, there was an announcement that no one could leave the Jodhpur Park building because the CBI and the communists were harrasing and deporting anyone caught leaving the premises. So we all had to stay there until the VSS deemed it safe to leave.

In the meantime, margiis and *acaryas* were 'in my ear' saying I had to go back in and face Baba again. I said, "No way, He threw me out!" Dada Yatiishvarananda came up to me saying, "Guhan, you're going back in there."

"Dada, no, I'm not." Finally, they coaxed and pushed me back into that little, heavenly air-conditioned room and the process started all over again – all those people getting cleansed, Baba prescribing asanas. It was ust the most amazing thing I've ever seen in my life to see Baba sitting there, like a king, a beautiful king, in complete control, guiding us through all this stuff. Anyway, I was so emotionally drained, burned out, I realized I didn't care, I felt surrender. When I came up before Baba, His stick was wavering. He brought His stick forward like He was going to strike me and then He gently tapped my ribs on each side and then pulled me into His lap. I grabbed His feet. He looked at me very seriously and said, "You must help humanity now!" It felt so cool and refreshing in His lap. Then He said, "Go!"

As I left, I realized, "I'm asleep, I'm not realizing what's happening in the world, Baba wants us to serve." I wasn't doing any work, in the true spiritual sense of service. I was doing my own personal survival stuff in the world, which all of us have to do, but I wasn't doing anything beyond that. I'd like to hope I'm now more active. The more I meditate, the more I'm active to fulfill what He did in *Dharma Samiksa*.

Bharat (2)

In *Dharma Samiksa*, all I remember is that I was there and all of a sudden I was getting these sticks, all up and down one side and up and down the other. I think no one had as many sticks as I did. I thought maybe I had some trouble ahead, that things were going to happen, and a lot of things did happen. A lot of problems, frustrations, struggle, but also a lot of success. I don't remember if He said anything, I think He was just busy giving me the sticks. But it didn't hurt. It was sweet.

Some time in the '70s, I had another opportunity to meet with Baba, with another mundane question. I had adopted the child of my wife, and her sister was living in the house, and I had a couple of kids. I was the only one who was vegetarian. They were cooking steaks and all this stuff. There was a lot of conflict between the way I was trying to live the Ananda Marga life, and their way of life. I went to see Baba, and rather than just have him say some kind of great thing to me, I said, "Baba, I don't know what to do, I'm trying to do vegetarian diet, and Liila is not eating it."

He said, "People are like planets. They follow a certain orbit, a certain path. You have to be patient."

I said, "Thank you."

And He was right again, because finally things began to change. I had to make a stand. I ate my food by myself in the kitchen. They felt badly and finally they changed. And it was really good for them, I think. But the most interesting thing about that was that some years later I went to the Philippines, in 1986. I was at a retreat, and a fellow there was an executive in some kind of business.

He said, "Why don't you stay with me? I've got this house."

I said, well, I appreciated it, but I wanted to stay with the retreat.

"No, You have to, you've got to stay with me."

So I stayed with him. And he started telling me his story, how he can't leave the country. He wanted to go see Baba so bad and he couldn't get out of the country. Then he told me he had exactly the same problem with his family that I did. The whole thing, what Baba had told me, was the answer for him. Exactly.

Later, I was making a video of Baba's speeches at Ananda Nagar. I was there with the camera, and it seemed like everyone was gone. I was sitting there with Baba. Other people were running around, and getting ready for things. We were just sitting there. Twenty thousand people, but here I was. I didn't know what to say, so I said, "Thank you."

And He said, "Thank you for patiently waiting."

He had remembered exactly what He had told me twelve years before.

I think my life has been changed because of this experience. Working with AMURT all these years, I've probably been to 30 different places in the last 30 years. I went back to school, really because of this relief work, and got a doctorate in public health. I teach now. I've helped support projects all over the world. And I think most of this has been because of this experience. There've been so many things that resulted from this contact with Him.

Dharma Samiksa kind of speeds up your *samskaras*, so you'll be a more spiritually realized person in this lifetime. Well, it sure speeded mine up. A lot of things I wish hadn't happened, did, and I learned from them. But I'm still learning how to deal with things. One time at Ananda Nagar we were having an AMURT meeting. Baba was there and we were giving reports. They asked me to give a report because I had been very involved in lot of the activities. particularly in Africa. I had to say all these different things.

When I got in front of Baba, I said, "Baba, I just, you know, a lot of these projects, we just don't have enough money."

Everyone was saying "No! Don't talk to Baba about money" [waves his hands].

He was very nice, and said, "If the program is right, the money will come."

And that's been a very important comment. In all this relief work, the experience has been, when you're not successful it's because they're not right. They're not doing the program correctly, haven't done the homework, they're not talking with the community, not doing what the community wants. And that's been the bottom line of what I teach. If you don't do what people want, deep in their heart, you won't have a successful program.

I think that He's still guiding. Because I'm still learning.

Dr. Ram (2)

I would like to narrate my experience with *Dharma Samiksa* around 1982. I was married in 1977 and my wife was not a margii then. Later she was initiated. But she had a lot of difficulties adapting to margii life and everything that was going on. There was a lot of struggle.

When Dada Yatiishvarananda told me to go to India, I had no idea what was going on. Baba was giving *Dharma Samiksa* to hundreds of people from all over the world. The *jagrti* was jam-packed. We were about 30 people in the room. One by one, margiis stood in front of Baba, and in a few moments He would look at the person and evaluate them totally, at the physical, psychic and spiritual level. Generally He asked questions, and gave asanas or physical punishment or rectification. For brothers a hit with the stick, and for sisters a spanking on the outstretched hand.

When Baba asked me why I did not bring my family along, I had no answer. I thought He knew. My wife did not want to come with me. And my daughter was very young. I could not think of an answer, and I got several strokes on my side. Several dadas in the background said, "Please say something." So I said to Baba, "I will bring my family next time when I come." Baba stopped, and took my face in His hand, and squeezed my cheeks. I guess I was a little too serious.

He gave me some instructions about my physical health, and gave some asanas. And then we were taken to the next room where we meditated. At the next *dharmacakra* there was a very different feeling, difficult to explain. It was like we were in a different vibrational world.

Then I had to leave for California. I reached the airport in San Francisco two or three days after the *Dharma Samiksa*. My wife came to meet me at the airport, and I happened to touch her. She was silent, but when we reached home afterwards she told me what happened. When I touched her, she felt a big shock, like electricity all over her body. She felt very blissful, like she had never felt in her life, and she could not explain it. After that, Prathima was almost totally changed, in many respects. Without going into too many details, this was a profound change.

But I could not keep my promise to Baba for another two years. Our second daughter was born, and two years later we all went to India. We went to Khanpur DMC. As soon as we reached the site, Baba was coming out in the car for His daily walk. Lots of margiis were assembled on either side. We were standing somewhere in the back. The car stopped right in front of where Prathima was, and it was only her that He looked at, and He talked to her in Hindi, “Did you just come?” and Prathima said, “Yes, Baba.”

There were many old margiis there, but Baba only talked to her. And I was thinking maybe this was an acknowledgment that she had come, the promise I made in *Dharma Samiksa*. The following day during DMC, during the *varabhaya mudra*, Prathima had an identical experience with the one she had in the San Francisco airport. I felt Baba was saying her experience was true. It was as if Baba transmitted a blessing through me to her, and He was taking care of the devotee’s family. I kept this story to myself for years, but later I told it.

Jyotishvar (2)

We heard that Baba was released from jail, and we were so excited. Baba was touring India, holding DMCs. Two margiis said they were going to India, and I went with them. This was 1978. I had never been outside the U.S. I had to get a passport, find my birth certificate, it was all so much trouble.

We were exhausted by the time we got to India. I thought we would go crazy once we reached India; with the crowds and heat, and culture shock, it was very rough. We landed in Bombay and flew to Delhi, and attended the DMC. I felt really happy once I was there. I hadn't slept in days. There were 20,000 or 30,000 people there. There wasn't enough room to put your knees down, and I kept dropping off to sleep and hitting the fellow's head in front of me.

Next day we flew to Bombay, and I was still very disorganized, and was standing at the bus stop for the airport. I would be on the same plane as Baba. I had my wallet in my pocket, and of course someone stole it. I was really upset – I got to the airport, and was almost crying. I had to check on my ticket. A number of margiis were there waiting for Baba to arrive. Suddenly I heard "*Parama Pita Baba Ki!*" I turned and there was Baba right next to me. He had not come in where they expected Him, but in a different door. He walked right up to me, gave namaskar, and then walked off. I had only seen Baba once before, and then He was just a little speck, three football fields away. And now suddenly He was just two feet from me. All my frustration and fatigue came out, and I just cried unashamedly. But in India, with the vibration of a holy man, crying is seen as a great thing. People seemed to be very supportive; people at the counter they thought I was a great devotee or something.

I was holding some bananas which I wanted to give to Baba. I wanted to fight through the crowd and give them to Him, but it was hopeless. It was time for Baba to leave and get on the plane. We went through security. Baba came through and sat down. And we sat on the floor by Baba's feet. He had His eyes closed, and I just stared at Him. I still wanted to give my bananas to Him. Someone asked Him, "Baba, how do you like flying?" some silly question, and Baba didn't respond. Then He opened His eyes and looked right at me, and said, "Are you flying to Bombay?"

“Yes, Baba.”

“And then to Madras also?”

“Yes, Baba.” I was really getting excited. Then we had to take the little bus out to the plane. I had on a tie and was trying to look official. I was worried about being deported, and trying to stay apart from all the hysteria, since this was an easy place for the immigration to catch me, but of course once Baba came I completely let go that idea. I dove in with all the margiis, and was sitting on the floor at Baba’s feet. What could be more obvious? So it was ridiculous trying to look like a normal tourist. I was weeping on the little bus. I was trying not to get too close to Him, because I didn’t feel it was too polite to sit right next to him, you know, “Is this seat taken?” I kept a little distance. But Baba motioned to us to come and sit close. I sat and I was weeping, and then I remembered my bananas. Ramananda read my mind – his mind was like permanently melded with Baba’s – and he just kind of motioned for me not to give them.

But Baba leaned over and said, “You take, you take.”

So I ate a banana, and it was really delicious. I was completely in some kind of walking samadhi. On the plane, I was sitting a little ways away from Baba, just feeling really relaxed and satisfied. Everyone on the plane was staring at me, I was weeping like a child. The lady sitting next to me said, “Your mind is completely gone” [laughs]. That’s such a compliment, in India. This was the best country in the world. I couldn’t have been happier.

We attended the darshans in Bombay, and it was great. But Madras was much better. We were always trying to get PC with Baba. This was a golden opportunity; there were so few margiis. Finally it looked like I would get in. It was a beautiful place, the weather was wonderful, the people so friendly. I went in, did *sastaung pranam*, and He asked who my *acarya* was.

“Do you want to be great?” He asked.

“Put your hands on your chest.” I had to take an oath. I would have said anything really, but it was very simple, that I would do sadhana twice a day. I put my head in His lap, He touched my head, and said, “Let this boy be great.”

Then I was about to leave. Baba was just doing namaskar, and I said “Baba?” and He stopped and quickly looked out and said “Yes?” I was just stalling, trying to delay leaving. “Could I touch your feet?”

He said, smiling, “But I have just touched your head.” And did namaskar. And then I left.

I’ll tell briefly about my *Dharma Samiksa*. I always felt a special warmth from Baba. I never felt any harshness from Him, even in *Dharma Samiksa*. My life since birth was always harsh enough, and Baba always took pity on me. He always treated me like a small child, almost an infant. There was always so much stored-up pain which came out when I was with Him. *Dharma Samiksa* was in August, and it was so much unlike my PC, which had taken place during the winter in Madras. In Kolkata, I became sick with typhoid fever and went in the hospital; I was almost deathly sick. We were really afraid of the police, everything was organized by Baba to make it difficult, and challenge us, and to remove the *samskaras* of countless past lives. So we were suffering greatly. The conditions in the *jagrti* were awful. And we couldn’t leave anyway for fear of getting arrested – some margiis did go out and got arrested. It was so crowded, we were packed in like sardines. We waited and waited. People were getting sick. Many were getting this eye disease, and Baba was very sensitive to that, and so they couldn’t go in for *Dharma Samiksa*.

We had to wait in a line to get there, and sometimes we had to close our eyes. Many people just got a whack. The dadas read out all the good things that people had been doing. I hadn’t done anything really. I got to the front and Dada was saying a bunch of stuff that wasn’t true at all, “He started three schools,” and Baba just stopped him from saying all that. Baba said to me, “Your spiritual life is very good. Your sadhana is good, but your personal life is no good. You’ve done many bad things with that body of yours.”

I had to pull up my shirt, and Baba took His cane, and He whacked and whacked, and it hurt. He started hitting on the same places. I never saw any Western margiis get so beat up. Just lashed left and right. Someone outside of the organization could never understand. A couple times He hit me on the hipbone, which was very painful. But I

really believe that He relieved tremendous past karmas, painful deaths, things we didn't even know we had in store for us. Basically it was a tremendous relief.

I remember I got out of there and waited outside. Baba came out, and they were holding the crowd back, but somehow I got pushed beyond the VSS guards. It was like I was invisible. Nobody could see me; I was walking along as if I was Baba's personal bodyguard. I was holding my hands right behind Him, like I was trying to touch Baba's aura. I remember looking at His neck, and the back of His head, walking right along behind Him, like I could just grab Him. I followed Him all the way down the hall, but couldn't go out for fear of getting arrested. I stopped, and then the crowds just crashed over me. Then I got very sick. I wasn't really well again for years. I think Baba must have brought out a lot of bad karma.

I felt Baba's *krpa* working on me, and began doing a lot of work in my unit. Baba just started to work on me, it was like fermenting, like yeast in bread. I tried to go to reporting one time, and for some reason couldn't get a visa. I saw some kind of fortuneteller where I was living, and she said I would never be able to get into India again. I was afraid I would never be able to see Baba again. I was doing a lot of work for AM at the time, and having tremendous sadhana, and felt like I could go into high *samadhi*, having these tremendous experiences you read about in books. And I felt I must go to see Baba. It was 1989. I was in Japan, saving money. I had been blacklisted in India and was afraid I would get caught.

Someone recommended I go overland from Nepal, so I did that, and got detained there. I had to bribe them. They asked me, "You're an Ananda Margii aren't you? Do you know Dada Daneshananda?" I said I didn't know anyone in India. I kind of convinced them. Finally I gave them some money. I got in, went to Ananda Nagar, and could really feel Baba's presence there, like He'd incarnated Himself in all the animals and plants and air. It was a full moon, and we had to sneak in. There was some kind of raid going on. We had to sneak out again, ran down to catch the train, and went to Kolkata.

Baba was very sick; it was hard to get into the darshan to see Him, but I finally got in. DMC was going to happen soon. Then Baba suddenly had a heart problem, and had to go to the hospital. We weren't supposed to go to the hospital, but we went anyway, brought some flowers, and wrote a little note. We gave them to the driver. He came out

and said Baba was very excited about these flowers and wanted to know who brought them. He gave us His namaskar. I never saw Baba again after that.

Jagadmitra (2)

Later on in my life I went for *Dharma Samiksa*. Actually I had just come back from India, and Dada Nityashuddhananda, the trainer here, called and said go to India. I said, “Dada, I’ve just come back from India.” He said, “Baba’s giving *Dharma Samiksa*, go to India.” Dr. Ram was here, and he called me, and said we should go. I said OK. I didn’t have any money at all at that time. I told my husband. I said, “I have to go to India, Baba wants to see me.”

He said, “You’re crazy.”

“I have to go, I have to see Baba again.” I had this friend I had taught school with. We used to always have these philosophical conversations. And so when I thought who could I ask for money, I thought of Bill Popovich. I called, and the person said, “Oh, I haven’t seen Billy for a long time, but his sister lives in...” and she gave me that number. And you know the feeling I had while all this was going on was the same feeling I had when the Jamaica thing was happening. My mind was racing. I felt like life was moving very quickly. I called his sister. “Hi, my name is and I’m looking for BP.” “Oh, well, Bill happens to be sitting right here” [laughs]. I said, “Hi. Bill, this is Gerry. Can you lend me \$1500? I have to go to India.” He said, “Yeah, I’ll wire it to you.” So off I went to *Dharma Samiksa*.

I made many trips to India. I thought, there’s nothing better I can do with my life than go to India and see Baba. I was there when He was writing these songs, and I remember as a musician, being very frustrated because I couldn’t understand the words to the songs; they were all in Bengali. One day, Baba came out. It was always a choice whether you were going to stand on that side of the car, or this side – which side is Baba going to get out on? I stood on this side, and of course He came out the other side. I remember thinking strongly, “Why doesn’t He do anything in English?”

So Baba came out, and He looked across the car, and started singing this English song, “Tiny Green Island.” And I thought, “Oh, He wrote a song just for me!” It was funny because the friend who was with me said, “No, He wrote that for me.”

“No, for me!” [laughs].

There were so many beautiful experiences like that. When I had such strong desires, He always gave me what I wanted. I think that's the most beautiful part.

When I went to India for *Dharma Samiksa* in 1981, it was a situation where I was on the list and got bumped off. Not just that day, but to another day. Finally I went to see Dada Yatiishvarananda, my *acarya*, and told him I must see Baba, and so I finally did. But they sent me out again; Baba said only 12 people in the room at a time. I was the 13th. I was sent out again. Then at the last minute they called me back in.

They had three rows of people, brothers and sisters mixed. Baba was seeing each individually and prescribing asanas. I didn't know exactly what *Dharma Samiksa* was, but I knew any personal contact with Baba was worth whatever I had to go through. Vijaya Lakshmi was before me. Baba was scolding her, because she wasn't doing enough work [laughs]. Oh my goodness, Vijaya did so much work! She was a nurse; she was very strong.

I never did any work. Even when I went to retreats, I never went to organizational meetings, but I went to every meeting where they talked about disciple-guru relationship, or anything like that. I just couldn't get enough of that. And I'm a musician, I wasn't a nurse. My service is playing, I guess. So I went up. Didi Ananda Karuna was there, instructing me what to do. And Baba said, "And you have done no work!" He took the stick and hit my hand three times, and then told Didi the asanas for me.

I left and went to meditate. The very interesting thing for me was, I had these three bruises on my hand. I'm a pianist; I've always had a strong passion for the piano. But once I started to meditate, and after I had PC, the music had kind of taken a second place, and meditation was becoming stronger and stronger; I was losing the desire to play. Well, after He hit my hand, it kind of opened up this door, for all these latent *samskaras*, musical *samskaras*.

Vijaya and Dr. Ram and I had taken a suite at a hotel; we were all back there meditating. While I was meditating, all of a sudden I felt this jolt, and I opened my eyes. It was so vivid, as if someone had taken a piece of paper and ripped it in two, and I felt separated from my husband, but I didn't know what that meant. It was very real, but I didn't know how to interpret it. So after I got back to the States, in two to three weeks, a letter came, and of such a nature that it destroyed the relationship. So what I had felt, I

didn't know it was going to manifest on the physical plane, but it did. But after that, the music began. I started playing more and more, and studying at Stanford and San Francisco Conservatory, and gave several concerts.

The music just seemed to blossom. I always wondered if that striking my hands had anything to do with that, you know? I was kind of frightened in *Dharma Samiksa*, mainly because Baba was giving punishment to some people, and I understood that later to be a blessing. But it was very, very beautiful to be that close, just that close, and to have Baba giving you personal instructions. Ananda Marga had already gotten so big that my relationship with Baba was mainly on another level. It was not like I could say, "Hi, Baba" and He'd say, "Hi, Jagadmitra." So it was very special to be that close to Baba and have Him give asanas.

Baba's been the love of my love, the highlight of my life. I'm very thankful.

Puspahrdaya

Montpelier, Vermont

In 1981, Baba began calling margiis to come for a special opportunity, *Dharma Samiksa*. My husband and our friend Pavan were able to go almost immediately, in June. I had just begun running a children's program I was committed to through mid-August, and bought a ticket for the first day I'd be available, August 17th. My husband and Pavan, like many other margiis, had wonderful experiences traveling to, waiting for, receiving, and then reflecting on the gifts Baba gave them. I was very excited to have my turn coming up. And then, perhaps a week before it was my time to go, Baba ended *Dharma Samiksa*. No more margiis were to come for it.

I was much disappointed. The travel agent in New York who booked so many margiis' travel to India, an Indian man himself, was most sympathetic and apologized for the non-refundable fee, but of course, that is not what saddened me. The acaryas and margiis said, "Maybe Baba will start up again, let us see." So we waited and wondered.

At a regional retreat in Ithaca the next month we were told that Baba wanted a First Global Conference to be held very soon. It would be in October, in Germany, and we thought, maybe Baba will come, He wants all the margiis from around the world to gather. Surely He will come.

But before even all these thoughts were voiced, I heard in my own mind, "I will go. Baba wants me to come whether He will be there physically or not. I want to please Him. I will go." I arranged travel right away.

I recall going to Kennedy airport with my parents. My mother, who had met only a few other margiis, picked out some family people on a check-in line and suggested that they may be going where I was going, "because they look so peaceful." This seemed funny but not uncharacteristic of my mother, who was known to see the objects of her affection and thought in the faces around her. Sure enough, though, they were margiis from the Carolinas, and I enjoyed traveling with them on the overnight flight.

When, after various interesting legs of the journey, we arrived in Russelsheim, Mainz, Germany, I was delighted by the conference site, a castle that was now a hostel,

with lovely gardens around it and situated near a train station. Bikes and bike racks were everywhere, and everything seemed so lively and friendly.

I started to meet margiis from all over the world, and there was a particular thrill to our first *dharmacakra* as the conference officially convened. There was still a question in our hearts, in our conversation and in the air, “Will Baba come?” as we went about diving into devotional, ideological, cultural and organizational programs with brothers and sisters from every continent.

By the end of our first day, which of course was bridged to the day before it by a sleepless night in transit and a time change, I was exhausted and depressed. Looking to settle down in a room stuffed with noisy sisters, I thought, “Why did I come? Was this a big mistake?!” But rest, the kindness of those around me and the wonderful morning muesli with warm milk soon revived my body and spirits.

At some point during the conference, it was arranged that every sector would have a group meeting with the respected Central office *acarya*, Dada Vijayananda. This was to be an intimate conversation between the margiis and Dadaji, in which we could ask him questions based on our own concerns. It was an intriguing and exciting prospect. When the appointed time came, our own Dada Yatiishvarananda, New York Sectorial Secretary, hosted the gathering, sitting with Dada Vijayananda before us in a large room. Because so many New York Sector margiis were fortunate enough to attend, we filled the room, sitting in rows and columns following some kiirtan and sadhana. I remember brother Sudeva from New Haven sitting behind me and to my right, toward the center of the room.

Dada V’s presence was strong and intense and compelling. His brilliance, devotion and integrity were unmistakable. I was very much aware of the unique opportunity this was for us, to discourse with one of Baba’s closest workers. And I was concerned about whether I would get a chance to ask a question, and what that question should be. Similarly, as the meeting progressed, I was restless when a sister I didn’t know, a new margii (compared to my five years at that point), asked about how important it was for her family to be vegetarian. I hardly paid attention to Dada’s thoughtful reply because of the noise in my own head – “What’s so important about that right now?? This dada could answer questions of the greatest subtlety! Let’s not waste time here. I want

MY turn!” Shortly following this internal ego-fest, I was called on by Dada Y to direct my question to Dada V.

I took *guru mantra* and asked, “What do you do when you have negative thoughts? I mean, I know we should take ideation and try to overcome negative tendencies by cultivating the opposite, positive tendencies, but wha...”

“You should speak in shorter sentences and do longer asanas!” Dada Vijayananda cut me off with controlled thunder. A bolt of energy went up my spine, jerking erect my head, which suddenly had the sensation of expanding with great speed, and I felt my whole body and head filled with tremendous force that was pushing against the borders of my entire being. I sat with my eyes closed, tears running down my face, feeling that Baba Himself was taking over, filling me, penetrating every organ and cell with His presence, stretching my body and nerves and whole physical, mental and spiritual existence to become one with Him.

I was only vaguely aware of the discourse continuing around me, in which Dada was explicating the tendency of people with narrow faces to use too many words, and so on and so forth. A couple of sisters around me responded to my shaking and tears, and to the palpable charge in the room, by starting to touch me, offering comfort. But I told them, “No, no, I’m fine, this is good!” Indeed, DadaYatiishvarananda injected a kind of joke to this effect: “In three thousand years no one has given *Dharma Samiksa* but Baba, and now Dada is joining in!”

But I knew, and I believe from those who approached me afterwards, that others knew, the truth behind both dadas’ words. I had a determined desire for *Dharma Samiksa*. I had gone to Germany only to please Baba. And in response, Baba had come to meet His little girl half way to satisfy my heart’s longing for His touch, His instruction, His blessing.

CHAPTER FIVE:

DID YOU COME ALONE?

“The devotional sentiment is the highest and most valuable treasure of humanity. This element of devotion must be preserved carefully. Because it is such a tender inner asset, to preserve it from the onslaughts of materialism, one must build a protective force around it... a proper philosophy which will establish the correct harmony between the spiritual and material worlds, and be a perennial source of inspiration for the onward movement of society.”

The '80s witnessed a burst of speed and dynamism in Baba's work, and in the organization as a whole. Baba began composing *Prabhat Samgiit*, a body of devotional songs of incredible beauty and lyricism that eventually numbered 5018. Many devotees recall magical evenings singing these songs at Baba's home in Kolkata. He developed the philosophy of Neohumanism, which rationally explained the interconnectedness of all life. Baba began to place emphasis on the spiritual and service communities called Master Units, especially the main MU, Ananda Nagar. And He continued to give Personal Contact. Through His glance, His touch, the hide and seek game of affection, devotees came closer and closer to Him.

Dhyanesh

Austin, Texas

My name is Dhyanesh, and my *acarya* 's name is Daneshananda. He initiated me in April 1980 in Denver, Colorado. Before my initiation, I was looking for my guru for seven years. In the university, I had read the *Autobiography of a Yogi* by Yogananda, and was receiving the Self-Realization Fellowship lessons every week – one a week – and I would look forward to these lessons so much.

I learned *sattvic* diet, and I learned all the asanas, and I learned *Yama and Niyama*, and so many things, and I changed my lifestyle, fortunately, by His grace. And in landscape architecture school I was designing ecological spiritual villages. My professors thought I was a little bit crazy... but I had a strong intuitional feeling that some spiritual master was training me for the future.

And even though I know Yogananda taught me so much, I also had a strong feeling that he was preparing me for my true guru – all intuition.

In 1980 I was living in Denver, and I had had many glimpses of Ananda Marga, but just a little here and there. I went to the AMUS, an Ananda Marga Universal Store that opened next to my house in South Denver, and I started associating with margiis. They were telling me Baba stories, and I liked the stories I heard about Baba so much, and their service projects also impressed me.

Anyway, Dada Daneshananda was giving a lecture at the University of Denver, and I went and was initiated, and he told me I could only do *nama mantra*. At this time I had many lessons in Kriya yoga, and I was very inspired and strict with my practices, so that was difficult for me to only do *nama mantra*, but even with *nama mantra* I had a blissful meditation.

Every day I would go to the sectorial office in Denver – every day I would go see my dada and we would talk, and after a few days he gave me first lesson, and after a couple weeks he gave me second lesson. After I got second lesson, I was doing midnight meditation in my room in front of my *puja* table. On my *puja* table I had a photo of Yogananda and I had a photo of Baba, because Yogananda was my guru for seven or eight years. In the meditation I looked in the Baba photo with all my heart and I asked

him, “Are you my master? Are you the teacher I’ve been waiting for? Are you the one that I’ve been feeling?”

Then I fell asleep in my meditation, and Baba came to me in a dream that was not a dream: Baba came to me through my subconscious mind. He looked right at me, and His two eyes looked right into my eyes and mine into His. I felt so much love coming up inside of me, and I told Him how much I loved Him. Now this shocked me to hear myself say this because before this time I had never felt love like this before; I didn’t even particularly like the idea of a guru. I felt we all had a personal connection with God inside and why do we need a guru?

But, my soul, my inner self, felt this love for Him, and I told Him with my words how much I loved Him. This was the first key, to open the door. Then I felt Baba taking me with Him, and in this subconscious state I said my *guru mantra* completely and exactly, and then I started saying my *ista mantra* over and over and over again. Baba was teaching me how to surrender myself using the *ista mantra*. Then Baba’s skin became like a vessel filled with liquid gold light, and with the *ista mantra* I went into Baba, I was absorbed into Baba. I went from subconscious to superconscious, I bypassed the conscious mind. This was His way for me. He answered my question beautifully, directly, clearly. When I came out of this after some time – and even to this day I remember it – all the cells in my body were vibrated. I was changed. I didn’t eat for days, and I felt so vibrated and inspired that He had answered my question.

It wasn’t so long after that that I quit my job and sold my house and was on my way to *Dharma Samiksa*. Our Sectorial Secretary was disappointed I quit my job: “Why does everyone change so fast?” he said. But anyway, I was on my way to *Dharma Samiksa* and I got halfway there and Baba stopped, He went into isolation. I was told to stay in Europe; Baba would come for the first world convention. At that time I was able to visit many *jagrtis* and I decided strongly inside myself I was not ready yet, so I went to LFT training.

I worked as an LFT for one and a half years in San Antonio. By His grace we did many wonderful service projects. I worked in Wyoming and Denver also. But then I was

re-posted, and asked to run the New York sector office until July. Then I was re-posted in Kolkata as an LFT and I was thrilled. Every night I got to go see Baba; this was in 1983. That was the most special time in my life. He taught me so much; every morning I would feel His vibration. Even though I was on one side of Kolkata and Baba was on the other side of Kolkata, I could feel His vibration. Even to this day I feel the vibration – His mood I should say. I was not allowed to go every night– there were communist rallies or something like this, but most of the time I went.

Even though I was in His special aura in Lake Gardens, my mind was sometimes here and sometimes there. Only once out of every two weeks or so did He allow my mind into a more special subtle plane, to get closer to Him. One night I had a fever and I was in a particularly devotional mood. And that night Baba came back from field walk and He sat on a chair in the garden and all of us sat around Him, and they started to play the *Prabhat Samgiit* song that He composed that day.

I started to sway in a devotional state with the music and Him in front of me. And the thought came to my mind that... Baba had used this concept that all the unit beings are dancing around the nucleus of the universe. We are all at our own orbits and at our own rates of speed but we are all orbiting around *Parama Purusa*, or this nucleus of *Purushottama*. So in my mind I had that thought that I was swaying, I was dancing to the rhythms of life around the nucleus of the universe inside Baba's form in front of me. And when I had that thought, while the music was playing, Baba turned and looked at me and said, "Yes," like that. A very blissful vibration was happening.

But then, and this is the big lesson of the story, I noticed that Dada Yatiishvarananda, my Sectorial Secretary, was standing some distance away near the garage and watching me be with Baba. He was watching me, and my relationship with Him. Well, this disturbed my mind because now somebody was watching me. I don't know what it is – ego or whatever comes up, but it ruined the vibration. But a thought came to me, and in my mind I said, "No! My whole life I've been worried about what other people think! What other people feel! About being accepted."

Maybe being number six out of seven children, it's been competitive. Prestige, Baba calls it. Whatever it is, I had this strong thought: "No! My whole life I've been worried about what other people think. No more. Baba, it's only you and me in the whole

universe.” Just that personal relationship. The second I had that thought, Baba turned to me and said, “Very good!” Like that, while the music was playing [laughs].

So much grace He gave me. This is what Baba calls the subjective approach in life. We get so caught up in the objective world and our position in it that we lose the closest one, and this was the lesson He was teaching me. The music stopped and Baba got up. I had a garland for Him that day. I think I was leaving the next day for somewhere. Baba got up and turned away from me and was going out, and I was behind Him and I had this thought in my mind, “With this garland, Baba, I’m giving you my all: my physical, my mental, and my spiritual being I’m giving you.”

And Baba stopped, and He turned all the way around, and He let me put the garland over His head, and He said, “Very good.”

This was a wonderful experience for me. All of these experiences are such special grace of the Lord. All of our souls love Him, and this was like news to my conscious mind, that my soul, my inner self, was already in love with Him. He was teaching me how to think, and how to feel, basically. I always asked, “Let me love you more.” That was the only thing I’d ever ask of Him. And I think it’s important that we spiritual aspirants ask this. Baba said we should only ask one question: guide my mind onto the path of bliss. It’s similar: let me love you more.

Jayamati

San Diego, California

I had the very strong desire to see Baba, to see His physical form. I remember when I lived in Denver and Baba was planning to come to the New York Sectorial Office. It was an exciting time, everyone working hard to prepare. It was so wonderful that Baba was coming to us. My sister Dipanii, who is a margii, too, and I were planning to go camping up in the Colorado mountains for about five days and then come back, and Baba would be coming to Denver. We stopped on the way to the mountains at a friend's house, and he told us that it looked like Baba would not be coming to Denver. They would not let Him in the country and He was going to land in San Francisco and we could see Him there.

Our friend was flying out and he lent us money and we decided to drive out in our little Volkswagen instead of going to the mountains. Our parents thought we were in the mountains. By Baba's grace it was an uneventful trip, and I felt like I was on a straight path to the Guru. My desire to see Him was so strong. When we got to the Los Altos *jagrti*, it looked like the U.S. officials would not even let Baba off the plane. It would be so wonderful if Baba could even step on the United States soil, so uplifting for this country. I did not get to see Him. I remember meditating before His picture and just crying my heart out. My heart was broken, it was a loss that I had never experienced. I wanted to see Him, to be in His physical presence so much.

About three or so years later, I got the chance to go to India and see Baba. I was so one-pointed, that I knew that I was going to see Him. Everyone else was going, "Oh, what if we can't get into Tiljila; what if we get deported?" all this drama stuff around seeing Baba. I knew that I would see Him. I remember flying on an airplane and a dada pointing out the Himalayas. I was not interested. I only wanted to see Baba. In Kolkata, I had a strong desire to see Baba's garden. I was at Baba's house and I was really stressed out with the travel. I walked through the gardens, and felt much peace. A dada scolded me afterwards, saying, "Didn't you see the sign that no one was allowed to walk through there?" I honestly did not see the sign.

When I finally arrived at the sisters' *jagrti* in Tiljila in the middle of the night, I sat down and did meditation. Baba appeared in my mind's eye and namaskared and welcomed me there. He knew that I had traveled all this way to see Him. The next morning a didi came and told me to hurry and come see Baba. He was walking on His verandah. I hurried, and then, finally I saw His physical presence. It felt like time stopped. I do not know how long I was there. All I could say was that it felt like I was home. I had finally come home. He would walk back and forth on His verandah, and I just wanted to keep seeing His form again and again. It felt like the world took on a beautiful, shining quality.

After that, I would do anything to be in His presence. I went and sat near the place where He had given darshan, and had the clearest and strongest meditation ever. At the *Dharma Maha Chakra* ceremony, when Baba did the *mudra*, I felt a strong jerk in the bottom of my spine and I cried and cried during *Guru Puja*. I remember crying a lot in India, and just opening my heart. In my lifetime, of all the things that I have done, the one thing that I am glad that I did was go see Baba while He was still in His physical form.

A few other experiences: I was in Alaska, sitting in a bar, and I remember asking the waitress for a pen, and I wrote Baba's name on my hand. That night I almost had a very bad thing happen to me, but it didn't and I knew that Baba was looking after me.

I had a very vivid dream that Baba had healed me. In this dream I got a piece of paper that Baba had written on and it said that he would take the contaminated matter from my fallopian tubes and put it in His pancreas. (I had been dealing with years of infertility). We did finally adopt a beautiful boy, Narada.

When Baba left His physical body, I tried to be sad, but Baba wouldn't let me. I remember crying before His picture. Then He would fill me up with such bliss, that I could no longer be sad. When I got the book in the mail commemorating Baba, and it showed the picture of Him on the funeral pyre, then it seemed so real and I cried and cried and cried. For a whole year I kept saying that I wish Baba was still here in His physical form. I had a dream that I was looking at a Baba picture and there was an empty chair where Baba was supposed to be sitting.

In another dream I was looking at a Baba photo and there was this light around Baba, and a dada told me that was Baba's light body. I knew that Baba was in his light body. He had not gone anywhere.

Yogendra

Cuernavaca, Mexico

When I make a retrospective of my life, I notice that Baba has been always near me and I realize that all experiences that I have had with the Guru possess an immense value. Nevertheless, there was one that began in a normal workday when suddenly the telephone in my office rang. It was Dada Brahmananda from New York who said, “Yogendra, Namaskar, I call you to tell you that you must go to India since Baba is giving personal contact and it is a great opportunity that you shouldn’t waste. So prepare everything you need for the trip: money, passport, visa, etc. and as soon as you are ready, let me know.”

As on many other times when a dada or didi called to tell me the same and I would always say that perhaps one day I would do it, on this occasion it was no exception – I continued my activities as if nothing had happened. In reality in my mind a trip to India was the same as if it were to another planet.

Some days later, Dada called me again asking about my advances on the preparation for the trip, which in reality were zero. For that reason, Dada got a little angry and told me that it was an opportunity that I might never have again. Despite the insistence of my *acarya*, I continued with my daily normal routine and my wife Malati and I decided to go to Mexico City for the next weekend to visit my parents. I remember that we arrived on Saturday evening and after dinner we chatted for a while and later on we went to sleep. Then, as we say in Mexico, “Here comes the best.”

I started dreaming that I was walking on a street on a big and populous city. People seemed to be like the people of my own town but there was a difference about them, and the houses and buildings were different also. I asked where I was but when I spoke to the people they would not understand me. Suddenly something on the ground took my attention; it was the metallic cover of a drain from the water system of the city which had something written in unknown characters to me, but that I had seen once in a book. And then I came to realize that these were words in Bengali or Hindi and I thought, “Well, I’m in India, I don’t know how but I’m here and as Baba is in India, what I have to do is to go to visit Him.”

I arrived at a house where there were many didis, dadas and people from all over the world, all of them waiting for an opportunity to see the Guru. I went into the house and sat on the floor of a pretty big room where most of the people were youngsters of different nationalities waiting for personal contact with Baba. When one of them would enter and come back from being with the Master, all of us would run and ask what He told him.

It was then that my turn came and I went into the room where He was seated on an armchair dressed in white, looking somewhere else. Then it was I said to myself, “Is He Baba? I don’t feel anything seeing Him.” In that moment He looked at me and a bright light came out from His eyes which blinded me and I saw myself in front of a huge mountain, maybe it was a volcano. I was in front of Him without being able to say a word. With a sweet but powerful voice that I have never heard again He told me, “I am not only in the human beings, I am also in the plants, and in everything that surrounds them.”

Suddenly I woke up with the great desire to meditate. I sat down, closed my eyes and a flood of energy started to run through my body and such an extraordinary happiness was felt in my whole being that tears broke out, as they never had before. I couldn’t stop them and this extreme happiness seemed interminable. I don’t know how long I stayed like that, I just know that when I came to “normality” I had only one thought, “I have to go to India to see Baba at any price.”

Next day we returned to Cuernavaca and right away I started to gather money and on Tuesday I applied for a visa that was given to me the next day. I spoke with the people I was working for as an architect and as much as I could, I left everything taken care of, things that were pending and situations that now when I think of them, I’m surprised I left because I was tied up in my job. On Friday I packed, prepared my documents and the money I had gathered and said goodbye to Malati. I drove north toward Dallas, and arrived there next day in the evening. From the first telephone I saw, I called Dada Brahmananda who was in another city, and when he answered the phone he started scolding me saying, “Yogendra, you don’t understand, you will never have an opportunity like this...”

“Dada, I’m in Dallas.”

“How come in Dallas, it can’t be?”

“Yes, Dada, I just arrived and that’s why I’m calling you.”

“Well, now what you ought to do is call Ravi Batra and when you are with him you’ll give him the money you brought and he’ll arrange everything so you can go to India as soon as possible.”

Once I hung up, I followed the instructions, bought a map of the city and soon I met Ravi Batra who took care that nothing was missing. It was done in a short time because he already knew that my flight to India would leave next Monday morning from Dallas to New York and from there to India. On Monday Ravi went early to the Prout office and took me to the airport where I continued my trip to see Baba.

I arrived in New Delhi at night and even though it was a strange place I felt secure. From the beginning I felt somehow that I knew and had possibly been in this place. I took a taxi, which drove me to an area where a *jagrti* was. I was nicely welcomed by a dada who happily took me to a room where I spent the night willing to be close to my master. Next morning I woke up early and after doing my routine I went to the airport where I received bad news.

Because it was Diipavali (the light festival, a season with great movement, almost like our Christmas season for people who travel during those days), all the flights to Kolkata were saturated. I was told that they would put my name in the waiting list and that in three or four days they would confirm my flight. I felt bad because my time was limited and this was very inconvenient. When I returned to the *jagrti* Dada told me that I could try to go by train, though I might have the same problem and also traveling by train was a lot slower.

I went to my room to do kiirtan and meditation, and that helped me to calm down. I decided to go for a walk and see a little bit of New Delhi. I took some reference points so I wouldn’t get lost and I left. In a few minutes I was in a zone where there were a lot of people and buildings that looked oddly familiar to me. As I was walking I looked down and I saw a drain with a metal cover with strange language characters written on it. My body shivered with the sensation that I had lived that experience before. A sense of impotence took possession of me; I felt that even when I was so close to Baba I couldn’t see or be with Him.

The next day I returned to the airline office to see if the situation had changed; however, I knew it was the same, and I had no possibilities of traveling at least in the next three days. Nevertheless, I wasn't defeated so I tried some other possibilities; I explained to them that I had traveled from the other side of the world just to see my father. I asked to speak with someone who had the power of decision. The lady that was taking care of my situation looked at the system for a while and then said, "Look, just now a cancellation was made; since this is a special case I'll give you the seat, but you must hurry because the plane leaves in less than two hours."

Nervously and at the same time happy, I accepted, thanked her for the attention and took a taxi to the *jagrti* to pick up my things. I was excited when I entered the *jagrti* in a rush and Dada asked me what was going on. I explained to him that in a few minutes my flight to Kolkata was leaving, and an uproar burst out with everybody who helped me with my luggage and called a taxi since I had limited time to get to the airport. Everything went fine after I arrived at the airport.

In a few hours I was in Kolkata; from there I went to Tiljala, where I asked for Baba, and I was told to go to Lake Gardens. I began to look for Dada Haratmananda who was the New York Sectorial Secretary. When I saw him he was very surprised and gave a place in his room so I could rest. At that moment the least I wanted was rest, so I told Dada that I wanted to go to Lake Gardens. Dada asked how much money I had. I showed it to him and he said, "Oh! Yogendra, that's very little money, how did you get here?"

Dada gave me a few rupees and directions to go to Lake Gardens. I took my briefcase and I left trying to not forget anything. I walked for a while until I heard my name; two dadas were calling me – one of them was very tall and the other was very short, they were always together and they also were going to see Baba. They told me that we could go together and while walking one of them asked me if this was my first time in India, and if I had never seen Baba, he recommended I do half meditation, to repeat my *mantra* mentally until we arrived at His house.

At Lake Gardens there were lots of people, dadas, didis and margiis from all over the world. I walked around for a while and then someone announced that Baba was about to come out to take His afternoon walk; our excitement became more intense. The didis

started to sing *Prabhat Samgiita* and a dada told me, “Sing even when you don’t know the lyrics; just follow the melody.”

When the Master came out, He gave us His Namaskar. I must admit that my emotion didn’t increase – I was very happy but I wasn’t altered. Some brothers and sisters were crying. I would have liked to feel like them but it just didn’t happen. Anyway I was happy and I stayed there waiting for Him to return from His walk so I could see Him again. Once everything calmed down, I introduced myself to some dadas including Baba’s assistant Dada Keshavananda who was very polite with me all the time and made me feel at home. He then took me to a room which wasn’t very big, and where some youngsters from all over the world were sitting on the floor waiting for personal contact with Baba. I talked to some of them and they told me that they were from different continents. I noticed then, that when someone came out from being with Baba, everybody in the room asked him what the Master told him.

The days were passing by in that way, and some people told that they had been waiting for months to have Personal Contact. Some others would come and leave, and others just weren’t allowed to see Baba. I remember a brother who was refused to have an interview, even when he explained he had good relations with wealthy people, he had to return to his country without accomplishing his purpose. There was another brother who had already entered Baba’s room but he wasn’t wearing his *pratik*, and he had to come out, crying. There were other cases when Baba asked something in Bengali to Spanish and English speakers and they couldn’t answer, and the interview was interrupted. For that reason a dada started to give us an elementary course of Bengali, in order that we could answer questions like: what’s your name? How old are you?

Every night that passed we were told to return to Tiljala to have some rest and to return the next day in the morning.

One day we heard that Baba was coming to Tiljala; the atmosphere turned festive. However, that day I was called to see Him, and when my turn came, a dada came out and said that was all for that day. My preoccupation increased because I had to return to Mexico due to the great amount of work I had there. My mind was crowded with thoughts like, “What if my interview is in two months?” “What am I going to do if I’m not received?” and “What about the job I left undone?”

Each day that passed my preoccupation increased, and sometimes I could not concentrate while meditating. One day I returned to Lake Gardens and for some reason that I never knew I was allowed to sleep at Baba's house. That night at dawn a young dada that I had never seen before and I never saw again, woke me up saying, "Yogendra, you are 29 years old." I answered him that I was 33 and he told me, "You are 29 and if Baba asks you about your age you're going to tell Him that, otherwise he won't give you personal contact."

I answered him, "Yes, Dada, I understand." He left and I went back to sleep. When I woke up I felt sick, I had a fever and I was tired. Anyway I did my best to wake up and took a shower; that day was fasting so I went to the waiting room. I felt even more sick, and tried to meditate but my preoccupations didn't allow me to concentrate so I decided to analyze my situation and make a definitive decision.

"I'm in India, I'm close to Baba, I see Him everyday, I meditate near Him, we have had *dharmacakra* in front of him, what else do I want? I should enjoy every moment of the happiness I receive just being near Baba; I have overcome the worst part already. Baba, I just ask for the patience to wait; it doesn't matter if I have to wait one week or two or even to wait months for You to receive me, I put myself in your hands."

I tried to meditate again. My mind was clear now, and a great tranquility emerged until I felt encouraged with the idea of staying there until I had personal contact. Once I finished my sadhana, I went to the garden for a while. It was a beautiful day, the sky had an intense blue, there were very few clouds but the shapes they had were very beautiful, the birds were singing and they demonstrated joy, and being calmed, I returned to the waiting room. I still had a fever but I felt a lot better now.

Maybe an hour or less passed when a dada called me and began asking, "Did you take a shower today? Are your clothes clean? Are you wearing *laungota*? Are you wearing a *pratik*?" I answered yes to every question and then he said, "Yogendra, you are going to see Baba right now."

My tranquility turned to nervousness. I went upstairs and at the entrance of the room was another dada who gave me some instructions and opened the door. Baba was there totally dressed in white sitting in an armchair, and He was looking at me firmly. I walked toward Him and gave Him a Namaskar and my *Sastaung Pranam* and suddenly

this thought came in to my mind: “*Tava Dravyam Jagat Guru Tuvyameva Samarpaye*” [To the guru I offer everything]. I stood up and continued walking. Baba answered my salute and asked me in English,

“WHAT’S YOUR NAME, MY SON?”

“Yogendra, Baba.”

“HOW OLD ARE YOU?”

I thought about my *Guru Mantra* and said, “Twenty-nine years old, Baba.”

“OH! YOU ARE A VERY LITTLE BOY.” I noticed by His smile that He knew my real age.

“COME CLOSE TO ME AND SIT DOWN HERE.” He pointed at a place in front of Him. I was so close to Him that if I moved my arm I could touch His foot. My nervousness increased and the fear of breaking up the interview made me ask, “Baba, can I touch you?”

Without saying a word He just raised His hand and made a gesture telling me to wait.

“WHERE ARE YOU FROM?”

“I am from Mexico, Baba.”

“MEXICO! YOU LIVE IN A PLACE SURROUNDED BY VOLCANOS. IT’S A WEALTHY COUNTRY BUT BECAUSE OF THE GOVERNMENT CORRUPTION, IT HAS BEEN SUNK IN A CONSTANT ECONOMIC CRISIS. YOU SPEAK SPANISH AND IT IS A LANGUAGE WHICH IS ORIGINALLY FROM A REGION NEAR VALENCIA, SPAIN.”

As He was telling me each phrase I would answer yes by moving my head because I was entering in a state that wouldn’t let me do any other thing, just look at Baba. My eyes were only for Him.

“YOGENDRA, YOU FORGOT THE RELATIONSHIP BETWEEN BROTHERS AND SISTERS. YOU WANT TO BE RESPECTED BUT YOU DON’T RESPECT THEM. TELL ME WHY YOU HAVE BEHAVED LIKE THAT ALL YOUR LIFE.”

“Baba, I think it is because I’m weak.”

“NO, YOU HAVE DONE SO BECAUSE YOU THINK NOBODY IS LOOKING AT YOU, BUT I HAVE ALWAYS BEEN OBSERVING YOU, ALL THE TIME. BECAUSE OF ALL THOSE THINGS AND FOR YOUR MISBEHAVIOR, DO YOU THINK YOU DESERVE A PUNISHMENT?”

“Yes, Baba.” For that, He was asking me with words I didn’t understand, and immediately He changed them into synonyms easier to understand.

“TAKE OFF YOUR SHIRT.”

Then He said something I didn’t understand, took His rod and raising it, He said, “HOW MANY DO YOU THINK YOU DESERVE?”

“I don’t know Baba, whatever you like.”

“TEN, TWENTY, OR THIRTY?”

“Thirty, Baba.”

“THIRTY ON ONE SIDE OR FIFTEEN IN ONE SIDE AND FIFTEEN IN THE OTHER?” He said, pointing to each one of my shoulders.

Believing that it was going to hurt a lot, I asked Him for fifteen and fifteen. Baba raised again His rod, took it back as if to gather strength to hit harder. I closed my eyes and felt a slight touch on my left side.

“WHEN A BAD THOUGHT COMES TO YOUR MIND, JUST REPEAT, ‘OH BABA!’ AND THAT THOUGHT WILL VANISH, BECOMING SOMETHING POSITIVE.”

“THIS IS ALL, NOW COME CLOSE TO ME.”

Opening His arms I came close to Him and I touched His hands, they were as soft as a baby’s skin. I touched His feet and He let me caress them. He put his hands on my head and pressing the crown of my head, He said some words, maybe it was a *mantra*; I can’t exactly explain what happened. I felt as if I was floating with Baba and only He and I existed. I held His hands again and looked at Him. A great love emanated from Baba, I felt protected, secure, and without any fear.

Little by little He let go my hands and said, “NOW, YOU ARE GOING TO PROMISE ME THAT YOU’RE GOING TO BE THE BEST OF MY SONS.”

“I’m going to try, Baba.”

“NO, YOU’RE GOING TO PROMISE ME.”

“And if I can’t?”

“PROMISE IT!”

“Yes, Baba, I promise you.”

He said an oath, asked me to repeat it and when I finished I could barely listen to what He said.

“NOW YOU CAN LEAVE.”

I stood up and walking backwards I moved away until I reached the door, I don’t know if I gave Him my Namaskar, I just remember that I knelt down again in front of Him and left the room. Outside I kept standing for a moment, and the dada who had given me the last instructions came close and asked me, “What did Baba tell you?”

I wanted to answer him but I couldn’t, it was impossible. Instead, I could only say, “Baba is God” and then I couldn’t articulate a word. A tremendous happy sensation started and tears began to come out without being able to stop them. The dada told me to sit down and meditate just by the side of Baba’s room. Again that energy and happiness overflowed through my body, I lost the notion of the place I was in and let myself go until I was totally calmed. I was meditating for about fifteen or twenty minutes. I went down the stairs and another dada asked me about what Baba had told me. I wanted to answer him but I couldn’t. I couldn’t talk and the torrent of happiness and crying invaded me again. The dada helped me, telling me to sit down and meditate more. I don’t know how long I stayed there. That intense happiness possessed me again and only after a long period of time could I incorporate myself. The dadas came but they didn’t ask questions. There was one who came and embraced me and took to the garden because he knew that other margiis were anxious to know about my encounter with the Guru and I wasn’t in a condition to answer to anybody.

As soon as I came out to the garden I saw the plants, it seemed as though they were beating, I could almost feel the circulation of life in them. I heard the birds and they seemed to accompany a kiirtan with its songs; suddenly I looked at the sky, beautiful blue and the few clouds that decorated it as if it was a monumental piece of art and inside my mind the remembrance of that powerful but at the same time sweet voice which was telling me,

“I AM NOT ONLY IN THE HUMAN BEINGS, I AM ALSO IN THE PLANTS,
ANIMALS AND IN EVERYTHING THAT SURROUNDS THEM.”

Jyotisa

Flagstaff, Arizona

During the summer of 1972, after my freshman year at college, I found myself exploring spiritual ideas. I read the autobiography of an Indian yogi who had lived many years in America. It fascinated me to discover that there exists a science of spirituality, a path one can follow to the spiritual heights. I was eager to undertake its practice.

The problem was that I felt that I needed a true guru, one who was fully realized. This presented a problem as the possibility of meeting such a guru seemed remote, at best.

I fell into a state of despair. For weeks on end my waking hours were haunted by a spiritual longing unfamiliar to me. One day while walking down the street I was unable to contain my pain and I burst into tears.

Shielding my eyes from other pedestrians I continued walking ahead, going nowhere in particular, my tears falling softly onto the concrete sidewalk. Suddenly a colorful hand-drawn poster caught my eye. I stopped and read it. It announced an upcoming lecture on yoga and meditation sponsored by Ananda Marga. I felt surprisingly hopeful, and resolved to attend the lecture two days hence.

The day of the lecture I left my home hours early to allow sufficient time to arrive at the lecture site. I had to hitchhike as I did not own a car and the bus was abysmally inefficient. While walking to the corner where I intended to solicit a ride I was seized with misgivings. How was I to know if this was a path for me? I decided to put it to a test. I mentally resolved that if God was real and if this was a path I should follow, then the first car which passed me on the road must pick me up and take me to the door of the lecture. This was no small demand as the lecture site was 12 or more miles away and a few miles off the main road.

I strode to the corner and with my back to the traffic I stuck out my thumb. Instantly a car screeched to a halt. I turned my head to see a silver Porsche sports car at my side. The door swung open. "Get in," the professionally dressed young man driving the car suggested as I was standing with my thumb extended and my mouth open.

"Where are you going?" he inquired as we pulled away. "Mission St. exit," I replied, giving the name of the freeway exit where I expected to be dropped off.

“But where are you going?” he persisted. Relenting, I replied, “I’m going to a lecture on meditation being held at the Unitarian Church.” Despite my protestations, he insisted on driving me miles out of his way to the door of the church. I was stunned yet elated. As I stood on the steps of the locked church (I was the first to arrive), I reflected on my experience. What did it mean? Was I being superstitious? Had I intuited the course of events and so placed my demands in keeping with them? Was it real?

I enjoyed the lecture and went the next day to meet with Dada to learn meditation. Feeling heady from my experience of the previous day I decided to repeat the test and again resolved that the first car must take me to my destination. I walked to the same spot as before and put out my thumb. Whoosh! Whoosh! The first two cars passed without stopping. My spirits sank. The next car, a small pick-up truck, pulled up beside me.

“Where are you going?” the driver asked as I climbed into the bed of the truck.

“Anapumu street,” I replied, giving neither the number nor a cross street.

Feeling somewhat crestfallen I reflected on my recent experiences as I sat alone in the rear of the pick-up. The more I thought about it, the more foolish I felt. If there was a God, most certainly this God was aware of my needs. Why was I making such trivial demands and tests? I should resolve to place my desires in line with that of the supreme rather than try to manipulate God. I decided then and there that since I had an intellect I should use it to make decisions even about spiritual matters.

Absorbed in these thoughts, I paid no attention to where my ride was going. Suddenly, the truck stopped at the curb. “Hey, get out!” the driver yelled at me. Waving my thanks I hopped to the ground as the truck sped away. I wondered how many blocks or miles I would have to walk to get to the desired address. Looking around I checked a house for a street number. To my astonishment, I was directly in front of the house I was looking for! I had been taken directly to my destination by a driver who knew only the street name and not the number. He had merely stopped at what was a convenient place in a busy part of town.

“Good enough!” I laughed as I walked up to the house to meet with Dadaji. I felt as if I were in a cosmic play being directed by a force I could not see.

My desire to meet Baba grew year by year. About six months after Baba was released from prison, I had a curious experience in my meditation. When I would sit to meditate I would experience an image of Baba. In this experience He was walking towards me, His hands together in spiritual greeting, and His gaze meeting mine. Somehow He was always walking towards me and yet He never reached me. He was always just a few steps away. It became impossible to meditate. If I had an hour to meditate, 55 minutes would be spent absorbed in this vision. In the remaining five minutes I would perform all my meditation lessons and run out the door to work.

This experience had continued for three to four weeks when an *acarya* came to visit my area. Feeling guilty concerning the lack of time I had been spending on my meditation lessons I asked the *acarya* what to do. He simply said “It’s OK. Don’t worry about it.” Immediately thereafter the experience stopped. I went on with my life and forgot that it ever happened.

I missed the DMC in Jamaica and was crushed as I felt I had missed the opportunity of a lifetime. Late the next summer one new Indian dadajii toured through my area. Feeling the pangs of my desire to see Baba and hearing how I had missed Jamaica he said, “You must go to India this winter for DMC. You must go!” Somehow, at that moment, I felt that somehow I not only could go, but I would go to India that winter. I had no savings and minimal income. I took my car to the credit union in an effort to take a loan against it. This car was a joke; it was always breaking down and having problems. Somehow, incredibly, the loan officer gave me a loan many times the value of the car. I suddenly had the money for my trip. I called Dada Yatiishvaranandaji and found that others would be going to India that winter under his guidance. Wonderful! I made arrangements to meet with this group in New York around December 20 and from there we would fly to India via Italy. I arranged my passport and visa as the time quickly passed.

To the best of my memory there were 18 of us total in the group going to India, most of us general margiis, with a handful of *acaryas*. We flew to Bombay and then took a domestic flight to Kolkata, where Baba lived and worked. We arrived at the *jagrti* in the early evening. It was my first experience in the tropics. I slept on the roof of the *jagrti*. Baba’s house was less than a mile away. One dadaji showed me the rickshaw

stand down the block where I could get a rickshaw to Baba's house. He told me how much to pay the driver. I bathed, did sadhana and asanas and went down to engage a rickshaw. I only had to say "Baba's house" and the rickshaw driver motioned onto the seat. As I was bicycled through the small winding streets of Kolkata I was filled with a wonderful anticipation. I reflected on my past eight years as an Ananda Margii. I remembered that first lecture, my first retreats, and the years of longing to see Baba. These thoughts were mixed with the scents and feelings of the warm tropical evening, the sounds of people walking and talking in small groups, the smells of people cooking in their homes.

Without warning the rickshaw stopped. I dismounted and paid the driver. A small door opened in the large gate and I was admitted onto the premises by a young man in a guard uniform. I found myself in a driveway where a small car was parked headed outward. There were many margiis from around the world milling about talking softly or just waiting. Hundreds of plants and trees were planted in the ground and in pots hanging from the walls and on the porches. There were a few statues of historical spiritual figures and small signs hanging from many plants which I learned later were Bengali poems. I had only a few minutes to take this in when suddenly two guards standing near the corner of the house snapped to attention. In just a moment everyone standing there reverently made a path to the car through which Baba was to pass.

And then Baba appeared around the corner. A guard walked backwards in front of Him making sure His way was clear and there were no hazards in His path. Baba was wearing a simple white *dhoti*, the traditional Bengali dress. I was some distance away from Him on the other side of the car. I could see Him stop and talk with an occasional person as He proceeded along. The entire route to His car from the time He came around the corner until He got in His car was only 15 feet or so. He got in the car, the gates opened, and He, along with those chosen for the field walk, were driven away by the driver. They were followed by a larger vehicle filled with more guards.

"Well," I thought, "so that was Baba." I wasn't sure what to think, and somehow I had expected more. After the car left, everyone started milling around again as it would be some time before Baba returned. I noted that there was one spot just near the corner of the house where, if a person were standing there, Baba would walk right past them as

there was no room for anyone to block the view. I immediately went over and stood in that spot. I didn't care how long it would be before Baba returned, I wanted to see Him close up.

After 50 minutes or so the sound of a car horn honking was heard coming up the street. The guards swung the gate open. Everyone suddenly shoved and pushed to get a good position to greet Baba. I was positioned so that I would be the last person Baba would pass before reaching the side yard and heading into the house. Baba got out of the car. He was so happy. He stood and with His palms together in spiritual greeting, He smiled at the crowd. He greeted everyone, turning slowly from His left to His right. Being the farthest to Baba's right I watched as His pleasant smile passed across the crowd. Suddenly Baba's gaze met mine. His face lit into a broad smile as if He were greeting an old friend. Holding my gaze He started to walk towards me. His hands together, closer and closer He came. I was so shocked I didn't know what to do. I tried to hold His gaze but my eyes kept rolling upwards into my head. Closer and closer He stepped and then, inches before colliding with me, He turned to the side, laughed quietly, and proceeded on His way.

Gazing at His retreating form I heard Him reply to His personal assistant (Ramanandaji), "Really? Eighteen of them? From America?"

Suddenly He turned around and faced me again. He walked up to me, smiling, and to my bewilderment addressed me.

"So," He said, "you have come from America?" I stood staring mutely at Baba. A voice in the back of mind was screaming "Baba is talking to you! Answer Him!"

But before I could collect my wits enough to put forth, an answer Didi Anandarama, a nun who was standing next to me and also part of our entourage, said, "Yes, Baba."

Baba smiled an acknowledgement to her response and again looked at me.

"So tell me," He began slowly. "Did you come directly to Kolkata or did you come first to Bombay and then to Calcutta?" Such a simple question and yet somehow I became completely confused. Before I could put together a rational response Didi again answered, "Baba, we came first to Bombay and then to Kolkata." Baba again smiled an acknowledgement to her response and looked once more at me.

“So tell me,” He said. “Did you arrive this morning or did you arrive this afternoon?” Now this was a very simple question. But in my perplexity I struggled. We had arrived in the morning in Bombay, in the afternoon in Kolkata, and in the evening at the *jagrti*. Once again, before I could put together an answer, Didi said, “Baba, we arrived this evening.”

Without removing His gaze from me Baba said, “This evening? Then you have arrived just now.” And when He said “Just now,” He reached out with His right hand and touched me very quickly, yet very softly, between my left eye and ear. Then He laughed quietly, turned, and walked away.

As soon as Baba disappeared into His house, people were all grabbing me. “What happened?” “Did Baba touch you?” “What was all that about?” Other than confirming that Baba had touched me, I had nothing to say. I had no idea what was going on. I felt happy, yet confused, and somewhat as if I were floating. It was not until many months after my return home that I remembered the experience in my meditation where Ba’ba’ would walk towards me and I realized that He had recreated this experience for me.

We were some of the first to arrive at Ananda Nagar for the DMC (Jan. ’81). After a few days many people would arrive, but for the time being we had the entire place, and Baba, to ourselves. Baba was paying a lot of attention to us and being very sweet. One of the first nights a small group of us, maybe 10 or 12, were waiting at Baba’s house for Him to return from field walk. It was dusk and at that time Baba’s house was very small with no gardens or other development. Just before Baba returned, Dada Karunananda suddenly closed the door to Baba’s house and brought out a chair. He said, “Perhaps we can convince Baba to have a short darshan with us.” And when Baba returned, He agreed, taking His place on the small wooden chair as we sat assembled before Him. There was a gentle breeze and the stars were just starting to appear. Baba sat still in a contemplative mood. I remember how beautiful and perfect He seemed. After some minutes He said, “Would the margiis from Italia please lead us in a kiirtan in which the brothers will dance and sing while the sisters sit and sing.”

One Italian brother with a guitar led the kiirtan as we followed His instructions. Baba simply sat as we did kiirtan, absorbed, smiling gently, eyes closed, in His cosmic mood. After ten minutes or so the kiirtan ended, Baba stood, gave us namaskar, and proceeded into His home. I had so grievously missed Baba for so many years that to have this special experience thrilled me then as the memory of it does today.

One curious thing I remember from this same time is simply that Baba used to look at me. As He was walking past, not infrequently He would stop, turn His head and gaze at me from the corner of His eye. His look held a mystic significance to me that I can never express in words, but it had to do with our relationship with one another. Baba often gazed at me in this way and touched me many times. In fact, one day in front of Baba's quarters in Ananda Nagar after He had gone into His house, Dada Karunananda (whom I had never met or spoken to) came up to me and in an excited voice said, "Baba likes you! Baba likes you!"

On one of the first mornings after our arrival in Ananda Nagar I was at Baba's quarters waiting for His return from the field walk. I noticed some carved pillars of stone about five feet long lying on the ground. I was told that they had been found somewhere in the local area and were going to be installed in Baba's yard. Shortly thereafter, Baba returned. Instead of going directly into His house, he wandered over by the stone pillars which appeared to be some kind of statues. I ventured nearby. Suddenly Baba started talking about the statues. Only myself and two European brothers were in attendance.

Baba said something to the effect of, "Many years ago this entire area was home to many large herds of cattle which roamed about. The bulls of the herds were admired by the people of that time for their strength and virility. And so the people created deities which were half human and half bull." Baba then described how during different eras of history, different styles of sculpting were used. In one era the figures were depicted clothed and in another era the figures were depicted "in the nude". Baba then asked, "Are these figures clothed or are they in the nude?" (Baba said the word "nude" with an extremely long "u" sound, "nuude".)

I looked at the statues but, other than recognizing that they had heads, I couldn't be sure what I was seeing. Baba continued. "They are clothed," He stated in answer to

His own question. He went on to say that this fact meant that these statues were from a certain era (which I can't remember).

"In fact," Baba said, looking up, "these statues were made during the reign of two brothers who were rulers of a kingdom 800 years ago." Gazing across the countryside Baba continued. "And their kingdom was located eight kilometers away," he said while extending his arm and pointing, "just there." The three of us gazed into the distance in the direction indicated (down river and approximately 30 degrees to the right). I could see only endless rice paddies, mustard fields, and small villages. I felt as though Baba was gazing through time and seeing the kingdom before him. Then Baba lowered His arm, nodded His head, and proceeded to His house.

At the time I thought that Baba was telling something which was well known to the *acaryas* and Indian margiis. I came to find out later that Baba rarely repeated such information, and that every day on His field walks He talked constantly of the local history, fauna, flora, agriculture, art, anything and everything. If those He was speaking to did not write it down, the information was lost. I don't know who those other European brothers were or whether they would remember this event. I did not write down the information when it was fresh in my mind and therefore do not remember the names of the eras described or the name of the kingdom. These statue pillars were placed at the sides of the drive entering the complex of Ba'ba's residence there at Ananda Nagar, a location they still grace to this day. This may be the only written account of their origins.

A few interesting events occurred during the time when we returned to Kolkata after DMC before returning home. We were getting more used to Baba, He was so sweet and approachable that people were becoming very friendly with Him. So one day Baba came out, and someone asked Him, "How are you, Baba?"

He replied with a question, "How should you reply if someone inquires 'How are you'?" Then again, "What should you say if someone asks 'How are you'?" Answering Himself He said, "You should say 'I am trembling with energy and dancing in divine ecstasy! I am TREMBLING with energy and DANCING in divine ecstasy!!'"

So saying, Baba smiled and proceeded on his field walk. On His return Vishvadeva spoke out. "Baba," he said, "How are you?"

Baba paused, smiled and said “Better than best. BETTER than best!”

Another night Baba had been ill. I am under the impression that this happened not infrequently after DMC. He missed some field walks and was taking some ayurvedic medicine. One day, Vishvadeva said, “Baba, are you feeling better?”

And Baba stopped, and then He started laughing. He started laughing the most hysterical laugh you’ve ever heard. Ha ha ha ha ha! Just laughing and laughing in this belly laugh. He never answered and just walked in the house continuously laughing this contagious laugh. We all started laughing. We never had any idea what it meant. Somehow this question of “Are you better?” was very amusing to Baba.

Permission was required before taking a photo of Baba. This was both to maintain the sanctity of the environment and also to prevent unauthorized use of His photo. One day, as Baba was leaving for field walk a European margii raised his camera and snapped a shot of Baba.

It was rather blatant, everyone noticed. As Baba got into His car and departed one of the dasas in charge of security approached this brother. “I’m sorry,” he said. “Unauthorized photos of Baba are not allowed. Please give me the film.”

The brother refused and held up his hands, indicating he didn’t have any film. The dada repeated the request more firmly. Soon an argument had broken out. Everyone felt very awkward, as this margii’s attitude towards the dada was very disrespectful. No one knew what to do.

Suddenly a motor horn sounded. Even though He had only been gone for five minutes Baba was returning! This was unprecedented. During the few weeks I had been there, Baba had never returned like this before. The gates swung open and Baba’s car pulled into the middle of the drive. Baba said not a word nor gave any sign. He merely looked upward into the ceiling of the car and sat still. You could have heard a pin drop. Everyone looked at the dada and the margii. The dada put out his hand and said quietly, “Give me the film.” That man ran into the house and got the film from his wife to whom he had surreptitiously slipped it. As soon as the film was in the dada’s hands Baba nodded His head and His car backed out of the drive, returning to the scheduled field walk. That man and his wife were forbidden to enter the compound for a few days

following. After travelling half way around the world to see Baba this was a painful punishment. In a few days, having learned their lesson, they were allowed back in and all was forgotten.

I do not believe that Baba cared about the photo. I think He returned primarily to protect the dignity of the dadaji who was being treated disrespectfully. In any event it was remarkable to witness first hand not only Baba's omniscience (there was no way for Him to know what was transpiring after He left the compound), but also the depth of His commitment to the workers of Ananda Marga.

Krsna

San Francisco, California

I am currently the *Bhukti Pradhan* of the East Bay area in the San Francisco Bay area. I was initiated in 1975 by *Acarya Adveshananda Avadhuta* in the city of Manila in the Philippines.

My realization of Baba since I first saw Him until I had Personal Contact in 1988 is that Baba – what we know as Baba – is not a person, not a human being. It is a creation that allows us to realize ourselves. This I first realized when I arrived at Baba’s house from the airport in 1982.

At that time I did not think that I could make the trip to India though I had been longing to see Baba for a long time. At one point in my sadhana I had this desire, so I spoke to what I thought was God, speaking to Baba internally, “If you are really the Lord of the Universe, the distance from the Philippines to Kolkata is very small. The universe is so big and the distance from Philippines to Kolkata is very small, so perhaps you can make it even smaller.”

I was working for an American computer company, and in ten days my office informed me that they were going to send me to Thailand to train other people in manufacturing computers, because I was a manufacturing engineer.

So after my stay in Thailand I quickly went to Kolkata. There were about 200-250 people there and we were packed to the edge of the room. When I first saw Baba I thought, “This is an old man. But I’m here anyway, so there must be something.”

What was unusual about that time was that after the darshan, Baba was singing the chants before what was to be the *varabhaya mudra* – He was going to do the *varabhaya mudra* in a Sunday darshan. And the margiis were all very excited.

And we were all at the back, squished back at the window, and the moment He did *varabhaya mudra*, there was like a spiritual wave – it started at the top, the margiis started crying and then after about three or four seconds it hit us at the back. There was like a force coming and all the margiis were crying and I thought, “OK, this isn’t an old man after all.”

I had about two weeks to spend in Kolkata and I was advised by dadas that before I left, I should take leave of Baba and give Him a garland. So I bought a garland from the market and before I left, Dada Arjunananda, the Personal Assistant (PA) of Baba said I should give the garland to him. And when Baba was coming out to His car in the morning Dada said, “Baba, Krsna from Maharlika would like to take leave of you.”

And Baba stopped and said, “Krsna from Maharlika – yes, I know him. He has a lot of energy.”

And then He took the garland and as He went to his car I spoke to Him. I said, “Baba,” and He put his face very close to mine and said, “Yes?”

His face was so close that I could see through His thick glasses, I could see His eyes. The eyes, they were so unbelievable, I have not ever seen eyes like that – they were so bright and shiny!

And I said, “Baba,” and He said, “Yes?”

“Do you have any message for the people in Maharlika, for the margiis in Maharlika?”

And He said, “Yes. Tell them to do all the good they can for the suffering humanity.”

I said, “OK, Baba. I will tell them.” And then I left. That was my first brief and wonderful encounter with Baba.

Then I had the opportunity to go again to Kolkata, by Baba’s grace, in 1988. This was the time of *microvita* and Baba was giving all kinds of demonstrations on *microvita* among wholetimers – some of whom I knew. It was very interesting, because in one of the demonstrations, our beloved Dada Nityasatyananda was there, and Baba was doing a demonstration with Dada.

It was for LFT brothers only, and Baba said, “Let an advanced soul come forward.” And GS was looking and tapped Dada Nityasatyananda on the shoulder and said, “Come here.” And then Baba asked Dada Nityasatyananda to undress.

Baba then took his stick and touched different parts of Dada’s body and said, “I am now taking out your shame, your shyness, your fear. Now tell me, do you feel any shyness, any shame or fear?”

And Dada said, “No, Baba.”

Baba also said at that particular darshan that *Parama Purusa* can liberate anybody, liberate the entire universe if He wants to. He can take all the propensities and liberate anybody if He wants to. But He doesn’t want to do it, for the evolution of the universe. And I think that was a time that I had a lot of inner conflict with the organization – “Why are we doing this? Why are we doing that?” But from this darshan I learned that this is all the play of *Parama Purusa* and He wants all of this to happen. If He wanted, He could get rid of all of this and collapse the entire universe but *Parama Purusa* doesn’t want to do that. He wants the evolution of the universe to keep on going.

The circumstances by which I got my PC were also very funny in a way because I went there as a Prout LFT. But at that time Baba was objecting to the Prout organization because it wasn’t performing very well. A lot of the Prout acaryas had their acaryaship removed and there was no PC for Prout LFTs. So I was waiting for more than ten days – that was in March of 1988 – to get my PC, and my name was on the list but I wasn’t allowed to go further because of the so-called ban on Prout workers, because they had not been performing well, in Baba’s eyes.

So I went to the senior central worker of ERAWS and told him, “You know, I’ve been here and I’m actually married with two children but I’m still working full time for the organization. This is the second time I’m working for the organization but I’m married and sacrificing and then you tell me that I cannot see Baba.”

And this central ERAWS dada said, “OK. Your name is Krsna Kumar and you are an ERAWS worker. Tomorrow you will see Baba.” I think he was touched by my sincerity and the next day I was next in line to see Baba – ten in the morning, March 10, 1988.

When I came into the room. I did *sastaung pranam* to Baba and He said, “Come here my boy. Come close.”

He asked me, “Did you come here alone?”

And my first knee-jerk reaction was to say, “Yes, Baba.”

Then He said, “Really?”

And then I remember coming through Bangkok airport on my way to Kolkata, I was in line to get a ticket and on the left side of me was a man who looked exactly like Baba. And as this was flashing through my mind as Baba was asking me this question I thought, “No, no, no – this can’t be! This is too much!” I had looked at his baggage and he was some kind of doctor. The man wasn’t paying attention to me at all – glasses, white kurta, and everything and he was also in line for his ticket. I thought, “No, no, it can’t be! I mean this is too much!”

And then Baba asked again, “Did you come here alone?”

And I said, “No, Baba. I don’t think I came here alone.”

Then Baba said, “Come closer.” And Baba took my head and massaged it. I don’t know, maybe He was correcting some loose screws! Then He asked me to put my hands like this, and He asked me to promise to follow 16 points closely and to do all the good I can for the entire cosmological order.

“OK, Baba. I promise.”

The first time I saw Him He said to do good for the entire humanity. The second time I saw Him He said to do good for the ENTIRE cosmological order! Sometimes I can’t even take care of myself and now He asked me this promise! But that was my PC with Baba.

And all through that time I had very good experiences and I realized that as you come closer to Baba you realize that it’s not a human being. I had many experiences that as I was looking at Baba, especially during darshan, I did not see a person. It was like an outline of a person but if I looked through it, inside that outline was the entire universe.

Vishvadeva

Eugene, Oregon

I was initiated in 1971 by Ac. Yatiishvarananda in the U.S.

From 1980 through 1990 every winter I went to India. The third time I went I decided I preferred spending more time with Baba with less people there and not going to the big DMC. And so I left in November; it was winter time. Before I left I the called sectorial office and asked if there was anything I should be aware of.

The dada who answered said, “If you like, you can bring a plant.” This was fairly early in the time that Baba was asking margiis to bring plants to India. So even though I wanted to be a *tantrika*, and be brave, I also thought, “If I bring a plant, I may get trouble from the immigration, they may even know I’m a margii, who else is bringing plants? So, I’m not going to do it, I’m just going to go.”

My flight stopped in New York City, and at the airport to my surprise Dada Yatiishvarananda was walking by, coming back from India. He asked me what I was doing. He said, “I hope you’re bringing a plant. Baba will be very upset if you don’t bring a plant.”

“Oh.”

This was Sunday, it was very cold and there was snow in New York, there was no place in the airport that sold plants, so I thought, I really somehow have to get a plant. I went outside the airport and looked around. I couldn’t really find anything outside the airport, but I found some pine cones that had fallen down, and I thought at least these are seeds, maybe this will be good enough. I stuffed them in the bottom of my sleeping bag, and thought, “I’ll see what happens.”

I arrived in Kolkata and at Baba’s house saw Dada Ramananda. He asked, “Have you brought a plant?”

I said, “Dada, I brought these pine cones.”

He shook his head and said, “No, this is not a plant.”

I started to feel a little bad that I hadn’t brought a plant, first of all that I’d been a little cowardly, and I thought it was not considered very good that I didn’t bring a plant. I

saw Baba, and didn't get a chance to talk with him, but Dada informed me that Baba was disappointed that I hadn't brought a plant.

Baba was a bit ill at the time, and they hadn't had Sunday darshan for a few weeks. Sunday came and all of a sudden, though no one was ready, no one expected that Baba was going to give darshan, suddenly Baba was coming for darshan.

All was in turmoil. Usually there would be some margiis dancing *kaoshikii* and *tandava*. On my first trip I had danced *tandava* in front of Baba, and I wanted to do it again. I usually enjoyed doing it at *Dharma Maha Cakra* and it assured me a good seat near Baba. I hadn't ever danced *kaoshikii* before Baba, and I didn't know it very well. It was new at that time. I thought I should do *kaoshikii* but I didn't have the proper clothes – there was a uniform for it. Two Indian brothers in normal clothes were going to dance, so I thought I could also do it, and I volunteered. I was still feeling kind of bad that I hadn't brought the plant, but I thought, “OK, I'm going to dance *kaoshikii* before Baba.”

It started – I was inexperienced with *kaoshikii*, and also inexperienced with the rhythm of the didi who was leading it; it seemed very sort of herky-jerky to me and I couldn't follow. When I was supposed to go up, I went down, when I was supposed to go left, I went right. I was bumping into a post there. I did everything completely wrong.

After it was over, we sat down, Baba said something in Bengali, and everyone laughed. I wondered what Baba had said. I asked one dada very quietly.

“Baba said that in spite of numerous defects, it was still very nice.”

Somehow when He said that, I got a very special feeling, I felt very loved. Because I realized that even though I was not a perfect yogi, that I was not as brave as I could be, I had made some effort and Baba still loved me and loved everyone in spite of all our imperfections. I couldn't stop laughing and smiling for some time after that.

I try to remember that experience whenever I become too self-critical and tend to be negative, because a yogi needs to be positive, and not feel that “I have this defect, that defect, God doesn't love me, I'm not going to be able to achieve my goal.” And so that has been helpful to me.

When I became a margii in 1971, I was aware that most people had Sanskrit names. But I felt this should not be some kind of fad – “Oh, I got initiated, and I'm going

to have a Sanskrit name, and I'm going to go play yogi for a year and then I'm going to do something else." No. It was a full three years before I felt ready to get a Sanskrit name. Also, I had a secret desire to get a name from Baba, that was another reason I was waiting, but Baba at the time was in jail and we didn't know when He was going to get out.

So given those uncertain circumstances I found one *acarya* whom I felt comfortable with, and liked a lot, and said to him, "Can you give me a name?"

However, I still had some prejudices about Sanskrit names. I told him there was a certain sort of name that I didn't want to get. He said he would think about it for a few days. And after one day, he said, "I've got the first part, but I don't have the second part yet. I'm still working on it."

Finally he said, "I have the complete name, your name is Vishvashakti." The power, the force of the universe, that's a very powerful name. I liked that name, but at the back of my mind, I had the thought that Shakti is the female principle, is that really a correct Sanskrit name for a male?

A number of years later when I saw Baba for the first time, He asked me my name. I had Personal Contact, but afterwards I was always thinking, "Is there something wrong with my name? I would like Baba to tell me about my name."

It was always in the back of my mind. Also, basically as a trick to see if I could get some attention from Baba, I asked Dada Ramananda if he would ask Baba if my name was correct. Each time he assured me my name was fine. I went each winter to India, had many interactions with Baba, and He never said anything at all about my name.

I went again and as I got there, some margiis were saying some people had gotten a second PC. I knew the rule was that margiis got one PC in a lifetime. And sometimes it was difficult to get even one PC –you had to promise to start ten schools and do long sadhana and all these things – and other times it was fairly easy. I had never thought I could get a second one, and when I heard this the wheels started turning in my mind.

There was one brother who had gone to *acarya* training, and left, and had changed his name and somehow had gotten in to see Baba for a second PC. Another brother from

Italy had by trickery managed to get a second PC. I thought, if these people are getting PC, I should maybe consider it, too.

The Sectorial Secretary (SS) of Berlin Sector came up to me and asked, “Have you ever had PC?” I was in a dilemma. I don’t like to lie; in the long run being straightforward will always be the best policy. But I didn’t want to be stupid, either. I didn’t want to miss a chance for another PC because of my attachment to always being honest.

So I just mumbled. I didn’t say anything one way or the other. When I came for my first PC there was a different Personal Assistant (PA) to Baba. The General Secretary (GS) was also different, and neither of them were there, nor was my SS. No one knew, except Baba, that I had had PC. I asked several *acaryas* whom I respected what I should do, and they all said, “When it comes to personal matters with Baba, there are no rules. If Baba wants to give you PC, He will. If He doesn’t, He won’t. Give it a try.”

So a few days went by, and one *dada* said, “Come, Baba’s going to give PC this morning, we’ll wait together.” While I was waiting, one brother who had just had PC came in and I asked him how his PC was. “Baba gave me some long vow to take, I don’t remember it.” In my mind I thought, “What kind of idiot is this, his guru is giving him a serious vow to take, and he doesn’t even remember it?”

Then we went to Baba’s house. I was sitting there, thinking it looks like I will get PC. The SS came out and said, “Baba does not accept your name.”

And I thought, “Oh, how I have humiliated myself. Baba doesn’t accept my name for PC. I should never have tried to play this game. Baba is probably upset with me.”

Then he said, “Baba says your name should be Vishvadeva. That Vishvashakti is not the proper name.”

All of a sudden I went from the depths to the heights, and then I was inside with Baba. And He asked me, “What’s your name?”

I said, “Vishvadeva, Baba.”

And He said, “Very good name!”

I started to laugh and cry at the same time. It was so funny. You just gave me the name, Baba, you should approve of it as a good name! Baba gave me a very long vow to take, and I do remember it included such things as to serve humanity, and help the world,

but I also couldn't remember the exact vow, it was too long, and I felt more humble than when I had criticized the other brother.

Baba also asked if I deserved punishment, and I said yes, and He asked me to raise my arms. But then Baba said, "No, you don't need to have punishment, you're sincere." I don't know if that was good or bad, because it probably would have removed some of my *samskaras*, but it was Baba's will and I accept it as such.

It was only a long time after that I remembered the story of how I had originally asked for my name, that I had always wanted Baba to give me a name.

I had said to the dada, "Please don't give me a name with a Deva, I don't like that." So at the same time, I had prevented myself from getting the right name, and Baba had fulfilled my desires by giving me a name. It completed a cycle, and I could only laugh how after all those years all those things had interconnected at one point.

Maitri

Portland, Oregon

In 1977, I was in the training center in Davao, Philippines. While at the training center, I got very sick with asthma. Our trainer, Dada Cidananda, put me on a strict milk-and-honey diet. I had this stuff three times a day and I loved it, except I was not getting any better at all. In fact, I was getting worse. I did not know at that time that I was very allergic to dairy. It got to the point where I couldn't lie down anymore. I could only sit up.

One late night, I was having a bad episode and I was sitting down on the bench by the dining table. I was very tired, so I rested my head on my folded arms, which were resting on the table, and tried to sleep. In the same room was a sister trainee who took care of me whenever my asthma attack was bad. She was dozing off also, when she was awakened by something she felt. When she opened her eyes, she saw Baba floating towards me. He was wearing a white shirt and was seemingly enshrouded by white clouds. She said only Baba's upper torso was visible. She watched Him floating towards where I was and stop by my side. He stooped down, giving an impression of inquiring how I was. Then He floated away and disappeared.

The following day, when she told me about this, I felt blessed. Although the asthma did not go away, I felt happy knowing that Baba cared. I did not finish the whole timer training because of poor health, but I'm very grateful of the chance to experience life in the training center.

Mayatiita

Mankato, Minnesota

I was initiated in Oct. '73 by Dada Yatiishvarananda. The first time I went to India was winter of '78. Dadaji wrote me a nice letter of introduction to increase my chances of getting Personal Contact, which I lost somewhere along the way. So I met Dadaji Tadbhavananda, who wrote me another letter, in which he said, "Mayatiita works more than an LFT." I found out later that one of the requirements for getting PC was to be an LFT.

Anyway, I arrived in Kolkata, went to Baba's quarters, and found some of the requirements for getting PC were to be either a college graduate or an LFT. I was still a student at that time, not a college graduate. I'd had a very strong feeling that I was just going to go in and get PC; it had never occurred to me that there might be any complication to my going in to see my Baba. So I started getting a little concerned, and I presented Dada Ramananda with Dada's letter, which was obviously exaggerated with my accomplishments. He was looking at it with great skepticism [laughs]. I got to know some of the other people there and realized some people had been waiting for months without getting to see Baba. I started feeling some inferiority complex, that maybe I wasn't good enough to see Him.

So I started doing sadhana, and calling out to Baba, "Baba, if I've done something wrong, it's your responsibility to give me guidance."

Actually I was just there a very short time, it was my first day there, and when it was time for Baba to give PC, Dada Ramananda called me first. So, it was a very surreal experience for me, but very special. I went into Baba's room, and Dada had to remind me to do *sastaung pranam*. I did that, then I looked up at Baba; it was almost hard for me to get Him into my focus, for my eyes to comprehend Him, and I felt like I almost floated over to sit in front of Him. He asked my name. Then He said, "Do you want to be a good boy, or a very good boy?"

"Very good boy, Baba."

"And if I give you punishment for the bad things you've done..."

"I'd be grateful, Baba."

I wasn't afraid at all. Then I remember Baba just beaming down on me. I was looking up into His face and He had this most beautiful smile, and it seemed a long time that I was looking at Him, just beaming pure love down on me. I had the feeling that love surrounded us in the room, almost like a physical substance you could slice through, the love in the room was just so thick. So that seemed to last for a long time. He had this beautiful look on His face, and then held His hand over my head for a while, then to one side, and then the other side.

He said, "I'll give you punishment at the proper time. Now go."

Being very obedient, I left immediately, and sat down outside, and waves and waves of bliss overcame my body, and I had great difficulty just sitting up. I was in the state it seemed for a long time. Finally Baba's PA called me over and gave me some duties.

Dada Sarvabodhanandaji was there and said it was very, very short. It didn't seem like that, but the whole experience was probably about two minutes. Of course it was very special to me.

It would be many years before Baba gave me the realization of what had occurred there. It happened very shortly after He left His physical body, which was fairly devastating to me, the first time that I really experienced a loss. In any case, I was at the next retreat. All of us were still grieving. I sat down to do sadhana and a feeling kind of came over me, a similar feeling to when I left Baba's room. And I just had the feeling that I knew exactly what I needed to do to express the grief in a concrete way, and also as a kind of penance. I felt it was kind of a message, clear to me, what I had to do. So for one year, every Saturday morning, I would maintain silence (as much as my children would allow me) and I also fasted four times a month, instead of my usual two times. I maintained that program for myself for the year. I felt that was Baba giving me the punishment at the proper time.

And I had always wondered what was the meaning of the blessing Baba had given me. I asked my *acarya* if he knew, but he had no idea. The following year I came to the retreat at Ananda Kanan. At the closing ceremony, I closed my eyes to do a little sadhana; there was a nice feeling in the room. Then all of a sudden out of nowhere I got again this feeling of being immediately in Baba's presence, exactly that sensation as after

PC, that extremely powerful vibration coursing through my body. Then I heard a voice internally, very clearly though very soft... it said, "You will never forget me."

And after that came the realization that that was the blessing that Baba gave to me in PC, that under any circumstances I would never forget Him. The enormity of that was exactly what I needed. I was living under difficult circumstances, and isolated from the flow of AM, and it could happen very easily. But Baba would not allow it.

On my first trip, I got the opportunity to fly in an airplane with Baba, from Kolkata to Patna. I had the desire to try to get close to Baba some way, but didn't know how to do it. I was sitting some distance from him, so I made a plan in my head, as soon as we landed to say something to Baba.

He frustrated my plan [laughs]. I got up and went over near Him quickly and said, "Did you have a good flight, Baba?" And He just kind of laughed at me and walked away. So I was actually one of the last ones to get off the flight, and we were to get on a shuttle bus to go to the terminal, and as I got on, Baba was sitting directly in front of me. He gave me a big namaskar, and a big smile.

During that flight, the stewardess would bring sandwiches around. It was a full moon day. She came to Baba, and He said, "No, no, we're fasting." So of course everyone else followed Baba's lead, even the general margiis. And a kind of unworthy thought came to my mind that some of these fellows had never fasted in their lives.

I got kind of greedy for free food also, so when the waitress asked me, "Would you like a sandwich?" I said sure. It was awful. The moral of the story is always follow Baba's example.

I had come for *Bhukti Pradhan* reporting, to represent Prout. It was a long time until Baba was finally ready to have reporting. There were BPs from all over India, as well as foreigners such as myself. He was asking people things unrelated to their work. At the time Baba was giving discourses on the *cakras*, and the relation between *cakras* and plexii, and what He called *padma*. I had overheard an *acarya* earlier in the day talking about some of the things Baba had given on the subject. Reporting time came, everyone was rushing in, people wanted to be close, there was some pushing and shoving

to get closer to Baba, and that seemed a little bit unseemly to me. I didn't want to participate and didn't try to force my way to the front.

But I felt something of a desire to report to Baba. Three other brothers were selected to report; they went in front, and He asked the question, "What is the difference between *cakra*, *padma* and plexus?"

None could answer, and everyone was disturbed. Someone had to ask, "Who here can answer the question?" Suddenly I found myself in front, not sure how I got there, and I raised my hand. The answer had something to do with plexus is something more subtle than a *cakra*, and *padma* is a more poetic kind of expression for the *cakras*. It was close to what Baba was saying earlier.

Baba said, "This boy said something of value, though not very clearly" [laughs]. That reporting session was over.

In Patna, Baba was giving discourses as a followup to the DMC, in a park in a public building. One snake charmer had the misfortune of bringing his snakes for a show, which the margiis enjoyed. But that gave some of them an idea. Of course, every time Baba came out the margiis would perform *tandava* for him. They took this man's snakes, at least the nonpoisonous ones to hold in the left hand as they were doing *tandava*. It was just really hilarious. They were mostly these middle-aged man, who were quite a bit overweight, and they were holding these poor snakes that were swinging from side to side as they did *tandava*. So, Baba, ever polite, afterwards said, "Very unique." But then He corrected them, "But if you use snake, you should use venomous snake."

During the DMC I saw one thing that at the time I didn't think much of. In Baba's atmosphere things that would seem miraculous to the common person, you just took in stride and it seemed very normal. I saw a kundalini experience when Baba gave *varabhaya mudra*. One Italian brother – before this Baba had given him a flower from His garland – anyway at that moment this brother shot up like a rocket. Some other spiritual groups talk about floating. He literally shot up like a rocket, with that speed, and landed about 20 feet away in the laps of some *acaryas*. It just seemed like a very normal

thing at the time. Now, I'm thinking that was a fairly unusual kind of occurrence [laughs].

In Jamaica, they put on a very dramatic *tandava* demonstration, with actual flaming torches. Immediately afterwards Baba said "Bravo." So of course people started applauding. And Baba stopped them, saying, "No, no, no, you don't applaud at a spiritual function." Something we should remember.

The sweetest I've ever seen Baba, was in Jamaica. It was a very happy vibration there. During the DMC He gave His *mudra*, and it was the first time I'd really experienced the power of His *mudra*. I was put into a state of bliss, and was sobbing for a long time afterwards, from the vibration. It seemed particularly sweet. After He did this *mudra*, He said, "Let everyone be happy, Let everyone see the bright side of things." Then He got up to leave – usually He leaves very quickly – but there was such a devotional feeling in this room, everybody got up and started calling Baba. So He paused, and it was such a nice interaction, people were enjoying His presence, and it was evident Baba was enjoying the company of the margiis. He was just shaking His head back and forth and had a big smile on His face. That's one of the images of Baba I keep in my mind.

Jyotirmayii

[Editor's note: Sister Jyotirmayii passed away in the summer of 2003. She was living in Ojai, California at the time. An LFT and sincere devotee, she will be missed.]

Before I transition, I'm going to record as many of my experiences as I can since I was blessed by Baba by encountering His Mission on Thanksgiving weekend, 1973. My life instantly changed. I realized the vastness of the whole mystery of "God," a word I associated up to that time with a limited, divisive concept. I was always searching for a spiritual base, though. When Dada Yatiishvarananda initiated me, I knew that the concept was more than the human mind could grasp, but that was perfectly okay!

Clash went along with my new peace and contentment. My husband and parents went into a reaction from which they never recovered and after seven years, I left my husband. (My children were all grown by then). I was never able to share much of depth with my parents.

My first experience of Baba was a dream, after a difficult day of haranguing by my husband at the time when Baba was imprisoned. Baba was standing in front of a small white cell. He handed me a piece of paper, saying, "Here are recipes for sweets to help you through difficult times..." It was a very special type of paper, "onionskin," a kind we used to use in drawing classes and rarely see. It was folded meticulously into quarters. I wondered at the significance of this particular paper and its form, so I kept this in my mind. The answer came years later when I was in LFT/Prout training in Los Altos Hills with Dada Nityashuddhananda in 1980. Near the end of the training, he pulled out a sheet of onionskin, neatly folded into quarters and read us the meaning of *Taraka Brahma*.

Shortly after initiation, I had another intense dream. My parents and husband had put me through what seemed to me an inquisition, trying to persuade me to get into some other religion, to give up my choice. My parents left for home. I was crying and feeling depressed. I spent the whole day doing sadhana. My husband had gone back to work in L.A. That night I dreamed I was in a building, looking out the front second-story window, watching Baba get out of a car and walking to the front door. Margiis were

sitting in the large room arranged for darshan, with a platform in the front. Baba walked out and for the first time I saw Him so clearly, in total detail. I'd never seen a full picture of Him, so I didn't know what He looked like exactly. He was dressed in a creamy white *dhoti*, with a shawl draped about one shoulder. I studied his hands, strong and powerful. He had by His side a staff shaped like a lightning bolt. He was exactly Baba as we know His physical form. He gave a discourse on greed. My parents were sitting on chairs along the wall on my left side, and kept an unrelated conversation running. I turned to them and said, "If you don't be quiet you'll have to leave the room." Baba continued His discourse, then walked to me, and touched me right on my *cakra*. I fell back. This was to be my personal contact – I was never able to receive another, though I tried many times, but this was perfect.

I continued my practices faithfully, as my personal family life continued to be very difficult. We moved to a town 100 miles from L.A., and my husband continued working there, staying away two nights a week. This was Baba's grace, as I could at last attend *dharmacakra* with a great group of margiis in Santa Barbara. It was a wonderful time on the spiritual level. When I had bad days, I would wake at night with a radiant sensation of loving, supportive energy.

Almost seven years passed, and suddenly things changed. I heard of a Prout training to be held in the Los Altos *jagrti*. I just got in my car and drove up there one afternoon. I must have left a note but I don't remember! The training session was wonderful. I have always been totally turned off by the inherent weaknesses of our political system, and of capitalism. Prout's total philosophy makes complete sense to me.

Baba would be coming to the U. S. so there were margiis and *acaryas* from everywhere there, all preparing for this visit. We gardened, prepared a beautiful room for Him, studied, and did long kiirtans. On the night before His arrival, everyone was so tired that we didn't do an all-night kiirtan. I woke early, and was told that He was refused entry. Such disappointment! I could hardly believe it! I have always felt that if we had done kiirtan all night, He would have come...

After all this, I ended up going back to my family. My husband promised to change, but he couldn't keep it up for much more than a week. But soon after, I did get to see Baba when He went to Jamaica. That was a beautiful experience, running down many

times a day from the hotel to His house, being so close to Him. The wonderful DCs, hearing and seeing Him at last. And He looked just as I had seen Him in my dream.

The next spring, I left home for good and moved to the Los Altos *jagrti*, where I stayed for over three years. In 1980 I started a new life, free to follow Baba's path of bliss! Soon more wonderful experiences came – I could finally go to India for DMC. Margiis arranged a flight for just before Christmas and I was able to sell my car for ticket money just in time. I had broken my ankle in November, so I went off in a fiberglass cast from foot to knee. I could walk without any pain, so I was eager to go.

India was immediately “home” to me. I spent the next three months in total bliss to be there, even though it started out with such stress. The two brothers that I went with didn't think to bring the Central Office address! So we searched fruitlessly for a couple days around Kolkata, then jumped on a madly crowded overnight train to Ranchi. Luckily we found someone who knew of the AM center there, so we joined margiis headed for DMC. The police met us at Pundag Station and took our names, but we then dashed into Ananda Nagar at last to see Baba again.

The next days were filled with such peaceful joy, surrounded by thousand of margiis, squeezed into a tiny space, waiting for darshan, kiirtan, meeting margiis from India and everywhere else. Baba filled our lives.

Suddenly DMC ended. We rushed, packing up and piling into conveyances. Fourteen of us crowded on a jeep and took off, headed north for Bokaro (the steel city). Immediately, the jeep broke down. A big open-backed truck came by, and gave us all a ride. We stayed with a margii family in Bokaro overnight, then a few of us led by Devashisa, rode a bus all day to Jamalpur.

Since reading a series of books on Krsna's life, I had a great desire to visit Mathura, where he spent so much of His life, but that desire left when I had been in Jamalpur. I was completely satisfied. There was so much to see and feel – the vibration of the early days of Baba's life and mission. We meditated at the Tiger's Grave, visited the house where Baba lived – so simple, so peaceful. Baba fulfilled my dreams even to visit Varanasi, where two sisters and I went before returning to Kolkata.

The next three months were filled with so many personal experiences with Baba. In those days, there weren't such large numbers of margiis and we had much closer

contact with Baba on a daily basis. We all attended morning darshan at the Central office to hear Baba's discourses, usually in Hindi or Bengali. We waited in front to greet Him when He arrived. In the evening we again waited at His house in Lake Gardens while He went out for field walk. During the day we could stand by the front garden. While He walked among us sometimes He would stop and talk to us.

During this three-month stay, I lived with other margii sisters at the didis' house and Didi Ananda Bharati, the first *avadhutika*, a loving and inspiring being. We slept in a stone room on straw mats. In the evenings, when we all trekked across Lake Gardens to Baba's house for field walk, we were always filled with excitement and anticipation. One night, a German margii sister was so anxious that Baba would give her some recognition that she could hardly contain herself. I thought to myself, "Well I know that He won't notice me!" When Baba returned from His walk, He got out of the car, walked to us, turned right in front of me, looked into my eyes and gave me a deep namaskar!

Another evening, we had seen Baba leave on walk, and I sat on a bench inside the garage space, thinking how tired I was and wondering how I could ever walk all the way back to our room that night and I almost fell asleep. Just then Baba's car neared the gate and we all jumped up and lined up along the walk. Baba got out, walked up to me, stopped right before me, leaned forward in namaskar, saying "Ahhhh..." with a powerful sighing sound. Jayanta and another Australian brother exclaimed after, "Did you feel that?" We were all uplifted with energy. We flew back to our places that night, laughing with joy. I was totally oblivious to my leg cast.

I spent some more time being near Baba, then thought that I should either go home or travel a bit to satisfy my desire to see more of India. Without making a conscious choice, I found myself on the way to the train ticket office. There I bought a three-week pass for travel and soon left for travels through north India, and thanks to Baba, some memorable experiences – meeting interesting spiritual people, visiting senior margiis and training centers, having challenging clashes. I stayed in Delhi, traveled to Agra, Jaipur and Kathmandu, before returning "home" to Kolkata, the big *samskara* satisfied. There I stayed until late March enjoying being with Baba.

One morning two sisters and I were standing outside a side door into the Central Office when Baba returned from His walk. When He reached the door He stopped before

us and asked, “And what do these sisters say?” We stood there probably with our mouths hanging open, and He answered His question – “They say nothing,” smiled, and went in the door.

He would walk among us in the front garden of His house in those early days, often stopping to speak on different subjects. One day I remember He spoke of languages – Spanish and Catalan and their differences and relationship. (It was, coincidentally, a subject that was of interest to me). Another time, when it was almost time to leave, I told him that I was to return home and asked if He could give a message to American margiis. Baba replied, “Tell them to continue working on all levels – physical, mental, and spiritual.”

The morning came when it was time to leave. Two brothers from Singapore were also taking a taxi to the airport and we were hoping to see Baba and talk to Him one more time. We thought we could if He came directly out instead of slowly making His way out, which He always did. Of course Baba can fulfill any wish, so He came directly out to us so that we could tell Him namaskar.

I stayed in Los Altos until the end of summer of ’83, when Didi Tripti (Girl’s Prout Secretary) asked me to go to Kansas City, Missouri to help Mukti put out a newsletter and work for GP. I took a three-month leave from my job in the Physics Dept. at Stanford University and went off.

After these three months, I ended up quitting my Stanford job (by turning it over to another margii) and moving to Kansas City. Mukti left for *acarya* training and Kamala came. This was a wonderful period of two and a half years of total immersion in Baba’s flow! We put out a newsletter every weekday, writing it, formatting and printing it, then distributing it to colleges and sites around town. We also distributed government surplus commodities to the eligible – tons of cheese, flour, peanut butter, etc. This upset our landlady so much that we had to move so we scraped up money and bought our own house, a three-story late Victorian in a great area for our work. We were involved in community, Latin and Native American issues. They were very exciting times. One of our greatest challenges was the gathering and shipping of plants for Baba’s garden. This

was really a big job! Now when you see the collection at Lake Gardens and Tiljala, you can see the results of margii's devotional efforts.

During the years of '83 to '88, I traveled three more times to India. Since I was an LFT during part of this time, I was there for only two or three weeks each time, either for reporting or winter or May DMC. The first DMC was in Ranchi, where I fulfilled another desire – to dance *kaoshikii* before Baba (even though I had a broken toe this time). During another trip, after Baba had introduced *Prabhat Samgiit*, we all sat around Him in Lake Gardens and sang these beautiful songs to Him. I sat there, singing and crying with joy – a dream come true.

On one of my last visits, I was given a demonstration of His constant attention to each of us. I was feeling very sad that, since there were so many margiis around by this time, we couldn't feel so close to Him personally and get the attention we'd had. I was staying over in Queens, the WWD office, on the way back to Kansas City. One morning, one *acarya* said that Central office had called, very upset, saying that Baba said a NY sector LFT had been using face powder and drinking alcoholic drinks. They asked Him if the person should be expelled and He said no.

I felt absolutely no connection to this for a short while. Then I remembered. I had gone to Delhi to do my usual buying expedition for our GP office sales. Giita, from Australia, and I would dress up like the usual tourist and I'd put on some makeup! I also remembered having a horrible headache one afternoon and going into a homeopathic store for help. They brought me a teacup of water with a very strong remedy in alcohol. It cured the headache, though! I laughed with such relief in the knowledge that Baba is never unaware of our deepest feelings (and doings)! This one experience seems to sum up how close He is to us always – and reminds me of His playfulness.

There is so much that I could say about my last thirty years as a devotee, so many reasons that I have had for being on this path, but now, at the end, I know that it is all just opening up to being in unconditional love with no boundaries.

Viveka

Albany, New York

I grew up in a religious family, but went to university and studied science, and science is very agnostic, so my religious faith fell away. I became a little bit disillusioned with science during the turmoil of the late '60s and early '70s. I was becoming fascinated with the mind, and consciousness. When I first came to a meditation class in 1972, I was looking for more of the impersonal consciousness, not at all a personal guru. I lost track of my original *acarya*, and about a year later Dada Yatiishvarananda took over being my *acarya* and gave me more lessons.

After I got initiated, I went to *dharmacakra* and retreats for a few months. Then I was traveling with my family, and doing my sadhana on my own, with *nama mantra*. We traveled across the country and reached Berkeley, California. In 1973, I started going to *dharmacakra* there. The energy there was kind of high. I really hadn't known the format, I was new, and nobody knew who I was. None of the *acaryas* knew me. And I became very clashed out with *guru puja*. Some of the people were being overly demonstrative – they were throwing themselves in front of Baba's picture. I still had the mind of a scientist, that logical mind. I didn't want another Jesus in my life, I wanted that consciousness. And it disturbed me very much.

So one afternoon I was trying to put my two-year-old to sleep. Despite the fact I was clashed out, I was always very regular in doing my sadhana twice a day. That day I couldn't concentrate at all, my mind was all over the place, and I started to daydream. The interesting thing about this experience is how ordinary it was, it was very much an ordinary daydream.

All of a sudden I felt I could see this light in the distance, and it became clearer and clearer, like a camera zooming in. And I saw the light was coming from a man. I knew who it was, I knew it was Baba. He came closer and He was holding up a frame, like a doorframe, and the light was coming out of that. And the thought just sort of came in my mind, spontaneously, "Don't get hung up on my image, I'm just holding the door open." This was a time when Baba was half a world away, no *acarya* knew who I was, but Baba somehow knew it was just what I needed to hear.

My relationship with Baba grew very slowly after that. For a long time that image – that I don't have to worry about guru, people telling all these Baba stories, and I don't relate to them – it was OK. But having children in those days – in New York sector there were very few margiis with children – I never really felt that much in the flow. I remember a few years later in Los Altos, there were a lot of activities going on, and I was feeling this kind of separation and loneliness, as if I didn't fit. And all of a sudden, in the middle of a meal, or something, I just got this image in my mind of a galaxy spiraling out, and in the middle was Baba, swirling right tight with Him were all the dadas and didis, and coming out further were people at different levels of involvement, and I felt myself there, very much at the edge. And the thought came to me, it's at the edge that I touch the rest of the world, the edge is very important to me. It's at the edge that I connect.

It took six or seven years before I got sixth lesson. And *Dharma Samiksa* was coming up and I thought maybe I should go, and there was always this thing in my mind, "Oh, I can't go to India." All of a sudden *Dharma Samiksa* was stopped, and I promised myself the next time I got the chance I would go.

In 1986, Dada Sumantrananda said, "Baba's giving Personal Contact (PC) now." If my wife agrees, I told myself, I'd go. She was reluctant, but said OK. Because of family and work, I only had ten days, including travel time. The first thing I found out was, people had been waiting for months to see Baba. And this was very discouraging.

We were on field walk, and people would all crowd together just to watch Baba get in and out of a car. If you step back from a spiritual perspective, it almost seems kind of silly. And I kind of had that feeling when Baba was coming back. He was not in a good mood, and He had a scowl on His face. He walked slowly, and all of a sudden I thought, "Oh my God, I've been following a despot all these years." It was the same clash I'd had before – do I really need a guru? I was very clashed the first time I saw Baba. But it was all stick it out, what else can one do? I was there in Lake Gardens.

So next walk, I got up there with some trepidation, and He was giving namaskar to this whole line of people, He was giving a sweeping namaskar. And I must've been somewhere in the middle, and as His namaskar got to me, I just felt this wave coming out

from Him; it's so hard to describe. After that, I was up there for every field walk, wanting to get a good spot.

Then the struggle came on, waiting for PC, and I said to the dada, "You've got to get me on the list."

And he said, "These people have been waiting for a long time." And all of a sudden my service began to look very small. I was discouraged. I was with Vishvamitra in a hotel, and we liked to walk. We were walking, and he told me how he'd gotten scolded the day before. He was at field walk, and as Baba got out of the car, he'd called out "Babaji!" and Baba gave namaskar. But one of the dadas came up and said you should never do that. When you call out, Baba has to respond.

And suddenly a light bulb went on over my head. Here He is, the Lord of the universe, but if we call out, He's helpless and has to respond. Just as a parent is running the household, when the child calls out, the parent drops everything. He has no choice. And once I realized that, I just went and sat outside His house in sixth lesson for two hours. I said to Him, "Baba, I want to see you. I want to see you." I got more and more intense. As a result, I got on the list.

The day before I was supposed to leave, I was at the end of the line. It was a long line. One brother would come out, in some other place, and then we'd all move up. Finally I got to the top of the stairs. The Personal Assistant came out and said, "Please come back tomorrow." My mouth must've dropped, because I was leaving the next day. He went in and talked to Baba, some exchange in Bengali, and he came back. OK.

Baba's room seemed to be filled with light, with blinding light. I seem to remember He had a fish tank, too. I did *sastaung pranam*.

He said, "Come here, my boy."

Then, "Move back a little further, I need to see all your *cakras*."

Then He asked for my name, and I was never very good with Sanskrit, so I said Viveka.

"What?"

"Viveka."

"Spell it."

"V I V E K."

“Vivek! Discrimination. Discriminate between what is right and what is wrong. Throw out what is wrong and do what is right.” The name has always had a special meaning to me.

Then He started asking me about my ancestors. What did your father speak?
“English.”

“No, your fathers. Your forefathers.”

“Oh, Scottish.”

“Ah, the highlander dialect,” He said, as if that explained everything.

Like everybody, I heard, “You’ve done many misdeeds in the past. I need to punish you.”

“Yes, Baba.” I’d heard that when Baba punishes you, you just feel bliss.

“Raise your hands.” I was ready to feel this blissfulness. He tapped my side.

“I’m going to make this hurt, I’m going to make this really hurt.”

All of a sudden, all this fear came to me. But then He said, “How can I punish my little boy? Come, I’ll give my blessing.”

There’s no way to describe the feeling, it went so deep, deeper than I’d ever felt before. The only thing I can say is I couldn’t stop smiling. I smiled all day. I was totally happy, totally clean, like this is where I should be, and have been all along. It was a feeling that just stayed with me; the most significant thing in my life was that moment.

Every moment I remember that. Since then the relationship has only deepened. When He left, I was shocked, but also encouraged to find that the internal Baba had deepened.

Cakreshvara (2)

Baba had also given a special blessing to me during PC in the Patna jail. He said, “You will be with us for some years.”

The vibration of Baba was more important than the words, as His intent was to impress upon me that I would be with the organization for many more years to come. If I were to visit India now, my experience would be much different. At the time, due to severe illness and harsh external circumstances, Baba’s words were more of a curse since I thought that I would be in India for many more years. When I was abruptly expelled from India, it seemed like Baba meant that I would be a WT for many more years. This, too, was not my destiny and I realized that I was to be an active margii for many years.

This prophecy was an assurance several times in the following months after leaving India because I found myself more than once in hostile, life-taking situations. After initial fear, I would remember Baba’s words and fight bravely knowing that I could not be killed. Many years had not passed and I felt like one figure in the Mahabharata who could not die. What other mortal human had been given such a guarantee? Some subtle ego arose over this and I would find myself taking unwise chances knowing that no death could come.

In my next tour to Africa, one of my favorite past times was to swim in the ocean. The local population would not enter the water because of man-eating sharks and deadly undertow. I would play in the giant waves and have my clothing sanded from my body by being dragged across the sea floor. One time something very strong grabbed my leg and was about to carry me off to deep water. After an initial fear, I remembered Baba’s blessing and scolded the creature that it was powerless to cause me harm. The creature then let go its grip on me and retreated into the depths. This made me only more brave and foolish.

One day of the full moon, the waves were extremely strong. The margiis were with me on the beach and advised me not to enter the water. The transition from the beach to the deep water was abrupt and is largely responsible for the energy of waves. The undertow was obviously very dangerous that day, but I could not be harmed. Many years had not passed. I dove into the 15 foot walls of water and swam out to sea to catch

the waves and “body surf” back to shore. Maybe I would swim fearlessly among the sharks for fun.

The effort to swim out to sea was easy since the undertow did all the work for me. I spent some time riding the huge waves in and letting the sea pull me back out. Getting tired after many waves, I began to swim back to shore. After several failed attempts to reach the land, I knew that I was in trouble. My strength was weakening and the undertow was pulling me farther out to deep sea. Several years had not passed, but I was beginning to sense real fear. The margiis watched from the shore, knowing what was happening, but powerless to do anything.

All strength was gone and I was about to drown. A calm came over me and I surrendered my effort to survive. Some people talk about reliving all the events of their lives at such a moment. I had no such experience, but was in a state of clarity in which the mind was free to race a thousand times faster than normal and to analyze Baba’s words, my arrogance and my changing interpretation of His blessing. Baba could have possibly meant that I would be many years with His mission on some other world since I was about to leave this one. I mentally thought the words, “Into Your hands...”

I raised my arms in kiirtan to disappear into the ocean.

Before I could sink into the darkness, my feet landed on something solid. I was standing on a freak sandbar in the middle of nowhere. The water at this place would have been over 30 meters deep. This caused an instant change of plan from dying in detachment to an all-out fight to survive. The outline of the sandbar was only a few meters across with black depth all around. I managed to bounce back to the sandbar for some time regaining strength to attempt the swim to shore. As I began the swim, there was a momentary favorable shift in the currents as if God’s hands were guiding the waters. I was in the end literally thrown on the shore where I fell unconscious for some hours.

This was a lesson not to tempt the limit of God’s Grace, especially when the ego is involved.

Ajay

Phoenix, Arizona

My *acarya* was first Surendra Kumar, but Dada Daneshananda gave me first lesson in 1976. I was initiated March 26, 1975. I first saw Baba in Jamaica and that was a real trip. It was 1979, and I was in music school at Indiana University.

After music school, I went to Istanbul because that is where the Renaissance Universal training was. There were no LFTs, and they had no money. I had a flute I wanted to sell, but we were waiting for that money to come. We were really suffering there because we had no money. There was myself and two other Turkish guys with Dada. It was very spartan. We had only one or two meals a day. Dada had a credit account with the grocer. He had borrowed money for about two months, and the grocer was getting frustrated because he wasn't getting paid. This dada was staying there and working hard, living on practically nothing.

One day the dada was arrested for overstaying his time. He was supposed to leave every month and go to Greece. And he stayed too long, and they arrested him. I remember I just spent the whole day cleaning the *jagrti*. It was a little disorderly, and I was in a cleaning phase. I spent the whole day cleaning. The others were worrying about what to do, and I said, "Well we don't have to think too much. It's a very simple solution. When he is ready, he will get out. We just have to give him nice food and let Baba take care." Everybody was fretting about it, but just watching me clean. I was very tired. I spent from about three o'clock to nine o'clock in this one little apartment.

I was tired and I was going to wash my hands, and I said to myself, "Baba, I don't know why I am doing all of this. I am supposed to have a nice LFT training. I'm supposed to have a trainer. I don't know what this is. If you really love me, you'll do something to show me you are Supreme." It was just a thought. I was kind of in a bad mood because nothing was going right. I was having internal clash. I wanted Him to justify why I had given up so much, and why there was nothing to show for it. So I thought, "If you really love me, you will do something to show me you're Supreme."

What happened was, my hands were dirty, and I put them in the sink and the water turned on by itself. The water turned on, and when I pulled them out it went off. It

was just like the faucets in the airport. I would put them in and the water would go on. I did this three times. After that I said, “Hey, something is wrong here.” I looked under the sink and everything was okay. Then I turned the water on and it worked.

That was the one experience that convinced me that Baba was much more than I had imagined.

Anjali

Los Angeles, California

I was initiated into Ananda Marga in the Philippines on May 7, 1971, in Baguio. I read in our local newspaper that there was a free orientation conducted by one lawyer margii. I had heard of yoga, and I wondered, “What can this be all about? Anyway, it’s free. For curiosity’s sake, I’m going to find out.”

I found it was so very interesting, and I began at once to discuss with the lawyer all about what he was lecturing about. When the session finished, the lawyer said to me, “When will you be initiated?” Oh, I was caught off guard! I was only curious. I didn’t have any intention to affiliate myself. But there was a retreat coming up, and I decided to go. And that was it, the beginning! It had a great impact in my life; it was a total revolution. Revolution is complete transformation. After the retreat, which I found so very enjoyable, I went home and told my children, “This is something you must know.” After a few months, when another *acarya* came, my four children were initiated.

Things began to crop up. Dada Sumitananda initiated me, and the second day, I was clashed. Oh my God, I was a strict Roman Catholic. Did I just convert, like a Buddhist? Because during meditation we had to sit in lotus position, which was like Buddhists. Did I get converted into another religion?

I rushed to Dada Adveshananda. “Dada, did I get converted? I am a Roman Catholic. I even graduated from convent school.” I was on the verge of dropping out, right then and there.

He said, “No. You’ll be all right.” He pacified me. From then on, I blasted along on the path of *dharma*, with lightning speed, smashing into smithereens the Rock of Gibraltar of obstacles. Clash and cohesion really functioned in me, stress and relaxation, speed and pause. I coped with all this beautifully. But the struggle was there. Life is never smooth sailing, it’s always systaltic.

I was struggling hard, and after so many years of meditation, I’m still struggling, but most beautifully, savoring every minute of it. After self-purification, I’m right here, hale and sound, spiritually vibrating, to last the whole of this life, beyond, and more, into infinity.

One thing in my memory is the knowledge that I saw the Lord, Shrii Shrii Anandamurti, when He was still alive, in India. Didi Ananda Tapati, a most devoted, dynamic, and conscientious worker of Ananda Marga, took me with her in 1987.

We zoomed to India. I was looking out of the airplane window, through a cloud of foamy bubbles. There were the Himalayas, snow-covered. From Kathmandu, we proceeded to India. At that time, Ananda Margiis were persecuted by the police. Didi had to dress in Nepali clothes, and separate from me, and walk in a separate place. We made it to Tiljala, and entered a vast tent. I had to wear fully covering clothes, the required garment, to see Baba. The tent was jam-packed. We were like sardines. I felt that I would be squashed to death. It's a wonder, because there were thousands of devotees, and everyone was accommodated. Finally, Didi said, we will be seeing Baba. I occupied a three-foot space on the ground, waiting.

The Lord was announced; Shrii Shrii Anandamurti was coming to the stage. The *acaryas* were all shouting, “*Param Pita Baba Ki*,” in an endless way, and Didi positioned me right in front, and then I soaked in the vibration of that great moment. I was just looking, there was no emotion yet in me. But the Lord was finally seated. The *acaryas* let the young children do *kaoshikii*, and Baba was fondly looking at them. I was still adjusting to my environment, squished in a tiny space, among a vast multitude.

All at once – I had only heard of this – Baba was giving the *mudra*. I received that *mudra*, and it created a great impact in me. Later, back home, I said that *mudra* will last me this lifetime, and beyond, into infinity. It was the greatest thing that happened to me.

Prema Priya

When I try to think of what Baba story to tell, I wonder if I should tell of my personal visits when I saw Him in India? But my experiences with Baba started long before I ever saw His face: when I searched for Him day and night; when I called out to the heavens, “Where, oh where, is my Lord?”; when I cried and cried, and asked, “Why couldn’t I have been born when my Lord walked the earth. Oh, how much I would love to sit at His feet and listen to His stories and follow Him everywhere.”

One night He came to me, and my bedroom filled with light. He spoke to me and I was assured that He indeed was here! I knew my Lord was on earth but not where or in what form. I was delighted and in my heart I felt at peace. My questions had been answered and I knew from that moment on that my life was being guided by the unseen Hand of my Lord.

Two years passed before I was led to Ananda Marga, took initiation in 1972, and saw the face of my Guru who had guided me! I am a simple housewife and mother; I am not aware of the reason that His shower of Grace has rained so sweetly on my life so many times. I know that if the longing for Him gets so strong that I can think of nothing else for nights and days, then He just has a way of coming into my life and flooding me with His waves of Bliss to let me know that He is very near. And His Love is all there is.

My first trip to India was an eventful one for me. I had anticipated this meeting with my Guru for many years and my heart was soaring faster than the airplanes that brought me to Him. I arrived in Kolkata and the taxi brought me and another margii to Tiljala. I was told Baba was inside the compound in Ananda Nagar so off I sped to get a glimpse of Him, along with a crowd of other margiis. We sort of flowed together on our hurried walks, sometimes feet barely touching the ground beneath us. My mind was already well ahead of my body, wondering if He would grant us a glimpse of His sweet form.

We climbed up on a roof to get a view of Him in the next building. We could see Him through a small window as He strolled back and forth across the room. I found a place to sit and then fixed my gaze on His magnificent form. Yes, the sweetest face I had

ever seen. A faint smile dancing upon His lips. Joy overwhelmed me and no words could express His sweetness. After some time He left the quarters there and in a whirlwind of orange *acaryas* He rode away in the most incredibly beautiful black car. And the chase was on. The game began. How to see Him? Where? How to get a better glimpse? How to let Him know that I am for Him alone?

Baba had just left for Lake Gardens. We, of course, followed, hoping to catch sight of Him again when He went on field walk later in the day. There was always a sea of margiis and I was having a hard time seeing when Baba came out of the house and into the car. My mind was spinning for a solution to this knotty problem. I tried to push up front but could not make it. I tried to secure a front spot long before Baba's arrival. This was impossible; I was becoming desperate to see Him. When He came out from the car after field walk I was in the back of the crowd and next to the garage. The garage was empty and as I looked inside, I saw a window! I ran to it and stood looking out, because the very path that Baba used to walk into the house came right in front of this window.

My heart pounded with anticipation as I watched Him walk towards me. I quickly gave my namaskar and started crying, "Baba, Baba." I knew it was He who had granted my strong desire to see Him. He stopped right in front of the window, looked at me, gave Namaskar back and then walked on with a smile. I reeled in His ecstasy, laughing. How He plays with His devotees! I have found that it is in the small matters that He reveals His Divine guidance.

Vinit

Berry Creek, California

I want to tell how I got into Ananda Marga. It was during the late '60s when the general trend was towards Eastern philosophy. This came at a good time in my life, because I was not satisfied with the religion that I was involved in; the answers weren't there. I was attending a community college, and met a brother who was in AM. The more I heard and read about it, the more it just made sense to me. There weren't any questions I had that weren't answered by it.

My first experience with guru was in a dream. I was raised Catholic. It gave me a good spiritual background, of God, but it wasn't quite enough. Studying the practices of Ananda Marga, in the back of my mind I still had pictures of the Pope, so that was not letting me be free with this meditation. Then I had a dream: I was in Rome, in the catacombs, where in the past they did their practices so they wouldn't be persecuted. I was at a mass, and the Pope was saying mass. I saw him from behind, then he turned around with a big smile on his face, and it was the guru. So I thought, wow, there's something to this, this is a direct contact through a dream.

Shortly after that, margiis were going to India – Baba was giving a special grace. I didn't know what it was about at the time, I just had the intuitive feeling to go, to see this guru. We were waiting outside this building where Baba was going to come. Baba came by in His car. I had never had any direct spiritual experience before, outside that dream, but when this vehicle drove by, the tears came. I could not stop crying; it was just an overwhelming thing for me. I said, "This is really something."

A few days later I was told to give a report. I didn't know what the report would be, even, since I was a new margii. I was supposed to tell what my duties were. Well, I didn't have any duties. So all this time, three days waiting, I had so many anxieties about what I was going to tell Him. I didn't even know what a report is. I was nervous, what was I going to say to this guru? Well, I understood He was omnipresent, so I knew He was going to know what I was thinking, and what the *acaryas* were going to tell Him about my duties.

There I was in front of the guru, and I felt completely stripped of everything. I felt like a skeleton in front of Him, I was so exposed. And still thinking, what was I going to say in my report? And the guru let me off the hook by asking, “Was this a satisfactory report?” And I said, “No.” So He let me off the hook.

The next thing I knew, and it was a quick process because there were so many margiis waiting, the *acaryas* grabbed me, and threw me on the guru’s lap. I was rubbing His feet, He’s rubbing my back. I lost all contact with everything, except I felt like I was a flower, a rose to be exact, being sucked up into a vacuum. The point was, everything left me, I didn’t feel anything. Next thing I was being picked up, pulled away for the next person to come in. It was a beautiful experience. Just feeling like I left the plane of the universe, a totally beautiful feeling. It actually took me years to experience it, and I’m still experiencing it. At that time I had just left the planet, completely spaced out.

But I had heard stories about people’s experiences with Baba, that He was joking, all these fun stories. So if you can believe, I felt cheated that Baba was not joking with me, that He was all business-like. A few months later, I still had this feeling, “Well, I really didn’t see the guru laughing, that funny nature.”

One night I had a dream. Baba pulled up in a pickup truck and asked, “Who wants to go to town?” Me, being humble, or maybe not feeling worthy, said, “Let someone else go.” But nobody else wanted to go. So I said, “Baba, I’ll go with you.”

So I jumped in and we took off. Then someone else came out of the house and wanted to go too. I said, “Baba, John wants to come too.” Baba said, “OK,” and He’s smiling all this time. So Baba backed up, I opened the door, and just as John was about to get in, Baba floored this thing, peeled a strip of rubber, and took off. And He was laughing and giggling. So I got my joking Baba through a dream.

Tapan Mallick

Hockessia, Delaware

Before leaving India to study in the U.S., I went with Baba on field walk. He talked about the importance of company in human life (*satsaunga*). He advised me on how to carry myself in a distant country. He emphasized that I should stay in touch with margiis.

One day, while we were waiting for General Darshan, a person (Mr. X) who spoke a different language started to make snide comments about Bengali-speaking people in front of me. He knew I spoke Bengali. I was very hurt by his comments and he enjoyed hurting my feelings. When General Darshan started, Baba said he would like to give a demonstration on past lives. He chose Mr. X for the demonstration. He put his stick into the *trikuti* of Mr. X and asked him what he was seeing. Mr. X said, “Baba, I see myself a Bengali living in the city of Dacca (capital of Bangladesh).”

Baba asked him what was his name at that time. He replied, “Ram Chandra Roy.” Then Baba asked him to see my past life. I was a south Indian person speaking Kannad language. Baba asked him to see my past life further back. He replied seeing a European person living in Johannesburg in South Africa speaking English.

Baba concluded the General Darshan saying (paraphrased): “All languages, all races, all countries belong to *Parama Purusa*. We should treat them with equal respect. We take different bodies, speak different languages and live in different countries in our eternal journey to *Parama Purusa*. Having a disrespectful attitude to anyone, any language, any country is to have disrespectful attitude to *Parama Purusa*.”

Mr. X apologized to me afterward.

By His grace I experienced sounds at different stages of meditation: the sound of crickets, then the sound of a flute – at that point I lost my concentration. For a moment I got distracted with the thought that I hadn’t heard from my father for a long time and wondering if he was all right. He was very sick at that time. Baba rebuked me afterwards for losing my concentration. He told me my father would be all right – why can’t we

surrender everything to *Parama Purusa* and enjoy His bliss? This memory still brings tears to my eyes – He knows all our thoughts, even if it appears for a split second.

I came to the U.S. in 1980 to attend graduate school. Someone was supposed to pick me up at the JFK airport. My flight for Austin, Texas was on the following day. On arriving at JFK, I found that the person was not there to pick me up. This was my first time in this country, I didn't know anybody, didn't have phone number or name of any margii. I didn't have enough money to take a shuttle or spend the night in a hotel. I just had about \$22 in addition to my first semester's tuition and one month's rent.

While I was thinking what to do, I saw a man approaching me. He was the elder brother of a student who I met while boarding the JFK-bound plane at Amsterdam. I just had a brief chat with him. He was going to attend Texas A&M and he spoke Bengali. That was the extent of our conversation. I never saw him in that flight again. Strangely enough, his elder brother told him, "Let's just check if there are any other Indian students and if someone is at the airport we can escort them." He knew someone in New York and arranged for me to spend the night there. My problem was solved. I never heard from that student again.

Tvarita

Millville, New Jersey

I had been initiated into Ananda Marga and had not yet gone to see Baba. My friend and spiritual sister, Sadhana, was planning to make the trip in the summer of 1982 and was urging me to travel with her. It is important to note that my Sanskrit name at the time was Tarita. Sadhana did not think the name suited me – but now I am getting ahead of the story.

I felt much confusion and mental clash over making the decision to go to India. One morning while working in my flower garden the thought came to me that I had to go to India in order to “speed up” my spiritual progress. So the decision was made.

While in Patna at Baba’s house, Sadhana approached one senior acarya and asked him to change my name. It wasn’t right for me, she said. I was feeling rather clashed because I wanted Baba to personally give me a new name. The *acarya* told us to wait, which we did. He came back in a short time with a small slip of paper that had my new name written on it along with its meaning. I opened the paper and read it, still feeling clashed that Baba had not personally given my name to me. I put the paper away and didn’t look at it again until I returned to my home in the States. When I read it the second time my new name and its significance hit me in full. My new name was Tvarita – one who is very fast. I cried and cried the instant I realized that all-knowing Baba had personalized my name from my very thoughts. Baba Nam Kevalam.

Alok

Iowa City, Iowa

I was initiated by Dada Ananjana in Austin, Texas, in 1982. Soon after that, I moved to Southeast Asia to work with Ananda Marga, so that throughout the mid- and late '80s, I had many opportunities to see Baba in India.

I didn't feel anything overwhelming the first time I saw Him, but something drew me to make the hour-long journey to His house from the AM *jagrti* in Tiljala every day. Perhaps it was a kind of inchoate longing, as if I felt something special could happen, if only I gave it enough time.

In the afternoons, He was driven to a nearby park where He went for a walk around the lake. When He returned, it was as if an electric pulse jabbed through the crowd. "He's coming, He's coming!" Everyone scrambled to get into a good position to see Him. The gates to the driveway swung open, and the car turned in. Baba would step slowly from the car. He was clean-shaven, and wore old-fashioned black-framed eyeglasses. His ears were large and elongated, framing a smooth brown face.

Everyone rushed to stand near Him, and someone would begin to sing one of His recent *Prabhat Samgiit* compositions. Baba would tilt his head and listen, then nod and smile.

"Do you like this song?" He would ask playfully. "Should we keep this one?"

One day, the crowd outside His house was as thick as usual. My chances of getting close to Him were slim. So I stood in the street outside the gate, which actually afforded me a better look, as His chair was just on the other side. An Indian *acarya* began to warble a devotional song, and the crowd followed in call and response. Everyone was singing earnestly, but I found myself just drifting as I sized Baba up.

The song went on. Baba nodded and smiled. Then, for seemingly no reason, He turned His head and glanced at me through the gate, out of the corner of His eyes. And it was as if a beam of light shot out from those eyes, piercing me.

With this one glance, my heart expanded, and my mind soared. It was not that I noticed a certain expression on His face, and that made me feel happy. It was something

deeper – an actual transformation of consciousness through a glance. I didn't understand what was happening. But I didn't really need to.

The look lasted for only a moment. Then things went on as before, except that I was changed. I couldn't speak, and after I left His house I stumbled about like a madman, drunk on a wine of great love. I didn't want to talk to anyone, but only to hold on to this sweetness for as long as possible, to hoard it, store it, to flow away into a new realm on the waves generated by His loving gaze.

Soon, Baba embarked on a tour of India, conducting a series of DMCs, and I followed Him. Thousands of margiis attended these three-day gatherings in a state of giddy expectation.

He made a stop in Tatanagar, a city famous for steel. A crowd gathered in the huge pinnacled tent, which was not unlike a circus big top. There were musical and dramatic presentations, and everyone looked forward to the highlight of the DMC, when Baba blessed the crowd with a bestowal of spiritual energy through His *mudra*.

As He sat on a raised stage with several local margiis around him, I found that I couldn't take my eyes off Him. He turned a very tender gaze upon the crowd as He spoke, and I felt flooded with feelings of fondness for this man.

Baba gave a discourse on the importance of discipline in one's daily practices. He had the most unusual voice. He drawled out his vowels, as if to emphasize the importance of what He was saying. At the end of His talk He seemed to shift gears, offering up a blessing of sorts. "Le-e-et everyone be-e-e happy," He said slowly. "Le-e-e-t everyone see the bright side of e-e-everything."

As He spoke, the crowd's expectancy leapt like barometric pressure. People leaned forward, and everyone was as if perched on the edge of some kind of revelation.

"Le-e-et everyone be free from ailments of all kinds. Let no-o-o one be forced to undergo-o-o any difficulties due to pressure of circumstance."

Then, slowly, His hands glided into the position of the *varabhaya mudra*. Baba held His right hand palm open next to the chest. His left hand was lowered palm down near the waist. The pose was not only metaphorical. An electric shock coursed through the crowd. People cried out, shuddered, fell over backwards. On the stage the local AM

leader was sobbing.

I felt cool electricity pulsing through the air, a subtle, tingling, blissful sensation that left me feeling refreshed and inspired. Someone mentioned afterwards that he felt as if time had stood still at the moment of the *mudra*, that Baba was intimating to us the timeless nature of the state of enlightenment, giving us a little taste of that state, as incentive to deepen our spiritual practices.

As the shock waves of the *mudra* subsided, Baba rose and began to walk slowly towards the exit. The local leader, with eyes wide and a trembling step, held out his hands to make sure Baba did not trip, and slowly backed down the stairs in this protective, overwhelmed state.

As they walked, a strange thing happened. It seemed to me that Baba was shimmering – that His body was now composed of thousands of tiny points of light, not one solid substance. His figure shone, vibrated, and the air around Him seemed to dance. I rubbed my eyes, but the phenomenon persisted. Swirling energy filled the air, as if the scene was bobbing up and down on ocean waves. Whether it was a result of my own heightened perceptions, or Baba was actually projecting this, I cannot know. But it touched me.

I went to Japan to work as an LFT. I was putting together a small weekly Prout newspaper in Tokyo. And so I had the opportunity to go to India for LFT reporting. A number of LFTs from around the globe were gathered to talk about their work with Baba. One dada poked me in the back, prodding me to stand in front. Like a squirming school kid called upon to give an answer in his worst subject, I approached Baba nervously, but with excitement. He asked my name and where I was working.

“My name is Aditya (my name at the time). I’m working in Japan, Baba.” Some of the *acaryas* ere laughed, since most LFTs worked in their home countries, and I did not seem to be Japanese.

Baba had been stressing the need to become fully knowledgeable about whatever place we were working in so that we could better serve the people. Flora, fauna, waterways, demographics, economics, agricultural and industrial potentialities – He wanted us to be well versed in all these things. Of course, He was interested in

everything. On another occasion, perhaps because He knew I loved literature, He asked a question about the significance of Harriet Beecher Stowe's *Uncle Tom's Cabin* to which I was able to stammer some answer. He also encouraged me to read French literature. Now He began speaking about Japan, mentioning that tidal power would make a lot of sense for the island nation. He then asked me something about Japan's geography.

I didn't know the answer, so I mumbled.

"What was that?" Baba asked.

"Baba, I don't know," I said.

"You don't know?" Baba repeated.

I sensed a sudden change in the atmosphere of the room.

"He does not know?" Baba's face assumed a stern look. As if electrical energy had built up in the room around Him, His anger flashed out.

"You should know this!" Baba said.

I jumped with the force of His *shakti*. Everyone in the room also seemed to sway back. This dispensation of energy lasted for only a second, but Baba's anger was palpable. "What have I done?" I thought, chastened yet strangely fascinated. Something was going on beyond His response to my lack of answer. Not everyone was fortunate enough to see this side of Baba.

Then, as quickly as it came, the mood shifted, and Baba assumed an expression I will never forget. He gazed into my eyes and I was overwhelmed by a sweet sense of His affection for me. I could have stood there transfixed for hours in the glow of this smile. The flip-flop of energy in Baba's demeanor and in the room was such that people were suffused with a feeling of great release. Everyone around me was laughing, pulled in by the charm of Baba's cosmic joke. I had a sense that Baba was showing me two distinct faces, of strict disciplinarian and loving father. Also that anger was a tool, which could be utilized to instruct. I had always suppressed strong emotions. Was He trying to teach me their utility?

During Personal Contact, I sat and watched Him gazing off into space, and it seemed to me as if He were reading a page out of the book of my life.

“Hmm,” He said. Then, as if something particularly interesting appeared before his inner vision, “Something in your past.”

I knew that He was referring to an incident in my recent, misspent youth. It was as if there was no need for speech, and He had only to think, and I would know what He meant. I looked up at Him, much affected. A tremendous, tender, sadness lay in His eyes.

“You have so much potential, why are you wasting it?” The sadness grew until it filled the room.

“Baba, I made a mistake.”

He paused for a moment. “No, no, it was not a mistake. It was commissional.” He continued to gaze at me. We sat there.

His mood seemed to shift. Inwardly I felt a sense of my own inadequacy, but from Him I felt no blame, only gentle correction. Baba’s message to me: Clean up your act.

Then, turning the focus away from my shortcomings, to what I interpreted as a way for me to move beyond those shortcomings, He said, gravely, “Do something for humanity.” He looked into my eyes, and although I did not experience what I had that day outside his gate, I felt a great love from Him.

I left His room, and don’t remember going down the stairs, but a friend later said there was a great light in my face. I went down to the darshan hall and sat for sadhana. Later that afternoon, an *acarya* came up to me and conveyed a message that Baba had given about me. “Baba said, ‘He will do some work,’” the *acarya* told me.

God has forced me to learn how to swim the rough waves of this life by throwing me into deep water several times. When I was young I suffered from an inferiority complex that curtailed my ability to express myself. Baba’s teachings about this, that such complexes – whether inferiority or superiority – are simply distortions of ego, and can be overcome through ideation, helped me a lot.

As I began doing sadhana more seriously, the arena of struggle in my life seemed to shift from psychic to physical. Fifteen years ago my body was slapped with an acute illness which turned chronic. Living with a debilitating illness has been no joke, but *Prabhat Samgiita* and sadhana, the explanatory idea of *samskara*, and the support of

friends have helped me to deal with it. The illness has forced me to become more accepting; to surrender.

I also had a huge clash with my parents, who felt that Ananda Marga was an unhealthy organization, and tried to persuade me to leave. As a result of this, for a while I developed some grave doubts about this path, but Baba never released His grip on me. The struggle was ultimately a useful experience, since it forced me to look with clearer eyes at my involvement in AM, and to understand and accept some of the organization's problems, instead of being in denial about them. For example, I began to feel that the emphasis on fearlessness and strength in our organization might sometimes come at the expense of compassion and humility. In any case, as I said, He brought me back to His shelter, for which I am grateful.

One final story. I was working for Ananda Marga in South Korea, and we had a *jagrti* in a city called Daegu. After several years there, the landlord asked us to move out, since she wanted to use the house herself. There was nothing we could do but comply, and so one brother and I roamed the streets in search of a 'for rent' sign. We walked all day and found no place suitable.

The next day, however, sister Parashakti called to say she had found a new *jagrti*. We hopped the bus over to a large, second floor loft for rent. Although it was large enough for yoga classes and group meditation, there was something about it I didn't like. It faced a noisy street, for one thing, and somehow it just didn't feel right. I told Parashakti that I really wasn't sure that this was the right place for us. She became a bit upset, and we rode the bus back to the *jagrti* in silence.

When we got there, the landlord was waiting for us. She began talking quickly in Korean, most of which I couldn't understand, but I knew something was up by the way Parashakti's eyebrows arched higher and her eyes opened wider as the landlady went on.

"What is it?" I asked.

"Well," she said. "She says she had a dream last night, in which a man came to her and told her that it was important that we stayed here, in this house. So she's decided to take only one room, and leave the rest to us." Just then, the landlady entered our DC hall, where a large photo of Baba rested on the table. She pointed and began speaking

again, in an animated fashion. Parashakti explained, “She says that’s the man who appeared in her dream last night and asks who he is!”

Tell her He’s someone very special...

Kalyani

San Diego, California

I was initiated by Didi Ananda Anuradha. I'd been wanting a guru for a very long time. I'd heard that if you want the guru badly enough, He will come. And I thought, "Who could want the guru more than me? I want the guru so badly, and it's not coming." I didn't realize then, but now I do, that maybe my ego was a little too much. Anyway, at the proper time, Baba came to me.

I went to a dinner where an *acarya* was speaking. I went not really expecting anything, because I think I'd kind of given up on finding a guru. I sat down with the margiis and did some sadhana, and then I saw Baba's picture.

I went up closer to His picture, and I felt a pounding in my heart *cakra*, and the vibration was really strong. Then I opened up one of His books, and the book was pounding me, and vibrating me really strongly, too. And I began to read, and thought, "Oh. Everything that I've been struggling to put together, the philosophy is right here."

It was really comprehensive. And I felt moved. When I went home that night, I started singing Baba Nam Kevalam, which was going through my mind strongly. I felt the one I'd waited for so long had finally come. I was crying and crying. In some ways I was so happy, and in another, I felt, why did I have to wait so long, and suffer so much? I had such a big ego. That I'm still working on. Still, I knew absolutely that this was the one I'd waited for many lifetimes, and whatever suffering I had to go through was worth it, to have Baba and Ananda Marga. I felt so completely blessed. I felt so sure about this path, and it never stopped.

The first year I went to India, I was getting into a lot of meetings with Baba. One particular day I'd been trying to sit for LFT testing so I could have Personal Contact, which I actually didn't get. But this one day I wasn't able to get into a meeting – Baba was having a meeting with some brothers. And I was sitting on Baba's porch, doing sadhana with some other sisters.

Then the meeting ended, and someone said that sometimes after meetings the door is open and you can go in. So I rushed up the stairs, the door was open, and one

person said, “Oh, you just missed Him.” I was crushed. The vibration was so strong in that room. I walked just a couple more steps, and Baba was standing right there.

I was so happy; He was so close. But He was just leaving, walking out. And so I ideated. He was preparing to leave. I called to him, kind of quietly, with so much love, “Baba.”

At that instant Baba stopped and turned around and walked back towards me. And He stood right in front of me, and looked at me. And I felt like I wanted to drop to my knees and bow, but at the same time I was feeling embarrassed to do that, and also remembering to always keep your eyes on the guru. So I didn’t bow. But my whole being wanted to. I was looking at Baba. Was He looking at me? Could He have heard me? Did He know that was even me that said that? We were in a room full of people. He stood there for some time, and then He moved on. That was really special to me.

Sudhiir (2)

Another visit I can remember was the September when the first *Prabhat Samgiit* was written. Baba was traveling; He was in Deoghar, in North Bihar. I took a train there. There were many margiis from Jamalpur there, and I got to know these margiis. It was like visiting Jamalpur, because they were all there. Baba was kind of in His Krsna mood; He wasn't acting like the head of a worldwide organization. All of His early devotees were there, and it was such a family situation, such a mood.

He used to come out and walk back and forth. The first morning He came out, He asked the dadas to sing this song He had written just that morning. His Personal Assistant, General Secretary and several dadas sang this song. I was standing a couple feet away while He was correcting them. "Bandhu He Niye Calo." It was the first *Prabhat Samgiit*. After a couple of days, as far as foreign margiis, there were only myself and three others. We were being trained by some of the acaryas to sing one of the *Prabhat Samgiits* to Baba, to be the first non-Delhi sector margiis to sing to Baba. We memorized the fourth or fifth song. But one brother left, and then it was just three Americans. That night something happened, and we didn't get the opportunity to sing the song. The next morning, the two other Americans had to catch a train, and that left me [laughs].

That night Baba walked up and down the driveway. He called for a chair, and sat there, and all the Jamalpur margiis sat in a semicircle. The margiis started to sing *bhajans*, and He stopped them, and said, "I only want to hear *Prabhat Samgiit*." Then He asked for the other-sector margiis to sing. I was the only one. I was so nervous, and I started to sing. It was a difficult song, but I managed to get out the first few lines, then the dadas joined in. I think they were terrified I was going to make some terrible mistake. We all together finished the song, and Baba said, "Very good." It was wonderful to have the opportunity to sing to Baba.

I was the only non-Indian margii there. It was like being in a land forgotten. I learned later that Deoghar was one of the places Shiva lived. There were Shiva temples there, which I visited. They were doing a form of kiirtan to Shiva. I couldn't help

thinking that Baba was revisiting it from His past life as Shiva. He spent so much time there.

And I needed to go back.

I said to Baba, “Baba, I’m leaving.”

Baba said, “So soon? Well, come again and again.”

I was dumbstruck. The way He said so soon, I couldn’t possibly leave, I couldn’t do it. They said He was going to Ananda Nagar. So I said, “The heck with my reservations, the heck with everything, I’m staying.”

We went to Ananda Nagar, a long dusty drive through the rice paddies and dusty countryside to Bengal from Bihar. All the margiis from around that locality were there. Again it was just Baba walking up and down His driveway, and us singing *Prabhat Samgiit* to Him. Occasionally He would sit, and everyone sat at His feet, and we were singing in the evening. It was unforgettable; there was just enough light to see Him, and not much else. It was more by the radiance of His light we were seeing, than anything else. Occasionally Baba would stop us and correct a word, or the way it was to be sung, and sometimes He would sing it the way it was to be sung.

I think in 1981 Baba asked for artists to come and decorate His house in Kolkata. There were only two other groups from around the world, a couple of Italians, and a German brother. So we were looking around His house, trying to pick out our favorite places to do. I thought the walls of the *dharmacakra* hall would be good, they wouldn’t be bothered by the weather.

Some days Baba would come walking around through the garden, inspecting the plants. This day He came around the back side, and we were all scrunched together to try to see Him. Then we started hearing shouts from the other side, they were shouting my name, as well as the Italian brother’s, to come and talk with Baba. We got to the porch, Baba was there, and He explained He was going to show us each where we would do our murals.

My spot was on the porch in front of the museum. I couldn’t help feeling a little disappointed because it wasn’t the spot I had picked. But I smiled, “Thank you, Baba.” Then we walked through the doors into the DC hall.

And Baba turned to me and said, “It would not be appropriate to decorate these walls.”

“Yes, Baba.”

And then I went to work. I had brought acrylic paints from the U.S., and I had permission to go up on the porch. I had the complete run of the place, and sometimes I took advantage of that. Sometimes Baba would come around, and I would go up to be the first to greet Him, before He saw the rest of the margiis. And I got several little namaskars from that. It took almost three weeks to finish. I did the ceiling and walls, and during that time Baba was going out into the garden some time and sitting. I was there all day long, and was getting fed with the leftovers from Baba’s meals. I’d be painting, or pretending to paint, because I’d be standing there in front of my mural, but my head would be turned watching Baba walk around in the garden.

I finished the painting, and at the same time I got very sick with bronchitis. The last couple weeks it was difficult to stand up and hold the brush and paint. But I wasn’t going to miss that opportunity. Also, all my friends got to pose for me, to hang out in the forbidden territory, and I painted them into the mural.

It was two days before my ticket to go home. In those days, Baba was showing groups of people through the garden and talking about the plants. Like everyone else I’d been trying to get on the garden party list, unsuccessfully. I was getting more desperate, and thought, “Well, Baba are you going to look at this thing?” So I took determination that I was going to stop Baba and ask Him about the mural, and see if I could get into a conversation with Him about it.

On the last day, I made sure I was right next to Baba’s car, with 30 margiis surrounding me. Well, Baba walked around, up on the porch, and I heard my name being shouted, and I was smashed in next to His car. I’d had the wrong strategy. So I had to fight my way out to the porch, and Baba was already looking at the mural.

And He said, “Very good, very good.” And He’s looking around, and I didn’t know what to say; I couldn’t think of anything to ask Baba about it.

Then He turned to me and said, “I think you will do more of this in the future?”

I said, “Yes, Baba.”

And at the time I didn't realize He was talking literally. This was the first and only mural I had ever done. I used all the wrong materials; everything peeled off, because the acrylic did not adhere to the oil paint. It was a total disaster in terms of technical skill. But it didn't matter, it was obvious to me that the whole experience was an excuse for me to be close to Baba. At the time I didn't really think of myself as an artist. I didn't have very much confidence that I could be a professional painter. He said that, and I didn't really take it seriously.

About twelve years later I did a mural, and have since done a number of them. And they have been a way for me to live out my ideals in terms of bringing art to people. Baba talks about the several kinds of art: that which deals with the spiritual, and the kind that deals with the everyday life of ordinary people. And this seems to me to be what I do best, to do art about the ordinary life of the people, and to put art out there in front of people who would normally never go to a place where art was. And to work with populations of children, and students, to be part of the community. It's been an excellent thing for me, and Baba saw it coming, of course.

One time I went to visit Baba and I had been there for two or three weeks and it was raining; it had been raining and raining and raining. And the whole city was flooded, completely flooded. Tiljala was underwater.

At the end of that week, I was the only Westerner left; otherwise it was all *dadas* and *didis*. I was with one *dada*, and he said, "Come on, everybody is going to give their *pranams* and *namaskar* to Baba and give garland to Baba."

So he took me. We went all over the place trying to find a stall that was open – everything was closed, everything was flooded – and finally somehow we found a place that had them and he bought one for each of us. So then we were standing in line – there was this long line of *acaryas* giving garlands to Baba, and I was at the end of the line, and only Westerner and non-*acarya*.

After everybody had given their garlands but me, there was this mountain of flowers up to Baba's eyes. Baba started taking them off one by one by one, and the VSS guard was shouting something at me saying, "No more, no more, this is too much, enough already." And Shamitananda, who was standing beside me, started arguing on my

behalf; the VSS guard and Shamitananda were arguing. And the garlands were coming off of Baba and slowly you could see more and more of Baba's face reappearing.

I was standing there with my garland not knowing what to do. So I just stood there. And Baba kind of had this twinkle in His eye. The guard was trying to get my garland away from me. So finally Shamitananda – I guess he won the argument with the guard – gave me back my garland, turned me around to Baba and mine was the last garland lifted up to Baba, and Baba said, “Oh, for me?” So I was able to give my garland to Baba and give my namaskar to him.

Arun

New York City

Let me thank Dhyaneshananda whose book greatly inspired me. As he stated in his introduction, these accounts are also sacred to me. They serve to remind me of life's purpose. I have attempted to sacrifice embellishment for precision in these stories. Direct quotes of Baba were only used when I knew the exact words, otherwise indirect methods were used. I also want to thank brother Giridhara who helped me to appreciate the historical significance of everything Baba said and did, and who helped me to realize that even an ordinary margii's contact with Baba was extraordinary.

There was a time I would go out at night in secret to search for my Master. These walks would take me to the loneliest alleys and dimly lit areas of the city where I hoped my Master might appear to initiate me in private. I was naive, and did not know that Baba had already made arrangements. An old friend had visited me weeks before with a female companion. She had left the phone number of Ananda Marga with my mother. When my night walks were finally exhausted, I called that number and attended *dharmacakra*.

I became quickly enamored of Ananda Marga philosophy and was soon initiated. Initiation took place during *dharmacakra*, and between the accent of the acarya and the loud kiirtan, I only understood one word, the *nama mantra*. I made a strong resolution to practice it regularly. I glanced at Baba's photo on leaving the room and thought, "Such a sublime philosophy! But this man is certainly not my Guru."

The next day after initiation I returned home by bicycle from work fully exhausted. I tried to rest without sleeping, knowing that I should meditate. Finally I sat up without washing or removing my shoes to repeat the *mantra*. As soon as the process began I felt tremendous energy rising in my spine and soon lost all physical consciousness. Buried memories of my life, infancy and previous lives' meditations flooded my mind. A voice said, "You have come home." I did not recognize the voice. This experience was brief but forever changed me.

Baba first revealed Himself to me in a dream. In a recurring nightmare throughout my life, I would be lost in the city behind the wheel of a runaway car, too young to drive. This time the car managed to come to a gentle stop in a familiar neighborhood of my childhood. I got out and sat under a tree with a sigh of relief. In a distant tree there was a sparkling light reflecting off of someone's eyes. In a flash, this person appeared in the tree above me. As I looked up, he fell down onto me with a jolly laugh. I was surprised to recognize him... "Baba?"

"Observe," He said. "Have you noticed that you are not wet?" There was a deluge of rain, yet we remained dry.

"Yes," I replied.

He then took me to a sloping lawn where He directed me to sit at the bottom while He sat at a higher spot. He waved His right hand as if dealing cards and Bengali *shlokas* began to emerge from His palm, forming themselves into three stanzas, each with four lines. He made me repeat each syllable with tedious precision. He told me that I must learn this. These lessons continued all night, and on other occasions also.

Once after receiving second lesson I was crossing a busy intersection. A car came speeding towards me and I stepped back. The car suddenly wheeled around and stopped, blocking traffic in all four directions. An angry large man came running after me shouting profanity and vowing to tear me to pieces. He caught me by the shirt and pulled back his fist to punch me. I only thought "second lesson" and immediately heard the *mantra* as if it were reverberating everywhere. I looked into the man's eyes. They were wide with fear. He panicked, ran full speed back to his car and drove away. Another *margii* witnessed the event from across the street. He came to me and asked for an explanation. "I think Baba just saved me," was my reply.

I learned from one *dada* that Baba loved *bhajans* and would sometimes listen personally to the offering. I resolved to compose a *bhajan* for Baba in hopes of playing it for Him. When Baba landed in Jamaica, I was unable to go due to unusual complications in my life. I was heart-broken, and sat alone crying for days. Later I learned that Baba was reluctant to make His first appearance, but that finally He walked out onto the stage when a sister began singing the *bhajan* I had composed. This fact was confirmed by

audio recordings of the event. My burden was lifted. He did choose to accept my offering after all.

I composed another *bhajan* to be played for Baba at the first Global Conference of Ananda Marga. He did not attend but I was asked to play this song during a slide show of Baba photos. During the *bhajan*, many margiis began weeping. A brother next to me fell over. Wailing and other noises came from the gathering. I noticed some of the senior *acaryas* were crying. Soon I also was overcome and could no longer continue to sing. I had to pause. When I regained some composure I completed the *bhajan*. Afterwards many margiis asked me to teach them that song, but I would always say, "It was not the song, it was Baba."

Finally I composed a third song to be sung for Baba and decided to take it to India personally, with my guitar. I was ashamed at having been a margii for 11 years without meeting Baba. I was seated on the plane next to another sister who had also been a margii for 11 years without meeting Him. "How He cares for our feelings," I thought. When we arrived and Baba emerged from His house at Ananda Nagar, I was overcome to see that the Baba of my dreams was also in real human form.

During my first visit to India I entered a request to sing a *bhajan* for Baba. I was told, "Since one month Baba will only hear *Prabhat Samgiit*." I was crestfallen. One dada saw my plight and encouraged me to learn *Prabhat Samgiit*. Later this dada became my good friend and Sectorial Secretary. After learning some songs, I reissued my request to sing for Him. I was told, "Baba will personally hear *Prabhat Samgiit* from you tomorrow. Come to the house by one p.m. and know ten songs." I arrived early and waited with anticipation by Baba's bedroom door. During this wait there was some commotion outside, as a group of European margiis had made their way past the gate guards expecting to receive darshan. Security promptly removed them and ordered all Western margiis from the compound. I tried to explain my circumstance, but was removed.

After years of this and other disappointing failures, I was still thinking about how I could sing for Him. I brought my guitar to His garden at an hour when He was walking and few others were there. I was told by a dada that only harmonium should be used for

Prabhat Samgiita, and the song was stopped. The next day I tried again, seeing that the person who had stopped me was no longer present.

Baba was walking in the garden when He stopped and said, “Your song is excellent. This *Prabhat Samgiita* can be played on local instruments such as the guitar and violin. Please continue.”

The next day was *Dharma Maha Cakra* (DMC). After much insistence, I was finally readmitted to Baba’s quarters. I waited outside His room, but the time had grown short and He was already doing sadhana in preparation for DMC. I was told to leave by 10 p.m. or I would fail to reach the *pandal* in time and would be left outside. I could not leave the spot. I did sadhana and *pranam* at His door. At last Baba came out for DMC and somehow I was whisked into a security car just behind Baba’s car. I watched Baba enter the *pandal* and, although the last to enter, I was then placed just in front of the dais, such is His Grace.

I returned to India with an electronic keyboard after learning 100 *Prabhat Samgiit* songs. While Baba was on field walk, the margiis were curious to sing *Prabhat Samgiit* with this accompaniment. But when Baba returned, I was shoved into the back of the garage for fear that it would not be acceptable. Due to the unexpected suddenness of Baba’s arrival, no new song could be started, so I continued to lead the song I had been singing from that spot.

After the car entered the gate and stopped, a senior didi by the car stretched her arm in my direction with the palm down and made a gesture that in my culture means, “Be Quiet!” I quickly stopped playing. She then turned her palm up and made another gesture that I took to mean, “Start playing again.” Once more she turned her palm down and I stopped playing. Finally she shouted, “Hurry up, Baba is calling for you!”

The crowd parted and I stumbled through expecting that I had made a major transgression. Baba rolled down His window, smiled sweetly and gave Namaskar. “Your pronunciation is very nice. Do you like this song?”

“Yes, it is lovely, Baba.”

He then told me that it was a *ghazal*. He patiently spelled *ghazal* for me and described its Arabian origins. He named the *ghazal* “Hava Ghazal,” or wind *ghazal*, and proceeded to sing various other types of *ghazal* melodies, noting their beats and

measures. I understood little of what He said, but He treated me like we were musical companions and I felt completely at ease and natural in His presence.

After that the dadas always arranged for me to be in front of Baba. I also learned that Didi's first gesture had meant, "Come quickly."

CHAPTER SIX: DANCING IN DIVINE ECSTASY

“Keep all your desires inclined towards Him. Always keep yourselves merged in His thought. Go deep into the mood of that infinite Love.”

During the latter half of the 80s, Baba’s speed in teaching and training *acaryas* and *margiis* seemed to accelerate, if such a thing was possible. He granted more Personal Contacts. The organization saw tremendous growth, and *margiis* traveling to India from New York Sector joined large gatherings of *margiis* from around the world at DMCs. Baba introduced the scientific concept of *microvita*, subtle entities linking matter and consciousness, and also taught “*microvita sadhana*” to a few senior *margiis*. He predicted the shifting of the Earth’s poles, and a coming Ice Age. He offered new perspectives on Prout and the world’s economic situation. He continued to compose *Prabhat Samgiit*, and to accept plants from devotees as part of a plant preservation program. Baba also began urging disciples to acquire Master Units around the world.

Pavitra

Los Angeles, California

I was born in Ecuador and came to the U.S. in 1976. I have always been interested in yoga and spirituality, because my dad introduced me to those subjects through books by Vivekananda. I became very interested, and met someone who told me even more, and I asked her if she could direct me to a place to learn. She had no idea. I looked in the yellow pages under yoga and found Ananda Marga in Los Altos Hills. That was in 1979.

I called and asked about yoga lessons. I was more interested in the physical part. The woman who answered the phone said, “You can come, but you have to come for six weeks of training which includes meditation.” I was immediately turned off, because I had done other things. She later called and invited me to *dharmacakra*. And I always resisted.

Finally she said, “If you won’t come to us, I’m going to come to you.” She came to visit me, and started talking to me about yoga. I said, “I know a lot about yoga,” and showed her all the books I had read. She smiled and said, “You know, it’s better if you stop reading and start meditating.”

I was deeply offended; she offended my intellect. But because of her ways – she was a very wonderful person – I was intrigued. Finally I went to *dharmacakra* on a Sunday. I felt really strange, and I thought to myself, “What am I doing here?” But something happened and I continued to go to DC, until someone told me there was a teacher there, and asked if I would like to be initiated. I was initiated in April, 1979, by Didi Ananda Anuradha.

I started with my meditation and got totally confused. I had a lot of preconceived ideas about what I was to do. There was one thing constantly in my mind. People kept talking about Baba, and we were meditating in front of His picture. I wanted to see this Baba. It became an obsession. Finally I convinced one of the margiis to go to India with me. Baba had just started composing *Prabhat Samgiit*.

The first time in India is such an adventure. We stayed at a hotel near Baba’s house. Then we went to see Baba. We were the only two Westerners there. It was very

intimate and beautiful. That first night Baba came from His room. We were waiting for Him; my friend was across from me – she kept saying I should come there where she was for a better view. I couldn't move. I wanted to move but I couldn't; it was strange. So I saw Him, and I was very taken by the fact that He was so short. I didn't have any feelings then for Him, as it was all very new.

We stayed for two and a half weeks, going to Baba's house twice a day, and all the while He spoke in Bengali. And I was really upset. I thought to myself, "I came all the way here, and spent all this money. I feel very uncomfortable, it's so hot." I had been thinking, "I wish I could understand what He's saying," but I resigned myself.

The last night He said, "And tonight I want to share with you that I have composed a song in English."

And He sang "Tiny Green Island." I was in such a state of mind, I thought, "Wow, I'm understanding Bengali." Anyway, that was really nice, that He had spoken to me. Then He came back and we sat at His feet. I was so close to Him that I could have stretched out my hand and touched His feet. It was just a fantastic experience. The night was warm, and it was a very beautiful atmosphere. People were singing *Prabhat Samgiit*. I had sort of a feeling that this was not the first time I'd had this experience.

The following day we were leaving and we went to Baba's house to say goodbye. I was still kind of upset in spite of everything. My friend said, "We have to buy a garland in the market."

I said, "I'm not going to do it."

She said, "You have to, this is the custom."

And I said no, so she said, "OK, get some flowers."

So I bought some beautiful red roses in a banana leaf. We went to Baba's house where He was walking.

Jagadmitra said, "Baba, we're leaving. We love you and we love your songs." And He turned around. He didn't answer her, but He turned to me and said, "Did you like the songs?"

"Yes, Baba, I did."

Then He explained to me the kind of music He had used to compose these songs, music from all over the world. I cannot explain in words how I felt. The only thing I can

say is that at that very moment I felt that the world had vanished and the only two people in this space were Baba and I. I gave Him the flowers in His hands, and I just looked at His hands, His beautiful hands.

After that I came back to the U. S. and my life was really turned into complete havoc. All kinds of things happened to me. But the connection was so strong, I never lost that feeling of deep devotion.

I went to India in January of every year. I used to start saving my money to go to India in December. Every time it was with such a feeling that I was going to go see Baba. At the moment I saw Him, something overtook me – they say that is the *kundalini* rising. I don't know if that's true, but I had this feeling and I couldn't stop crying. It was something fantastic. There has not been anybody before or after that made me feel that way. I didn't cry out of sadness; it was something I couldn't control.

My experiences with my guru have been very personal. They have reflected my own state of mind, or was it the other way around? By that I mean that Baba came into my life and really opened up my potential, my possibilities of being human. I was very limited before I met Baba because of cultural and other circumstances. After I saw Him in 1982, I had terrible experiences, very painful experiences. Yet, I always tried to understand why. If I had this fantastic guru, why was I going through such misery?

And it took many years for me to understand that what was happening was really the flourishing of my own being. That's how I understand the relationship with this energy; that's how I see Baba. I mean we have the photo of this person, but my take on this whole thing is that it's not a person, it's a universal energy. And yet He, it, has graced me with His love.

I have always been an intellectual. It seemed that Baba talked to me through the books I read. I was always desperate to find answers. And it seemed I was directed. Well, at first I thought it was my own doing. But now I understand that everything that I did, I was really guided. And so that understanding which came many years after, created in me – I don't want to sound mystic – but it created a total, total devotion to this energy. I don't understand it by any means, but this is my experience.

Baba came to me through dreams. One time I was clashed about something. Probably because He knew that I'm a person always in my mind, He came to me and said, "Use your mind." And I have.

Even though I had that dream, I was still limited. I was very fearful. The feeling came back to me with such strength that I felt I had changed completely. Now I feel very strong, that I have no fear. When I have to take a decision, which was difficult for me in the past, I have the sense of going into my heart, and saying I have this connection with this energy and it's a very loving one, so what should I do in this situation? I always get a very good accurate answer. So I attribute this to something beyond me.

I came to the U.S. and spoke no English. It was so difficult. In the years I've been here I have changed so much. I attribute my growth to my guru. I've explored other organizations, the Tibetan Buddhists, the Self-Realization – this is after Baba passed, the Brahma Kumaris – and I never found anywhere the type of vibration that I feel in Ananda Marga. Not to say that AM is paradise, but it's the feeling that I've experienced personally.

I met a dada from India, and he told a story about his being in Sweden. He was in a very difficult situation, and someone was going to kill him. The only thing he remembered was his second lesson, and the man calmed down and nothing happened. That stayed in my mind. In 1984, I was in a situation in which I thought there was no way out. And I remembered that story. I kept repeating my *guru mantra*. And I always do anyway. I think each of us has something favorite of Baba's teaching. *Guru mantra* is that for me, I'm always saying it. And in that situation I was saved. That's not the only time. There have been several occasions – I have to attribute it to something protecting me. I was told once by a psychic that he was able to see an energy at my side that always protected me. My surrendering to this energy is really complete. Not to say I haven't had doubts. Because of the kind of person I am, I've had lots of doubts.

When I went to Ananda Nagar, I was experiencing a lot of physical hardship. We got there late so all the rooms were taken. We were given a tent with no roof. It was very cold, and I was suffering tremendously. And in that state I felt a wave of unconditional love. It's difficult to explain it in words unless you have experienced what I'm talking about. It was like a cloud and I felt that unconditional love.

Kirit (2)

In 1979, Baba came to Europe, and I saw Him in Germany. There I had my first personal contact with Baba. The first thing Baba asked me was, “You came to India, why did you not ask for PC there in India? Weren’t you there?”

“Yes, Baba I was there.” And I told Him that PA Dada had told me that His health was an issue. After that I had a very nice PC. There was lot of discussion about my life, Baba told so many things, that He had given me new life on that day, and asked many promises, which I gave Him. He asked me to be an ideal person, and to live according to the ideals and teachings. He gave me a lot of blessings, for a long time. Everyone asked why it took so long. Many specific instructions He gave, which I cannot disclose. Many things He told me have come true. Some things are still to come.

Thereafter I went again to India, the January, 1980 DMC in Patna. Baba was no longer in a wheelchair, and He was walking without a stick. His health was coming back. He had black hair, not gray hair. He was turning younger. He was going on field walks, and I had several chances to go on field walk. He talked about geography, the courses of different rivers, so many things, where the river Yamuna used to go when Lord Krishna was there, the geography of hundreds of years before. And how the vibration of the space has changed accordingly. He used to talk about grammar, and the comparative study of languages.

One time I was in the car with Him, and Baba looked at me and said, “Remember, don’t waste a moment of time. You see how I work, I don’t waste a single moment. This life is a short period. Don’t think about material resources. When you do spiritual and ideological things, those resources will be arranged automatically. Move forward with full faith. Other resources will be managed.”

One time we were walking in the streets of Patna. Baba was in a very happy mood. It was like talking with a personal friend. For a moment you forget the fact that He is Baba, guru, the cherished goal of life, you forget everything, because He creates such a lively environment around Him. Everything is so light, you forget all tensions. Baba just hit me on the back, like a friend. As if to say, everything is fine.

After that I went to see Baba for winter and summer DMCs. I spent a lot of time doing sadhana in India, and tried to focus more on sadhana. Many things happened during that time in my personal and spiritual life. I could see a major progress in my sadhana. Every DMC was like a struggle for survival, with a lot of obstacles, yet Baba used to take us through those obstacles. And you could tell that spiritual progress had happened. I could see myself progressing by His grace.

During that time I developed some special relationship in my mind with Baba. This is also described in *Namami Krsna Sundaram*, as supra-aesthetic science. Baba talks about a personal relationship with *Parama Purusa*, the different stages. I could see my mental state developing. Gradually you begin to comprehend His attraction, and all you have read in philosophical books becomes real. I'm talking specifically about attraction, *mohan vijnana*, supra-aesthetic science, and Krsna, the supreme attracting entity. You cannot sustain separation from *Parama Purusa*. You cannot tell how or why this mind is feeling this, how it developed this attraction. It is as if a piece of steel all of a sudden has become a magnet. You cannot tell the difference by looking at it.

It became very hard for me to leave Baba, to come back to the U.S. It was an enormous struggle to leave Baba behind. I was like a child who has to go to school on the first day and wants to stay home with his mother. I used to feel very sad and almost depressed. Two or three days before coming back to the U.S., I would feel so much pain, like I wanted to give up everything and just stay with Baba. I remember Dada Jagadiishvarananda-ji asking me, "Why do you look so depressed?"

I said, "No, Dada, this is how I feel, I don't want to go back, but I have to go back. I cannot tell what it is about Him that is holding me here. When Krsna was there, the *gopis* could say it was the sound of the flute that was holding them there. But Baba was not playing the flute. What is it that was holding me?"

I was like a madman. He started laughing. Like this I used to spend some difficult days.

One time the DMC was in Kolkata, and it was coming to an end. I had to go back to the U.S., and I didn't want to. The Tiljala *jagrti* was complete, but there was no electricity there. This was soon after those dadas and didis were murdered [by Communist partisans]. Taxi drivers were scared and didn't want to drive there at night.

Baba also used to return from field walk very late, at 11 o'clock. We would wait for Him, spend some time with Him, and then go back to Tiljala. They were using the generator for electricity in the evening until 11 o'clock in Tiljala. It was my last day, and the following day I had to fly. Again I felt very depressed. My body would not accept any food. I had Baba's darshan that night. Somehow we managed to come to Tiljala.

I went to my room, put up the mosquito net, and was doing my night sadhana, when the generator shut off. I could not do much sadhana because I was thinking, "Tomorrow I have to leave." I became very angry at Baba.

I told Baba, "This is not a just thing; you are doing an injustice. I know you are *Parama Purusa*, I know you give spiritual talks saying you are always with me. OK, it's fine, you are with me, but I don't feel I am with you, and this is the difference. I am an insignificant speck of dust in the macrocosm. That you are always with me is consolation for you, not for me. You are my Lord, I am your devotee, this is the relationship. Not that you are macrocosm, I am microcosm. In this relationship why is it I must suffer the agony of my leaving tomorrow, but you will not suffer because you are always with me? This is an injustice. I am upset with you, I don't want to do your sadhana."

So, abruptly I stopped the sadhana. With heavy heart, I went to sleep. In the morning I did my morning sadhana, and thought I would go to Baba's house one more time, then go to airport. As soon as I came in to Baba's house, PA Dada called me.

"Come here. What happened last night?"

"Nothing, Dada."

"No, something happened. Last night, at eleven o'clock, Baba was reading all the newsletters from different parts of the world, and all of a sudden He stopped, rang the bell, and called me. He said, 'How is Kirit? What does Kirit say?' I told Him, 'He is fine, he is enjoying DMC.' Baba laughed and said, 'No, he is complaining against me. He wants to say something to me.' 'No, Baba, he has not said anything.' "

Then Baba said to Dada, "Do you know Kirit is leaving for U.S.A. tomorrow?" He laughed, and said, "He has some complaint against me."

Then I remembered my conversation with Baba. Keshavananda asked me, "What is your complaint?"

"I don't have any complaint."

I was waiting, and Baba came out, and walked right up to me, and smiled at me, very nicely and very gently, and said, “You can tell me now. I am willing to listen to your complaint.”

I felt so overcome by emotion, and I said, “No, Baba, I have no complaint.”

Baba said, “Sometimes our mind loses devotion, and we think inappropriately.” But Baba smiled and said, “Don’t worry, you have to go back, but you will be back very soon.” So I also smiled. But little did I know what He meant.

The whole thing is so strange. I am by profession an engineer and we only get two weeks vacation a year, that’s all. And we have such tight schedules, and difficult work. Instead, two or three times a year I was spending so much time in India. It was impossible to think that someone in my profession got that much time. But something always happened. Either I was moved to another area and nobody knew that I hadn’t taken vacation, or I always used to take unpaid time from work, and nobody knew I was taking off. I always got changed from department to department and my bosses never knew I’d been taking vacation. Miraculously I was able to attend all the DMCs in the 1980s. When I look back it seems impossible but Baba always managed the time so I was able to do it. Baba prearranged everything.

One time I was called from India by Baba directly, personally. “Call him,” Baba said. This was the time He was giving *microvita* sadhana. I had just come back from India, but again Baba created such circumstances, that everything fell into place. The funny thing is, after giving His blessing, He smiled and said, “So Kirit, do you think you came or that you were brought here?”

“I was brought here, Baba.” He laughed. So before He tells us to do certain work, He has already completed the work on the psycho-spiritual plane. And it’s just a matter of tightening up, nuts and bolts; someone simply has to become an instrument. But the work has already been accomplished.

Like this, in His *liila*, I learned one thing. In the ’80s, Baba’s speed of work was unimaginable. He would erect a palace in a desert in no time, and remove a desert from a palace also in no time. It was nothing short of a miracle what He led us through. One thing was for sure, that when He gave some work to do, the work was already

accomplished by some force, and you were only filling in the gaps. When Baba tells you to do something, you do it right away. That's the best time to do the work, with the least amount of energy. Go with full force and do it. Otherwise, as time goes by, the work becomes difficult, and eventually impossible. Of course, if you are not able to accomplish it, it's His *liila*, something has already been done. His *liila* does what it has to do. But for you, who have the chance to fulfill His work and thereby progress through your *samskara*, you have the choice to take that opportunity to do it or not do it.

Many such experiences I had, and all taught me about His fundamental teachings – sincerity, humility, courage, hard work, love for humanity, sacrifice, service, and devotion and dedication. He personified all these qualities, and taught us about these things.

One time before Tiljala was built, Baba used to come to Jodhpur Park for reporting purposes. There was a limited amount of bathroom space, and no place to stay. You were there seven or ten days and you had to stay in the vicinity to be near Baba, but in Jodhpur Park there was no space. One of the local margiis asked me to stay with him, but unfortunately he lived so far away that when I would come to Jodhpur Park, Baba had already finished His morning darshan. I used to miss it. That went on for two or three days, and I realized that Baba was very unhappy with me. I was still a new margii and just learning about the ways of the spiritual world. I'm still learning, but at that time I did not understand the propriety of my behavior. I was thinking, what happened, what did I do? Maybe nothing, I should just try harder to see Baba. The harder I tried, the more difficult it was to see Him. There were so many people pushing and shoving to see Him, and I could not keep up with it.

I decided to wait downstairs by Baba's car, and when He came out, then I would be able to see Him closely. I waited, and Baba started coming downstairs. Baba's driver tried to start Baba's car, but it would not turn over. It cranked and cranked and did not turn over. The car wouldn't start. He was scared he would be taken to task for not keeping the car in shape. But guess what? Baba didn't even go to His car, He climbed into the VSS jeep and left. Then the car started. I was helpless and couldn't get Baba's darshan. My blood was frozen, and I became motionless. There could be no greater

evidence that something was wrong. It was His thought, His idea, not mine. None of my tricks would work. Finally I thought about the problem. And from that day on, I took the vow, that when I go to India to see Baba, I will not go anywhere, not see anything, I will always be near Baba, and spend my time in sadhana. This was the vow I took. I broke that vow one time, but I asked Baba's permission to go. There was one family that had given three children for wholetimers. They had some crisis. So I traveled to meet with them, and that was the only time I was away from Baba. So Baba teaches so many things, sometimes in a harsh way that we will never forget.

One time the plant program was going on. I used to bring hundreds and hundreds of plants. Baba loved orchids, and there was an orchid farm in San Francisco. I used to take a lot of orchids. One time – winter DMC – I thought I would not take any plants. Since Baba would be in Ananda Nagar where it was cold, I would bring a nice soft warm blanket. I learned that the best wool comes from Ireland. I found one blanket in the Neiman-Marcus store. They said it was the best, very lightweight and warm. I purchased it and went to India. Normally Baba is very happy to see the devotees coming. All the dadas have to give good news to Baba, and when I used to visit, it was considered good news. But that time, when Baba got the news, Baba didn't say anything. Not only that, when Baba came down, I was standing to see Him, and He looked at me and didn't say anything. He bent His head and went like this [shakes head back and forth]. And I knew what He was saying.

It was one of the most painful days in my life. You feel like your heart has broken into a hundred pieces, and you would prefer death over life. I had the desire to completely vanish into the earth. I didn't know why Baba was angry, but it was obvious He was disapproving. I saw a couple of dadas, Dada Shamitananda and others, outside the gate. Baba had sent them out because they had not made their quota for the plants. I realized, "Oh, they also are being punished, and I am being punished. What do I do? OK, why not go to some nursery in Kolkata and bring some plants? But no, it was not just about simply replacing the plant, but about a mistake I made. By doing that I would not be rectifying my mistake. What was the process that caused my mistake? Why did I make

this mistake? *Parama Purusa* created every leaf on every plant. Who am I to bring Him what plant? What was it that went on here?”

So I thought and thought. Yes, it was related to plants. Why did I not bring plants, and brought this blanket? It was a subtle expression of ego operating. A lack of surrender. When we do something for Him *we* think is the best thing, we are being guided by our thought process. As opposed to our thought process being what He wants, what He expects, and acting accordingly. So that was my mistake, I did not allow my mind to be guided by what He wanted. It was a subtle expression of ego. This I learned on that day. That’s the reason I did not go to a nursery in Kolkata and pick up a few plants. *Parama Purusa* cannot accept any ego. I had to go through some difficulties, strive to correct myself. So I asked where the best plants were? I was told Nepal. I thought, “OK, I will go to the mountains there, I will climb those mountains and find the plants myself. I will not buy plants, paying my way out; I will pay with my labor.”

I flew to Kathmandu. I went to the training center, and the dada there said he would accompany me. It was so cold there, and I did not have a blanket. Next morning, Dada and I started climbing the mountain, and we collected a big bag full of plants. Meanwhile there were some difficulties on the way, with my visa back to India. Somehow the Nepal consulate on a holiday miraculously was open and I got approved. I came back and deposited the plants with Dada Asiimananda-ji. I distributed bags to the dadas outside to fulfill their quota. I submitted my plants also. Next morning Baba was smiling so much, and He was so happy to see me again. What we should think is what He wants, what He would like, and conduct ourselves accordingly.

Rekha

Oregon

I have resisted sharing my stories over the years, feeling somehow that mine were insignificant compared with the more directly powerful tales of senior margiis and *acaryas*. Over the years, however, like all our deep learnings, my experiences with Baba have deepened and, to me, become more available and thus significant. Truly any words concerning our Lord can spark beauty and significance without warning!

I was an “instant” margii after attending Arjuna’s class in Pasadena in September, 1983. Everything about Ananda Marga’s practices felt “right,” despite the fact I wasn’t even aware of being on a spiritual search. Baba’s grace is truly amazing in the way it surrounds and enfolds. I was about to turn 30 and the first thing I wanted to do after beginning my sadhana practice was to study physics, thus satisfying strong internal questions I had. Devotion to Guru eluded me, as I was a Western intellectual – yet I felt strong yearnings in my heart for... something. My initial reason for taking the meditation class had been to solve health problems, and within two weeks my health not only improved, but I felt my body transform – almost as if I was beginning another puberty.

One night during dinner following *dharmacakra*, a didi mentioned she was leaving for India soon. I remarked politely how wonderful this was, wishing her a great trip. She looked deeply towards me and said, “When will you be going?”

I felt a jolt of recognition, and great surprise. In July when Arjuna described his plans to go in August, I quickly swung into action. Miraculously, passport and visa applications all came together smoothly. There was no question but that I should go directly to Baba. This is how it came that I spent three and a half weeks at His lotus feet in August, 1984.

My daily schedule was pretty regular: waking in the sisters’ *jagrti* at Tiljala, traveling with two or three other foreign margii sisters to Lake Gardens, listening to Baba’s darshans (sometimes twice a day), singing lots of *Prabhat Samgiit* (often to Baba), returning to Tiljala in the evening. I often played my flute as others sang *Prabhat Samgiit* to Baba. He looked sweetly toward me several times as I played. Since He was

composing six or seven new ones each day, there was much excitement when when someone came out of Baba's house with new melodies and lyrics.

Being such a new margii, I spent a lot of time talking with and observing other margiis and *acaryas*. It was August and "off season," there were no more than 20 or so foreign visitors. I explored the idea of guru, watching Baba, hoping for a "sign." One Sunday, during a darshan packed with people on an extremely hot day, I relaxed into a hazy dream state. Baba, who was speaking Bengali, began speaking English to me in my mind. I couldn't quite follow His points, but I was tremendously impressed.

On August 15, two thousand sisters prepared at Tiljala for a Proutist demonstration march in Calcutta. They were making ten demands for women's rights. We foreigners were told to stay at the *jagrti* and not participate. Baba was so impressed with the women's efforts that He gave a special darshan the next day. His subject was "The History of Women." I recall that He gave the talk at least partly in English. Afterward, without warning, He gave the *varabhaya mudra* and many people in that small gathering room fell on the floor. I felt a sudden cramp in my stomach and had to race out of the room to vomit outside. What a shock! I was ill for the next three days.

Toward the end of my visit Baba composed *Prabhat Samgiit* number 3000. He celebrated this by ordering *rasagullas* for all of us in the garden. Up until that point I hadn't really enjoyed Indian sweets, finding them, well, just too sweet! But here was a sweet dessert sent to me by Baba, so of course I savored every bite. And to my complete surprise, I felt myself slowly transform into a flower! Every detail was clear, but especially the taste of the incredible nectar! What a lovely gift.

Over the years, with retelling and resavoring my experiences in India, I have come to cherish and delight in that special time with Baba. I never returned. However, I did finally "get" the concept and joy of guru, after five or six years of margii life. After Baba's passing His presence became quite strong during my *dhyana* practices. Twice I have had experiences, seemingly out of the blue, with fragrance. One day, during an ordinary workday at my job, I smelled lilacs the entire day. It wasn't the right season, only Baba's grace. Another time it was sandalwood. I feel Baba sends reminders, and holds me always.

Dhyanesh (2)

I went to Hong Kong Sector and worked there for a year as a Local Full-Timer (LFT), as Seva Dharma Mission (SDM) Sectorial Office Secretary in Kyoto. I was studying the Japanese meditation gardens, thinking about my future career as a landscape architect. And looking for some good sister to marry.

After one year in Hong Kong Sector I went to *Dharma Maha Cakra* in Ranchi in 1984. The second I saw Yamuna from a distance, I felt strong love for her. Not her beauty, just the way she stood. I felt something. But we were talking, and she was hiding, so shy, and I was talking only with her father, and my mind would not listen to that first intuition.

And I was thinking, “This is insane. I live on the other side of the planet, and they live in some remote village in the countryside.” So I said, “After DMC I’m going to do some traveling, and maybe I’ll come visit you.” But in my mind, foolishly, I was thinking I would not come back.

It was a wonderful DMC, and afterwards I went to visit Bhagalpur to design a Master Unit and a mango orchard. I also designed a Baba’s quarters there. When it was completed, Baba stayed there, and I felt very honored.

I was staying with one family *acarya*, Dada Pashupati, who reviewed my lessons for many years. Yamuna’s father happened to come at the same time I was there. So I took it as a sign that I would go back with them to visit Yamuna. I felt so much love in the family – really I fell in love with the family – more love than I’d ever felt in my own country, but I was still...

Anyway, I cornered Yamuna. I was so cautious and reticent about commitment, like so many American boys are. I said, “If I come back from Hong Kong Sector, do you want to marry me?”

And she did not answer. In her mind she was saying, “This is my father’s decision.” But finally, she looked up and said, “Yes.” And my heart was so happy. This was another sign. Actually she thought I asked her to marry, but still I had some escape clause there [laughs].

So I went back to see Dada Pashupati, and asked him, “Dada, you’re my *acarya*, should I marry this girl?” And he had the habit of always going into deep sadhana when

he reviewed my lessons. And this time, he came out of his sadhana and he said, “Yes, you should take a *tantric* stance in your life. You should invite struggle in your life. You should be a shining example to society!”

And I felt the *tantric* feeling so much, and I said, “Yes, I will do it!”

I sent a telegram, “Please meet me in Kolkata and we’ll marry, if it’s to your liking, after I get back from Hong Kong Sector.” And we met and got married in an Ananda Marga school in Kolkata. There was a flood. I was so happy, even with all the clash, the flood, and the *acaryas* who were going to marry us, saying, “You’re an LFT, you can’t marry.”

Lots of clash, but during the marriage I felt so much of Baba’s bliss. Then I had to come back, I had one week left on my plane ticket. We decided we were not going to be together until Baba blessed our marriage. We got married on June 24th, and my ticket was for July 2nd. Every day in Lake Gardens, we would petition the Personal Assistant and the other *dadas* to please say something to Baba about blessing our marriage before I had to leave. On Saturday, the P.A., Dada Ramananda, got angry with me.

“Ohh, why do you keep asking this question? Baba never blesses marriages outside of DMC. Just forget it, go on!”

Oh, we were so dejected then. We felt pretty bad. That night when Baba got back from field walk – this is a beautiful Baba story – we all sat around Him, and they started playing this beautiful *Prabhat Samgiit*. And Yamuna was feeling very feverish, sick, and in the middle of the song, she stood up, and tried to get out of the crowd, and she passed out. And I was looking at her, and then looked at Baba, and Baba looked at me, and with His mind, said to me, “I am doing something.”

Then the music stopped, and Baba said, “And how does Dhyaneshe like this song?”

“It’s beautiful, Baba.”

“So it is Dhyaneshe’s decided opinion that this song should be included in *Prabhat Samgiit*?”

“Yes, Baba.”

The second He called my name, Yamuna sat up, and heard that. Then we left. The next day was darshan. We were all waiting, crowded in there. And He called me and

Yamuna up, and took our hands and He blessed our wedding. Not in DMC. It was very special. And He looked at Yamuna almost the whole time. “Be like Shiva and Parvati. Be an example to society.”

Later He said He was very pleased with our marriage. Because she comes from a very strict caste, a very sentient caste. They observe *ekadashi* [fasting], and sentient diet. They never marry outside their caste. Not only did she marry outside her caste, she married some boy from America. So it took a lot of courage.

Then I had to go back to America. I had been an LFT for three years. I had to get a job, a house, all these things. After three months I received a telegram that she was pregnant – we had been together one night – and I came back to India to get her. During that time she had been ostracized by some of her extended family, and the village. They were cruel to her, they shunned her. “Oh, you married an American, all Americans get divorced, he only wants to use you.” Mean things they would say to her.

We had a difficult time getting her passport, because she was from a known margii family. There was a Member of Parliament who was a member of Ananda Marga who helped arrange the passport. I brought her back to the U.S., where it was so difficult for her. You know, we have such a lonely society here – air-conditioned house, air-conditioned car, the streets are empty. And in her village, everybody knows everybody, and the streets are always full of people. She cried so much, it was so hard for her. She never wanted me to see that. But we believe Baba took some *samskara* from Yamuna that evening, so that she could adapt, adjust, to her new life. I could not adjust to India, I always get sick, and also it would have been difficult for employment. I’m the weaker of the two.

And when our first child was born, we always felt she came from Baba. She was born very alert, and she did not cry. They were measuring her, and she reached and grabbed the tape. She was born very conscious. That was very special.

After some years I had the opportunity for Personal Contact.

It was in Lake Gardens, and I had to wait a long time, many days. I fasted, and waited, and every day it was not my time, not my time. And I saw other Western margiis

going directly in and coming out. This was part of my purification process, I'm sure. Finally it was my time.

Most of it was very personal. He told me many things about my past lives. And He made me promise many things, to serve society. Then He called me closer, and I was hugging Baba, and I was crying. I'm normally a very rational, intellectual person. But by His Grace, He balanced my mind so nicely with devotion.

Baba said to me, "Dhyanes, you should do one more thing."

Our faces were close together. "Yes, Baba?"

"You should laugh."

And the two of us started laughing together. I mean really laughing. It was so blissful, and everything fell away from inside me, as if nothing mattered any more. All the fears, the clash, it was all His play, all His drama, and everything was happening according to His will. There was a moment when our two laughs became one. This was the bliss. And to this day, in my sadhana, I feel these stages of sentiments as the stories relate. You must have a strong, but surrendered mind. It seems paradoxical. A strong determined mind to stay focused, but a surrendered mind, that surrenders over and over with each *mantra*. This is the beginning stage of sadhana. In the next stage, I feel a loving proximity with Him. And then, if it is the time He wants for you, you feel a union, and go into Him, and this is the best joy.

Suprabhata

Longmont, Colorado

I was initiated in Carbondale, Illinois, by Dada Jiitendra. I've been a margii for 28 years (2001).

I went to India in 1988. It was the second time I had gone. One dada came to my house in Iowa where I was living. He was raising money for Ananda Nagar. I didn't really have any money; I had just finished paying all my bills, and my bank balance was zero.

And I thought, "Well, something will happen and I'll have enough money to buy food until I get paid." Then Dada came and said, "We really need money for Ananda Nagar." I really wanted to do something so I gave him a check for \$100.

After he left, I got a check in the mail for \$100 for an income tax refund. The Internal Revenue Service said I had paid too much money on my tax return two years ago. That's never heard of, you know. A couple days later I got \$100 from a company which was a reimbursement for medical expenses. And then a couple of days later I got a check from my mother, who never sent me money. She sent \$100.

"This is for you, Steve, for being a nice boy," she wrote [laughs]. So then I had \$300 in the bank, enough for whatever I needed.

I went to the summer retreat a month later at Ananda Kanan, and they were giving a big talk about how Ananda Nagar needed money. So I told this story to everyone, thinking that might help the situation. At the end of the story, I said, "And then they paid me \$100 to come here to tell this story!" And everyone laughed. But that night they got pledges for \$50,000 for Ananda Nagar.

Later in the retreat, they were trying to find someone to go to India for reporting. They were doing a rotation, one person for each region. It was my region's turn. Dada Devashraddhananda was pushing me to go, because I was a *Bhukti Pradhan*. I didn't think I could do it – I didn't have the money, there wasn't enough time to give notice at my job, all these things. But I decided that if I could get the money, I would try to go.

So when I went back to Iowa, I asked permission from my boss to go, and he said, "No problem." I went to the bank and tried to borrow money – I didn't have any assets,

but I had a good record at the bank. I asked to borrow \$2000, and they agreed. My first daughter was living with me, she was 10 or 11, and I needed someone to watch her while I was gone. I asked a friend, and they said sure. Then I needed to get my name changed because the previous time I had been to India I had been blacklisted. I had only a few days to do that, but had to fly to Denver, so I did and got my name changed. At this point there were two days left.

In Denver, I went to the sisters' *jagrti*. One didi there was scheduled to take all the money for Ananda Nagar to India. She couldn't go, and needed someone to take it. I agreed, and she gave me a little pouch with \$25,000 in cash, which I wore around my neck.

I flew to New York and applied for my visa and passport. It was the last day. The person at the Indian embassy said, "I see that you just changed your name two days ago. In order to get a visa, you need two weeks where you advertised that you changed your name."

I said, "Well, I would, but I have a ticket to go tomorrow, and I don't have time."

They said, "This is against the policy and I'm sure we can't."

I replied, "Well, at least ask your supervisor."

And she went to ask. Up to this point, I hadn't been feeling strongly that I needed to go to India. I was going because Dada asked me to. But now I started thinking, "Baba, I really want to come." My attitude changed. She came back to the counter and said, "Well, we never do this, but for some reason the supervisor says you can have your visa."

In Kolkata, people were waiting for reporting. It was 110 degrees, and we stood outside the door in Tiljala. Day after day we waited. After four or five days, Baba called me in for reporting with several others. I was trying to think of what I could say in reporting, I hadn't really been doing anything. Baba only asked three people to stand up and say their name, and He would explain what their name meant. He never called me, but it was a great experience watching Him, and hearing Him talk.

A few days later was the ten-year anniversary of His coming out of jail. He gave a talk, and at the end, He let everyone do *guru puja* and then gave His *varabhaya mudra*. A lot of screams and people falling over. It was a beautiful experience.

When I got back to Iowa, the first day at work I checked my mailbox and there was a check in there for \$2001! The company had made more profits than they expected, so they divided the profits proportionally among the employees. It was the first time they had done that, and they haven't done it since. I had been worried about how I would pay back the \$2000 to the bank. All my debts were paid, and I had a beautiful experience.

Keshava

Los Angeles, California

I was initiated in 1985, by Dada Ratneshvarananda. When I first got initiated, I very much wanted to see Baba. Each Christmas I tried to go, and for two years, I got really clashed out because I always had some big problem happen where I wasn't able to go. I'm an actor and I had this pilot for a comedic series I'd had a terrible experience on, and then I booked this film, "Memphis Belles," a big film, the biggest film in my career to date. And I couldn't do both because I had this contract to do this television show. And I remember praying to Baba that if I could get out of the one and get to London for the film, I'd be so much closer to India, that I'd just go to India and pay my namaskar, my respects, and that I wasn't going to come to get anything. I realized that's what kept me from making it the other two times, that I had wanted to get something.

And at that moment, in my meditation, I felt a wind blow through the house, like the winds of change, and I knew the series was not going to happen, and that I was going to go do this movie. And I did do the movie, which was an incredible experience, and I went to India. I didn't have Personal Contact, because I didn't have all the requirements they had then, in 1988.

But I was very fortunate to get to see Baba give darshan. I remember being in the darshan hall, and hearing His voice, He was having a conversation with someone, in a reporting meeting, like, "Ahhh? Ahhhh." This went on for a while, it sounded like someone was going to be scolded, and then that He was happy with the progress.

Then He came. As an actor I watch human beings; I was watching Him carefully. He was moving so slowly, and subtly. He seemed like He was old, kind of, but I watched Him closely, and for some reason sometimes He would move faster than the eye could see almost, and then move slowly again. I was in the presence of such a subtle human being, *Parama Purusa* possibly.

I see energy around people; I've been around a lot of celebrities who have huge presences, and you can see it around them. My experience of Baba was like none I've ever seen before; it was coming off of Him in waves, across the whole room. He only spoke Bengali, and I didn't understand a single thing He said, but He was so charming,

and so funny, everyone was laughing, just delighted with Him at all times. So even though I didn't understand a word, it was a completely blissful experience. After He left, we meditated, and as soon as I closed my eyes, immediately I was in white light, through my third eye *cakra*. I was completely full of white light, which I guess is what Baba was emanating to us the whole time. And I understood why people just wanted to be in His presence all the time; you were just so full of bliss when you were around Him.

Shortly after He passed away, my fiancé Jayashrii made me a *pratik*. I heard that Baba was supposed to bless the *pratiks*. And He came to me in a dream, and took the *pratik* in His hands, and He blessed it. I woke up in tears, the dream was so... it was more than a dream. He took care of it, His last business with me was to make sure I was taken care of. It was such bliss.

Gaunga

Toronto, Canada

I was living in Kolkata for several months following the New Year's *Dharma Maha Cakra* of 1988. Away from the responsibilities and hectic pace of Western life, in the atmosphere of sadhana, service and fraternity, I used those times as an opportunity to throw myself wholeheartedly into sadhana and cutting the bondages of the selfish and the mundane. In those days I was doing long meditations, deeply and sincerely, and was strictly following all my practices. Every day, I tried to think if there were any of His practices or suggestions that I had overlooked.

Each day I went in a taxi with a group of sisters to Baba's house in Lake Gardens. Each night we came back together to the sisters' quarters in Tiljala. One day, as our taxi was passing through a narrow market street, I noticed some loofahs hanging up in one of the many small shops. I saw some more in another shop and it seemed that most of the shops had them. Suddenly it came to me that Baba had once said that we should use the loofah when we take our bath because it removes many toxins from the skin that come out in the perspiration. I said to myself that I must buy one, but as it was not practical to stop the taxi at that moment, I would get one when I had the chance. Many days passed like this, and I had still not bought the loofah.

One evening there was to be a *Prabhat Samgiit* program at the large hall in the brothers' compound in Tiljala. I had arrived on time, but the program was not yet ready to begin. Many were rushing to and fro with a lot of people milling about, inside and out. I was standing in the collonade outside the entrance doors, enjoying the cool air, when I noticed an Indian man smiling at me. Often, strange men would approach me; usually they would ask if I could arrange a job for them in Canada. As he approached, I noticed that he had something in his hand. He stood very close, and began peeling this thing, which I could see was a loofah. He took my hand and started shaking the seeds into it. He said, "Take these back to your country and plant them."

I had a habit of collecting seeds. I just stood there, incredulous, looking at the seeds in my hand. He then placed the loofah in my hand and stepped back. He smiled and

said, “Use this when you take your bath,” and with a twinkle in his eye, added “and you will have beautiful skin.”

I noticed that his own cheeks had acne scars. Within seconds, he turned and stepped into the hall. Suddenly the realization hit me. What stranger would give me such a gift? I stepped into the hall, but he was nowhere in sight. I had become familiar with the Indian margiis who regularly attended Baba’s programs, but I had never seen that man before, nor have I seen him since. He was very average, very ordinary in appearance.

Several years ago, Dada Sujit Kumar, a family *acarya* who was close to Baba since the early days, described how Baba had once pointed out a man doing namaskar from the back of a crowded train platform at a stop, as Dada accompanied Baba by train to some place for DMC. Dada was intrigued as Baba identified him as one of the “other” margiis, who were rarely seen, but who were highly evolved spiritually, and in whom all the occult powers were fully developed. Dada complained that he and the margiis close to Him were working so hard for His mission, and that these margiis should also be helping them to do this important work. Baba explained that He gives them their duties also, and that they are intuitively tuned to hear His directions.

Through the medium of so many forms, He is fulfilling His initiation promise of taking care for the devotee’s progress. No one takes so much care as He does. It has often been said that in our spiritual life, He will coax us on, like a mother encourages her baby to walk to her. To those who take even a small step toward Him, He will take ten steps toward them and will scoop them up in His loving arms.

Kamalanayan

Portland, Oregon

In late December 1987, shortly after arriving at Ananda Nagar for the first time, I was invited to visit the director of one of the schools there; he had some questions relevant to my profession. His office was upstairs in Baba's House, adjacent to the large room where Baba would hold meetings such as reporting sessions with workers and margiis. We were having a very pleasant visit, half-business in response to his technical questions, and half-tourism because of my curiosity about his life at Ananda Nagar, the projects, etc.

Suddenly, a call echoed through the large room outside Dada's office: Baba was arriving in that room to take His indoor walk, and was not to be disturbed nor confronted by anyone. All the doors opening into the big room were to be closed. Dada jumped up and shut the only door to his room. Now we were closed in his tiny office, and Baba was in the next room. By his casual manner I estimated that this was a normal situation for Dada, and I looked silently at him for some hint as to how to act: was it OK to talk, to move, to think normal thoughts? I closed my eyes for a moment. Meanwhile, I heard Dada get up and go to the door again.

When I opened my eyes, he had the door ajar about two inches and was peeking out, crouched a little. He gestured vigorously, summoning me to his side, then stepped away as I arrived and put me in his place. As I brought my eyes into viewing position, I saw the orange robes of an *acarya* only a few feet from me, then Baba was there, moving left to right across that little opening. Had I been more crazed with devotion I might have thrown open the door and grasped my Master's feet with one leap, He was so close. But I stood there, the passage of time seeming to slow down as I saw first His right shoulder, then His cheek, His ear, hair, the back of His head go past. He was walking along slowly and steadily, a cane in one hand, His other hand resting on the arm of the *avadhuta* who walked protectively at the side of his Guru.

Everything important a few minutes earlier was forgotten: Dada's questions, my travels, my hopes. This glimpse of the guru I had thought about for seventeen years seemed to fill my awareness, leaving nothing else to think, to see, to feel. This seemed

enough. I had the feeling, not easy to defend logically, that this was why Dada had called me to his office. I looked again at Baba's back as He advanced carefully around the circular room. How grateful I was for this opportunity, so simple, so personal it seemed. I felt that Baba knew I was looking. Maybe in some way he had arranged this for me. Externally I had no special status among the ten thousand margiis who surrounded His house that day; I had earned no privilege. Internally I was one of his very own, near and dear. I was thinking like a child, like a devotee.

Now, many years have passed. The images seen through that barely-opened door are among my treasures. I keep them safe in my memory. They do not tarnish. Is this event significant? Imagine a two-inch fragment of mirror directly reflecting the sun at noon on a clear summer day. Is the light intense? Can the memory of a moment's gaze at Baba illuminate the mind of one who seeks to know Him? Can it touch the heart of one who loves Him?

He knows.

Dr. Ram (3)

This story is about my experience going to Kolkata for *microvita* sadhana. I did not know what it was really, but I was told I should go. There were several margiis from the States in Lake Gardens. I was there only for a few days and had to come back to Delaware. About a month later, there was a call from Kolkata asking me to come immediately, because Baba wanted to give special sadhana. My wife was pregnant with our third child, and expecting the baby any time, and she was quite upset that I was going to leave. It took a long time to persuade her that everything would be OK, that Baba would take care of it. So finally she gave me permission to leave, and I was going to go for a quick trip.

I was told I would see Baba the next day at 8:30 in the morning. I was the first person to see Baba that morning. *Microvita* sadhana, or sometimes called *shakti sampat sadhana*, was given to a few people, who had to meet certain criteria: within a certain age group, in good physical health, and doing all lessons. I understood that people were supposed to apply for it. I didn't know that and hadn't applied. Apparently Baba picked my name and asked General Secretary (GS) about it. GS later held my hand and said, "Baba loves you very much, you don't love Baba enough" [laughs]. I was trying to love Baba, but His love is overwhelming.

I was alone with Baba for two hours. Part of that time was missing, an hour or so. Then Baba told me that I received *anandam*, which I understand as a form of *samadhi*. That day in the hotel room, I was not able to do anything, only constantly say, "Baba Baba" nonstop. Some *acarya* told me that Baba commented on it, that Ram is saying Baba nonstop and could not hold back. There was that effect from the special sadhana. I don't know why I did that, it was only His grace. So I came back to the States, and within a week my wife delivered our third child. There was no problem. Baba was taking care of everyone.

Let me tell about my experience with Baba the last time I saw Him, in Dec. 1989. We had planned a trip to India to see our parents, so the whole family went to India via Bombay. We had a short vacation, but we were fortunate that on the first day in Kolkata

Baba was giving a darshan. This was the continuing Sunday program when Baba talked about *Shabda Cayanika*, the letters. I think He was talking about the letter ‘ka.’ The darshan hall was packed with 200 people. And Baba appeared very healthy and in good spirits. He was smiling and very humorous, making everyone laugh very much. And He talked without any fatigue for two and a half hours. The next day we took a flight to South India – we had to change planes twice and reached home in evening. When I arrived I was told that GS called from Kolkata, and there were some calls from Bangalore by the regional *acaryas*. I called Bangalore and Dada told me that Baba had been admitted to the nursing home in Kolkata. A nursing home in India is like a hospital, with intensive care. GS wanted me to come back to Kolkata right away. Dr. Ramesh was attending Baba, and functioned as a liaison between the nursing home doctors and the *dadas*. They wanted me to relieve Dr. Ramesh.

I took my wife and children to her home in a nearby village. The local airline was on strike, so my only chance was to take a night bus. It was 10 to 12 hours to Bangalore. Fortunately I got a plane ticket to Kolkata. I didn’t know what my parents thought because I was seeing them after four years and suddenly I had to leave. But they did not object to my leaving. Dada Santosananda-ji met me and told me not to worry about anything, that it was simply Baba’s *liila*. He was on his way to New Delhi. I’m saying this because all along, throughout the years, there was conflicting opinion on how to care for Baba. And some would say we should not pressure Baba to follow any points about diet, medical care and so forth, that He was all-powerful. Years ago I had written letters to PA, because I had seen Baba’s electrocardiogram, and there were some problems with it. And several instructions concerning diet were really not paid attention to, because of the same feeling, perhaps.

Anyway, I was at the nursing home morning to evening, for four or five days. And Dr. Wolden was the cardiologist who was taking care of Baba. Baba was admitted for high blood pressure and out of control diabetes, and a heart problem. And Baba was not taking rest even in the hospital, probably because He wanted to meet with people and all that. He then was heavily sedated, so that He was resting. I’m a cardiologist also, and I talked to Dr. Wolden on a daily basis. One day an echocardiogram was done. I had access to Baba’s records, and what I saw from all those, even though Baba had heart problems

and other physical problems, if given the proper attention and care, He could have lived another twenty years or so. That is our experience with some patients here in the U.S. who have cardiac problems. We did try to bring Baba to the U.S. for some treatment, but of course Baba refused. And I heard that Baba would not follow instructions at least some of the time, and would get angry when people insisted. On the fourth day, things were reasonably under control. I noted certain follow-up tests for Baba through PA and I understood Baba did not want to go through all of those things. So PA told me I could go back to South India because Baba would be leaving the hospital soon.

And one old margii, a businessman, he was like a millionaire, he knew a lot of people, went with me to the airline office and talked with several people but there was no way I could get a ticket. It was Christmastime, tickets were booked until mid-January, and I didn't have much leave. By train or bus it would take me three days to reach. So I was kind of disappointed. Then this brother Rate-ji took me to all the sweet shops in Kolkata. Next day however I was sick, with fever and headache, but I knew I had to leave somehow. Miraculously, my ticket arrived, someone brought a ticket for me. It was Baba's Grace only, because there were 150 people on the wait list, and they even said there was absolutely no way.

So then I wanted to take Baba's permission to leave, but Baba was sleeping, sedated. I didn't want to disturb Baba, but saw a little opening. Somehow the room door opened fully, and PA was inside, and it was as if I fell inside the room. I quietly did my *sastaung pranam* next to the cot. PA said something, and Baba was fully alert. He chanted something and I understood this was a blessing, and Dada Keshavananda told me later, you had something like PC that day. So I told Baba I was leaving, and Baba gave permission. I came out and had no fever, headache, nothing, all fresh, ready to go. Baba was supposed to be the patient lying in bed, but you didn't know who was doctoring whom.

Mahajyoti

Los Angeles, California

I became a margii in 1970 in the Philippines. My acarya is Didi Ananda Mitra. My husband Phanindra encouraged me, but I didn't really want to be a margii. It was so hard to be vegetarian. He continued going to the *jagrti* that time. Many people were attending there. One day I became curious, and said, "I'll go and see, and if I like it I'll take initiation."

Phanindra said, "You cannot go unless you get initiated." And I said, "No way."

Anyway I went, and got inspired, and went to Didi Mitra's *jagrti*. She gave me first lesson. The experience I had was very beautiful; I felt elevated off the floor. What is this? I felt like I was floating. I told Phanindra about it, and he could not explain why. It was a very good feeling, but never happened again.

In 1989 we decided to visit Baba in India; that was my first time. But unfortunately He was in the hospital. It was frustrating for me. We waited a week to see if He would come out, but He did not. There was instruction that everyone was to go to Ananda Nagar for *Dharma Maha Sammelan*, because He might go there. Our flight back to the U.S. was on Jan. 3rd. We arrived back to Tiljala on Jan. 3rd in the morning, and found out that Baba had come out on New Year's Day. The only time I could see Him was that day, because our flight was in the afternoon, but they said He was not coming out. I wanted to see Him so much.

Then they announced that Baba was coming at 10 that morning, but they said no kiirtan, everybody should be quiet. He needed to walk around in a quiet and peaceful environment. So everyone stood at the fence. I had my five-year-old daughter Liila with me. I put her on top of the fence, but they said no one should be sitting on the fence. But she had made friends with the VSS guards, so they let her stay. And I also was able to stay there, close, to see Baba.

When Baba came out of the house, He did a very long namaskar. That namaskar was very inspiring. Every time I have a hard time in my meditation I just think of that namaskar, and the nice feeling, and I get back in the flow again.

Anyway, He came out of the house with his son Kinshu, and walked around. We were told not to make any noise at all. But since Liila was a handful and talkative at that age, she just continued talking. I said, “Liila, we were told not to talk, just think of Baba.” But she would not. But the minute Baba came right in front of us, she stopped talking, and did namaskar to Baba. Again when Baba went in the house, He gave a very long namaskar on all sides, and went in. Then I asked Liila, “Why did you stop talking when Baba was just in front of us?”

She said, “I just thought to myself, I love you Baba, that’s what I was thinking inside me.”

After He passed away, I had a nice vivid dream. I saw Baba in front of the *puja* table, cleaning the *puja* table, dusting it, taking off the cloth and shaking it out. Liila and Phanindra were talking to Him. That time I was very sick. I had a severe chronic cough. In the dream, Baba asked me, “Mahajyoti, how do you feel, are you still coughing?”

“No, Baba, I am feeling better.”

And He continued cleaning. And Liila had this lungi given to Phanindra by an *acarya*. She jumped on Baba’s lap, and said, “Look, my molar is coming out,” and Baba held her like a baby. Baba started to feel the molar coming out. Then He said to Phanindra, “Do you still want to change Liila’s name?” because we had thought about changing her name.

“No, it’s OK.”

I said, “But Baba, she’s very slow in learning in preschool.”

And Baba made a gesture like, don’t worry, she’ll catch up.

After Baba finished cleaning, there was a pot of roses, and one branch was broken, and Phanindra was going to remove it. Baba said, “No, this is how you do it.” Baba planted the branch, and as soon as He stuck it in the foil, like magic, red roses came up. I whispered to Phanindra, “Are you going to bring Baba to your office, and give him a denture?” He didn’t say anything. After that, Baba stood up, we did namaskar to Him, He went into a dark room, and then I woke up. I had thought it was real. This dream was very nice for me, and I cannot forget it.

Phanindra

Los Angeles, California

I found Ananda Marga, or rather AM found me about 1972 or '73. I feel it was not an accident. At the time I was searching for something, but could not find it. My place was very close to the AM *jagrti* in Paco, about ten minutes ride away. I always passed that place. I met one *acarya* there. He was a very good man, Dada Adveshananda. I learned *nama mantra* from him.

I didn't really understand what AM was all about. In my first encounter with him, he told me to bring all the people around my area, then come back and he would give me another lesson. I didn't have money for my fare; I was in total hardship. I thought, "How am I going to bring all the people around me?" We lived in a hard-pressed area. So I was not able to do it. But I still came to Paco.

One time there was a retreat and I really wanted to go. I was very excited to go, but I had no experience of what it was. There was one *acarya* (at DC) who asked who will go to the retreat. I raised my hand. He looked at me and said, "Do you meditate twice a day, for at least 30 minutes?"

I wasn't doing that, but I had this buddy with me, and he hit me in the back with his elbow, "Just say yes." I said yes. But this *acarya* looked me in the eye, and I felt he had X-ray vision, and he was just looking internally at me. And I couldn't say anything, but just stayed quiet and dumbfounded.

"No, no," he said, "you are not meditating for 30 minutes a day, twice a day." I was shocked, and thought I should not go to the retreat. I went home, and I was crying in the jeepney. I felt so bad. I had really wanted to go. That was my first clash with AM. I did not go back. But my seeking was still strong, that longing for something. I started looking around for other practices. There was one place where some old folks were doing some practice. It was kind of a Biblical yogic practice. I did it very sincerely. I was in college at that time.

When I finished my studies, I practiced, giving it more time than my studies. I had this longing within me. And I had some experience I could not understand or explain, like being out of the world. Every morning when I woke up, I saw this person before me,

wearing white. Every morning I saw this person, and the experience was becoming stronger and stronger. One day I had a desire to go back to AM, even though the clash was still in my mind. And I attended classes for beginners at the *jagrti*. In the evening I would see a person in orange standing by the stairs, looking at me. Why is he always looking at me, I thought. The third night we were asked who would like to learn meditation. I was directed to come to that *acarya*. He initiated me. I had no idea that I had already been initiated by Dada Advshanada.

Next morning, I woke up and saw the same person, but this time there was a face to the person – before there had been no face – and it was the face of my guru, of Baba. And all the difficulties I had in meditating, one by one they disappeared.

Years later I went to India. I had read many spiritual stories. I knew that Baba as guru could know and see everything, but sometimes the mind has doubt. In one darshan I was at the back of the hall. I knew the story of the man who was asking for a boon from the Lord, that he not die. He would remember God during the day and night, but unfortunately not at evening.

I had this desire to have something from Him. I said, “Please let me not forget you at daytime, nighttime, or dusk or dawn. Let me not forget you.” He would look at me and nod. Then again I repeated my request, that “I should remember you.” And again He looked at me, and nodded again. Then He was talking to General Secretary, and my mind was focused on my desire, and He would look at me and nod again.

After some time, He looked at me with a very serious face, as if to say, “Don’t you understand, I know what you’re doing, and I have granted what you want.” From that time on, I never doubted Him. I always remember Baba now, whether I am thinking, or happy, or just woke up or asleep, or taking a bath. He always comes in my mind. He kept His promise.

We had to wait for Baba to come out, and we knew the hour He would come. One afternoon, it was not time for Baba to come. But I was getting a strong desire to go to Lake Gardens. Nobody was there. Generally people would be in line there. I saw Baba

walking, and all the *dadas* were smiling at me, as if He was telling me, “This is the time you can see me.” I was not supposed to go at that hour, but I had felt a strong pull.

One morning, Baba was passing around His house, telling stories to the *acaryas* walking with Him, and all the *margiis* were standing there. I developed the desire for Baba to talk to me. In my mind I had a picture of Him holding my hand and talking to me. But every time, Baba would stand in front of me, and talk to the person on one side of me, then the person on the other side of me, but not to me. I was looking at Him, and I kept internally asking, “Please talk to me.” But anyway I was enjoying His presence. It must have gone on for a long, long time. Every time I would say “Please, Baba talk to me, hold my hand.” And He would come back and talk to the other brother and hold his hand. And He was playing with me like this. And finally I let Him go, but He did not hold my hand.

Then there was this *acarya* standing by the fence, and he said to me, “So, Phanindra, this morning Baba was for you alone.”

I said, “No, He was talking to the other brother.”

He said, “No, He was for you alone.”

It was a nice experience. He fulfilled my desire, and He was playing with me.

We moved to America, and were barely surviving. People coming here get a kind of social shock, especially Asians. We did too. We were hard-pressed; my wife used to work in the morning, and I worked in the evening. And we took care of the baby in turn. My sleeping hours were disrupted, and I barely got enough sleep. By the time I was about to go to sleep, it was time to go to work. This went on for four years. But in those four years, He was always prepared to help us. It was a blissful time.

I had a shift all day, and in the night. We used to live in another part of the city; it took several transfers to go to my work. I took the last bus of the evening. If I missed it, then I had to walk. I reviewed charts for doctors at that time, so I had to be there. Most of the time I was very sleepy. So I slept in the bus stop. I said to Baba, “Wake me up for the bus.” Before the bus came, automatically I would wake up. Always. One of those nights, I was really very sleepy, and I did not wake up. And someone came and shook me,

“Wake up, are you waiting for the bus?” So I should say that for many years He never forgot. He is always there; His hands are really very great and very long.

One time I was not yet practicing dentistry; I didn't have my license. My wife had oral surgery. They gave her codeine, but she had an adverse reaction. We were eating with friends, and she passed out on the table. I didn't know what to do. In my confusion, I closed my eyes, and saw Baba in divine gesture; in my mind I saw some *mantras*. When she was unconscious, and we didn't know to call 911 or not, I closed my eyes, saw Baba in *varabhaya mudra*, and these *mantras* came. I put my hands on her *sahasrara cakra*, hoping the *mantra* would come through. And after that she opened her eyes. After that I also forgot the *mantra*. He just gave me enough chance so that she would recover.

His hands are everywhere. One time we were driving to our apartment, on a small side street. There was a big car and for some reason it was running past us, and I moved over. It was so fast I could not take any precaution. It almost hit us, and at that moment I was just looking at the car and in my mind I saw Baba in *varabhaya mudra*, and at that moment, the car went by, did a 90 degree turn, and went into an open driveway without getting into any accident. And I felt the Lord saved us from an accident. So much help He gives us.

I was wondering whether to go to India or not. To go or not to go. One of those times, I was sitting there and crying I was thinking of Him. My eyes closed and I felt the door open, and someone standing there before me. I turned around and looked, and I saw Baba waving His hands at me. After that I felt that He was not really playing, that this was His real body.

There was a time I went to India. I had to go home before DMC, so I did not get the chance to see Baba and enjoy His *mudra*. I had to return and so deep inside I started developing some resentment that I couldn't see His *mudra*. I wanted to see how peaceful it was. Of course we know it from His picture, but I wanted to see it personally. One day when I was still working in the hospital, and I had no sleep, I woke up very late. I ran to my bus, and I missed it. I was so worried about how to get to the hospital. I did not know how to drive at that time. I said to my wife, “Please help me, accompany me.” My

brother-in-law had an old used car. The key was there. I got in the car, and somehow practiced. I said to Baba, “Please help me, watch out for me.” I was driving very, very carefully and in my mind was always Baba. By His grace I was able to get to my job, without a driver’s license or anything.

That night, during my break I was very tired. I put Baba’s picture in front of me, and looked at Him, and laid my head down to rest. Before I slept, I felt all my hairs standing on end, felt a different energy like someone was looking at me. You know that feeling when you are young, and someone wants to fight with you, and your hairs stand on end, you are all excited. I had the same feeling, but this was different as if someone was looking at me. I raised my head, and the first thing I saw was Baba in front of me. I saw Baba from the picture coming out, and He was giving me the *varabhaya mudra*. His hands were moving, and He gave the *mudra*. That night was so blissful for me. And after that, I never dreamed or desired that I missed *varabhaya mudra* in DMC. It just satisfied my desire.

I remember when my wife was pregnant, and we were going to the hospital. They were monitoring the baby. We held hands, and thought of Baba, in front of the doctor. The doctor was surprised, but we were just smiling. The baby was not due to come out; it was being monitored.

Then the alarm sounded. The doctor came and checked and said they had to operate. But we were not prepared for it. The doctor said, “You must have the operation right now.”

We said, “Please just give us a few minutes.”

So we held hands and were ideating on Baba, and saw Him in *varabhaya mudra*. And when that happened, the alarm stopped. And the doctor came and said, “It’s OK. Maybe we should bring her to the labor room.” After some time, the baby was born. We sang Baba Nam Kevalam to the baby. The doctor said, “I don’t know what you did there, and we cannot explain it, but it was a very big risk that you took.” We just smiled, because in our heart we knew that He was with us.

After all these years I still have the habit of going to work a little late. After I passed my board exam, I more or less knew how long it would take me to go to work. On my first day, I had just enough time for the travel. But the traffic was not moving. This was my first day, I was going to be late and I thought they would fire me. I was crying inside. I said, “Oh Baba, with all your powers, still what can you do with this traffic? I will miss my job.” I leaned on the steering wheel. Then someone honked from behind, and I looked up and the traffic was moving, faster and faster. When I got off the highway, all the traffic lights were green. And the only red that happened was the red just before my job. I came in, and the doctor said to me, “Oh, you are so precise, on time.” I felt, never doubt the power of guru, He can do anything. I was thinking it was almost impossible to make it, but by His grace I did.

Purodha Pramukha [the head of the organization after Baba left His body] came here. Margiis were walking with him, just like on field walk. He was asking how we were, and he asked me, “How’s your second lesson?” I said, “Fine, Dada.” I felt it was just casual. After the retreat I went home, then to work. I had a patient, and I was not doing anything yet, but she started vomiting, and started holding her throat. I didn’t know what to do, and she also did not know. I thought of Baba, and saw Him in *mudra*, and as soon as I said my second lesson. All of a sudden she just recovered. It was like a miracle. I had thought she was going to die. Then I went in my room, and cried to Baba, and remembered PP Dada asking, “How is your second lesson?”

Girija

San Diego, California

I was initiated in 1979 by Didi Ananda Rama, so I've been a margii a very long time. When I first moved to San Diego there were no other margiis here, and there was a time when I didn't really know if I was a margii or not, because there was no one else here, and I didn't follow the practices so strictly.

One day I went to this metaphysical place where they do aura readings. There were two people in training there. The teacher came into the room, and she looked at me, and asked, "Do you have a guru?" I was surprised, because I hadn't really thought about it for a while.

"Yes, I guess I do."

She said to the two people, "When you're reading her aura, her guru is right there, so be aware of that."

I was surprised about it. They started doing the reading. The man started talking, "I see you are very spiritual. Deeply spiritual. Wow. You are so spiritual!"

And the other woman jabbed him with her elbow, and said, "That's her guru!"

Then I thought, "OK, Baba, even though I don't know if you're my guru, you still know that you're my guru, and you're still with me." That's what He was telling me. That no matter what I think, He's still with me all the time, even if I don't know that He is.

I had another experience like that. I think Baba just needed to keep telling me this. We did this card reading – I don't really do this very often, but every time, they talk about Baba. So I went, and the person said, "You know, you've had a very powerful spiritual guide, since your childhood."

And suddenly, I remembered, that since I was five years old, I had thought I had a guardian angel. And it clicked with me, Oh, that was Baba. Even then. He was with me my whole lifetime, waiting for me to find Ananda Marga.

When I went to Tiljala, I was in GV (Girls' Volunteers). I was in the guard when Baba walked into the darshan hall. I had never met Him before. I always felt so close to Him without seeing Him. And when I actually saw His body, it was like, who is that? It

took me a little while to see the person I was internally so attached to, and the physical body was kind of hard for me to see.

But when He walked by me, He turned, and looked straight into my eyes, and then walked on. I didn't really think very much about it. Three years later, I was doing some meditation, and all of a sudden, I saw Baba, that image of Him walking by me and looking directly in my eyes. It just pierced my very being.

And I could feel that that was what He was doing, looking directly into my soul, and knowing who I was. It took me a long time to recognize what He was doing, but finally I understood. I may be slow about knowing what He wants me to know, but even though it takes me a long time, Baba always waits for me.

□ Gagan Monterrey, Mexico

I've been in Ananda Marga for more than 20 years. I was very interested in meditation, and began reading different books by different authors. I wanted to practice, but I didn't know how to do it. Even in the books it said it was not good to do it without the guidance of a guru. All of a sudden, Ananda Marga came into my life. I met Dada Citsvarupananda, who came to stay with me for a few weeks. And I became completely involved with all the activities, the practices, social service, reading Baba's books, hearing about His philosophy, everything. The Ananda Marga way of life was now in my house. It was a great opportunity, having Dada stay with me, and I began to practice regularly. Since then I have done meditation every day, twice a day.

Later, Dada Shankarananda said it was very important to have Personal Contact with Baba, and he lent me money to buy a plane ticket to India. So I went in October, 1987. It was an incredible experience: meeting margiis from all over the world, seeing Baba every day, and getting Personal Contact with Him. The more time passed the more I realized it was the ultimate privilege for me to meet Baba and to be in Ananda Marga. All the margiis in India around Baba's house were always talking about Baba and His philosophy. There wasn't any other topic of conversation. It was a complete involvement in His mission. After I came back, I began to realize more and more the personality of Baba. At the time of Personal Contact, I was not fully aware of His greatness. Now, the more time passes, the more I realize His all-encompassing personality.

At one time I was tempted to leave because I thought Ananda Marga was not growing. We did not have new margiis, we were just a few constant in our practices, and I felt something was wrong with Ananda Marga here in Monterrey. So I was tempted to leave for another yoga group. I have been in several groups, but only for a few days, because they did not fulfill my expectations. At that time I had a dream, and heard Baba's voice, and He was telling me that I have come to Ananda Marga to stay. In the morning, I thought about it, and realized He was right. It was stupid for me to think I could leave Ananda Marga. It was my life. So many times I have had guidance from Baba. I ask for His guidance, and He is always with me. I have the greatest faith in Baba.

Arun

Denver, Colorado

I was initiated March 27, 1971. In 1980, *Dharma Samiksa* had just ended. I was wanting to go see Baba. Dada Yatiishvarananda had returned to the U.S. and he said, “Don’t go, you won’t see Baba.”

But I wanted to go, and it was time. I got to New York, and the airline strike was going on, and my luggage did not come with me to India. That was my first taste of leaving to go into Baba’s presence, that we don’t need our physical possessions. I flew into Kolkata. When I went into downtown Kolkata, I had no idea how to get to any of the Ananda Marga quarters. So I thought if I sat down, something will happen. And lo and behold, within a very short time, someone came over and said, “You want to go see Baba?”

I said, “Yes, I do.” I was taken by rickshaw to His quarters.

At that time His body was weak, and so we were only able to see Him at the time of field walk. There were many Italian margiis there and their kiirtans were very sweet.

The next time was in 1986. I went with Mahadeva and I was able to get Personal Contact with Baba. We played the game that Baba likes to play, which was waiting. We had to make sure we memorized the 16 points. It took two or three days. We were told, “Wait,” then, “No, Baba’s not seeing anyone now.” Finally, I got to go in.

I remember going into His room. I don’t remember what I saw except for Baba sitting there on the bed. He told me I had been a bad boy, and that I had to serve humanity. He asked my name. I had some questions, but my mind was completely gone in front of Baba. I didn’t remember anything. He said, “You are the son of a great father.”

He touched me on the head, said some *mantras*, and then it was over. I came back to the U. S. and my whole life was in an uproar for about two years.

Baba on the spiritual level has been more profound, even though the experience of being with Him for PC was the most special thing in my life.

There have been a couple of profound meditation experiences. I came back from a summer retreat. It was the first year I had organized the Ananda Mela and I just had a feeling that something was going to happen. I came back to Denver on the 4th of July. I

had been having these dreams where I'd be on an island. There would be a tetherball pole. I'd be holding on to the string and swinging around, and I had fear of letting go. There was this vast ocean all around.

So I sat for sadhana and had the feeling of my 'I' withdrawing to a point, where there was just space. Thoughts were like little boxes floating by. All the fear I had had, it related to having earlier been in the training center in Los Altos, where someone had said you should be called Viira, which meant fearless, and I had never felt that way, until now in this meditation. I felt there was no need to fear anyone, that we have a responsibility to serve on this planet, and we cannot fear.

I remember sitting down, closing my eyes, and swinging on that rope on that pole. Baba was with me, and we were jumping in and jumping out of the ocean. It was incredible. That feeling of not having any fear was very profound.

Gayatrii (3)

In 1984 I was in Kolkata, in the beautiful abode of Baba. The name of His residential house is Madhu Malanch, meaning ‘The Abode of Sweet Charm.’ And so it was. Daily, the devotees waited and waited, hour after hour, for Baba to come downstairs and out onto the driveway, to distribute His infinite love and affection by a mere glance, or a sweet charming question to a dumbstruck disciple. People came from all over the world to visit Madhu Malanch. His attraction was so great. What He gave to the world over the span of just a few decades was so vast. It will take centuries for the earth’s inhabitants to realize the vastness of His gifts to our planet.

But this was not the main reason people came from all over the world. People came simply to experience His love, to feel His love. His love was the Infinite Divine love of the Infinite Entity, the Supreme Entity, the Cosmic Nucleus – the Supreme Stance. His love and affection were so great, just a drop put one into ecstasy, into higher levels of existence, into intense great rapture. People came because they could comprehend that Baba was indeed their best friend, their dearest darling. Nay, He was their Only Friend, their true Beloved.

All others come and go, move on in this world. But Baba is always there. Through whatever joys we have, He will be there, silently witnessing. And through our unbearable sufferings, our horrible pains and agonies, He becomes the most intimate companion, never leaving us alone, but keeping us so very close to Him. It is for this that we keep running to Him. Once we have experienced His care and His love, we cannot leave it. When we cannot leave His love, it means, we have simply fallen head over heels in love with the Lord! We have become mad with loving Him. It is called devotion.

In 1986, some of us were allowed to accompany Baba on a tour of His garden. There were perhaps twelve of us. We collected on the driveway and then Baba came and humbly thanked us for coming to see His garden. His words were the epitome of humility, the epitome of courtesy and politeness, of gentlemanliness, of Supreme Charm and Supreme Benevolence. In His every move, every gesture, every word, and every tone and accent when speaking any word, He was teaching us. He was showing us the Supreme example of how to be in this world. On a practical level, it only made Him

infinitely and unbearably irresistible. Then everyone began to move down the path. By some strange miracle – by His miracle – Baba and I were the last two to proceed on the path through the garden. By some unbelievable miracle – His miracle – Baba and I moved, side by side, down the path. It was a distance of maybe 50-60 feet, and then the path took a 90-degree left turn.

During that time, we walked side by side, almost touching each other. We were silent. But the vibration was overpowering! Was I walking? My mind was just spellbound by His close proximity. I do not know why, without asking, He gave me His close proximity so many times. I wanted to walk with Him forever and ever, side by side, in Divine Peace, in Supreme Shelter. But, the path took a left turn and Baba suddenly was ahead. I felt so much pain that He had moved a little ahead. And so much stunned disbelief that He had walked with me so far, alone, oblivious to all! In a short while we were upstairs in His room, sitting in a circle in front of Him. He asked some, “How did you like it? How did you like my garden?”

After a few minutes He pointed in my direction and asked, “And how did you like it?”

I quickly turned my head to the right, thinking He was talking to someone behind me. And then I heard, “No, you, you!” He was speaking to me! O Lord! Without a second’s wait, I simply said, “It is wonderful, Baba!” And then Baba smiled. He smiled with a closed mouth. But His smile was the biggest smile in the world! Infinite joy was being expressed through His smile!

How many times I was waiting amongst hundreds of devotees in the driveway of Baba’s house, but standing so far back that there was no hope of getting close to Him. And I would not push my way through. But again and again it happened that the rain came. With only a few drops of rain, the vast number of devotees would scurry into the garage seeking protection from the rain. The rain became my best friend and ally! The rain allowed me to move just so close to the very spot where, say, Baba would step out of His car, where He would begin His walk along the path, where I could even speak with Him if I wanted! Tiny, tiny miracles to arrange close proximity to my Beloved – all adding up to His supreme grace, His supreme love for His small child.

Another time I came to Kolkata, riddled with complexes, feeling so unworthy, so undeserving, feeling I should not even be a part of His mission, feeling He should make me an outcast in the farthest reaches of this earth. I stood in the driveway the first day, waiting for My Lord to come, but full of fear and complexes, thinking I could hardly dare to look on Him, or look at His glorious face. But He came and walked right up to where I stood, and stopped. He did namaskar to me and to me alone! And He smiled – how He smiled! – all teeth showing, smiling from ear to ear! It was such a magnificent, glamorous smile – it was full of His love, His affection! I was stunned. I thought, can this be happening? Why is He smiling at me? Why not others? Others around me are far more important; they are the VIP’s of this world. I am nothing. I am nobody.

And in fact, I make hundreds or thousands of mistakes every minute of every day. Why did He smile at me? Baba turned and again walked down the path to His door. And then, again He came to the driveway and walked right up and stopped AGAIN right in front of me! AGAIN He did long namaskar, and AGAIN Baba was smiling – such a vast smile! This time, in a tiny little voice, I said, “Namaskar, Baba!” I was still too stunned, still convinced that I did not deserve His love. Look at my Baba! To the most undeserving and unworthy, He heaped and continues to heap His love!

Daily I used to play guitar and sing for Baba. I used to sing His *Prabhat Samgiit*, His tender songs. Once it happened that a brother said to me, “What’s this? You’re singing the same songs again and again!” I felt so hurt, and resolved not to sing again. I went to sleep that night firmly resolved not to even bring my guitar the next morning. Just before waking up, I had a short dream. In that dream, Baba was sitting in front of me. He said simply, “You will bring the guitar. And you will sing.” It was crystal clear, this dream. So when I woke, I felt I should take the guitar. I took the guitar, but with much hesitation and trepidation also, worrying that again that brother might be tired of my songs. After coming to Baba’s quarters, many sisters and brothers were there and were singing one song after another, as Baba sat in His chair on the driveway. I felt so hesitant. Finally when there was a small break between songs, I started to play and sing the song *Elo Anek Yuge Se Ajana Pathik*.

But I sang very quietly and, as they did not hear me, the sisters/didis started to sing another song and I was completely drowned out. Not only that, I was gradually pushed by all the sisters right into the garage, still feebly singing and playing, and completely out of sight of Baba. I felt weak due to the heat. I didn't know whether to continue or to stop. I started to feel some mental irritation with Baba, thinking that, if this was going to be the state of things, then why did He appear in a dream and give me specific instructions to sing for Him! Feeling full of mental complex, I was almost crying. Suddenly, dadas and didis near me started saying, "Sing louder! Move forward!" And they made a path for me to move. They told me, 'Baba is asking, "Who is singing '*Elo Anek Yuge Ajana Pathik*?' It means 'The Eternal, Unknown Traveler Came Today!'" Without any effort, I moved forward and then stood just close to Him, maybe four feet distant, and finished singing my song. How gracious He was!

On the last day, when departing, I was putting a thick garland of flowers over Baba's head and around His neck. (Often on such occasions, BABA would become shy and would ask sweetly, "Are you sure these are for me?") This time, another devotee said to Baba, 'This reminds me of a song, but I cannot remember it.' Then Baba Himself started to softly sing, "*Ajana pathik tamogo kanik Tomay parobo mala.*" It means, "Oh Lord! Please wait and accept my garland!"

One day a very simple quiet lady came to Madhu Malanch. She was around fifty, and told me she had taught yoga for most of her life, but for one year had been in Ananda Marga. Now she had come to see Baba. She had come all the way from the little island of Cyprus, all alone, and was now in Lake Gardens! I used to sit with her on the little bench while we waited for Baba. I used to tell her also where to stand when Baba would come. In spite of this, she still had not got the chance to do namaskar to Baba. One time, Baba came down the path and got into His car and was sitting in the back seat. This time, I pushed this sweet sister in front of me so that she could quickly get right in front of the car window. In this process, I then could not see Baba. Perhaps just two feet separated me from Him, but as He sat back in the seat, and I had put her in front by His window and by Him, I could not see Him.

In this way, she was able to give Him a big personal namaskar. He also responded by giving her a big namaskar, just for her! Seeing her thus, I felt so excited. Then, as the car slowly moved out of the driveway, I began to smell the most beautiful scent or fragrance – of the most divine flowers or nectar – just enveloping me. The fragrance was so divine that it seemed almost unbearable. It took some moments for me to speak. Then I began asking others around me if they also smelled that most divine heavenly fragrance? But the others said that they did not smell anything. Then I realized what Baba had done. Baba knows everything. He knew that even though I myself was longing to see His sweetest smiling face, I stayed just a little bit behind and out of sight, to give my sweet Cyprus sister that opportunity. What did Baba do? He showered me with His own divine nectar!

January 1990. Due to His sweetest grace, and due to the sweet kindness of Baba's personal assistant, I was inside the gate of Tiljala, His new residence on the outskirts of Kolkata. I was kneeling outside His door and peeking through a tiny crack in the door. BABA was not well. Hence, He was not coming outside for walks through His garden. Baba walked slowly from His bedroom to His living room, and there He lay down on His sofa. Only one brother was with Him, His guard of honor. This was the ONLY WAY one could see Baba, peering through a small crack in His door! What was Baba doing? He was telling jokes to His guard. And then? Baba was laughing! He was laughing so much! He would tell the joke, then the guard would laugh, and then Baba would Himself laugh so much, at His own joke!

Sometimes He laughed so hard, He would roll over onto His back, on the sofa, still laughing and laughing! It was unbelievable! Day after day, for nearly a week, I was peering into that crack, and watching Baba talking and then laughing, telling joke after joke, story after story, and laughing and laughing! It gave me so much realization to see the Lord in this way. I realized, first, that the funniest person in the entire universe is God – my Baba – that all humor emanates from Him. And second, I realized that the Lord wants all of us, all human beings to be laughing! He wants to see us all laughing! He does not want us to be sad or depressed. He wants to see us smiling and laughing! But, who could imagine the Lord of the Universe, laughing and laughing?! This is a beautiful

secret. Very few people know that the Lord, our Baba, is the funniest person in the world!

Baba's health was somewhat better. He had resumed His daily walks through the garden in the mornings. Evenings He used to walk just outside His room. Baba was so beautiful. After His walk was over, a few of us were allowed to wish Him Namaskar, and gaze in bliss at His smiling face – a face whose smile was so vast that if we began to comprehend and feel it, we were in tears. On the last day, just prior to departure, I had so much desire to kneel and touch His feet – nay, to kiss His feet. But, how to dare to fulfill this desire! It was a strong and deep desire I had had for many months. How to do this? I felt it was too bold. Hence, I decided not to even attempt it.

But on that last day, when it was time to garland Him and tell Him goodbye, by His miracle, I stood directly in front of Him. Suddenly, in a flash, I felt myself going down on my knees. In fact, I felt myself pushed down by an external unseen force. Then I was holding His feet in both my hands. Then I was kissing His feet! Baba knows everything. He knows each and every desire. He must fulfill each and every desire before we leave this world. It happened so fast. But it happened. I knelt in front of Him, I touched His tender feet, and then I kissed them. This event would become the greatest treasure of my life. Henceforth, wherever I moved and lived, I would carry this event, this happening, with me in my heart. I touched His feet. And I kissed His feet. It was an event unsurpassed by any other event. Oh, Baba!

Dharmapala

Asheville, North Carolina

By December of 1980, I knew I was overdue to see Baba. I had been initiated in 1973, while Baba was in jail and now He'd been out for over three years. I had graduated from college earlier in the year and finally, I knew it was time. Over the years, I had developed my own special relationship with Baba, through my spiritual practices and Baba's books. It was, of course, an internal relationship. I wondered if Shrii Shrii Anandamurti and my internal Baba could truly be one and the same.

I set my sights on the January *Dharma Maha Cakra* to be held at Ananda Nagar. I traveled with a few other local margiis, who were also making their first trip to India.

We arrived in Kolkata on December 26th, 1980. Soon after landing at the airport, we realized that in ridding ourselves of any information about Ananda Marga that would make Indian Customs suspicious, we had no directions or phone numbers to Ananda Marga *jagrtis* or houses. We booked a room near Sutters Place, figuring we would connect with some margiis easily enough. But alas, it took us three days before we finally ran into an *acarya*. We then found out that Baba had already traveled to Ananda Nagar so we quickly headed there ourselves. We arrived in time for the DMC festival.

I remember that incredible experience of seeing Baba for the first time as He was quickly whisked by me, surrounded by His VSS guards and wholetimer workers, on His way in to give darshan. It was just a glance but I felt such great anticipation and joy. Immediately after darshan Baba was touring the Master Unit projects by car. A few brothers and myself decided we would run to each project and try to "catch" a namaskar from Baba, which we finally did by His third stop.

Later we headed down to the river for a bath. Earlier it had been so crowded but now it seemed deserted. It's strange to have this memory of that bath being so exquisite and refreshing. Relaxing in the cool water, the sun was shining brightly against the rocks and reflecting off the water. A light breeze was blowing

sweetly on my face and there was a joyous feeling in my heart. I didn't know it at the time, but Baba was saying, "Hello, my boy, welcome home."

After the DMC program ended, I, along with so many other margiis, followed Baba back to Kolkata. After no time at all, Baba returned to His daily routine schedule. On my first evening of observing this routine, there were 40 or 50 Westerners and even more Indian margiis hanging around outside Baba's Lake Garden house, waiting to see Him leave for his evening field walk.

When Baba came out through His usual path from His garden, all the margiis converged towards Him. It was quite crowded and I was pushed backwards and wasn't able to get close to Him. Afterwards some margiis were giving beads and garlands to a dada for Baba to bless. The thought entered my mind, "How foolish are these people? What could you possibly give to Baba?"

A few days later, I arrived early at Baba's house, not wanting to miss Him as He left for His morning field walk, and was happily surprised to see that there were only six or seven margiis present. Baba would first do His garden walk which would end at His driveway; from there He would proceed to His car. Of course, if you could put yourself on the driveway between the garden and car then Baba would have to walk right by you. This was the goal of most the margiis during this time and that morning I had the best spot, at the beginning of the driveway.

As Baba came out of the garden I bade Him namaskar, which He immediately returned and then He stopped before me.

He was smiling so sweetly at me and then His eyes went from the top of my head down to my toes and back to my eyes. Even though I had never experienced it before, I was acutely aware that He was looking at me like a loving father looks at his son after a long separation. It was a look of total acceptance and love. Needless to say, I was stunned.

Baba departed quickly, leaving me standing there and I remembered the thought from a few days before, about what you could possibly give to Guru, and I remembered that it's your mind that you give to the Lord and the garland represents that mind. My heart jumped with joy at that moment and I immediately

headed to town in search of the most beautiful garland that had ever been given to Baba.

That evening, the large crowd had returned and I wasn't in such a good spot. But I had my garland which I had so carefully picked out and I was hopeful for a chance to give it to Baba. After what seemed a long wait, Baba again made His way through the crowd towards His car, and again the crowd pushed towards Him and I was pushed back, behind the crowd and I realized I had missed my chance, or so I thought.

I closed my eyes and mentally said, "Baba, this is my mind, and I give it to you," and I held out the flowers. At that moment, Baba stopped dead in His tracks and turned around and walked back towards me. The crowd now opened up like a wedge to let Him through.

He took hold of the garland and said, "And which is sweeter? Are these flowers sweeter or is this boy sweeter?"

He answered His own question touching me on my *anahata* (heart) *cakra*, saying, "This boy is sweeter."

He smiled at me again and quickly disappeared through the crowd. I felt an intense, tingly vibration in my chest that began permeating my body and again felt stunned by the experience. Some of the margiis approached me and were congratulating me and sharing the experience but I was practically oblivious to them. Baba had just shown me that He and my internal Baba were One and if you have a pure, devotional thought, He responds.

I had now been in India over three weeks, staying in Kolkata, in January of 1981. Since returning from DMC at Ananda Nagar on the 1st, I had watched the large contingency of margiis slowly dwindle. I took advantage of this by getting as much contact with Baba as possible. I was blessed with some great experiences with Baba, (some direct and some indirect).

But I was greatly disappointed when I discovered I wasn't allowed to go on garden walks or field walks with Baba due to the rule that you had to have PC (personal contact) first. Of course, this was one of my primary goals of going to India: to get PC

with Baba. For seven years I had listened to the stories of so many of the margiis about their PC and how important it was to get it. I wanted it and I had to somehow get it.

I wasn't alone. A few other margiis that I was hanging around with also shared this goal. But there was bad news. We had been requesting different important-looking dadas to have PC, but we would get different reports. At first we heard that Baba was only giving PC to LFTs (local full time volunteers) who had committed to *acarya* training. Then we would be speaking to a group of Indian margiis and one would mention that he had received PC that very morning. We went back and complained and one dada said "The senior *acaryas* have decided that Baba should not give PC at this time due to His being ill with piles.

This I found interesting (and a bit disturbing). I felt bad for Baba but I thought, "What's a few more PCs for *Taraka Brahma*?" And who was in control here? The Central dadas? (This had also been a nagging question discussed among certain margiis in my unit in Palo Alto. Was Baba in charge of things or were the Central dadas somehow manipulating Baba?) Finally, another American brother and myself saw Baba's personal secretary *Acarya Ramananda Avadhuta*, standing by himself, so we approached him. I asked, "Dadaji, we have been waiting here for three weeks to get PC; now we are told that Baba is sick and the dadas are not letting Baba give PC. Are we just wasting our time? Should we return to our homes and get on with our lives?" Dada thought for a moment and said "Mmmm, that's a good question... I will ask Baba." I accepted this answer, but for some reason I didn't really take it so seriously.

As I said earlier, I had been trying to get as much contact with Baba as I could. This I was primarily doing by being at Lake Gardens when Baba left and returned for His field walks about mid-morning and again in the evening after supper. One afternoon my friend invited me to go downtown with a small group of margiis to have supper. I declined, stating I wanted to make sure I was at the gate (to Lake Gardens) for Baba's field walk. He assured me that we would be back in time so I accompanied him. We had a great dinner but I realized it was running late. I tried to rush back by taxi but when I arrived at the gate, it was clear that Baba had already returned. While standing at the gate, I took an oath that for my remaining time in India, I would be at Baba's house twice a day to see Him.

A few days later I was standing in Baba's driveway waiting for Baba to emerge from His garden walk. I had gotten a great spot as there were only a few margiis present that morning (and I was the only Westerner). Baba stopped in front of me, and my hands were up in the 'namaskar' position.

Baba said, "Ramananda, what do they say?" Usually, this is where Ramananda would say, "Baba, they say 'Namaskar.'" But instead he said, "Baba, they say they have been waiting here for many weeks to have your PC and they are wondering why no PC?"

Of course I was shocked. It now seemed so disrespectful and pathetic to make any such request from Baba, and my smile froze on my face. But Baba appeared entertained by it.

Baba again looked at me and said, "The answer to that question is "Why?"

He chuckled to Himself and then climbed into the back of His car with His cadre for the day. After they had left, one *acarya* said to me, "Now you will get PC" and he and a few others instructed me to hurry to Jodhpur Park (Central office) where Baba would be heading for reporting after His field walk. This was seven or eight blocks away so I decided to run all the way.

When I arrived, Baba was already inside the reporting room with the wholetimers. A large group of mostly Western margiis were in the DC hall outside the reporting room, singing *bhajans*. Ramanandaji was sitting outside the door waiting to assist Baba at the end of reporting. I approached him and requested PC. He shook his head in agreement, took out a small notebook and pencil and began asking me my personal data (name, unit, *acarya*, etc.). Finally he said, "Now, you are *bhukti pradhan* aren't you?" I told him I was not, that I was *upa-bhukti pramuk* (below *bhukti pradhan*).

Dada said, "Oh, too bad. Baba is only giving PC to LFTs and *bhukti pradhans*. Are you sure you are not a *bhukti pradhan*?"

I hesitated only a moment. "Yes, I am *bhukti pradhan*." At that very moment there was a loud roar from the reporting room and a dada opened the door and frantically signaled for Dada to come. Dada jumped up but Baba was already coming through the door followed by his guards and all the workers and then all the margiis followed downstairs and outside. I was left standing there eerily alone and wondering, "Did my little white lie cause that?" A dada later told me that Baba had jumped up so quickly to

leave that he (very uncustomarily) left His sandals behind and had to be brought back for them. What a morning.

That evening, I was alone outside the gate when Baba returned from His evening field walk. He looked up and pointed at me and said to the dada that accompanied him, “Look, he’s getting PC twice a day.” And it was so true. I am remembering that warm, sweet feeling that covered my body that night as I hung on that gate, watching Baba slowly make his way up the stairs and disappear into His home.

I returned to my home shortly after this. Baba began giving PC again right after I left (including to my friend). I was to make three more trips to India over the next five years before I finally got it. And it was worth the wait. But that is another story.

Ista

Albuquerque, New Mexico

I was born in the Philippines and that is where I became a margii. I learned about Ananda Marga in December of 1980, but I didn't have a chance to see a dada. I was fourteen years old. I learned of it from this hippie-like community in our town from which some became margiis.

I had a longing since I was a small child for something better than what common culture offered me: drinking, smoking, listening to music. I experimented, but it didn't really make sense to me. I grew up Catholic and at one time tried to be an altar boy. My parents were agnostic; they didn't really go to church. But I always had a longing. I just felt Western religion wasn't for me.

In April 1981, my friend said, "I'm going to show you something interesting." It was Yoga night, and I got initiated by Dada Kalatiitananda. Immediately after, I experienced a very strong response. I had this feeling like I was seeing bubbles. This intoxicating feeling stayed with me for several days doing sadhana. My first experience in Ananda Marga was so deep that I used the memory of this to help me pass through difficult times. I can remember listening to people singing *bhajans*, and the songs went so deep into my heart. It was very strong.

My first experience with Baba was when I was told I had to do *paincajanya*. I started doing it every morning when one day I saw the face of Baba floating on the wall. It was His picture from the *varabhaya* photo without the *mudra*. The interesting thing was I had never seen that picture before.

Shortly afterwards I turned fifteen and my mother died. Although it was a tragic experience, I think it was what made me serious with the practices. I had to take care of my brothers. Often, teenage life is fun without responsibility. But this made me become serious. I finished school but always felt that Baba wanted me to do something different with my life. So I left my scholarship and went to wholotimer training to become a dada. In the training center, I think the most powerful experience I had was when I received sixth lesson. I felt this laughing sensation for days. It was a blissful experience, and when I looked at people I felt laughter and joy. This was a very significant experience, and

many times in life I have wished to feel this state of mind again. At that time I was really convinced I had seen Guru personally, and it was a very mystical and important part of my life.

When I went to India I felt a sorrow in my life and I couldn't understand why. I guess it was one of those things that Baba gives you to prepare yourself. My theory from speaking with everyone who went to see Baba is that He makes you experience some chaos, sorrow, or distress in your life because it makes you more open to see Him. With everything smooth and no problems, you will not receive Him. Always He makes the circumstance that you have to be almost frantic and searching.

The first time I saw Baba was after several years of doing sadhana as an acarya. It was like I was a very dry flower for weeks. Very dry – and then seeing Him I was drenched. I looked into His eyes. There was something remarkable about His eyes. One of His eyes was like in a dreaming state, and the other eye was very piercing. I have never seen a person like this in my life. I know that Baba had trouble with His eyes from the poison He was given in jail. But to see Baba's eyes like that in person was very interesting. It was like He was in two worlds. One eye very aware of everything happening and present, and the other very distant or lost. It reminds me of the stories of Shiva. One of His personalities is very contented, and His one eye reminded me of that. Baba was going to His car for fieldwalk. At that time everybody would try so hard to see Him, but I didn't feel the need to. I just stayed there like a flower drenched in rain.

At this time Baba opened personal contact to everyone. Before, it was hard, but I think Baba wanted to see all of His missionary workers. Baba wanted to give them all P.C. I was at Lake Gardens. It was a cold morning around seven o'clock. Although there was a long line, they threw me right in. Even though Baba did organizational work all over, this house felt like it was His house, His home. Later, I found out it was the only house registered to Him, to P. R. Sarkar. Anyway, it was beautiful. I was waiting there and I saw a Dr. Seuss book. It was a nice feeling to see that Baba had a Dr. Seuss book. As a child, his books had always given me tremendous joy, and it felt nice to see them right before I went to see Baba.

I went in. I remember clearly that day. He was wearing a yellow *khurta*, and He smelled so fresh and naturally pure. I felt a little conscious about myself, whether I was presentable. But I also felt my own self was affected by His fragrance. Whenever I recall that moment even before Baba said anything to me, I think about how the environment changed. When we do sadhana we are supposed to feel alone in the universe. At that moment I felt this feeling of aloneness. I can see now why the scriptures always say Guru is everything. It is my opinion that without this personal relationship with the Guru, one will never achieve the goal of realization. I felt this teaching in the meeting, and maybe now I can share it with others.

Baba asked me, “Did you come alone from the States?”

And I said, “Yes, I came alone.”

Baba said, “Really, you came alone and you weren’t afraid?”

I had ridden on many planes in my lifetime and so I said, “No, no, I wasn’t afraid.” And Baba asked this question about five times. Then, I realized what He was really asking. I realized He was trying to teach me that one is never alone in life.

I caught myself and I said, “No, Baba, I didn’t come alone, I came with you.”

Baba was very happy, and He smiled. And then He became very serious and said in a very deep voice, “Yes, you are never alone.”

He recited some *mantra* and said, “Yes, you are not alone, you can never be alone.” This struck me very deeply inside and really made my heart jump. Then He closed His eyes and really made me feel very peaceful. This was another experience of mine. I felt Baba could control my heart rate. After He closed His eyes, He made me feel very peaceful. And with all of my experiences since then, I have never felt that level of intimacy again in my life.

Jyotisha (2)

This trip was coming to an end all too quickly (although I was tired from the excitement and third world environment). I wanted to stay but was supposed to deliver a baby in a home birth back in Oregon in a few weeks. Also I was almost completely out of money. So I finally decided it would be irresponsible to stay and that I should leave with the group that day on the scheduled flight. I sat that morning and set aside the funds I would need: a rickshaw to Baba's house, a taxi to the airport, food for the day. Cutting the estimations to the bone, I found that I had one rupee left over (I actually had to borrow money later from friends for an airport tax that I had not anticipated). I went out and

with that rupee bought a simple garland of marigold flowers to offer as my parting gift to Baba.

There was a moderate crowd of margiis at Baba's house that day. In recent days Baba had sometimes walked around His house inspecting the many plants and giving instructions for their care before getting into His car. The significance of this is that one could only guess which side of the car to wait on in order to be nearby to Baba when He walked by. If you guessed wrong He would be on the other side of both a crowd and His car. I chose the same spot that I had used the first night I met Baba. No one could get in front of me and I would be able to offer my garland easily. I waited and waited. Suddenly the guards snapped to attention. Baba was coming! Everyone crowded around. Baba came out the side door and immediately turned to walk the long way around the house away from me. I was crestfallen.

As Baba passed the rear corner of His house where He was no longer visible, the crowd shifted over to the far side of His car and everyone jockeyed for a good position. I was left alone standing unmoved in the other corner. I just couldn't believe that Baba would not come to receive my offering. After a few minutes, Baba reappeared around the far corner of the house into view. I could see Him across the car and the crowd walking slowly, stopping before plants and discussing their care with the dadaji responsible for their welfare. He simply must come to take my flowers, I felt, yet He showed no sign that He would alter His route.

The door was open on the far side of the car. He was greeting people as He walked forward to enter the car. I was standing alone many feet behind the people on this side of the car. Vishvadeva and Divyamrta at the back of the crowd were waving me forward, “Jyotisha!” they whispered urgently. “Come on, you can give your flowers through the window.”

But I stood still. I didn’t want to just shove my flowers through the window. Baba was now approaching the car, never looking in my direction. My friends forgot me as they stood in salutation. Baba put one foot inside the car and started to stoop down. Suddenly I realized He wasn’t going to come for my flowers, that I must run over and put them through the car window if I could! At that moment I gave up and a wave of emotion swept through me. I just barely started to move in that direction when, at the same instant that I gave up, Baba stopped. I stopped, not having moved more than a fraction of an inch. He was part way into the car and looking upwards away from me. Baba stood upright. Everyone looked perplexed as if thinking, “What is going on?”

Baba, His back to me with a car and people between us, called out to Sudhiira, who was supposed to paint some murals on the walls in Baba’s garden. Slowly Baba started to walk back around the house the way He had come talking about the mural project. As He disappeared around the far corner of the house the crowd jostled me as they returned to my side of the car and tried to get a good position. But no one could move me from my spot nor could they stand in front of me. Baba came back into view as He rounded the rear corner of the house. He continued to walk and talk, pointing at the wall, presumably discussing the murals that should be painted. Then He nodded His head at Sudhiira and the workers indicating that the discussion was over.

He turned. He looked directly at me. He walked straight up to me and stopped. He cradled my hands in His, the marigolds flowing over the top and covering all. He drew Himself closer, His face just inches from mine and gazed into my eyes.

“Marigolds,” He said slowly. “And who would these be for?”

I was overcome. In a choked whisper I replied, “They are for you, Baba.”

Taking the marigolds between His hands, His palms together, the marigolds cascading over His fingers, He touched His thumbs between His eyes in spiritual greeting and said, “Thank you” with such feeling as if I had given him something wonderful. Yet

it was nothing more than a commonplace little garland of flowers purchased from a bare-foot street vendor at the cost of a mere one rupee.

He turned, gave the garland to His personal assistant (as was the system), and continued walking to the car. Just as He passed me, He stopped. He turned and looked back at me. With a knowing smile He reached out and patted me affectionately on the cheek, then turned away again and proceeded to His car.

I heard from Dada Shantibodhananda (VSS CS in 1980) who'd been living in Baba's house, that one day Baba said to him, "Look at your thumb," and he saw a moving picture on his thumbnail, a motion picture, like a little TV screen. He said it frightened him. And Baba said, "Don't be afraid, this isn't magic, this is science."

As I understood it, Baba said, every event that happens in this universe is recorded in the ether. And it's possible to catch those vibrations from the past, and project them onto a transparent screen and view them. And that Baba was using that technology, so to speak, to project an image from the past. On his thumbnail. Baba said that in the far future scientists would learn this technique and be able to view historical events from the past.

My second trip to India, Fall '86, I was deported on arrival from the Bombay airport. So I went again the next opportunity which was June '87. Baba was very distant at that time. It was the only time I could go, the summer, and Dada Caetananda was asking for good news for Baba. We had recently had an interesting experience in our unit in Oregon, where the landlady would not renew the lease for our school in Portland. She wanted an exorbitant amount of money to purchase it. She said she was going to sell it, and wouldn't change her mind. Finally, my wife got involved and talked to her, and she said OK, and changed her mind.

Dada told the story to Baba, and then told me that Baba had said, "Oh, very good, very good" and that it was positive catalytic *microvita* that brought the change in this lady's mind. Dada also said that Baba asked if the woman was of a certain racial type who, according to Baba, are characteristically very stubborn. I didn't know if she was or was not.

In May of 1990, I had the good fortune to spend a month with Mahadevi and our four-year-old son in Tiljala followed by the DMC in Ananda Nagar. This was really the last big DMC. Back in Tiljala, before the DMC, Baba would walk in His garden everyday and we'd go to darshan every week. Caetanya, our son, was extremely popular. Everyone knew him, and no one knew us except as his parents. He knew GS, he knew PA, everybody, they were all carrying him around. He liked to do *tandava*. So they got him this little bitty skull, really just a face, and a knife, and a little *tandava* outfit. I had a *tandava* outfit, and we were going to do *tandava* before darshan. So since Caetanya was going in, Mahadevi said, "I'm his mother, I'm going to take care of him," and we all got to sit right next to where Baba sits.

Then Dada Caetananda came in and said, "What's that boy doing here? Children can't do *tandava* at darshan! Get him out!" It was completely packed, you couldn't get anyone in or out. Baba was coming. Dada was so upset that he hid his face behind his clipboard. Then Dada Priyaksnananda came in to call *tandava*. And Baba sat there and beamed at Caetanya at the whole time, just smiled, and really enjoyed, and afterwards He said, "Very good."

So everything was OK. The next week the whole family again got to sit near Baba and we danced again, and Baba said, "Excellent." The third week, Baba was very angry. He was yelling at all of the dadas, "You haven't started a single school. You're no good. You're all scoundrels! Get out, you scoundrels!!"

The dadas went out; they were all looking in windows and peering around doors. It was tense, very uncomfortable. We got up to do *tandava*. Caetanya was a little out of rhythm. I jumped, and my knee came down and hit his skull, and it rolled across the floor in front of Baba, all the way over by GS and PA. Baba was sitting there with a very stern look. I whispered to Caetanya, "It's OK, just keep going."

But Priyaksnananda stopped calling the *tandava*. We didn't know what to do; we were all in the squatting position with our knives and skulls outstretched. It was tense. GS picked up the skull, looked at it, looked at Baba, then he rolled the skull across the floor in front of Baba. Caetanya picked it up, they started calling *tandava* again and we finished. Then Baba enthusiastically called out, "Well done!" And then Baba's mood completely changed. Suddenly He was happy and He let everybody come back in.

Mahadevi and I were in Tiljala before the Jan '88 DMC (at Ananda Nagar). We went to the didis' quarters to pay our respects to the head didi (Ananda Bharati) whom everyone called Auntie. I remember she said to us that the secret to success in spiritual life is to follow the instructions of the guru to the letter, to do everything He says and to do it purposefully. That is something I have always tried to remember.

Parvati

Los Angeles, California

I was initiated around 1966 or '67. This was after I had had a very rare experience. Long ago I was a dancer, and at a studio in the suburbs of Manila. During our ballet break, we heard the most incredible chanting outside our studio gate. I rushed out to peep through the gate. The timing was just incredible. I saw lots of Filipinos and people in orange robes, screaming, "Baba, Baba." I was so curious. I just kept on looking. And there He was, in a white *khurta*, very little, a holy man, I thought. He looked very holy, very strong. And everyone was going after Him, screaming, and He was just smiling and shaking His head.

And I said, "Hey, that's really nice." But all of a sudden my uncle ran out of the house and said, "Stop watching those pagans."

I said to him, "Please, stop it, don't say anything," I felt like he needed to be hushed. There was a presence there, very rare.

A year later, a friend of mine said, "Would you like to check out this place, with monks in orange, you go there for meditation?"

I thought, "Meditation, what's that?" Anyway, I said OK. We went, and sure enough there were monks sitting in meditation. I learned later they were Dadas Sumitananda and Advshananda. They had their eyes closed, and all of a sudden they would jerk up in their meditation. And I said, "What the hell are they doing?" Some people would scream "Baba," and then continue with their meditation. It was strange. I left, though it did not really get out of my mind.

Another year later I went to the mountains. A friend told me, "I heard there was a dude," – we went for this hip talk – "let's check him out." And there was a monk in orange. I remembered him; it was Dada Advshananda. I started talking with one Filipino about this path, the Ananda Marga path. He was saying how we have to practice this. I'm the kind of person, if I commit myself to something, I really practice it, to see what happens. So I was practicing twice a day, and I immediately changed my diet from non-veg to vegetarian. It was really something else.

But I was curious about this man in white I had seen, because His was the picture of the guru. “I’ve seen you before, and I need to see you. I need to know you more, to know how to know you more.” This was in my head. One day I made a wish. “I want to know what it is to realize.” I kept saying, “Baba, I want to realize.” I thought I was the kind of person who couldn’t do good meditation. I would close my eyes and open them and not know where I was, and I thought, this doesn’t make any sense. I was looking for sense, you know. So this is how I met Baba in a realization way. It came like a dream.

I was sitting, and out of nowhere things started coming in my mind. In the vision I was sitting at a table with a few friends, and I was saying, “I have never been happier sitting with a group of people.” This is really fun, my idea of fun, sitting with my friends and talking about holy things. We were having fun. All of a sudden one man stood up and said, “Oh, but I’ve got to go.” The man stood up, and I saw very clearly it was Baba, there at that table. It was really strong. I saw Him in every way no one could have ever felt. And I can’t explain it, and I will never be able to explain it.

I jumped out of where I was seated, and went to His picture and I said, “I’m surrendering to you, now I know what it is to realize.” Yes, Baba can do that for you, if you wish for it hard enough.

This path is very rare indeed. It’s like you’re thrown into a laboratory, where you’re experimenting with your *mantra*, your practice, and you’re exposed to all kinds of experiences. Before that I had a life that was mostly dream space, you know, but meditation is like consciously going through some kind of struggle. That memory of Baba saying, “I have to go,” was the thing that kept me going, and gave me courage to overcome every obstacle I had.

Of course He knew that I was a person who wanted all kinds of experiences, and He gave them to me. From living in the mountains, to working in film and coming to different places; He brought me to this town. I asked one dada, “Why is He bringing me to Hollywood? It’s a town that has a very bad reputation, all kinds of things here.”

That dada told me, “No, you will be exposed to a different kind of life where you will understand how to act.” And sure enough, I came and met people in the acting world,

and ended up being an actress myself, and finally realized the truth of the experience of a yogi, in terms of acting, consciously.

Now I'm an older woman, and I understand what consciousness is about, and for that I only have Baba to thank. That little head that moved, that smile that is unforgettable, but always there, to catch you, whose hand is always there to hold you, when you're coming through some kind of a loop, you know. He never, never fails with His grace. He made me realize, Baba, my beloved guru, made me realize, that only through His grace can we go through life.

I will talk about how Baba inspired me. I was in Hollywood, in Hollywood movies and everything, but there was something missing. One day we had filming downtown and I saw all these people living in the streets. When Baba left His physical body, it was one of the strongest, most difficult experiences I ever had. I kept saying, "What to do, what to do, what will I do now?" And again He came into my mind. "Oh, He's still here," I said. "I have to make clear what He wants me to do for society." And one day I was in the center of L.A. and I saw these people and out of nowhere I said, "Yeah, I'm going to feed people, I don't know where to start, but..."

This was twelve years ago. I talked to Phanindra and Mahajyoti. I said, "I don't even know where to begin." But I said, "OK, I'll just cook something vegetarian." We were feeding people at night, and it was scary. I had to make believe that Baba was there, so that I would be able to go through the fear of going there and facing those homeless people, and not separating them from me. And sure enough, He performed, Baba performed for us in the form of those homeless people. He made us laugh, He extended His hand. Instead of seeing poor people, I'd see Baba joking. It started to be so much fun, all of us doing this, Jayashrii and everyone, we were not thinking actually that we were helping the poor, but only that we were being with Baba and having fun.

So if you want to do something on this path, you really have to connect it with Godhead. Baba is not away from us, He is within us. Nowhere else. You can forget how you wanted to do it, because He is the one doing it for you.

I remember Dada Adveshananda in the Philippines. He had an accident, and it was really a bad accident. He was in the hospital. None of the injections worked, so they had to operate on him without painkillers. His body would not take them. Long before that he said, “I will see Baba in any shape I can imagine, and I imagine he comes like a butterfly.” In the room after the operation, he was in pain, and he kept on moaning and groaning, and all of a sudden, I would see this butterfly, this big butterfly inside the room, and he would just pass out, be calm.

That was very strange. And I really believe that Baba visited him at that time. You don’t need philosophy too much, you need love. You need to know how to love, and then Baba is there. You can pull Him with your heart. Your mind will follow, if you feel strongly for your guru, because the guru is the one who leads you from darkness to light.

Dada had two accidents in a row, it was incredible. He had an accident, and told the WTs to go get help, and while they were gone, he was hit again by a bus. He was so human, and at the same time, a very high saint. Not only a holy one, but someone who was aware of everything happening around us. He said, “That’s what we’re here for, to be aware.” We spend so much time being unconscious. This is a path of consciousness, not unconsciousness. He told me not to worry about the world. Just do service. If you run out of service you can pour water on a plant, or give food to a cat. Or say hello to a bug. It’s the easiest thing to do. Service. If you don’t do it and realize who you’re serving, you’re wasting your time. You have to realize who it is. Poverty is just a word that has been coined. Nobody is really poor. Everything is *samskara*. Everything in this created universe is working out reaction.

Giridhara (3)

I went to Jamaica to see Baba but left Cirasmita and our little Madhurii at home as we believed that Baba would finally come to the States or somewhere close. I had made myself a card that said Official Photographer – AM Public Relations Department and with that badge, I could go on all the field walks and take pictures of Baba. Chandra Shekhara, not to be outdone, volunteered to carry my camera bag so that he could join us on the field walks. Nothing like a clever margii.

It was very crazy as there were no more accommodations at the main hotel, so several of us rented hotel rooms in Kingston. We had to travel each day and late at night back to the hotel. I slept on the floor as there were not enough rooms for all of us. I ran after Baba many times to try to get Personal Contact. Finally I got close enough in line and got in to see Baba.

I did *sastaung pranam*. I was very happy to be with Baba. He spoke to me for a long time. He told me to do something great for the society and He told me of the suffering of so many people and the planet. I could feel that He really felt the pain of these people and the planet. I really understood His compassion and where He was coming from when He wanted us to help the people. He told me to do intellectual service.

I could barely walk when I left the room. I had to sit down in an outer room and I was lost in sadhana for some time.

The rest of the trip was very crazy but extremely blissful. I flew back to the states with a brother from Texas, who was very clashed out. He had a terrible time with the problems with accommodations, getting food, running after Baba, the overcrowding, etc. That was all he could think about. I realized then that I had been in the eye of the storm the whole time, feeling nothing but bliss while the chaos was all around me, clashing out others.

The last time I saw Baba was when I was leaving India in 1988. I had come for *bhukti pradhan* reporting and had spent much time with Kinshuk, Dada Pranavananda, and others showing them the computers. I was also working with Dada Vishvarupananda on publications. We put Baba's books on disk with the capability to search them. This

was shown to Baba, who was very appreciative. Kinshuk spent a lot of time working on the new computer and at one point Baba asked him, if he “loved the computer or loved Baba?” After that Kinshuk left the computer alone for awhile and resumed working with it, when he felt more balance about it.

I was leaving and I was able to garland Baba. I followed Baba and eight or ten workers back towards His door on the side of the house. As Baba and GS had just reached the lower porch and looked back out to the path, GS saw me and said to Baba, “Baba, Giridhara is leaving.”

Baba turned to GS and said, “He has done some good work.”

Baba then turned to me and said, “So, is Giridhara a great intellectual or a great worker?”

I was almost speechless, but a nearby dada prompted me to say both.

I said, “By your Grace, Baba, both.”

Baba smiled and said, “That is a very graceful answer.”

He smiled and namaskared me and continued up the stairs. This brief conversation satisfied a desire that I had to share a regular conversation with Baba and especially to share puns.

I felt that Baba was telling me several things in this brief conversation. First, to go ahead doing what I was doing with putting His books on computer and helping the mission to use computers and to work towards translating His books into many languages. I felt like what I understood that He wanted me to do was correct and that it was accomplishing something. On a deeper level, I immediately realized that His comment was also to tell me that I was strong in intellectual and action areas, but devotion was lacking. I immediately felt I needed to do more kiirtan and develop more devotion.

Shortly after this Cirasmita and I took on Innersong, and over the next several years I spent time recording and making kiirtan available. I spent time with Jyosna and other great kiirtan musicians, and I found more depth in kiirtan. I found more depth in devotion. This was truly Baba’s grace for me and I feel that He personally put me on the right path for me, that last time that I saw Him alive.

CHAPTER SEVEN:

I WILL ALWAYS BE WITH YOU

“If wise people take every object of the world as the expression of the one and single Cosmic Consciousness, then on seeing the changes in the name and form of any particular object, they will not be affected by pain or pleasure. Cosmic Consciousness to them would remain Cosmic Consciousness...”

On Oct. 21, 1990, the Ananda Marga community received a tremendous shock. Our beloved, our guru, our teacher, left His body, in what is known now as His *Mahaprayan*. Many traveled to Kolkata to pay their last respects, while others gathered locally to grieve and console one another. Up until His last moment on earth, Baba worked with incredible speed. It became clear He had known how much time He had, and that He had made sure the organization was ready to carry on His mission in the absence of His physical body. The loss was devastating. But on a spiritual level, He has demonstrated time and again that He continues to guide His devotees.

Chandra Shekhara (2)

I did not see Baba again in physical form. In the late 1980's I experienced a growing desire to see Baba and talk to Him personally about what I should do in my life. I knew that this type of access was pretty much impossible, but I still wanted to do it.

In 1990, people began speculating that Baba might be coming to New York Sector so we were getting excited. One morning – it was very early, maybe three a.m. or so – I was in the state between dream and wakefulness, not really awake but not really dreaming. I felt Baba's presence very strongly. It was a physical presence – I couldn't see or hear Him, but His presence was very strong and very real. He told me that I should work on creating a constitution for the world based on His principles.

Later that day I called Sectorial Office to ask if there was any news about Baba coming to New York Sector. The *acarya* who answered the phone told me that Baba had left His body earlier that day. It was a big shock and very difficult to comprehend. It wasn't until many days later that I realized that the time that I felt Baba's presence so strongly was about the same time of His *Mahaprayan*. Ever since, I've felt very deeply that Baba personally took care of me and answered my questions.

Krsna (2)

When Baba left His physical body in October of 1990, I was in San Francisco and got the message from some sister in Los Angeles. At that time I did not have independent means of confirming this. I called the sectorial office and they didn't know. I called some other margiis and they also didn't know. But I did my sadhana just the same.

And in my sadhana, I was doing my *shuddhis*, and all of a sudden I saw or thought I saw some globe of light coming from the earth and speaking to me. And then I was speaking to this globe of light and said, "Is it true?"

And the globe of light said, "Yes, my son. It is true."

"But why didn't you say goodbye?" I asked this being I was speaking to.

"I am saying goodbye now," it replied.

And then there was some interchange between us and that globe of light passed through the bottom of my *anahata cakra* and then proceeded onwards to another place of the universe. This small light is still there in the bottom of my *anahata cakra*. I still see it, and whenever I talk to it it's still there, it still responds, it never left. It's like Baba left his imprint there and has never left. It is always there.

Dhyanesh (3)

I was doing *paincajanya*, and after I did my sadhana I fell asleep, and I had a very vivid dream of Baba. I was so happy to see Him. But immediately I started to cry; I was crying so much. He kept on stroking my head and saying, “Don’t worry, Dhyanesh, everything is going to be fine, I will always be with you.”

Then I woke up. And I couldn’t understand why I was crying so much. That afternoon we got a call from Kolkata that Baba had left His physical body. This was the saddest day of my life. But I feel He came to me in the dream to say goodbye to me, and so that I would not lose my mental balance. He is always with me. And I still feel Him so directly and closely. This was one of the great lessons, when I was in Denver and He was in India, and yet He came to me.

Some people who got to see Baba physically develop some ego that they saw Him. But Baba said, “Yes, there are good people in Ananda Marga, but better ones are coming, and then the very best are yet to come.”

The last few years He talked about *microvita* and the distance between unit mind and cosmic mind, and that there is no difference. That all is one.

This guru, this level of guru consciousness in the universe manifests itself to us through the form of Anandamurti. His nucleus may be in another planet at this time, but there is no distance. He’s that close, inside us., with so much compassion and love. If we make a little sincere effort towards Him, He makes so much for us, to help clean our minds, to teach us how to think and feel. He allows us to absorb into Him, to come closer. He is so loving, so compassionate.

Arjuna (3)

In 1990, October, I got a call from Dadaji Devashraddhananda that he'd heard that Baba had left his physical body. He wasn't sure, but if I could, I should go to India for Baba's *Mahaprayan*. Somehow five of us here bought tickets and got on the plane and when we got to Delhi there were no plane flights to Kolkata, everything was sold out. We went into the main Indian Airlines office and went upstairs and gave this guy some money and somehow they got some VIP seats for us. We got into Kolkata about two in the morning. Everyone on the plane was crying. We did kiirtan all that night at Tiljala. The next day was *Mahaprayan*, a very, very sad day. Every space in Tiljala was filled up with people. The thing I remember most, after the fire was over, were just the birds coming, and a very peaceful feeling over the whole place.

I guess when I saw Baba the first time in the jail, and had this feeling of seeing this white light, this totally peaceful feeling, I hadn't known what it was. I had never experienced it before. I'd never really studied Ananda Sutram before, just read parts, not really studied it in a deep way. But the past three or four months, I've been memorizing it. One *shloka* really sums up that experience of how I felt after seeing Baba. *Abhavarota ananda pratiya lambaniir vrititasya pramana*. The lingering bliss which follows that state of vacuity is proof of that state, the means of firm belief in that state. Now I know what that means, from that first experience with Baba. It was my introduction to a different world.

Devinistha (3)

We didn't go back to India for two years. I did go back for *Mahaprayan*, after Baba died. We heard one Sunday afternoon. I came to *dharmacakra*; I had been in Boston for the day. All the way back I was singing kiirtan while driving, and I was getting so blissed out. I pulled in the driveway and my husband came out and said, "I have to tell you something. We got a call from India and Baba's either in a coma or He's died. We're doing *akhanda kiirtan*." And I was so confused, I said, "Wait a minute, I was just with Baba, I spent the last two hours with Him in the car; how could He be dead if I'd been feeling Him so much?" We did DC, and afterwards we talked. Punyatman agreed that he would take care of the children if the rest of us went to India. So he stayed behind with our children.

We got our visas and left that next day. I only took my oldest child with me, who was nine. In New York, everywhere we looked there were margiis, and all of us were pretending like we didn't know each other, just to be safe, so they wouldn't prevent us from getting visas. But we were able to get our visas and take the trip. Again on the plane, we agreed to all enter separately.

We got to Kolkata and went directly to Tiljala. There was a room there where they had Baba's body on an ice cake, surrounded by flowers. I went in; they didn't let us in for very long. I put my garland there, and I remember even before I got out they were removing my garland.

There was a garden outside and I sat and faced where Baba's body was, and did sadhana. I had such an intense sadhana, that I didn't really know how long I sat. I got up afterwards and I just felt so happy. I guess I had had a blissful experience. You know how you don't know when you've had such an experience, you only know afterwards? And I couldn't stop smiling. And everyone there was so sad and upset, and I couldn't stop smiling. I felt embarrassed, but I was so happy to be there, and that all these other people were there. I felt blissful. I went through the burning of Baba's body. I cried a lot, but it wasn't a heavy sadness. In a way it was like all the sadnesses in my life were pouring out in the tears there; it was very therapeutic.

After the *Mahaprayan* we returned home to our children on October 31st. I had ridden with Giridhara and Cirasmita on the return trip. We decided we wanted to put together a book of all the people's experiences. Many people had not been able to go to India, many had come to Ananda Kanan. Some people had been stuck at home, and had not had the chance to deal with these experiences. So we decided to put all these experiences in a book, and we didn't have a name for it, but suddenly it occurred to me that we could call it "The Last Garland."

The last garland was in the form of this book. We collected different stories, and also the stories about Baba's leaving, and the last practices He had taught, such as *guru sakasha*. I stayed high, blissed out for a whole month until the night we completed the book. I was at Giridhara and Cirasmita's home, at two in the morning, and we had collected every Baba picture in order to choose what we would put in the book. They were all lying on the floor, and waves of bliss were going over me. I was having trouble staying in my body looking at all these pictures. Finally after making some decisions, I went to sleep. I woke up, and that's the point at which everything just went like that, and suddenly I was overwhelmed by sadness, and the bliss that I had felt was gone and I had to start dealing with the reality of His leaving.

Jayamati (2)

When Baba left His physical body, I tried to be sad, but Baba wouldn't let me. I remember crying before His picture, then He would fill me up with such bliss, that I could no longer be sad. I remember when I got the book in the mail remembering Baba, and they showed the picture of Him on the funeral pyre, then it seemed so real and I cried and cried and cried. For a whole year I kept saying that I wish Baba was still here in His physical form. I had a dream that I was looking at a Baba picture and there was an empty chair where Baba was supposed to be sitting. In another dream I was looking at a Baba photo and there was this light around Baba, and a dada told me that was Baba's light body. I knew that Baba was in His light body. He had not gone anywhere.

I hope that someday that my husband, Amarendra, can be healed about his pain of not seeing Baba, to know that Baba still loves him, even if he did not go and see Him.

Prakash (3)

The final time I saw Baba was in 1990. When Baba died there was this big shock. I felt scared and sad and didn't know what to do, but we only knew we had to go see Him. So we took Anandamayii, who was ten, and I remember seeing Him for the last time. What was most wonderful was the actual experience of *Mahaprayan*. They carried Baba's body out and put it on the funeral pyre, and lit the pyre, and quoted Baba saying, "You're all mini-Babas" and started singing kiirtan for a long time. The flames were coming up, and birds circling overhead. We were all breathing in the smoke coming from Baba's body; it was becoming part of us.

I was crying and feeling tremendous sadness and grief, and a tremendous love. We were letting go of our attachment, and breathing Him in. It was healing and inspiring, grieving and joyful; we were merging in Baba. Merging in Baba. I remember they were afraid someone would do something crazy, like jumping in the fire. They made a very strong statement, that nothing should happen. No one did anything crazy. What kept coming over and over again in my mind was, "If you want to merge with me, you have to see me in yourself and in everyone." It was incredibly loving: the basic ideology, first and second lesson.

I knew that all of us had this intense desire that Baba would do everything; He would become recognized, this savior. But He never taught that; that was our desire. It wasn't Baba's mission, which was about making everyone realize the Brahma in everyone. Brahma alone is the guru, no other, not the physical form. How could we ever know until Baba taught us through this incredible sacrifice? He seemed to say, "You can't understand me as long as you have this attachment." It's painful. But Baba said, "I came into this world crying and everyone laughed, but when I leave this world, I will laugh and people will be crying."

Vishala (2)

I never got Personal Contact. I had this big drama about PC with Baba for the rest of my life. But everyone who got PC in Jamaica that I went with are no longer margiis. And the only people who did not are Arati and myself. And we're still best friends and margiis. So that was an interesting drama. Jamaica was really the only contact I had with His physical body. I spent years after that trying to get to India, but always had these dramas and couldn't go. But after Baba left, He's given me many, many experiences in my sadhana. I've had many experiences of Him, and He's kind of given me an experience of PC in samadhi. I feel like my PC with Baba started after He left His physical body. You can have so many experiences with Him, internally. He can touch you now very deeply, more deeply.

When Baba left His physical body, everyone was going to India. Again, a big drama. I was crying and crying, but I couldn't get there. Instead I went to New York; they were doing something there. My daughter, who was seven, used to say, "Mommy, we have to go to India to see Baba." I'd say, "We can't go, I have a three-year-old and a seven-year-old." Now she said, "See. Now I will never see Baba and His body is gone."

Then we were in New York, and people were coming back from the ceremony, and the vibration was so high. I thought, "Oh Baba, I'll never get to see you, and have PC with you." And all of a sudden I felt like I was leaving my body, my body fell away from me, on the floor, and I was just with Baba. It was very beautiful. And Baba looked down and said, "See, little girl, before they had the advantage, but now you have the advantage."

In my mind I thought I was the most unfortunate margii, because all my friends had seen Him so many times. But really I was the most fortunate. Because His relationship with me is inside. Now that He has left His body, I have that place He created inside of me. And since then I've had so many experiences with Him. I'm the most fortunate margii.

Vishvadeva (2)

This story occurred after Baba left His physical body. I waited five years before going back to India. I thought maybe it would feel empty for me there. Finally I decided it was time to go back. I went with brother Divyamurti, and did some sightseeing, which I had never done before, wanting to spend maximum time with Baba. We went to Kolkata, to Lake Gardens, and then to Ananda Nagar. There I was being bothered tremendously by the mosquitoes. I became disturbed. I was supposed to be enjoying meditation in this beautiful place, but I was tired of being bitten, feeling that although it wasn't a bad experience to come to India, Baba wasn't there, and it hadn't served much purpose in coming.

I went to the station to catch the train to Delhi. I was waiting and put on a Walkman, and listened to kiirtan. And all of a sudden I became ecstatic. Usually I'm a very reserved sort of person – I wasn't jumping up and down in the waiting room, I restrained myself, but I just felt a strong feeling of Baba. And I said, "Baba, even though you're not here in physical form anymore, please just remind me every once in a while that you're still here, so I don't get too foolish in my mind and think that you're not."

I got on the train and found one empty seat. I was talking to some young people, and they said one lady was in the seat next to me, although she had stepped out. Into the compartment came a didi, and she sat down next to me on the train. She said, "You know, I'm feeling very sick, and was thinking I wanted the comfort of having a margii on the train with me."

And I said, "This is too much coincidence, the only empty seat on the train, and we're sitting next to each other. I was thinking that I would like Baba to remind me that He's still here, and I think He just has."

CHAPTER EIGHT:

SEEK NOTHING BUT TO SERVE THE LORD

“In the highest form of devotion, the devotee says, ‘Oh Lord, I love You. I want to love You. And why do I want to love You? Because I want that my love should give You pleasure... I love You not to get pleasure, but to give You pleasure.’ And by means of this type of devotion, the Yogi comes in closest contact with the Supreme Self and becomes one with Him.”

When Baba was physically present, many people reported receiving inspiration from Him through dreams and visions. This guidance continues to manifest itself through such indirect experiences today. A whole new generation is coming onto the scene, with many strong margii families and wonderful margii children, many of whom affirm that they feel His guidance in their lives. In the thirteen years since Baba’s physical passing, Ananda Margiis in New York Sector and the world over have worked with redoubled effort to realize His vision of a world grounded in justice and spirituality. They continue, of course, to grapple with *samskaras*, but also to immerse themselves in service. And, with the knowledge that He has already laid the groundwork, they work together to actualize Baba’s mission.

Das Ragu

Los Altos, California

I was a pre-university student and had the opportunity to see Baba in Kerala in 1968. Inspired by Dada Citiswarupananda, I became a VSS cadre. In VSS dress, I had a chance to get PC with Baba. I was hardly 16 years old. They said, “Hey, come on, come on,” and pushed me into the room.

Baba was sitting on a beautiful bed, and said, “Come, my little boy.”

I did *sastaung pranam*. He pinpointedly told me, “You are doing some naughty things.”

I said, “Yes, Baba.”

“You need punishment.”

“Yes, Baba.” I was reading AM literature, and I was a little egoistic. I said, “Yes, Baba, as you sow, so shall you reap. For every action there is equal and opposite reaction.” Baba brought his face close to mine and said, “You are teaching me?” Oh my God! I was so shocked, you know. And I just put myself in *padmasana*, and closed my eyes, and Baba came and blessed my eyes, probably to see the right thing in my life.

In 1978, just after my marriage, DMC was held. An early morning flight was scheduled to go to Hyderabad. We went to send off Baba. We were late, and the flight took off. Baba was in the Madras airport, seated alone, and it so happened that I and my sister-in-law, Shobha Shettigar, were sitting there. In the whole universe, we were only two souls singing to Baba. It was so nice that we had the privilege to be with Baba.

In Ananda Nagar, my family all went to see Baba at DMC. Everyone was assembled. Baba was walking up and down, and everyone was chanting Baba Nam Kevalam. I was holding my daughter. I told her, “Tell namaskar to Baba.” She was five or six years old. Amidst all the devotional things there, she said, “Baba, Namaskar!”

Instantaneously Baba turned back and gave namaskar to my daughter. It is one of the most gracious moments for me and for my daughter.

In 1988, I had the opportunity because of my revolutionary marriage to go across the oceans to America. I am from a poor village, and I would never have dreamt of going so far without the grace of guru. It is only the element of service that allowed me to come this way. In 1988 it was difficult to get guru, but somehow guru's grace is so gracious on me. We went from California to Kolkata. There were group sessions. Baba was explaining the term 'archipelago.' He wanted a margii from South India to answer his questions. I was the only south Indian margii. I sat near His feet, trying to touch His toes. He was saying, "No matter what, if the grace of guru is there, then one can always be near to Him anytime."

I planned to work as an LFT from 1990 for ten years. I had the opportunity to go with Dada Susmitananda. I was supposed to drive a car from Los Altos Hills, cross Mexico, Guatemala, and El Salvador, to raise money for a master unit in San Salvador. I was so excited. I brought the car, and crossed the border. In a small village, my car broke down. The part was small, a gasket, costing only \$5. But because it had to be imported from New York, I stayed one month in Mexico. Anyway, it was one of the greatest experiences, because in these thirty days I was able to go to schools, colleges, even a prison, to teach yoga techniques, whatever little I knew. The beauty of it was that I did not know Spanish, and they did not know English. Somehow I was able to go through and give a lot of certificates to a lot of people. I had beautiful quarters in the police station. I would get rice and vegetables every day. I would cook and then go and do service. After that I got my car back and went on to San Salvador. I stayed for nearly one year and was teaching in the University of Technology. Believe it or not, *kaoshikii* dance was displayed on national television, because they videotaped it in the university.

There are so many elements in one's life to make oneself great. For example, Dr. Ravi Batra took one word of Baba's theory of the social cycle and made it known to the whole world. Similarly, I have some kind of love for the *kaoshikii* dance taught by Baba. Without *kaoshikii* and *tandava*, *Prabhat Samgiit* and *kiirtan*, Baba never spoke to any group. These are the four fundamental things. I made a song about *kaoshikii* and introduced it as a stretching exercise. It goes beautifully. If I start a class, it takes a

minimum two hours. The students will be laughing and laughing. And still I give the sense of what was given from guru.

Jagadmitra

Vancouver, Canada

My acarya is Dada Priyaksnananda, and I was initiated in the winter of 1989 in New York. My personal experience with Baba has been through the practices and through my dreams. My devotional life was very powerfully affected upon my initiation, and getting into Ananda Marga practices. And so I recognized by the intensity of my inner experience, how effective Ananda Marga practices really were. Over the years I've had a number of blissful experiences.

But more recently, in the last month, I had an experience of Baba in a dream, which was quite different. It was a longer dream than I'd ever had, a very intense experience with Baba. I recall in the first part of the dream I was in a house somewhere, maybe a *jagrti*. And Baba was in the house as well; there were two Babas. I saw a man sitting in meditation posture, up on a dais. And in front of him there was another man, who looked like an average man, but as I looked closer I realized he looked like Baba. How could there be two Babas? The man sitting up higher's head was larger, he looked larger, rounder, and the other looked like an average man. And so I imagined perhaps one was P. R. Sarkar and the other Shrii Shrii Anandamurti [laughs]. Baba had dual representation like that.

I did *sastaung pranam* before Baba, and lay down on the floor. What I observed was, He was angry, Baba was upset or angry. He walked past me and didn't really acknowledge me. Also I experienced that somehow my vibration was uncertain. Perhaps my devotion was not straightforward; my dream was showing me, perhaps Baba was showing me, that my devotion was wavering. It was very interesting.

In the next part of the dream, I found myself out on the ocean, on a large sailing ship, moving through the ocean at night. It was very stormy, the waves very choppy. Baba was being carried in this boat. He was sitting on some kind of wooden platform, and the boat was carrying Him across the water, but the boat fell apart. This wooden boat split, and broke into three pieces. Immediately Baba emerged from the boat and started moving by His own power across the ocean. Then He went to the front of the ship. He was grabbing these huge sails, and the boat started moving forward. The boat was no

longer carrying Him, but He was carrying the boat. He was the propelling force carrying the ship.

I interpreted this as in society or in Ananda Marga society, Baba is our treasure, we are the vessel carrying the treasure of Baba, but perhaps what it comes down to is He is in fact the force that moves us forward. Sometimes we can't withstand the pressures. But it is in fact the power of Baba who is moving the vessel. That was the second part.

In the third part of the dream, I was in a courtyard. It seemed to be in Asia, in India perhaps, and perhaps in a different time – people were dressed in traditional Indian clothing, sitting on the ground in a courtyard. I had the sense these people were devotees. I was in this group, and observing this group. Then Shiva appeared. He was wearing a loincloth, had long hair, and was carrying a spear, not a trident, and I recognized him as Shiva.

I became aware of the contents of his mind. He was observing these people and saying to himself, “Who are these people, what kind of people are they?” And I had the sense that they were like the kind of people who might go to a nightclub, average people, colorful, not necessarily strict *sadhakas*. Shiva smiled at all these people, except for one boy, about 12, who kind of cringed away, and didn't want Shiva to see him. He didn't want Shiva to know he was there. Shiva recognized him, and became very angry. He took this boy, and I became this boy. Oh, no!

Shiva was leading the boy, he had a whip, and was taking him to a place of punishment. And they went to a field. It was dawn on this wide open field, with hills, perhaps what Ananda Nagar looks like. In the field was someone who looked like Krsna. He was standing in a one-legged pose, with foot tucked into his thigh, holding a device that looked like a big trumpet. It amplified his voice, and he was singing, vocalizing, not words, but musical sounds in a beautiful male voice, very resonant, and it was sunrise. It was a beautiful, colorful scenario, awesome and blissful.

So this boy was being led to punishment, and it was a beautifully intense scene. And I woke up. I never saw the punishment, I woke up, the child inside crying “Baba, Baba.” It was so beautiful, rich and overwhelming. In that part of the dream, the theme was about punishment, perhaps some kind of wickedness. Baba was upset, Shiva was

upset, the boy was willing to go for punishment and with that, there was a tremendous amount of love that he received. I felt this intense devotional bliss.

I had never had a dream that involved Baba being angry, He was always very blissful. Baba was angry this time! [laughs]. My devotional life has been filled with these kinds of experiences of direct realization, which are very subjective, but authentic to me, so I've been able to evaluate the instruction received from my *acarya* as very authentic. How else could I receive such intense experiences?

Prashanta

Denver, Colorado

I was initiated by Ac. Jitendra Kumar in 1973. My two most important Baba experiences were pretty much internal. They happened around 1975.

All these experiences progressed out of the sleep state. In the first one, there was just white light, and I saw Baba's face. My mind was completely still. Baba started very slowly smiling at me, the corners of His mouth just started slowly lifting up. The more He smiled, the more of this infinite ecstasy I felt, the experience of pure consciousness, like they talk about, the sugar dissolving in the water.

So by the time Baba was smiling all the way, I was gone. Some time later I started to become aware again, and I saw Baba, and I started to have some unit identity. Then Baba started smiling at me again, and I disappeared again. I had this experience two different times. It was so far beyond what I thought I could attain. This was something given to me to help me be motivated, to understand what my spiritual work was.

The repercussions are, when you go to that place, I don't think you ever come all the way back again. There's always some part of you still left there, some awareness. And, it's pretty hard to be impressed with anything or be that attached to anything after that, it's just so far beyond everything else.

The other story is about a series of visions I had. It was interesting, kind of opposite of the other experience where all I saw was Baba's face. I saw this small gentleman in white clothes, but I couldn't see the face. This individual had so much white light radiating from him that I couldn't really make out the features. But the person was the size that Baba was, and was wearing the kind of clothes Baba did.

I found myself in this place, a physical place. I was seeing people, there was grass, a little road or path. But these experiences somehow changed my state of consciousness, so I understood more and more, so that I began to understand all of science.

I had the experience of knowing all these secrets I'd always wanted to know, and simultaneously, it wasn't that I could understand anything I wanted to, it was that I understood it all at one time.

There was a state of consciousness where that knowledge actually exists. I'm extremely interested in science and math, it's been a great love of mine, and this was having all questions completely answered. And then the knowledge would bleed away, and I would begin weeping, because all of these wonderful realizations were leaving me. I think that one of the repercussions has been that I've attempted a level of difficulty in my understanding of science, to merge back with that point of view, that state of consciousness. So I've been much more aggressive in my work.

Ranjan

Los Angeles, California

Ananda Marga was introduced to me a long time ago, in 1970, when I was studying in college. But I became a margii and practiced meditation for the next six or seven years. I finished my college degree, and I really don't know what happened, but suddenly I got out of practicing meditation and Ananda Marga.

When I migrated to the U.S. in 1990, one day I was reading in the library. I saw a book by Didi Ananda Mitra, and I had an awakening, remembering that I had been practicing yoga before.

In the middle of 1998, I received a call from Dada Sarvabodhananda, inviting me to Phanendra's place. Then I realized I had to practice yoga again. I asked Dada to renew my lessons and I attended the weekly *dharmacakra* in Phanendra's place. I had a lot of clashes and problems, because my family was not yet introduced to Ananda Marga. I had a hard time convincing my family about vegetarianism, to follow what I was doing. I had to really feel a lot of help from Baba. I said, "For me to be able to practice this, you have to help me."

From then on, I did not stop practicing. I told myself that maybe some day they will realize that this is important. After two or three months, I asked them to attend *dharmacakra*. And they were convinced, so now they are regularly attending, and got initiated. I told Baba, that really He gave me the opportunity to bring all my family to the path.

I would like also to relate a story which happened just a month ago. I've never been absent at *dharmacakra* since that time. One week I was very sick beginning on Wednesday. I had a high fever; it seemed I had the flu, and I couldn't work. I was taking medicine. By Friday I said to Baba, "I don't want to miss a single *dharmacakra*."

Saturday came, 7 o'clock, 8 o'clock, then 12 o'clock and I asked Baba, "Please, I don't want to miss."

Suddenly, I started to feel better. I took half-bath and told my family, "Let's go," and they were so surprised. I was able to attend the *dharmacakra*. I thought that was the end of that, that my sickness was gone. But then on Sunday, I got sick again [laughs]. I

told Baba, “Oh Baba, you only let me attend the DC, and now I have to suffer two more days.” Anyway, I realized He helped me to go to *dharmacakra*, and if you need help with some good deed, He will help you.

Liila

Taiwan

I was initiated in 1981 and I first met Baba in India in 1986. I went there to attend DMC and also I got married there and got Baba's blessing. When Baba gave blessing it was really like I was just in front of Him, and my self seemed to disappear. Only He was there. His eyes were so big. I visited India several times after that. The last year before Baba left His physical body, I was going to have a baby and I knew I would not be able to come for many years. So I went there for Baba's birthday in May.

Always we read and got some information that Baba would stay until the year 2000 something. We never thought He would leave so early. That October when we got the news, I had so much pain inside. I tried to go to India that day, but because I had one more baby I could not go immediately. For many years I always felt much pain. Until three years ago I went to India, to the *Mahaprayan* commemoration. When Baba was physically there, the main purpose in going to India was to see Him, and wait for Him to come out. But this time He was not physically there. And I tried to compare the difference. When I went inside Baba's room, there was such a strong vibration, as strong as when my eyes saw Him. In that moment, it completely fulfilled my desire. I knew that without the physical I still could feel Him everywhere. Later I went again to DMS. DMC and DMS were different, but even without His physical presence, really Baba was everywhere.

The important thing I feel is just to do His work. And it is very easy; you can feel He is there. I also never feel lonely, because He is always with me. This is the first time I came to the U. S. to attend a retreat, but there is the same big family feeling. It's really Baba's grace.

Kirit (3)

On many occasions Baba gave me messages through dreams. And every one came true. I received information about my health, received certain medicines, and if I had physical problems, they were resolved. Many things He told about the energy crisis, about how one should conduct aspects of organizations, about training centers, and issues related to them. All these things He told me in dream.

One time Baba was angry because we did not have a medical unit in Kolkata. He said, “What is this, the headquarters are here in Kolkata and you don’t even have a medical unit. Scoundrels!”

All this stuff He used to throw at us, all His drama and *liila*. “I have to have a clinic by next Tuesday,” He said.

The *acaryas* promised. But how do you get a clinic in less than a week in Kolkata? You can’t even get a rental building. But they promised. Baba threatened to fast if they didn’t get it. And they called Dada Dharmadevananda. Dada called me, “We have only a few days to open a clinic.”

I said, “Well, OK, Baba wants us to do it, so He probably has done it already. Let us see what we can do. Let us try.”

I got the phone call on Wednesday and it had to be done by Tuesday. So Rathi-ji, a *margii* in Kolkata was running around like crazy to see if he could get some building. Real estate is so hard to get there, nothing is available. Finally he went to where they were constructing homes. He went to a businessman friend who owned a house, and said, “My guru wants this house, can you give it to us? Tell us what you want and we’ll pay you for it.”

He agreed, and the price was set. My target was to raise \$22,000 in a week. That was a lot of money in those days. So we were all thinking, trying to get cash and some loans from the bank.

All of a sudden some *margii* called from New York, and said, “Dada, I had a dream.” He was given the message in a dream that some work was going on and he needed to talk to Dada to find out about it. He saw Baba in the dream, and saw the need for some project, and saw that some assistance was required. He called Dada, who said,

“Oh yes, we just received the news, they want to build a hospital.” That person contributed almost \$10,000. So we put together some cash and got some additional loans, and we had the \$22,000.

I decided to deliver it in person; at that time we could not send money through the bank. The earliest plane would not get there until Thursday, and so we asked if we could get some extension from Baba. Baba did not accept. He said, “No, don’t come to me. I gave you the date; complete the work by Tuesday. It’s not my concern when the plane arrives.”

PA Dada told me that Baba didn’t accept the delay; it must be done by Tuesday. So I was running around getting my visa, and we said we would come no matter what. I was traveling with Phanendra from L. A. I was hiding all this cash on my body. I got caught in the airport. The CBI asked, “How much money do you have?”

“I don’t have any.”

The man said, “I know you are carrying cash.” We were going to lose the money, and then what would happen? I turned pale. I don’t know what happened to that officer, but he let me go. “I’ll let you go but don’t insult my intelligence,” he said.

I went straight to the *jagrti* and handed the money over, “Please take this, I don’t want it in my possession any more!” Then I saw Baba. The last time, He had told me, “You will be back very soon.” And it had only been a month and a half. So when Baba gives some work, it is always predetermined.

Baba started giving *Prabhat Samgiita* on Sept 14, 1982. Ten days before that I had a dream. In it, Baba was sitting on a cot, all the margiis were there, and Baba was singing, composing a song, and teaching music. Next morning, I asked Dada Yatiishvarananda-ji, “Did Baba ever write any song?” “Oh no, Baba doesn’t sing, he never wrote any song.” “I don’t know but I had a dream that Baba was singing, teaching music.” He laughed at me. Within a week, Baba gave the first *Prabhat Samgiit*.

When Baba left His body, I got the news on a Sunday. On the Wednesday before that, I saw in a dream Baba walking through the desert. He was very hot, perspiring. He was unsettled. There was no umbrella to shade Him from the scorching heat. People were

walking around, looking very tired. I looked at them and said, “What are you doing? Where is the umbrella?” I was looking everywhere for one, running around in the desert. I became more nervous. Finally, I noticed Baba, and all His heat was gone. He was very cool and nice.

Next morning I woke up and thought, “What is the message of this dream?” Baba looked so red. And then, Baba left His body. I came to India. We were all so broken-hearted. I was on the second story of Tiljala. They put Baba’s body there for the final rites, and finally they started the cremation. Then I recalled my dream. “Oh, this is the same picture of heat, redness, that I have seen in my dream, and this was what my dream was.” So Baba gives indications.

This is my last dream, a very special dream which I can never forget. After Baba’s departure, it became very hard for me to adjust in my life. I became worse than a machine. I could not tolerate the separation, and life became impossible for me. However, Baba had told me some specific instructions on Sept. 8, 1987, and I remembered those and it helped me to go through this period. When He told me they didn’t make any sense. I thought, “Why did He tell me these things? They would never happen.” But it happened. Those instructions saved my life. I could not do sadhana for a long time, I could not concentrate on *mantra*. Many times I tried to do any lesson, I could not see any *cakras*, I could only see Baba. My eyes were constantly crying when I did sadhana. My body also gave up. I became very sick. My body collapsed because my mind collapsed. And to make things worse, Baba no longer came in my dreams. It became impossible to live, and impossible to die. It was the worst period of my life.

During this time I only had one question for Baba – “Baba, I was never worried about my spiritual progress, or what will happen to the organization, or who will guide us?” I had no questions like this. I was convinced there were no problems there. The only problem I had was this: How is it that Baba can break the bond of my love and go? How could He do this? Was this bond so weak that He can just break it and go? It didn’t matter to me that He was my guru, and that He chose to do this; those issues did not matter. As guru, whatever He did, I accepted. But what did come to me as a question was how it was possible that He could break the bond of love.

Finally after nine or ten months I had a dream. Baba was the most beautiful I had seen Him any dream or ever in person. I was sitting on a ledge of a building; He came close to me. In my dream I did not know that He had left the body. I was so happy to see Him. He said He had come to say something. “My work on this earth is complete.”

“Yes, Baba, no problem.”

“No problem?”

“Yes, Baba.” Whatever He decided was OK. I already assumed that He loves me so much that wherever He goes, I would go with Him.

“My work is finished and I have to go. And I have come to ask your permission to go.”

“Baba, what are you saying? How can you ask permission from me? You are everything. You cannot ask permission from me. Even for me to hear this word is not acceptable. That means that you are going and I am staying behind. No, I cannot hear this. It is not up to me.”

Then Baba explained, “It is important that I have your permission before I go.” How could that be? That got me thinking. I had some responsibility here.

“Do I have your permission?”

I became very sad, because I knew He would leave. Finally I folded my hands and said, “Of course, whatever your decision is, how can my thought process be different from yours? Of course my thoughts are in agreement with yours.” I did not use the word permission.

He smiled and said, “Yes, I know.” Again He talked with me for a while.

When I woke up next morning, my pillow was wet. I realized that *Parama Purusa* is such an expression of love. His littlest creation is of such importance to Him, that He comes back to insignificant existences and communicates through dream, and says that He cannot leave the earth without permission. Not only that, but He came to tell that He did not break the bond of love, which is what had been bothering me. Now I cannot think that He broke it, since He asked me.

To me all these dreams are much more vivid than real life experiences, because *kamamaya kosa* is not existing. In a subtle state of being, the higher *kosas* are present, and experiences are much more vivid.

My personal desire simply is to remain with Him and serve Him, truthfully. I don't search the ultimate realization, I only want to serve Him. As Baba said, the devotee should seek nothing else but to serve the Lord. I want to serve Him all the lives to come. So that His existence, His form, remains comfortable and satisfied, His work gets completed, His desire gets completed.

Vijaya Laksmi (2)

In 1980 there was a tremendous earthquake in Guatemala. I was working in the mountains for AMURTEL in Chimaltenango. That was where the most damage and loss of life was as a result of that terrible earthquake. I was working with Dr. Ram and we were in charge of the field hospital that the Red Cross had left. Because we had the professional know-how, they put us in charge. I had many very beautiful experiences there. In fact, the head of nursing for the Red Cross got initiated as the result of Dada's talks. I remember getting up early to do kiirtan. All the volunteers that had come from so many countries including the nuns said to me, "It is so beautiful to get up in the morning and hear you chanting Baba Nam Kevalam. It is so inspiring."

When our work was done there, we went to Lake Atitlan. We thought we would take a holiday for a couple of days. It was a beautiful blue lake with volcanoes in the background. There I had a beautiful dream about Baba. I remember that I looked out in the morning at the beautiful lake and there was Baba coming up in this boat. He was dressed in blue, on this silver lake, rowing towards me. Then He called me to Him. I'm not a very good swimmer, but as soon as He called, I just dove in and swam to Him. I was actually kind of surprised that I had gone in when I could have drowned. I went up to Him, and He looked towards me and just signaled for me to hold onto the boat. I was looking up at His face. It was just so beautiful. He did a namaskar and then rowed away. It was so nice. It was such an example for me to do exactly what He wanted me to do, and the scenery was so fantastic, purples and blues. That was just one very nice dream.

I have a story of the first time I had a spiritual dream. It was right after I was initiated and I was new to Ananda Marga. In the dream, everybody had met Baba in the airport and they were singing Baba Nam Kevalam. I was so new that I felt I had to sit in the back just to observe. Then Baba got off the plane, and He walked all the way to the back. At that time I didn't have the name Vijaya Laksmi. I was called Vicky. And He said, "I really came to see you, Vicky."

And He looked right at me. He was so beautiful dressed in brown. I was so amazed and He looked so intently at me. At that time, I used to drink coffee, and He took

my hand and said, “C’mon, let’s go get a cup of coffee.” We went over to the corner, and we were talking. The talk was so moving that I don’t even remember what was said, but I remember the feeling was something deep and special for me like I had never felt before. Then He did namaskar, and He went out to His silver plane and flew away. That was so special for me. I had only been initiated for about a week or so. It also had humor as you can see because Baba would never go and drink coffee.

One of the many times I went to India was a special time. It was when I formed a very special bond with Baba. I had been in India for about two weeks and I wanted to go to Nepal just to look around. I was a little hesitant because I wanted to go to all of Baba’s darshans. I thought I would just go and come back. I got all ready to go with my flight and everything. It was getting late, and I guess Baba didn’t want me to go because a huge herd of water buffalo came onto the street. I was feeling desperate because I thought I was going to miss my chance to go. They never did get the water buffalo out of the street, and the man had to turn the taxi around and go back. But I was so glad I didn’t go and miss the darshan because there was such beautiful *Prabhat Samgiit*, with dancing and everything. I thought this was so much better than going to Nepal. Obviously, Baba didn’t want me to go that time, but later I went to Nepal on vacation.

I had been healthy all of my life. But as a result of my illness, and falling and breaking my hip, going through this tremendous *samskara* which Baba put me through in my old age, I believe Baba said, in this way you will burn a *samskara* and come close to me. And that is exactly what happened. There is a tremendous spiritual affinity that seems to grow and get deeper, and now I know Him more. When I was first diagnosed with cancer, I realized that this was how I have to surrender, it was pretty final, it was serious enough. Baba was calling me, and finally I said, “Now I am going to another planet.”

It seems that He is taking care of me in different ways. He is allowing this time for me to get closer to Him on a much deeper level than I had experienced before. Your life changes. You’re looking at things in a very different way, and it is almost as though you died and now you’re getting a chance to restructure everything. And you look at

everyone, every situation, in a much more spiritual way. Because of that I am exceedingly grateful. I feel it is a gift.

We become impatient. Ananda Marga has been around for a long time, and we are still struggling. But we do not take into account the many countries where Baba has developed strong ties with schools, and *acaryas* struggling all the time to make things happen, working with children's homes. Certain things have happened in India with different *acaryas*, and we can lose perspective of who Baba is and what He is doing.

He is a dynamic force in this world right now. I would say the most dynamic. I think it is important that we go deep inside and realize that His mission is a special beautiful *tantric* mission; I don't think we realize that. We may need to look deeper and through sadhana we can begin to understand. Baba left His body, but He is definitely in everyone's *sahasara cakra* guiding leading you into a more spiritual path, putting all kinds of *tantric* obstacles in front of you so that you can really know that you have to go through this battle, this internal and external battle.

And that is something I feel is unique to Ananda Marga and to Baba. This is a very special mission. I think that we need to look at it and understand that it has a special meaning to us individually. I know that I will not be alive and things are going to get pretty tough. We will need to prepare our young people and ourselves mentally. We are going to need strong hearts and minds and bodies to develop Baba's mission.

Nirmala

This is the story of when I went to India for the first and only time to see Baba. It was the winter of 1986; I had been initiated in 1973. I was so excited and nervous that I left my passport in Denver. So it was quite a problem when I arrived in New York. I watched as all my friends, Guhan, Jayamati and Dada Shamitananda boarded the plane to India. I stayed with the didis for two days. They were wonderful to me; took me back to the airport and rearranged my flight. By His Grace I flew first class.

When I finally got to Kolkata and Tiljila, I was exhausted and exhilarated at the same time. I climbed upstairs to the room where all the margii sisters from Denver were staying. I could hear the kiirtan and smell the cook fires from the open window of the darkened room. There was an orange sheet waving in the breeze just outside the window. As I looked out I could see Baba's residence and the Christmas twinkle lights all around the compound.

It was crowded in the cubicle and as I lay down on the concrete floor between two sisters, I fell into a restless sleep. I dreamed that Baba was at a dining room table with me and many other devotees. He was giving a discourse on the desserts on the table. There were jelly-filled tarts and tiny vanilla cakes with designs on top, there were cookies and coconut bars, orange- and lemon-scented breads and slices of some sort of Indian torte. He was describing all of these delicacies in great detail. And when He finished, He said to me in a melodious, sweet voice, but with a hint of mirth, "Nirmala, would you like one of these sweets? Which one would you like?"

I could feel the kindness and radiance of Baba's being, but I could not answer Him! When I awoke, I felt so close to my guru, and in fact, I was only 200 yards from Him physically. This dream stayed in my mind for many days, and although I never spoke directly to Him or got very close to His physical body, He arranged for me to have a sweet visit with Him!

Krsna (3)

Baba has come back to me in dreams, and at specific times He tells me something. One time, when we did not yet have a Master Unit in the Bay area, I had a dream that there was a gathering and the margiis and the dadas and the LFTs were reporting to Baba and all of a sudden Baba got very angry.

He said, “Who’s taking care of the Master Unit?! There’s nobody taking care of the Master Unit! Who’s taking care...”

And He was furious! All of the dadas and myself were saying, “OK, calm down, Baba. We’ll take care of the Master Unit. Calm down.”

So we promised that we would take care of the Master Unit. Within a few days we got news that Vijaya Lakshmi had got a Master Unit. And since that time I have always tried to keep my promise to Baba that I gave in that dream, to take care of it.

The most recent dream I had of Baba was unusual, at least for me. I’ve had many dreams of this type, some of which I only remember when I’m doing sadhana, but in this last dream Baba appeared and we were in VSS uniforms, escorting him to a door. There were margiis there and they were saying that Baba has resigned, that He is no longer Baba. Because I was a VSS guard I had the opportunity to talk to Baba if I wished, and in that dream I did not even speak to him as Baba, I spoke to him in my own language. I said, “Papa – is this true?”

And He said, “Yeah.” And He pulled out a paper in his own handwriting declaring that He was no longer Baba.

I said, “But why?”

He told me, “YOU are Baba!”

Then the dream collapsed and I had a very strong feeling and awoke. My realization from that dream is that all of the margiis and *acaryas* and LFTs – it is now our ballgame. We do not have Baba as a physical person to tell us what to do anymore. It is now us that has to bring Baba’s mission to success. It is now up to each of us and we have to work together to make certain that His mission goes forward and is successful. We don’t have a physical person anymore to tell us, “OK, do this.” That person has imprinted Himself into each of us and He’s relying on each of us to fulfill His mission.

Lokesh

Albuquerque, New Mexico

I was initiated in Ananda Marga in 1980. I had this dream about five years ago. In this dream, I was walking up a spiral staircase. I walked up a little while and came to a level area, a little platform. I stopped and rested for a little while and thought, “No, no, I need to go higher.” So I started walking up this spiral staircase again, reached another little platform, rested for a minute and said, “No, I should keep going higher.” I kept going up this staircase; I would reach another level, rest for a while and then keep going higher. Finally, when I got to the top there was a very, very nice meditation room – beautiful drapery with a nice level area for meditation.

I sat down and waited there thinking, “You know, Baba is around here somewhere.” I looked over to the room on the left and the door opened. Baba was sitting there kind of leaning back in a bathtub. You could see His head and shoulders, and He was looking over and He just had this big grin on His face almost as if he was playing a little joke or having fun. It was very nice going up this big spiral staircase and reaching a little meditation hall and then seeing Baba with this big smile. It was delightful and very refreshing.

Krsna

Los Angeles, California

I was recently involved in a car accident. I was on my way to the Master Unit one day in December, 2000. The farm has a windy road, and for some reason I felt very heavy, and all of a sudden I fell asleep at the wheel. The truck hit a tree, but there was a big lake nearby, and I was lucky that I didn't drive straight into that lake. There were people around who came to help me and called the paramedics. They called Dada, who came and took me to the hospital, and I got a few stitches. But the truck was totaled.

Just looking at the damage of the truck, I felt it was Baba's grace that I came out of that accident with just a few cuts and bruises. It could have been much worse; I could have driven into the lake. But I hit a tree, and the truck was totaled. And I only had a few cuts and bruises. And I felt that Baba was really with me – He is with me every day, every time – and I think He saved me from that accident. Just looking at the damage of the truck it is hard to believe anyone came out of it alive. I think Baba is with us all the time.

Karun

Los Angeles, California

My name is Karun, and I started meditating in February of the year 2000. I was initiated by Dada Rudreshvarananda on June 13th of 2000. I was in prison at the time. I was doing the last year of a five-year sentence. Rajiv started a *dharmacakra* in the prison, and that was how I was introduced to Ananda Marga.

Dada began to make visits to the prison. My meditation was going well, and it was a nice experience to be in prison and practice yoga. Before I was initiated I was only doing Baba Nam Kevalam ideation. My meditation was going nice, and I was having some small, blissful feelings.

Then my meditation became more stale or stagnant and the blissful feeling began to leave somewhat, and I didn't understand why. I was only doing maybe 15 minutes of ideation at a time, and no kiirtan or half-bath; very basic things as I had just started.

One day at *dharmacakra* in the prison, I sat down for my meditation and there was Baba's face in my meditation, big, and He told me, "If you wish to have more blissful experiences and you wish to further your meditation, you must stop eating meat now."

The only feeling that I had then was complete love. The only way I can describe it is like a father giving love to you, but so much stronger, with no conditions to it. In a sense I felt like I had mud all over my clothes, and the father would look at me and say, "Oh, you're dirty," but he still loved me. At that time, the way the embrace was, no mud mattered, nothing mattered. It was just purely love, and the feeling that He loves me so much.

From that time I stopped eating meat, and my meditation got better. And slowly I started to implement the other practices, half-bath, kiirtan before meditation and all these different things. And my meditation grew and grew.

I recently got out of prison – May 22nd of 2001 – and I've been out a couple months now, and adjusting to the different life in society, which is very difficult for me, but the meditation is definitely helping me to make the adjustment. I don't know that I

would be adjusting so well without it. Recently I've been becoming very involved with Ananda Marga, and I'm very happy with the progress I'm making now.

Kiirana

Albuquerque, New Mexico

I was initiated by Didi Ananda Shamita in 1995. As a new margii, I was enthusiastic to learn about Guru – where He came from, what He did, and all He passed on to us. I was coincidentally reading a book called *Who's Afraid of the Tantric Guru?* which turned out to be a pretty good primer for new margiis because it explains the life and travels of people who traveled with Baba. Those of us who never saw Baba physically of course are interested in everyone else's stories.

So, I was reading along in this book written in journal form, and the date May 29th sprang up. Baba was landing in Geneva, Switzerland. I just stopped right there and was riveted with that page because it occurred to me that I was living in Geneva then. Of course, at that time I didn't have a clue. I didn't know anything about Baba, Ananda Marga, or spirituality for that matter. I was beating myself up over this. I started to look back through my notes, tickets and all other kinds of things to determine where I was the day Guru came to Geneva. I became obsessed over this and what I thought of as my delinquency at not knowing about Baba. So, about a year later, I would still find myself in tears over this.

One day I was driving back from town with Dada Rajatakrishna, and he said very matter of factly, "If you want to know Him, if that is your desire, then that is what you will get." He didn't say specifically how to do this, but I had an idea that it was probably through my sadhana. After several months of thinking about Guru and obsessing with knowing Guru, I had a dream. I'm not certain whether it was a real dream or a result of my intense desire. The Australian Aborigines say that we dream the creation into existence. If that is what happened, then so be it.

The dream unfolded in the Geneva airport. At this time I was long back in the United States, having come back in 1982. So in my dream Baba was coming to visit me in Switzerland. I was to meet Him at the Geneva airport. I was on my bicycle as I usually was in those days. It was a cold, foggy day, and there was no visibility. There were no incoming flights or outgoing flights, no cars. It didn't occur to me that Baba wouldn't come; after all, He was Guru. So, I continued and got to the airport and parked my bike

against a chain link fence. I waited and then heard the sound of an incoming flight. First, it was very faint in the distance, then it became stronger and stronger. I was hoping against hope that it was Baba. The plane landed and I saw it was a small Cessna type. Baba was the pilot, and He came down. I was very nervous.

He came over and said, “Namaskar, Kiirana.” I looked over my shoulder and since there wasn’t anyone else there, I assumed He was talking to me. So, I said, “Namaskar, Monsieur Sarkar.”

We were speaking in French, and I said, “Nice day today.”

Of course it wasn’t and was just a stupid nervous thing to say. But, Baba being very kind didn’t smile or question me. He simply agreed, saying, “Yes, it is a very nice day today.”

I looked down and noticed He was wearing sandals. I wanted to offer Him my socks, but I was too nervous. He said something in French, “Shall we have a walk?”

We began to walk through the airport. The fog was so thick it was like walking on a treadmill. He was talking about Switzerland, how He loved the mountains and how He was looking forward to staying for a while. He mentioned how He loved the flowers in the windows. Switzerland is famous for its flowers. He said that it was good that I was there and that once I was finished, I wouldn’t be interested in going back. I don’t remember much else of what He said. Finally, He asked me in French, “Is there something I can do for you?”

How do you answer such a question from Guru? The sky is the limit. I didn’t think about it very long. I said in French, “Yes, may I try on your glasses?”

He didn’t bat an eye and acted as if it were a very normal request. So, I put on Baba’s glasses. I realized it was the perfect question. It was the perfect thing to ask of Guru because behind His glasses was what I was looking for and what I would still be looking for if I hadn’t put on His glasses. It is still hard to explain in language. It was stillness – the formless, all-knowing, all-pervasive entity. Easy to read about, and even mildly possible to understand. But this was actually It. There was the motionless stillness that was holding up all the creation. The creation in this image was like fireflies blinking on and off. There was nothing that I could identify as form, just that blinking on and off.

But that wasn't what was so noticeable. It was that stillness, that formless entity that was the Supreme entity that sustains us, that holds us. We were the fireflies in the creation. It was bliss. I was witnessing that bliss. I didn't need to have His glasses on for long to feel this, but I left them on for as long as possible.

So, I asked him in French what He saw with his glasses. And He answered in French, "I see what you see."

Thus, I assumed to myself that He knew what I saw. So, we continued our walk a little more. Finally He said, "I have to go now, Kiirana." I said, "Yes, Monsieur Sarkar."

He said, "Au revoir." "Au revoir" doesn't just mean goodbye. It literally means, "Until we meet again." It is really a nice way to say goodbye, and I had never really thought about what it meant. Whenever I hear the word, I think of my meeting Baba. So, He went off towards His Cessna, waving. I said, "Au revoir, Monsieur Sarkar," and He replied in French, "You can call me Baba, Kiirana."

Since that time, it has always been "until we meet again," meaning that any one of us can have Him anytime. Only the desire has to be there. My relationship really changed with Guru from that point on. If it wasn't really a dream, it doesn't matter. It was a turning point for me in my relationship to Guru, which became very personal for me from that point on. We had a lot of fun and played together. We had some really funny moments, as Baba can be funny. And I do call him Baba now. Certainly that turning point helped me escape a lot of clash – as clash is defined as a crisis of faith, wondering if we are doing the right thing, following the right path. Since then I haven't had many doubts, and it has allowed me to live my life in a much calmer way and be more disciplined and confident about the future, which is obviously the present if we can go back to the airport anytime.

Prakash 4

I feel that some of our strongest Baba stories are the ways in which our children come to us, because of connections, because Baba wanted them to be in our family. Several months after we adopted Anandamayii, we were visiting the birth mother. When she was in labor we spent five days with her. She told us, “I knew you were the right parents because Anandamayii was conceived on Devinishta’s birthday.” Later, [my wife] Devinishta was looking through journals and saw that she had written, “Today is my birthday; I asked Baba for a baby.” She asked Baba for guidance. But Baba had already arranged it.

Mahajoy was adopted two years later. Anandamayii’s mother was a friend of Mahajoy’s mother, and she wanted us to adopt her. The mother couldn’t make up her mind whether she wanted to accept us as parents or not. But all of this support came from family, friends and margiis all around the country. I would write letters about what was happening, and we got so much support; she was really part of Baba’s family. That was the most amazing time, when I really felt Baba’s direct hand. We went to court and the mother basically decided that she would not like us to adopt Mahajoy. Our lawyer went in to talk with her lawyer and the judge, and I sat and said to Baba, “Do whatever is best for Mahajoy. I don’t know.” The judge came out and met with the lawyers, and then said the mother had changed her mind. I felt my surrender made it possible. When I surrender to His love, miracles happen.

In 1985, we gave birth to Liina, which was another miracle. We had had an operation to reverse infertility. There was a 20 percent chance of success. We discovered at Ananda Kanan that Devinishta was pregnant. And all the margiis gathered around and did kiirtan. After the surgery, the surgeon had said there was one in a thousand chance of her getting pregnant. It was again a miracle of Baba. All of our children are gifts from Him. I experience His grace every day because of my family.

Anandii

Longmont, Colorado

I was born in Argentina and initiated there in 1986 by Didi Ambuja. In December, 1992, I was pregnant with Jasmine. She wanted to be born when I was only six months pregnant. I was rushed to the hospital, and the nurses said it was too early.

So what happened was the doctor tried to stop all the contractions; they put an intravenous drip (IV) into me with magnesium sulfate. It relaxes all the muscles, which relaxes the uterus. It's like torture, like you're on fire. Finally they stopped the contractions. They showed me the care unit, with very tiny little babies, weighing one or two pounds. And I made a firm determination that Jasmine wasn't going to be born for three more months.

During the time I was with the IV, Baba came to me. He was holding the hand of one of the nurses. He was all in white, with His stick. He was older, and needed some help walking. He came, and pointed with His stick to me, and He said, "You take good care of yourself. Don't worry about Jasmine, I will take good care of her." And that's what He did. He took good care.

He was constantly guiding me about what to do. Many times I wanted to pray, "I want a girl that is strong and healthy," because I saw the little babies in the care unit. But Baba said, "Don't pray, I don't want you to be a beggar, don't do any prayers." He did take good care of her.

We drove home and I had to stay in bed. Two weeks later I was in the hospital again. This time I told the doctor I preferred to walk on my knees from here to New York than to be put on the magnesium sulfate again. The baby at this point was only 900 grams, not even one kilo. We had thought that the baby was going to be a boy but they did an ultrasound, and it was a girl. I wasn't ready with a girl's name, and I wanted to name her. I wanted to stop my mind, but it was going very fast like a washing machine. And then suddenly, like a drop of water, the name "Jasmine" came. So Baba gave this name.

In January, there was a big storm, and it was the full moon. With the full moon, there is a tremendous pull on the uterus. And so I ended up again in the hospital. It was the 30th week. I said, “I don’t want Jasmine to be born yet.”

The lungs and the immune system needed to be developed. I started my pregnancy with 110 pounds, and had gained four pounds, and I didn’t want to lose them. I was fasting for 48 hours. The next morning, the sun started rising, and all the contractions stopped. The doctors were ready to do the Caesarean section, and I didn’t want to go through that – the baby wasn’t ready. By Baba’s Grace, the nurse came over and asked, “Did the contractions stop?” “Yes!”

In February, at 35 weeks, the contractions were at every six minutes, and that was OK, but at every three minutes, I had to rush to the hospital. We thought, well, maybe Jasmine should be born. But still, there were parts of her lungs that needed more time, the lungs might collapse. Baba’s presence was always there. We had kiirtan going constantly, 24-hour kiirtan. And He stopped the contractions again. The nurses were thinking she would be born by the thirtieth week. “You did a wonderful job!” and I thought, “I did nothing, it was only by Baba’s Grace.”

Her due date was March 29th, and on March 11th the doctor said “No more.” I wanted her to be born naturally, but the doctor said no. So she was born by C-Section, and I was able to watch it, because I was looking at the doctor’s glasses. She was born very healthy, six pounds, and everything went very well.

Anjali Natarajan

Houston, Texas

Jagannath's baby naming ceremony was a memorable event. A devotional vibration encircled the *jagrti* as we charged the place with *Prabhat Samgiit*, kiirtan and sadhana. We had the honored presence of six *acaryas*: *Acaryas* Ananda Ragamaya, Ananda Sucandra, Giitainjali, Ishvarakrsnananda, Nityasatyananda, and Shankarananda. It was a day to welcome our little one into the spiritual community as well as a golden opportunity to introduce my parents to the sweetness of Ananda Marga culture; to show how we are all connected and how we care for others.

I was feeling hesitant that I had invited my mother and father to the ceremony. They both have had a hard time seeing the changes in me since I have become a margii. My mother is Jewish and my father is Catholic and their views on Eastern spiritual practices are not so positive. For instance, my mother is always questioning "guru."

"Why does anyone need a spiritual master? You can find your own way to God."

My father is not so verbose, but I felt that he might be uncomfortable just the same. I invited them out of great love and respect. Jagannath is their only grandson and the only grandchild living in the state, so I knew that for them it would be very important to take part in this ritual. They are also both retired and relish the time spent with their grandson. I worried about how they would fit in, and how the margiis would treat them. I realized that these were unnecessary worries and surrendered my mind to Baba. "Let it be in His hands."

Dada Nityasatyanda began the ceremony leading *Prabhat Samgiit*. The celestial voices filled the room as I led my mother and father in. Giita sang a beautiful song that she had written – a window to the loving dance between a young child and his mother. I began to cry, feeling that it was a great gift that Baba had given us our little child. Didi Ananda Ragamaya began, explaining that the Baby Naming Ceremony was for the society to welcome the child and that we would take an oath to care for his well being.

My mother asked suspiciously, "Do the grandparents *also* have a part in this?"

"Oh, no," I thought, "Please don't embarrass me."

“Of course they do,” beamed Didi, “They have a very important part in his life, and we are all very glad that you are here today!”

The other *acaryas* echoed parallel responses as we all laughed lovingly.

At that moment, I felt so proud to be a margii. I saw everyone embracing my parents, giving to them from the core of their hearts, and making sure that they felt a part of our spiritual family. Dada Ishvarakrsnananda and another brother moved my parents’ seats up close so that they would be a part of the circle. Didi Ananda Ragamaya moved the bath closer to my mother (who has difficulty walking), and got up to give her the cup so that she didn’t have to bend so far. Both Didi and Dada Nityasatyananda explained all of the procedures and the naming song to my parents directly. They went out of their way to make certain that Jagannath’s grandparents were included.

The air was full of love and joy during the ceremony. Everyone was laughing and sharing in the delight of seeing a new margii child into the community. I’d never felt so much love from a group of people before. From the day he was born, the *acaryas* and margiis have treated Jagannath as if he was more than their own little brother/child/grandchild and this day was just as special for them. Jagannath’s eyes were shining as we sang the *mantras* to him. He was wiggling around and expressing his pleasure as if he knew exactly that this day was for him. I had seen the same response in Trimurtii when he had his naming ceremony. It’s as if they realize that something wonderful is taking place.

I wondered, “How much do these babies understand...? Can they see and feel Baba as we do, or even more?”

Everything became profoundly clear as we began to bathe him – that this was a spiritual bath, a bath that had been blessed by Baba through the tender, loving hands of the margiis and my parents. I could feel His love and blessing as we washed our son’s body, and mentally gave thanks to Him for choosing us to be a part of his family.

At lunchtime, Dada Ishvarakrsnananda continued to demonstrate Baba’s unconditional love towards my parents, running back and forth asking them if they’d like anything to eat or drink. He was just like a beloved mother to them. My parents commented on how wonderful the ceremony had been, and how kind everyone was. They had enjoyed themselves tremendously.

In retrospect, I know that any other religious ceremony such as a Catholic baptism would not have been as joyful. That which sets the Baby Naming Ceremony apart from others is that everyone participates, all are equal. This demystifies our relationship to God because *we* are the expressions of His love, not some distant pastor who is put on a pedestal. Baba's love is directly, deeply present and felt. As the years go by and my sadhana and devotion intensify, I can experience His vibrant force more and more. I wonder if my parents felt it too? On some level, I'm sure that they did.

At home that evening as we began to sing kiirtan, the sweet fragrance of sandalwood emanated from Jagannath's body. I was perplexed... I had not smelled it on him earlier. The scent lingered as the kiirtan flowed on and I realized that this was Baba's blessing.

GLOSSARY

Acarya – one who teaches by example; a monk or nun of Ananda Marga engaged in teaching meditation and service

Ajina cakra – the so-called third eye cakra, located between the eyebrows; central point of the mind.

Akhanda kiirtan – the singing and dancing of kiirtan in three-, six-, twelve- or twenty-four- hour increments.

AMURT – Ananda Marga Universal Relief Team; an international relief and development organization.

Anandam – bliss

Ananda Mela – a festival sponsored by Ananda Marga.

Aparigraha – one of the ten points of morality; not overindulging in the possession of material goods; non-acquisitiveness.

Avadhuta/avadhutika – an acarya who has learned kapalika sadhana; a complete renunciate, wearing full orange dress.

Bhajans – devotional songs.

Bhakti – devotion for God.

Bhava a state of deep ideation in which the mind is completely concentrated.

Bhukti Pradhan – family person who is a local leader of Ananda Marga.

Brahma – Supreme Consciousness or God.

Cakra – psycho-spiritual controlling point in the body, linked on the physical level to the endocrine glands.

Darshan – “to see.” Being in the presence of a master. Also refers to the talks and lectures given by Baba.

Dharma – Spirituality; original nature or innate tendency; the path of righteousness.

Dharmacakra – “circle of dharma”; collective meditation.

Dharma samiksa – “analysis of one’s adherence to the path”; a program conducted by Baba in 1981 during which He gave direct guidance to many margiis.

Dharma pracar – the propagation of spiritual ideas among the public.

Dharma Maha Cakra (DMC) – a spiritual gathering of Ananda Marga, often attended by 20,000 people, in which Baba presented a discourse, and then bestowed a blessing through the varabhaya mudra.

Dharma Maha Samellan (DMS) – a gathering similar to DMC, without the presence of Baba.

Dhyana – contemplation; merging one’s mind into Cosmic Consciousness; the sixth lesson of AM meditation.

Diiksa – initiation into spiritual practice; learning meditation.

Ekadashi – eleventh day after the full moon and new moon; a fasting day.

ERAWS – Education, Relief and Welfare Section of Ananda Marga.

Gopi – a village devotee of Krsna.

Guru mantra – second lesson of Ananda Marga meditation; a process for seeing the divine in all things.

Guru puja – a mantra by which the devotee offers his or her ego attachments to the guru, sung after meditation.

Guru sakasha – “to be near the guru”; a practice which involves visualization of the guru.

Ishvara pranidhana – first lesson of Ananda Marga meditation on the Supreme.

Ista cakra – cakra upon which one concentrates during meditation.

Ista mantra – individual mantra which allows one to focus on one’s spiritual goal.

Jagrti – “place of spiritual development”; local Ananda Marga meditation center

Japa – repetition of the mantra

Kamamaya kosa – one of the five layers of mind; the conscious mind.

Kaoshikii – a dance exercise designed by Baba, which harmonizes many glands of the body.

Kapalik sadhana – meditation designed to overcome fear, done at night in the graveyard, most often by avadhutas and avadhutikas

Khurta – a long Indian shirt

Kiirtan – singing the Lord's name, accompanied by a rhythmic dance.

Krpa – grace, as in God's grace.

Laungota – men's yogic underwear.

Liila – play, as in Divine Play.

Lungi – Indian garment that wraps around the lower half of the body.

Mahaprayan – Baba's Great Departure; His leaving the physical body.

Mahasambhuti – a great incarnation.

Mohan vijnana – supra-aesthetic science; deals with the irresistible attraction human beings feel for God.

Mudra – meaningful hand gesture.

Nama mantra – simple mantra used in introductory form of meditation.

Nirvikalpa samadhi – absorption into pure Consciousness; total merger with the Supreme.

Padmasana – cross-legged sitting posture for meditation.

Paincajanya – spiritual practice done at five a.m., which includes Prabhat Samgiit, kiirtan and meditation.

Parama Purusa – Supreme Consciousness; God.

Prabhat Samgiit – a body of over 5000 mystical songs and poems composed by Baba.

Pranam – respectful greeting.

Pranayama – fourth lesson of AM meditation; control of the breath.

Prasad – food infused with spiritual vibrations.

Pratik – the symbol of Ananda Marga ideology; representing service and self-realization.

Prout – Progressive Utilization Theory; a socio-economic theory proposed by Baba.

Purodha Pramukha – the spiritual head of AM organization after Baba’s physical death.

RAWA – Renaissance Artists and Writers Association; a department of AM focusing on the arts.

RU – Renaissance Universal; a department of AM serving as a forum for intellectual discussion.

Rudra – Shiva’s mood of great anger.

Sadhana – meditation.

Sadvipras – spiritual moralists; revolutionaries working for social change

Sahasrara Cakra – the seventh or crown cakra, located at the crown of the head.

Samgacchadvam – mantra sung during dharmacakra signifying the unity of those present.

Samadhi – state of complete absorption; merging with Cosmic Consciousness.

Samaj – literally, “society” or “a group of people moving together.”

Samskara – karmic reaction lying in potential form in the mind, waiting to be expressed.

Sannyasi – renunciant, monk or nun.

Sastaung pranam – posture of respectful salutation to the guru; lying prone with arms and legs extended.

Satsaunga – good company; the fellowship of other spiritual people.

Sattvika – sentient principle; referring to one of the three gunas or qualities in the universe: tama, raja, and sattva; quality of purity and peace.

Shabda Cayanika – “A Collection of Words”; a series of lectures Baba gave on the linguistics and philology of the Bengali language.

Shloka – Sanskrit verse.

Shravanii Purnima – a day commemorating the first initiation Baba gave.

Shuddhis – process of withdrawing one’s identification with the material world during meditation.

Siddhis – occult powers.

Sixteen Points – a summary of the most important Ananda Marga practices.

Tandava – a vigorous dance for males that stimulates all the glands and develops courage.

Tantra – the oldest and foremost of spiritual traditions, originating in India in prehistoric times.

Taraka Brahma – that being that links the spiritual world with the material world.

Tattvika – one trained in AM philosophy.

Trikuti – ajina cakra.

Vanii – a spiritual message

Varabhaya mudra – “blessing of fearlessness”; a bestowal of energy through a particular hand gesture; Baba performed this mudra usually during DMCs.

WWD – Women’s Welfare Department; a department of Ananda Marga run by women and dealing with women’s development and issues.

Yama and Niyama – ten cardinal points of morality.

I Am Yours

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stories from devotees of
Shrii Shrii Anandamurti**

It is said that the life of a great spiritual master can best be understood through his relationship with his disciples. "I Am Yours" chronicles the relationship between the great 20th century master, Shrii Shrii Anandamurti, and his devotees from North America and the Caribbean, spanning a period of more than three decades. Through the oral histories of more than 70 disciples, we get a unique look into that mysterious bond between teacher and disciple, a bond that begins and ends in the love which shines forth from the devotional heart of these beautiful stories.

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Ac. Jyotirupananda
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